

123

Under the Palm Tree

A Literary Adaptation of "123 Let's Learn English Under the Palm Tree"

تحت ظلّ النخلة

By Thuraya Al-Naabi

36 Palms · Literary Edition

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A work of literary fiction inspired by real memories and experience.

First Edition

“When you live in your imagination, many things can happen — even the impossible becomes reality, and you can act out your secret personalities.”

“Under this palm tree, a small village taught the world how to dream in two languages.”

*To Samail — to its falaj, its palms, and its children.
And to every teacher who plants a word and waits for it to grow.*

إلى سمائل... وإلى كلِّ معلِّمٍ غرس كلمةً وانتظرها حتى تثمر

The Palm, the Woman, and the Beginning of Change

When the pain of birth seized Maryam, she cried out, “*Would that I had died before this!*” — and heaven answered her not by lifting the pain away, but with a palm tree: *Shake the trunk toward you, and ripe dates will fall*. The palm did not take her suffering; it gave her the strength to carry it. The dates eased the ache of her body, and the call from below eased the ache of her soul. And out of that pain came Isa, peace be upon him — a miracle, and the beginning of a change that would touch the whole world.

The palm knows this kind of dignity. In Oman, a sickness sometimes strikes it — the people call it *al-mataq*. A stricken palm begins to gleam: it shines like glass, like still water, more beautiful than it has ever been — and all the while, it is dying. If it is not healed, it dies. But it dies standing — tall, luminous, shining to its last breath.

And so are the Omanis: called by the gentlest of names in peace, and called *sons of the noble* in hardship. A quiet people who harm no one, they entered Islam without a single battle — not out of weakness, and not out of innocence, but out of a wisdom that recognizes truth the moment it knocks. Even those who once sailed toward them came not to make war, but to seal a peace.

All of these threads gather in Samail — not merely because it is the soil I was born on, but because change itself began there: when **Mazin bin Ghadhuba**, the first of the people of Oman to embrace Islam, broke the idols with his own hands. And because the emblem of Samail is a palm — the **Fardh palm** — standing, giving, enduring.

From that soil this book has grown. And under the shade of that palm — we learn.

قبل أن تبدأ الحكاية

النخلة والمرأة وبداية التغيير

حين اشتدَّ على مريم وجعُ المخاض قالت: «يا ليتني متُّ قبل هذا وكنتُ نسياً منسياً» — فما أجابتها السماء بأن ترفع عنها الألم، بل أجابتها بنخلة: «وهْزِي إليك بجذع النخلة تُساقطُ عليك رُطْباً جنيّاً». لم تأخذ النخلةُ وجعها، لكنها أعطتها ما تحمله به؛ فحَقَّقَ الرُّطْبُ أَلَمَ الجسد، وحَقَّفَ النداءُ أَلَمَ الروح. ومن ذلك الوجع وُلد عيسى عليه السلام: معجزةٌ... وبدايةُ تغييرٍ غيَّر وجه الدنيا

والنخلة تعرف هذا الشموخ. يصيبها في عُمان داءٌ يسمُّيه أهلها «المتق»؛ فإذا أصابها لمعت كأنها رجاغ، كأنها ماءٌ ساكن، وازدادت جمالاً على جمال — وهي تموت. إن لم تُعالج ماتت؛ لكنها تموت واقفةً، شامخةً، تلمع إلى آخر تَقَس

وكذلك العُماني: يُدعى في السلم بألين الأسماء، ويُدعى في الشدائد «ابن الأطايب». قومٌ هادئون لا يؤذون أحداً، دخلوا الإسلام بلا حربٍ واحدة — لا ضعفاً ولا سداجة، بل حكمةً تعرف الحقَّ حين يترك الباب. حتى الذي جاءهم من بعيد، جاءهم ليعقد الصلح ويطفئ الحرب

وتلتقي الخيوط كلها في سمائل — لا لأنها مسقط رأسي فحسب، بل لأن التغيير نفسه بدأ منها: حين أسلم مازن بن عضوبة، أولٌ من أسلم من أهل عُمان، وحطَّم الأصنام بيده. ولأن شعار سمائل نخلة — «نخلة القرص» — واقفةً، معطاءةً، صابرة

من هذه التربة نبت هذا الكتاب. وتحت ظلِّ تلك النخلة — نتعلَّم

How to Read This Book

This book is a journey of **36 Palms** — thirty-six stories set in the village of Al-Qurawashiyah, Samail, Oman, in 1973. Each Palm is one complete story, told scene by scene.

Inside the stories, important English words are marked with a dotted underline. **Tap or click any underlined word** to see its meaning, synonyms, and an example sentence — then keep reading. At the end of the book, all the words gather again in The Word Harvest glossary.

Between the Palms you will find photographic interludes — moments of the real village this story grew from. Read slowly. Read aloud. Read under a palm tree if you can find one.

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Meet the Characters

John جون The British English teacher who answers a letter from Oman	Sophia صوفيا His partner — patient, curious, learning the village
Thuraya ثرىا Omani teacher, guide, and keeper of the Book of Thoughts	Malood مالود A small white goat. The most famous troublemaker in Samail
Mansoor منصور Student	Saeed سعيد Student
Khamees خميس Student	Ahmed أحمد Student
Khalil خليل Student	Noura نورة Student
Ali علي Student	Mustafa مصطفى Student
Marwa مروة Student	Rahma رحمة Student
Salma سلمى Student	Mathila مثلة Student
Sadou سدو Of the village	Marhoon مرهون Of the village
Shayb Khalaf شايب خلف Elder of the village	Mohammadeen محمد بن Of the village

Nasser

ناصر

Of the village

Fatakat

فكات

Of the village

Zahran

زهران

Of the village

Obaid

عبيد

Of the village

Al-Qurawashiyah — Samail, 1973

A village threaded by a falaj — clear water running in an ancient stone channel, feeding the palms, the farms, and the small green patches at the edge of the village. Mud-brick houses. A school with wooden desks and open windows. A souq a morning's drive away. Mountains all around, holding the valley like two cupped hands.

The year is 1973 — the dawn of a renaissance. A letter has crossed the sea, a truck is raising dust on the road from Muscat, and under the oldest palm in the village, everything is about to begin.

PALM

Palm One

Thuraya's Book of Thoughts

SCENE ONE

Turkey / The Notebook

The morning had settled over the city the way certain mornings do — not with noise, not with light, but with a kind of held breath. As if the world had agreed, without speaking, to pause. To wait. To let something begin.

Thuraya sat on a wooden chair near the window, her back straight, her hands still, her gaze somewhere between the glass and the water beyond it.



The **Bosphorus** lay before her like a long, slow thought — its surface **shimmering** in the thin spring light, moving without urgency, carrying the morning on its back.



A breeze moved through the open window — slow, unhurried — gathering the scent of the sea as it came, and weaving it gently into the deep, warm **aroma** of Turkish coffee that rested, untouched, on the table beside her.



The coffee had grown cold. She had not noticed. It sat where she had placed it — patient, faithful, slightly forgotten — as if it had accepted its role long ago: not to be drunk, but to be present. To fill the silence with warmth. To remind her, quietly, that she was still here. Still in this room. Still in this year.



Her **posture** was calm — the kind of calm that is not absence, but presence. The kind that comes from having sat with oneself long enough to stop performing stillness and simply become it.



In her hand, a blue Cartier pen.

Her father's gift.

Professor Mohammed Al-Naabi.



He had pressed it into her palm the afternoon she received her **scholarship** — the afternoon she stood at the edge of one life and the beginning of another, not yet knowing which direction the wind would take her.



He had not made a speech. He was not a man who filled important moments with words. He had simply taken her hand in both of his — her small hand disappearing inside his — and held it. Just held it. Long enough for something to pass between them that neither could have named. Then he let go. And she understood that some things are not said because they are too full to fit inside language.



She could still hear his voice when she tried — low and unhurried, steady as stone.

Not loud. Not searching. Not asking anything of the moment except that it be real.

And it had been. It still was.



Her fingers moved across the notebook's cover.

The leather was soft — worn at the corners in the way that only time and hands can wear things — as though the notebook had been waiting to be written in long before she had thought of writing.



On its cover, in her own hand —

"A story that might have been in Thuraya's mind."



She had written that line herself. She was certain of it. And yet, reading it now — in this morning, in this light — it felt as though she were reading something left behind for her. A message from a version of herself she hadn't yet become. She read it the way you read something that was always yours but that you are only now, for the first time, ready to understand.



She opened it.

The paper breathed — **delicate**, dry, holding its silence the way old pages do.



She raised the pen above the page.

Did not write yet.

Simply held it there — suspended — as though the words were already present in the air above the paper, waiting only for her to lower the pen and let them arrive.



Then, slowly and without ceremony —

She began.

﴿

التاريخ: 10 / 09 / 2027

اليوم هو يوم عيد ميلادي.

أبلغ من العمر ثمانية وثلاثين عامًا،

وأنا في تركيا حيث أتابع دراستي لمرحلة الماجستير
في تخصص تدريس اللغة الإنجليزية باستخدام التقانة والذكاء الاصطناعي لغير الناطقين بها.

﴿

She stopped. The pen rested against the page, its tip barely touching the paper — caught between one sentence and the next, the way breath catches between one feeling and another.

﴿

اليوم... رأيتُ حلقًا غريبًا.

﴿

Her eyes lifted from the page.

Not to the window. Not to the water.

To somewhere further — somewhere the room had no wall for.

﴿

...حلُمُ أعادني إلى زمنٍ بعيدٍ

﴿

A long pause settled between one breath and the next.

Her fingers tightened almost imperceptibly around the pen.

Not from tension — from recognition.

﴿

كيف يمكن لذلك العام أن يبدو قريبًا إلى هذا الحد؟

﴿

Her hand moved slowly toward the corner of the page.

She turned it.

﴿

1973

London



And just like that —

the room in Turkey grew quiet in a different way.

The coffee, the curtains, the water — all of it softened at the edges, like a painting left too long in the sun.

And then, gently, it was gone.

SCENE TWO

Transition

How can that year feel this close?



It was not a thought exactly. It arrived differently — not through the mind but through the chest. The way certain memories do not announce themselves but simply appear, already inside you, already warm, as though they had never truly left.



As if time had **folded** back on itself — quietly, without warning — pressing something distant against something present until the distance ceased to feel real.



Thuraya's pen slowed. Did not stop entirely — just lost its direction, the way a river loses speed before it widens into something larger.



Her fingers still held it. But the words were no longer coming from the page. They were rising from somewhere deeper — from a place that had no name in any language she had studied, a place that preceded language altogether.



She did not look at what she had written. She looked past it. Past the notebook, past the table, past the glass of the window — into something the room could not contain.



The Bosphorus was still there. She knew it without looking — still moving, still shimmering, still carrying its quiet freight of light. But she no longer saw it. Her eyes were open and yet entirely elsewhere. Turned inward. Turned backward. Looking at something that existed only in the part of the mind where time does not flow in one direction.



Her expression softened — not into sadness, not into joy — into that particular stillness that comes when a person is no longer entirely in the present.



How can that year feel this close?



Her thumb found the edge of the page. She turned it — slowly, with a kind of care that was almost ceremonial, as though what lay beneath was not paper but a threshold. As though turning it was less an act of reading than an act of crossing.



The room changed. Not visibly — nothing moved, nothing fell — but the air shifted its weight. The sounds outside seemed to step back. The warmth of the coffee, the rustle of the curtains, the low voice of the city beyond the glass — all of it drew away, like a tide going out, leaving the shore bare and still and waiting.



She lowered the pen. This time without **hesitation** — with the certainty of someone who has decided, quietly and completely, to go somewhere.



1973

The number sat alone on the white page — stark, patient, absolute.



Then below it, like an address, like a destination —

London



And the moment that word touched the paper, the room answered.



Something shifted — in the light, in the air, in the quality of the silence itself.



The room was no longer the same room. The morning was no longer the same morning.



And she — without moving from her chair, without standing, without crossing any visible threshold —

was no longer in Turkey at all.

SCENE THREE

London Apartment

The sky over Britain was the colour of old linen — pale, flat, pulled tight across the rooftops as though someone had smoothed it down with a wide, cold hand.

It did not threaten rain. It simply was. Permanent. Inevitable. Entirely itself.



London in this season wore its grey like a coat it had owned for too many years — not uncomfortable, simply familiar. The cold was not sharp. It did not cut. It was the kind of cold that settles, that seeps slowly through walls and windowsills and the narrow gaps between old buildings, taking up residence in the spaces between things. It asked nothing of you. It simply stayed, the way certain presences do — not demanding, not leaving.



Inside the apartment, the light entered reluctantly — pale and thin, slipping through the glass as though uncertain of its welcome, touching the edges of the room without ever fully committing to it.



Sophia sat curled into the wooden chair by the window — her knees drawn slightly toward her body, her shoulders softened, her whole self gathered inward in that particular way of people who are not hiding but simply elsewhere.

She was entirely **absorbed** in her book.

The Palm Tree.



Her fingers turned the pages with a kind of reverence — unhurried, deliberate — as though the story beneath her hands was something that needed to be handled gently. As though it might bruise.



On the small table beside her — a box.

Omani **frankincense**. Closed. Unlit. Untouched.



It had lived on that table for weeks — longer, perhaps. She had never opened it. And yet its presence was not absent. There was something it gave to the room simply by being there — a density, a quiet gravity, the kind that certain objects carry when they hold within them a world the room has never seen. It sat among the ordinary things of the apartment like a word in a foreign language — meaningful, patient, waiting to be understood.



Beside it — a photograph in a plain frame.

A boy. Young. Standing between two people who were clearly his parents, his small body leaning slightly toward his father the way children lean toward the things that feel most solid.

John. Behind them — mountains. Palm trees. A sky that was not this sky. A place that was entirely not here.



She had not heard the time pass. It had moved without her — quietly, undemanding — the way time moves for people who are truly, completely inside something.



And so she did not hear him enter.

No footsteps. No sound of a key, or a door, or a coat being removed. Nothing that the ear could name.



Only a change — not in the room, but in the room's quality. In the texture of the air itself.



A scent. Arriving before he did.



Faint at first — just the edge of it, a suggestion. Then more present. Then unmistakable.



Oud.

Warm and deep — the kind of scent that does not simply enter a room but changes it, the way a single note can change the feeling of a piece of music. **Unfamiliar** to her, and yet not unwelcome — the way certain unfamiliar things arrive and make you realize, without knowing quite how, that you have been waiting for them.



It did not rush. It settled — the way dusk settles, gradually, without announcement.



Sophia's fingers went still against the page. The book remained open, mid-sentence, mid-breath.

She lifted her head — not sharply, not with surprise — but with the slow, deliberate attention of someone who has sensed something and is now choosing to look.



She breathed in first. Then turned.



John was standing just inside the room. Still. Watching her with an expression she had learned to read over time — the expression he wore when something had already changed inside him, when the decision had already been made, and he was waiting, carefully, for the right moment to let her know.



Not happiness exactly. Not excitement. Something held below the surface — something that wanted to rise but was being held, gently, until she was ready.



A letter was in his hand. Open. Read. Held the way you hold something that has altered the weight of the afternoon.

~
ℳ

Sophia looked at him — really looked, the way you look when you have put the book down inside yourself as well as in your hands.

~
ℳ

And in that silence, before a single word had been spoken —

she already knew.

Something had changed.

SCENE FOUR

The Decision

"Sophia..."

~
ℳ

His voice was low. Measured. The voice of a man carrying something he does not yet want to put down.

~
ℳ

She did not look up immediately. Her eyes remained on the page, though they were no longer reading — moving across the words the way eyes move across a landscape they are no longer seeing, their attention already somewhere else entirely.

~
ℳ

"You sound serious."

~
ℳ

Now she looked. She set the book down — deliberately, without haste — and gave him her full attention. The kind of attention that is not just listening but arriving. Being present.

~
ℳ

He moved closer. The letter still in his hand, held the way you hold something significant — not tightly, not loosely, but with awareness.

~
ℳ

"I got the job."

~
ℳ

Four words. Simple, plain — the kind of sentence that takes less than a second to say and a long time to absorb. She felt them land before she fully understood them, the way you feel a stone enter water before you hear the sound it makes.

۞

Her fingers tightened at the spine of the book.

۞

"What job?"

۞

He **inhaled** — a quiet breath, barely noticeable, the kind that is not nervousness but its opposite. The steadying breath of someone who has already made peace with what they are about to say.

۞

"In **Oman**."

۞

The word entered the room and stayed there. It did not echo. It did not fade. It simply remained, suspended in the air between them — two syllables that carried the weight of a geography she had never touched, a life she had never imagined, a direction she had not considered.

۞

"**Oman**... as in the Middle East?"

"Yes."

۞

He did not rush. He gave each sentence its own space, the way you give a room its own silence before you begin to speak inside it.

۞

"They are opening schools."

A beat.

"Building roads."

Another.

"Starting something new."

۞

He met her eyes directly — fully, without apology.

"And they asked for me."

۞

She said nothing. She sat down slowly — not from weakness, not from shock, but from the instinct that the body has when the mind is processing something too large to hold while standing. Something inside her needed ground beneath it.

۞

"I don't know anything about **Oman**."

"I know only a little,"

he said quietly. An honest admission, offered without embarrassment.



He did not reach for **certainty** he did not have. Did not dress the thing in a confidence that would have been false. He stood in the reality of it — incomplete, unknown, uncertain — and simply named what he did know.



"But I know this..."

"It's a chance."

"A real chance."



She studied him. Not quickly, not lightly — but in the careful, patient way that she had learned to look at him over the years. The way that went past the surface of a face and into what the face was holding. Past the words and into what the words were covering.



And then, without deciding to, her eyes moved — away from him, toward the table.

To the frankincense box.

To the photograph.

To the mountains behind the boy. To the palms. To that unreachable, particular sky.



And suddenly — without crossing any distance, without any physical movement at all — she was no longer in the room.

SCENE FIVE

Memory / University

A lecture hall. Wide and high-ceilinged, with the particular acoustics of rooms that have held many years of voices — absorbing them, holding them somewhere in the walls.



Rows of students faced forward — notebooks open, pens moving, pages catching the quiet industry of learning. The afternoon light fell in long diagonals across the desks, indifferent to what was written beneath it.



On the board, in clean letters — *Literature Around the World*.



The professor moved through the material the way certain people move through a room they have known for a long time — with ease, with ownership, but also with something that had not grown routine. An Iraqi man with a voice that carried its weight without effort, each sentence arriving as though it had been considered long before it was spoken. He did not simply teach. He inhabited the material. He brought it forward like something retrieved from a place students had not yet visited and made them feel they almost had.



Sophia sat in the middle row. Her pen moved across her notebook — but more slowly than the others, falling behind, pausing at intervals that had nothing to do with pace.

She was not writing. She was listening to something the lecture had not put into the room.



A voice. Off to the side. Speaking in a language she did not know.



She could not have said when it had started. It was simply there suddenly — clear and steady and entirely at ease, moving through the syllables of Arabic the way someone moves through a city they grew up in. Without hesitation. Without a map.



Her pen stopped. Her head lifted.



At the side of the room — **John**.

Standing, not reading from anything, speaking **fluently** — not as someone performing a learned skill, but as someone for whom the language was already part of the body. Part of the way breathing works.



*There is a difference that the ear can detect, even without understanding the words, between a person who has studied a language and a person who has lived inside it. One carries the language. The other is carried by it. **John** belonged to the second kind. You could hear the kitchen in it — the road, the early morning, the specific silence of a house in a country that was not this one. He spoke Arabic like a man returning to something, not arriving at it.*



The professor responded — easily, warmly — and the exchange moved between them with the **effortless** rhythm of two people sharing the same native water. The class shifted. Some looked confused. Some looked impressed. Most looked briefly up from their notebooks and then returned to them.

☺
☺

But **Sophia** did not return.

☺
☺

She watched him. Not the words — she could not follow those — but the way the words came from him. The ease. The absence of effort. The quality of **confidence** that was not performance but simply — presence.

☺
☺

It was **unexpected** in a way she could not yet explain. Not just the language — but the person standing inside it.

☺
☺

She leaned back slightly. Still watching.

☺
☺

Who is he?

☺
☺

The question did not arrive with urgency. It settled — softly, without fanfare — and stayed, the way questions stay when they already know they will be answered. Eventually. In time.

☺
☺

The professor nodded. The moment passed. Pens resumed their movement. Pages turned. The lecture continued in the direction it had always been going.

☺
☺

But for **Sophia** — the lecture had already become background.

She lowered her eyes to her notebook. Stared at the half-finished sentence she had been writing before the voice reached her.

She did not finish it.

☺
☺

She was thinking about something else entirely.

☺
☺

And without knowing it — without any announcement, without any decision she could point to — that was the moment. The precise, unremarkable, entirely ordinary moment in which everything that came after had its beginning.

SCENE SIX

Back to Present / The Choice

She blinked.

The lecture hall dissolved — voices, light, the long diagonals falling across desks — all of it drawing back like smoke pulled through an open window.

~

And she was back. Back in the apartment, in the pale grey light, in the particular quiet of a London afternoon.

Back in front of him.

~

John had not moved. He was still standing exactly where she had left him — still holding the letter, still patient, still waiting with the composed stillness of a man who has learned that some answers cannot be rushed. Who has learned, more precisely, that rushing them damages them.

~

This was something she had come to understand about him over time — not through what he said, but through what he chose not to say. He had an instinct for silence. Not the silence of uncertainty or avoidance, but the silence of trust — the kind that says: I am here. I am not going anywhere. Take the time you need to arrive. He was not afraid of a long pause. He never had been. And that, she had come to understand, was one of the rarer things.

~

Sophia looked at him carefully. The way she had looked at him in that lecture hall years ago, for the first time — trying to see past the surface of a face into the thing behind it. The thing that stays when all the words have gone.

~

Then her gaze moved — deliberately, slowly — across the room.

To the table. To the frankincense. To the photograph.

~

The boy between his parents. Mountains behind him. Palm trees. A sky she had never stood beneath.

A place that had always been part of him — long before she was.

~

She inhaled — not deeply, but with intention. The way you breathe when something inside you is settling into position. When the parts of a thing are finally **aligning**.

~

She looked back at him.

~

She closed the book. The sound it made — soft, final — seemed to mark something. She placed it on the table with care, as though setting something down for the last time.

u
e

"I'm coming with you."

u
e

Six words. Said quietly, without drama — the way the truest things are often said. Not performed. Not announced. Simply placed into the air between two people, where they belonged.

u
e

John went very still. Not the stillness of someone who hasn't heard — but of someone who has heard too completely, and needs a moment before the moment can move again.

u
e

"You're not even going to argue?"

u
e

There was warmth in his voice, barely contained — not teasing, but genuinely, quietly surprised. The surprise of a man who had prepared himself for a longer road and has just been told the distance is shorter than he feared.

u
e

She shook her head. Gently. Certainly.

"No."

u
e

A small pause — a breath, really. And then:

"Book the tickets."

u
e

The room filled with a different kind of silence. Lighter. As though the air itself had exhaled — released some weight it had been carrying since he walked in with the letter. The grey light through the window seemed, just for a moment, to soften.

u
e

John exhaled slowly — his shoulders dropping with it, the way a held breath drops when it is finally let go. Not from exhaustion. From the deep, specific relief of a man who no longer has to carry something alone.

u
e

"Together..."

The word came out quietly. Almost to himself.

u
e

It did not sound like a decision. It sounded like something older than a decision. Like the recognition of something that had already been true, long before it was spoken.



Sophia said nothing.

She didn't need to.

Some things require no answer. Only the willingness to begin.

SCENE SEVEN

Preparing

The apartment changed the way certain things change — not all at once, but incrementally, one addition at a time, until the original thing is no longer recognizable beneath what has been added to it.



First one bag appeared near the door. Then a second. Then a third. And then — the process seemed to accelerate on its own logic — many more, arriving from rooms and cupboards and places that had held things quietly for years, releasing them now into the light.



Clothes. Books. Shoes in their pairs. Objects that made sense alongside one another and objects that made sense to no one but their owner. The careful taxonomy of a life being boxed up, sorted, reconsidered.



The room, which had once held its empty space with a kind of dignity, had been entirely overrun. There was no longer a floor to speak of. There were only bags — arranged in no discernible order, stacked and leaning and spreading in every direction, filling every available surface of the apartment with their quiet insistence.



John stood in the middle of it all. Utterly still. His eyes moved slowly around the room the way a man's eyes move when he is trying to understand something that has exceeded his ability to understand it.

One bag. Two. Five. Eight. Ten. More.



He blinked.



"**Sophia...**"

A pause — long enough to suggest that what followed required careful phrasing.

"Are we moving to **Oman...** or **relocating** London?"



She did not turn. She was on the floor beside an open suitcase — her movements precise and unhurried, folding each piece of clothing with the attentiveness of someone who has already decided that this, at least, will be done properly.

~
~

"This is normal."

~
~

Her voice was absolutely calm. The voice of someone stating a fact they consider self-evident, slightly puzzled that it requires stating at all.

~
~

John looked at her. Then back at the room. Then at her again.

"For who?"

~
~

She zipped the bag halfway. Adjusted something inside with the methodical patience of a person entirely at peace with their process. Closed it with a finality that seemed to settle the question before she even answered it.

~
~

"For women."

~
~

A silence followed that was less empty than full — full of **John's** effort to formulate a response that was simultaneously accurate and survivable.

~
~

He moved carefully through the landscape of luggage — each step deliberate, the way you step around things you respect even if you do not understand them. He reached down and lifted a dress. Turned it in his hands. Looked at another. Then a third.

~
~

"...You told me you have nothing to wear."

~
~

The evidence surrounding him did not support this testimony. It could not have supported it with any more thorough contradiction had it tried.

~
~

A quiet smile pulled at the corner of his mouth — involuntary, helpless, the smile of a man who has lost a battle he did not know he was in. He set the dress down. Shook his head, slowly, once.

~
~

Then — without argument, without further comment, without the speech he had perhaps been composing — he crouched beside the nearest unopened suitcase, unzipped it, and began to help.



Not because he had been convinced. Not because he understood. But because the decision had already been made — the real one, the one that mattered — and everything else was simply detail.



Across from him, **Sophia** did not look up. But she noticed. She noticed in the way you notice the things you have been quietly hoping for — not with surprise, but with a warmth that settles somewhere low and steady. He was not resisting. He was here. Entirely, without reservation. With her.



She continued folding. But now, just barely visible at the corner of her mouth — a small, private smile.



And the apartment — buried under its mountains of luggage, impractical and overloaded and entirely itself — was no longer just an apartment. It was a beginning wearing the disguise of chaos.

SCENE EIGHT

The Flight

The plane climbed steadily, and Britain fell away beneath it — slowly at first, and then all at once, the grey rooftops dissolving into grey cloud, layer after layer swallowing what had been familiar until there was nothing left to swallow and the sky above was clean and clear and entirely indifferent to what had just been left behind.



*For a moment — just one, before the last of the cloud closed beneath her — **Sophia** thought she could still see it. The rooftops. The particular density of a city's streets from above. The small bright squares of windows behind which other people were sitting in their own rooms, reading their own books, living their own unremarkable Tuesdays with no knowledge of this departure and no reason to have any. She pressed her hand lightly to the cold glass. As if touching it were a kind of farewell. Then the cloud came up like a curtain being drawn, and London disappeared, completely and without ceremony, into the white.*



The cabin settled into its long hum — that low, persistent note that becomes, after a while, not a sound but simply the sound of being in motion. Of crossing. Of the space between one place and another.



John was asleep. Not lightly — completely. His head resting at a slight angle, his breathing slow and even, his face entirely unguarded in the way that sleep alone permits. His body had accepted the journey in a way his mind had not yet had the chance to consider. Some part of him, she thought, had already arrived.



Sophia remained at the window. Awake and still, her hands resting loosely in her lap, her attention entirely outward. Not tense. Simply alert. Present in the particular way that comes when you are in the middle of something you cannot yet name.



For a long time there was only the cloud. White and seamless and without feature — a nothingness so complete it became its own kind of landscape.



Then — gradually, the way certainties emerge from uncertainty — it began to break.



Shapes appeared through the gaps. Dark at first, formless, like shadows beneath very still water. Then definition came, and with it, the unmistakable geography of something massive and ancient.



Mountains.



Not the gentle, softened hills of the English countryside. Not the polite elevations of a landscape that has made peace with being inhabited. These were something else entirely — wide and dry and absolute, rising from the earth with the patience of things that have been rising for longer than there have been people to watch them. They did not welcome the eye. They simply were — present and vast and entirely indifferent to being observed.



Sophia leaned closer to the glass.



She had expected sand. She had carried, without fully knowing it, the flat and featureless image that distance creates — emptiness, heat, a landscape made of absence. What she was looking at was not that. What she was looking at was its opposite — terrain of enormous presence, of density and weight and depth, of something that had refused, across all the years of its existence, to be softened.



And the light. The light was different in a way she could not yet articulate. It did not filter through haze or cloud or the polite diffusion of a northern sky. It arrived directly — clean, intense, making everything it touched more sharply itself. It did not illuminate the mountains so much as argue with them. And the mountains held their ground.



A thread of that light reached through the glass and touched her face. She felt it on her skin — warmer than she had expected, more immediate.



She glanced sideways. **John** slept on, undisturbed, his breathing steady, his face serene. As though none of this — not the mountains, not the light, not the fact that they were crossing the sky toward a life neither of them had yet lived — required anything of him at this particular moment.

~

"How...?"

she whispered. Not expecting an answer. Simply unable to hold the question inside.

~

How could he sleep, when the world outside the window had already become so completely different?

~

She turned back to the glass. The mountains were closer now — more detailed, more present, more themselves. She looked at them the way you look at something you are beginning to understand you will need to learn.

~

And in that looking, something settled inside her. Not peace exactly. Not readiness. Something quieter than both. The recognition — arriving slowly, without drama — that this was not a journey with a return ticket built into its logic. That what lay ahead of her was not an adventure to be lived and then folded away.

~

This was a life. Beginning now. Irrevocably, and in the most ordinary possible way, beginning now.

~

Nothing after this would be the same.

She pressed her forehead lightly to the cold glass and let herself look, for a long moment, at the mountains below — at their stillness, their scale, their absolute refusal to be anything other than what they were.

And she held that.

SCENE NINE

Arrival in Oman

The airplane door opened — and the heat did not wait.

It entered the way only heat enters — not through the door but through every opening at once, filling the space immediately, completely, without introduction. Alive in a way that London's air had never been alive.

~

Hot. Immediate. **Unavoidable.** The kind of heat that does not politely offer itself but simply wraps around you, presses against you, makes itself known with the directness of something that has always been here and has no particular interest in your adjustment.



Sophia stopped mid-step at the top of the stairs. The heat hit her like a wall she had walked into without seeing — not violent, but total. Not cruel, but entirely without consideration for her expectation of something gentler.



She blinked. Drew a breath that was also, somehow, warmer than the last one.



"John..."



She reached for the nearest paper — a boarding pass, a customs form, something — and began to fan herself with it.



"This is not warm."

A measured pause.

"This is fire."



John came down behind her. He lifted his hand against the sun instinctively, squinting into the brightness with eyes that were not yet calibrated for this quality of light. And then — just for a moment — something moved across his face that was not a thought but a feeling. Something older than thought.



It was not a memory he could hold in his hands — not a specific scene or moment, nothing he could point to and say: there, that. It was more physical than that. The weight of this particular light, the specific pressure of this heat against the skin — something in his body recognised it before his mind had the language to follow. He had been very young the last time he stood beneath a sky like this. Young enough that the memory had bypassed the mind entirely and lived somewhere deeper. In the chest. In the hands. In the way the eyes knew, without being told, to narrow.



He looked ahead — at the tarmac, at the low buildings, at the shimmer rising from the ground — as though searching for something familiar in a face he had not seen for a long time.



Then, quietly — almost to the air itself:



"I don't remember it being this hot... when I was a child."

A pause. Something almost like a smile.

"Or maybe... I forgot."



"How do people live in this?"



The ground beneath them **shimmered** — the tarmac breathing its heat upward in slow, visible waves. The light here had no interest in being soft. It was full and complete and arrived without apology, asking the eyes to meet it on its own terms.



And beneath the heat, beneath the brightness, the air carried something else — something that had no precise name in any language she owned. Not the scent of food, not of the sea, not of anything mechanical. Something drier. Older. The particular smell of a place that has existed long before it was named. Something that belonged to the earth here, to the stone and the dust and the long accumulated heat of it — waiting, without impatience, to be breathed in.



The airport was smaller than she had imagined. Quieter. No wall of sound coming at her — no urgent **announcements**, no crowd moving with the collective, purposeful rush of people who believe they are all late. People moved here — but they moved without **urgency**. As though the day was long enough. As though time, in this place, had not been divided into the same sharp intervals it had been given elsewhere.



She tightened her hand on the strap of her bag. Gathered herself.



"John..."

A pause just long enough to carry the weight of what she was not saying.

"What if we get lost?"



John looked at the signs overhead. Read them carefully, with the particular steadiness of someone who solves problems by beginning with the first one in front of him.

"Exit."

"Taxi."



He looked at her. Calm. Without false reassurance — but without doubt either. Simply certain that forward was possible, even if the way was not yet entirely clear.

"We'll take it step by step."

~

Not fast. Not perfect. But forward.

~

Sophia drew a breath. Let it out. She was not convinced exactly. But she was willing — which, she was beginning to understand, was sometimes the more useful of the two.

~

And somewhere in the heat and the brightness and the air that carried its ancient, nameless scent — something inside her had already begun to shift. Slowly. Without announcement. The way all real changes begin.

SCENE TEN

Airport / Luggage & First Realization

The luggage belt moved in its slow, patient circle — indifferent, unhurried, offering its contents one at a time to whoever was waiting.

~

John stood at the edge of it. Focused. Watching each bag as it came into view, leaning forward slightly as the conveyor turned.

~

His bag appeared. He reached for it, lifted it down, set it beside him.

Then another. Then another.

~

Sophia stood just behind him. Watching. Not the belt — him.

~

Then more bags came. Then more still. The pile beside them grew with a kind of inexorable momentum — each addition requiring a slight rearrangement of what had come before, a subtle expansion of the perimeter of their claimed territory on the airport floor.

~

John stepped back. Looked at what had accumulated. Took inventory.

One bag. Two. Five. Eight. Ten.

~

A long silence.



Then, in a voice pitched precisely at the threshold between being heard and not being heard — the voice of a man **muttering** to himself while fully intending to be overheard:



"Every day you say you have nothing to wear..."



His gaze moved slowly, almost ceremonially, across the mountain range of luggage surrounding them.



"...and yet... you brought London."



Sophia heard him. She processed the statement. She elected, with the serenity of someone who considers the matter entirely settled, not to engage with it. Because something else had taken her attention completely.



Across the arrivals hall — at a distance that made the details soft but the impression clear — a figure stood waiting.



A woman. Still. Not searching the crowd, not checking a phone, not leaning against anything for support. Simply standing — with the quality of presence that belongs to people who are entirely certain of where they are and have no need to demonstrate it. Her **hijab** was neat, her posture composed, her stillness not passive but active — the stillness of someone who has chosen it.



*She was not performing waiting. She was simply there — the way mountains are there, the way water is there — occupying her space with a completeness that had nothing to do with effort. There was something in her bearing that **Sophia** noticed immediately, the way you notice something that is not common. A steadiness that did not come from certainty about the future but from deep familiarity with herself. The kind that is not performed. The kind that simply is.*



The woman raised her hand — a single, unhurried gesture — and waved.



Sophia's eyes narrowed slightly. Recognition moved through her — slow and quiet, like light filling a room when a curtain is drawn back.



"That's her..."



John turned — following the line of her gaze — but before he could respond, **Sophia** was already moving. Walking through the crowd with the particular certainty of someone who has seen where they are going and no longer needs to think about how to get there.

SCENE ELEVEN

First Meeting / Thuraya

They walked toward her — the crowd thinning between them with each step, the distance closing in the unhurried way of things that are meant to meet.

~

As they drew close, **Sophia** extended her hand — and then, almost imperceptibly, paused.

~

Something had reached her before the woman had. Something in the air immediately around her — arriving softly, without announcement.

~

Oud. But different from **John's**. His carried depth — dark, resinous, the kind that settles into a room and stays. This was something lighter in register, less dense, moving the way good things move when they are not trying to be noticed. **Balanced**. Quietly **feminine**. Present for only a moment — then gone, leaving behind it the faint impression of something considered. Something chosen carefully.

~

"I'm **Thuraya**."

~

Her voice carried the same quality as her presence — unhurried, clear, entirely without pretence. The voice of someone who has never needed to fill space with unnecessary volume.

~

"Welcome to **Oman**."

~

The words were simple. But the way she said them — without ceremony, without performance — gave them a weight that ceremony would have diminished. This was not a greeting. It was an opening.

~

John stepped forward.

"I'm **John**."

A slight gesture toward **Sophia**.

"This is my wife, **Sophia**."

٢٧
ع

Sophia smiled — genuine, a little uncertain at the edges, the smile of someone who is still orienting herself but is willing to be present anyway.

"Nice to meet you."

٢٨
ع

Thuraya nodded — warmly, simply.

"Nice to meet you too."

٢٩
ع

Her gaze moved — briefly, almost casually — to the sprawl of luggage that had accumulated behind them. It was a great deal of luggage. It was, in fact, an impressive amount of luggage for any reasonable calculation of what two people required for a new chapter of their lives.

٣٠
ع

A small smile — knowing, unhurried — moved across her face.

٣١
ع

"Do you need help with the bags?"

٣٢
ع



Did You Know?

Oman's Modern Renaissance (1970)

Remember John's words in this chapter: "They're opening schools, building roads, starting something new"? That's an accurate picture of real 1970s Oman. When Sultan Qaboos bin Said took power, the country had only three schools for 900 students, nine health clinics, and just six miles of paved road. Within a few years, schools, hospitals, and roads reached every corner of the country, in what became known as the "Blessed Renaissance."

Source: en.wikipedia.org · pbs.org

PALM

Palm Two

The First Walk in the Village

SCENE ONE

The First Night

The room did not announce itself. It simply was — quiet in the way that unfamiliar places are quiet before they have been lived in, before a life has settled into them and made them its own. The **stillness** had weight to it. Not emptiness. Expectation.

~

The walls were clay — **uneven**, warm at the surface, their imperfections left exactly where they were, as though someone had decided long ago that a mark made by a hand was worth keeping. In the corner, a small **qandeel** gave what light it had — soft, trembling slightly, making the shadows on the walls breathe rather than stay fixed. On the floor, a **bisat**, pressed thin from years of use. No bed. Nothing assembled from catalogues. Only what was needed — and nothing more.

~

The window was open. The night entered freely.

~

Sophia stood near it, her hand resting lightly against the wooden frame — not gripping, just touching, the way you touch something when you need to be sure of the ground beneath you. The air came in layers she could not immediately separate. **Oud** first — deep, unhurried, the kind that changes a room. Then something lighter beneath it — **musk**. And below both of those — something she recognised without knowing its name. **Luban**. She had smelled it once in London, inside a small box that had lived on a table and been left, carefully, untouched.

~

She stood with the window and breathed it in — not trying to name what she was inhaling, simply receiving it. Some things arrive too complete to be taken apart. You can only let them in and hold them, for as long as they stay.

~

Behind her, **John** was asleep. Entirely, without resistance — the journey had settled into him the moment the door closed. His breathing was slow and even, punctuated now and then by a sound that

was almost a snore. Almost. **Sophia** glanced at him once. Something pulled briefly at the corner of her mouth. Then she turned back to the window.



The village was not silent. But it moved differently than the cities she had known. Footsteps passed somewhere below — unhurried, purposeful. Voices drifted low and calm through the air. And then, from a distance that might have been a street or a hillside —



The **adhan** for Fajr.



*It rose — not breaking the quiet, but becoming part of it. Deepening it, the way a voice that knows how to enter a room does not disturb it but adds to it. **Sophia** went still. Not from fear. From the simple fact that she did not yet have a place to put this sound. It arrived the way certain things arrive when you are in a country you have not yet learned to read.*



Then — movement. Footsteps, faster now, multiple. Small.

Children.

Sophia leaned forward slightly, her eyes searching the path below. Small figures moved through the dim light, their voices carrying up —

"ياالله ياالله صلوااا"

"أنا أسبق! أنا أسبق!"



*She watched them. They were running toward the mosque — not being pushed, not being called by a voice behind them, but moving under their own **urgency**, with the energy of children who have somewhere to be and have decided, entirely on their own, that it matters. There was no **obligation** in their voices. No complaint. Only the particular joy of people who have somewhere to go in the dark.*



She watched them until the path below was empty again. Then stayed at the window — thinking.



If they wake before the sun does — if they move through the dark this willingly —



She did not finish the thought. But something settled inside her — quietly, without announcement. The specific feeling of a question that has decided it wants to be answered.



She looked once more at **John**, entirely absent from this dark and moving world outside. She almost said something. She didn't.

~

"Where are the girls?" she murmured, to no one. "And the women?"

Not concern. **Curiosity** — the precise, alert kind. She knew she would ask **Thuraya**. She would ask everything.

~

At some point, without deciding to, without noticing when it happened — she sat down beside the wall. And sleep reached her at last.

Because tomorrow — she would walk this place.

SCENE TWO

Letj

The sun had already decided it was morning by the time **Sophia** stepped outside. It offered no gradual transition, no northern sky's gentle easing of dark into light. It simply was — present and certain, spreading across the village without apology, revealing everything it touched exactly as it was. No flattery. No softening.

~

Thuraya stood waiting near the path. Entirely still. At ease in herself the way water is at ease in a vessel — filling the space completely without effort or announcement. She did not check the hour or glance at the road. She simply waited, as though time here had agreed to move at a different pace and she had accepted the arrangement long ago.

*"Ready?" she asked. **Sophia** nodded. "Yes."*

~

They began walking. **John** came beside them, his attention moving freely between the path and everything it offered. The ground was **uneven** in the way that earth is uneven when it has not been forced to pretend otherwise. Not rough. Simply honest.

~

The houses stood close to the land — not placed upon it but growing from it, the way things grow when they have been in one place long enough to forget the difference between building and belonging. Clay walls held the same colour as the ground around them, the same warmth, the same refusal to be anything other than what they were. To walk between them was less like moving through a settlement and more like moving through something that had always been here and had simply, finally, been given a name.

~

*"Everything feels very open," **Sophia** said. "And very quiet."*

*"It's like the village is breathing slowly," John said. **Thuraya** glanced at him. "That is a good way to describe it."*



Then — from ahead — laughter. A group of girls, gathered in a loose circle at the side of the path. One of them held a stone. She threw it — a short, practiced arc — and it landed in a shape drawn on the ground. Precise **rectangles**, some single, some paired.



*"What are they doing?" **Sophia** slowed. **Thuraya** stopped beside her. "This is **letj**," **Sophia** repeated the word softly. "Letj..."*



Thuraya explained — the stone must land cleanly, the player must remember where it falls, then move through the squares without touching a single line. One foot in the single squares, both feet apart in the paired ones. Every step chosen. Every position held.



The girl moved through the shapes with the focus of a child who has played something so often that the body has absorbed it entirely — no hesitation at the edges, no second-guessing the weight of a foot. She bent, without losing her position, and lifted the stone from the square it had chosen. Then returned the way she had come, equally precise, equally certain. The ground keeping score. She had never given it reason to mark her.



Sophia exhaled without knowing she had been holding anything. *"That's not easy."* "No," **Thuraya** said. *"It isn't."* *"They don't need toys," **Sophia** said quietly. "They make their own," **Thuraya** replied.*



Sophia stepped forward. *"I want to try."* **John** turned immediately, a smile already arriving. *"Of course you do."*

One of the girls handed over the stone without ceremony. **Sophia** took it. Studied the ground. Threw. First square — good. Second — steady. Third — her foot found the edge of the line. She stopped. Looked down.



The girls burst into laughter — immediate, honest, entirely without **mockery**. The laughter of people who have failed this game themselves, a hundred times, and carry that knowledge warmly. **Sophia** laughed with them. *"I lost."* *"They are very good,"* she said, looking back at the girls. *"Better than us," **John** agreed.*



And then — without announcement — **Malood**. He came from somewhere, direct as always, and ran straight through the game. Through the lines. Over the shapes. The carefully drawn rectangles blurred and scattered in a single pass. The girls shouted — "**هيبه! مالود**!" — furious and delighted in equal measure.



Thuraya shook her head with patient affection. "*He doesn't follow rules.*" **John** crossed his arms, watching **Malood** with an expression that could only be described as **admiration**. "*I respect that.*" **Sophia** looked at him. "*You would.*"



*The girls were already redrawing the shapes — fingers in the dust, recreating what had been erased with the same care that had made it the first time. No debate about whether to continue. No decision required. They simply returned to it. And perhaps that — **Sophia** thought, watching them — was the thing most worth learning. Not the jumps. Not the stone. The returning.*

SCENE THREE

The Falaj

They walked further. The village continued to open in front of them — not all at once, but in the way a person opens: a little at a time, each layer offered only after the previous one had been received.



The sound reached them first. Water. At first barely there, almost lost beneath footsteps and distant voices. Then clearer — steady and **continuous**, carrying a rhythm that did not change with direction or distance. "*Do you hear that?*" **Sophia** slowed. **John** nodded. "*Yes.*"



They followed the sound. And then — the **falaj**.



Water moved through a narrow channel of stone — clear, uninterrupted, making no particular effort and wasting none. It did not rush. It did not pause. It simply flowed, with the calm certainty of something that has been doing this for longer than any person watching it has been alive, and that will continue long after the last person stops to look. The surface caught the light in small shifting patterns — not still, not turbulent. Something between the two. Something alive.



But the falaj was not alone. Women sat along its edges — hands steady, movements practiced. Some washed clothes, rinsing and wringing with the ease of people for whom the task has long since become simply the rhythm of a morning. Others scrubbed large metal pots, voices moving between conversation and laughter without interruption. Children played in the same water. Splashing freely. And just to the side — **Malood**. He stepped forward, lowered his head, and drank. Without consulting anyone.



"They are washing clothes there," **Sophia** said slowly. "And dishes," **John** added. "And the children are inside the water." A pause. "And the goat is drinking from it."

Malood lifted his head briefly. Blinkered. Returned to drinking. As though none of this required comment. **Sophia** exhaled. "They are using the same water for everything."



Across the channel, **Nasser** stood beside the pickup truck, pouring water over it in long arcs, scrubbing with focused patience. **Sophia** turned toward **John**. "Everything," she said again — not as complaint, but as the word for something she was still trying to hold.



Then **John** crouched at the edge. Placed both hands in the water. And washed his face. Cold. Immediate. He looked up — entirely refreshed, entirely unconcerned.

"**John!**" "What?" "You just washed your face in that!" "Yes." "People wash clothes there. And the goat is drinking from it." He wiped his face. "They wash everything in it. And the children drink from it."

Sophia froze. "They what?" He didn't look concerned. He looked — **thoughtful**. As though the falaj had just offered him a question he hadn't expected to find interesting.



One of the women had noticed them watching. She smiled and spoke in Arabic — easy, warm. Another joined in, adding something that made the first woman laugh. **Sophia** looked at **Thuraya**. "They're talking about us, aren't they?" "Yes." "What are they saying?" "Ablan... welcome." A pause. "And they are asking who is your husband."

Sophia's eyes widened. "Already?" **Thuraya** laughed softly. "It is normal here."



Sophia gave a small, uncertain wave. The women waved back, still smiling — with the warmth of people who have no reason to be anything other than exactly that.



She turned back toward the falaj. But her face had changed — the reactive expression of the early morning had shifted into something quieter. She was no longer reacting. She was looking. And there is a difference between those two things as large as the distance between watching a river and understanding that the river is what makes the valley possible. The same water. Different uses. No order imposed from outside. She didn't fully understand it yet. But she could see it working. And that — she was beginning to think — was always how understanding begins.

SCENE FOUR

Sadoo's Shop

They left the falaj behind — but it did not entirely leave them. Its sound continued somewhere beneath the village's other sounds: steady, present, like a sentence that continues below conversation. *"It's still there," John* said, glancing back. *"The falaj. It feels like it's moving with us. Like a long line running through everything."*

"That sounds unsettling." *"No. More like... it's watching," Sophia* looked at him. *"You're making friends with water now?" John* nodded — completely serious. *"Yes."*



They walked a few steps further — and then something hit him. Fast. Entirely without warning. **John** lost his **balance** entirely. The ground slipped. He fell straight into the falaj. The water received him with cold, democratic completeness.



A moment of silence — the kind that arrives before laughter. Then **Thuraya** laughed first. Then **Sophia**, helplessly. Then **John** himself, sitting in the water, still trying to understand what had happened. Beside him — **Malood**. Standing at the edge. Entirely unbothered. Regarding the situation with the golden, **philosophical** expression of a creature who has long since decided to accept whatever the world offers.



Thuraya pointed at **John**, still smiling. *"Your friend just bugged you."* *"I think... I chose the wrong friend."* *"No. Now you have two."* **Sophia** added — *"The falaj... and Malood."* **Malood** stepped closer. As if agreeing. *"No. Not Malood."* But **Malood** followed — one step, then another. **Persistent**. Certain that **John** was the correct direction. *"Can I return him?"* *"No," Thuraya* said calmly. *"He stays."*



They continued — **John** still wet, **Malood** still following — until around a bend in the path a small shop appeared. Simple. Open-fronted. Alive in the way that small shops in small places are alive — not with the curated energy of commerce, but with the specific warmth of a place that knows every person who walks through it. *"This is Sadoo's shop," Thuraya* said.



Before they reached the entrance, children arrived from every direction —

"Sadoo!!!!!!!"

"أنا باغي مينو!"

"أنا باغي داغوص!"

"أنا باغي ديو!"



The voices **overlapped** — all of them the most important person in the room simultaneously. *"Are they shouting?"* **John** listened. Then smiled. *"No. They're ordering."*



Inside, **Sadoo** moved between them with the composed **efficiency** of a man who has never been overwhelmed by any of this, because all of this is simply Tuesday. *"What is 'minu'?" "Chicken-flavoured snacks." "And 'daghoos'?" "Spicy sauce." "And 'Dew'?" "A drink."* **Sophia** turned toward **John**. *"Chicken... spicy... and soda?" "Balanced diet."*



A boy stepped forward proudly — barefoot, dusty — and dipped his snack into the daghoos without a moment's hesitation. **Sophia** watched. *"Children eat spicy food?"* **Thuraya** nodded. *"Yes. They start early."* **Sophia** looked at **John**. *"Our children would cry."*



Sophia picked up a colourful bottle. Read the letters slowly. *"Bo... ba?" "Boba,"* **Thuraya** said. *"A drink."* **Sophia** shook it slightly. *"It's gas?"* Before anyone could answer, a boy ran out, opened his bottle, and drank it in three enormous gulps. **Sophia** looked at **John**. *"This village will kill me."*



And then — something small and fast shot between their legs.

"Malood!"



*He was inside **Sadoo's** shop before anyone had time to respond — moving through the space with the single-minded energy of a creature who has located something interesting and intends to investigate it completely. He went at the shelves. He smelled everything. He jumped onto a low box, then onto another. Children shouted — "ياالله! مالود! برا" — and then followed him, which meant half the village was now involved. **Malood** ran outside, pursued by the children, the children's laughter, and the particular chaos that only he could generate from a standing start.*



Sophia laughed so hard she had to hold the door. **John** stood beside her, still wet, still followed at a careful distance by **Malood** upon his return — and somehow, in all of it, looking entirely at home.



From across the road — a figure. A boy. Standing still. Not laughing. Not running. Not joining any of it. He only watched. Quietly. Carefully. His eyes moving from **John** to **Sophia** to **Thuraya** and back — taking in everything without giving anything away.



Thuraya noticed him. Her voice became softer. *"Who is that boy?"* **John** asked. *"That is **Saeed**."* *"Why doesn't he come closer?"* **Sophia** asked. **Thuraya's** answer was simple. *"He is not allowed to go to school."*



Sophia looked at the boy — at his stillness, at the way he watched, at the quality of attention in his face. She did not ask another question. She simply looked. And something in her, quietly, filed the moment away.

SCENE FIVE

Thursday / Khamis

They stepped away from the shop. The voices of the children faded gradually — not disappearing, but drawing back into the village's deeper register, becoming one thread among many in a place that never entirely goes quiet. The path stretched forward, carrying them further into something they had not yet learned to name.



For a moment, no one spoke. **Sophia** walked slightly slower than before — her eyes no longer jumping from surface to surface but settling, taking longer. She was watching differently now. With more of herself in it.



Then she saw them. A man walking ahead. Tall — his **posture** firm, his steps heavy and certain against the ground. His **dishdasha** simple, marked by use rather than display. A **turban** wound tightly around his head. In his hand, a **ma'ool**, the metal edge darkened from years of actual use.



Behind him — a boy. Walking in the same rhythm as the man — same pace, same weight, same angle in the shoulders. Not the imitation of a child performing what he has seen. Something more absorbed than that — as though the pattern had moved past the mind entirely and settled into the body itself, the way habits settle when they have been practised long enough to stop being habits and become simply the way things are.



"Who is that?" **Sophia** asked quietly. *"That is **Khamis**."* She repeated the name. *"**Khamis**..."*



John stopped. *"Wait. Like... Thursday?"* **Thuraya** smiled. *"Yes."* *"You name people after days of the week?"* *"Sometimes. If the child is born on Thursday, he can be called **Khamis**. Friday — **Juma**."* **John** let out a small laugh. *"So you don't try to avoid Friday?"* **Thuraya** shook her head, **amused**. *"No."* *"Because it comes every week,"* **John** added. **Thuraya** laughed softly. *"Ya rabee..."*



But **Sophia** had already turned back to the boy. **Khamis** — still walking behind his father, step for step, without distraction. Without being a child in any of the ways she had expected children to be.

"This doesn't feel like a child," she said quietly. *"He looks older."* **John** nodded. *"Like he's thirty."*



"He's copying everything." "Yes," **Thuraya** said. "And his father?" "A farmer." "He works with him?" "Yes." The answer was simple. But it stayed — the way simple answers stay when they are carrying more than their words.



The man and the boy continued ahead, their *rhythm* unchanged. Not hurrying. Not slowing. Simply moving — the way the *falaj* moved, the way the morning moved — as though time here had made its own arrangements and the people had simply agreed to keep them. **Sophia** watched them until they had become small in the distance. Then said — not to anyone in particular — "I want to understand." **Thuraya** met her gaze. "You will."

SCENE SIX

Nahsher / Another World

They continued walking, leaving **Khamis** and his father to their path. The ground softened slightly underfoot — the dust giving way to shade, the air holding a different quality. Greener. Cooler at the edges. The particular temperature of a place where something is growing.



"Look!" **Sophia** said, lifting her eyes. Trees — a loose collection of them, their branches wide and heavy with **clusters** of fruit. Different shapes. Different colours. "Those are *farsadb* and *lamba*," **Thuraya** explained.



A group of boys stood near the trees. Already decided. One picked up a stone and threw it — a sharp arc, a crack of contact, leaves moving, fruit falling. Another stone flew. Another fruit came down. The others ran forward, collecting before the next throw was even in the air. No wasted movement. A system arrived at through **practice**, not planning.



"They're attacking the trees!" **Sophia** gasped. **Thuraya** laughed. "They are doing *nahsber*. They throw stones so the fruit falls." **John** repeated the word immediately, the way he always did with new words — carefully, giving each syllable its proper weight. "Nah... sber." **Sophia** smiled. "You are learning fast." **John** nodded seriously. "Let's go and... *nahsber*." **Thuraya** burst out laughing. "Maybe another day."



The boys had collected their fruit and were eating now — and with their fruit, something else. Something bright orange. Something that smelled sharp even from a distance.



Sophia blinked. "They put... salt and pepper... on mango?" **Thuraya** nodded. "And chili." **Sophia** looked at **John**. **John** looked at the mango. Then at **Sophia**. Then — because he was the kind of man

who believed in trying things — he reached forward and took a small piece.



He stopped. Chewed slowly. His expression passed through several stages. Then, finally — a slow smile. *"It's... strange. But good."* **Sophia** shook her head. She did not try a piece. But she watched **John** with the particular expression of a person who is revising their understanding of someone they thought they knew entirely.



As the sky began to turn orange, they walked back toward the apartment. The village settled around them — **Sadoo** closing his shop, children drifting toward their houses, the sounds of the afternoon folding quietly into evening.



*And somewhere behind them — still there, still standing, still watching — was **Saeed**. He had not moved. He had not joined. He had only watched, the whole afternoon, with the particular stillness of someone who is taking in everything and giving nothing away yet. Still silent. Still thinking. Dreaming, perhaps, of a place called school.*



That night, **Sophia** sat on the bisat and looked at the room around her — the clay walls, the qandeel, the open window, the warm dark beyond it. Then she looked at **John**.



"John... I think we didn't move to another country."

John looked at her. *"Where did we move?"*

She smiled. *"We moved to another world."*



And somewhere in the village, **Malood** bleated. **Sadoo's** door clicked shut. Children went home. And **Saeed** dreamed quietly of a place called school.



Did You Know?

The Falaj Irrigation System

In this chapter the falaj is used for drinking, washing, and watering animals all at once, under an unwritten but strict order. This system is real and ancient: UNESCO added "Aflaj Irrigation Systems of Oman" to its World Heritage list in 2006, and archaeological evidence traces its roots to around 2500 BCE. The falaj uses gravity alone to carry water from underground springs, governed by fair community rules passed down through generations of Omani villages.

Source: whc.unesco.org · en.wikipedia.org

PALM

Palm Three

The First Day at School

SCENE ONE

The Assembly Yard

The school did not announce itself. It appeared the way the village had — without fanfare, without any effort to be distinguished from what surrounded it — offering itself simply as the next thing along the path. Stone and clay. **Uneven** walls that carried the marks of their own making, not hidden but held, the way a face holds the years that have crossed it. Nothing polished. Nothing pretending.



Two long classrooms made of mud brick. A small yard in front. A wooden door that made a loud sound every time it opened — as though it wanted to be heard, as though it considered itself part of the announcement. Inside, wooden desks, some old, some newer, all with scratches and names carved into them by children who had wanted to leave something of themselves behind.



The blackboard was not very black. And the chalk was not very white. But for the children of Al-Qurawashiyah, this place was something new. Something **important**.



That morning, the village moved differently. Mothers walked with their children. Some boys ran. Some girls walked slowly, holding their books like **treasures**. Some children were excited. Some were scared. Some wanted to go home before they had even arrived.



Inside, **Thuraya** stood near the board, arranging the chalk, cleaning the table with her hand — the particular preparation of a teacher who has been in this room before and knows that what happens in the next hour will matter. She heard footsteps. Then many footsteps. Then noise. A lot of noise. She smiled. *"They are coming,"* she said, to herself.



John stood near the door, holding a book like a soldier holding a map — with more confidence than was entirely justified by the situation. **Sophia** stood next to him, her dress simple and long, her hair covered with a light scarf. She looked around the room and whispered — *"I feel like I am about to meet one hundred small judges."*

John smiled. *"They are not judges. They are students."*

"They look dangerous," she replied.



They stepped inside through the wide blue wooden doors — the same shade of blue that **Sophia** had noticed along every threshold in this village. A large open room. A **bisat** pressed flat across the floor. Walls that curved slightly, forming natural edges. A ceiling fan turning slowly above — more out of habit than necessity. Wooden tables. Simple chairs. Shelves carrying books and notebooks in the particular disorder of things that are actually used.



"This is the teachers' room," **Thuraya** said. **Sophia** moved through it slowly. *"It's different,"* she said — not as criticism, but as the honest statement of someone still deciding what different means. **John** ran his hand along the edge of a wooden table. Felt the grain. *"It's enough,"* he said.



The classroom was even simpler. Stone walls. A blue wooden door. A single window through which the light entered directly — not filtered, not softened, just present. A few wooden **benches**. Open space.



***Sophia** stood in the center and looked — at the walls, at the window, at the space. An empty classroom has its own particular quality. Not emptiness. The specific silence of a held breath — the feeling of something about to begin that has not yet been given permission to. She felt it. This room was ready. Whether she was, was another question.*



They moved back outside into the **assembly yard**. Wide. Flat. Firm from years of feet. Near the front stood a wooden pole. A folded cloth at its base. *"The flag,"* **Thuraya** said.



John and **Sophia** unfolded it together — slowly, deliberately — the colours emerging as the fabric opened: red, white, and green, the **emblem** at the centre standing clear. Against the clay and dust and earth tones surrounding it — the flag did not blend. It stood. For a moment, all three of them were still.



Then — the sound of running feet. Children pouring into the yard — their energy arriving before them, dust lifting behind their steps, voices rising. They were not being pushed or called. They were coming because they had decided to come. They reached the yard and slowed, arranging themselves with the loose, practiced order of people who know where they are supposed to be.



Sophia stepped forward — **instinctively**. *"Why are you late?"* The boys answered quickly, in Arabic, faces bright. **Sophia** turned to **Thuraya**. *"What did they say?"* *"They had a **Qur'an** circle before school."*



Sophia looked at them. Not **reluctant**. Not distracted. Not waiting to be entertained. Simply present — as though the decision to be here had been made long before this particular morning, and what remained was only to begin. This was not a school waiting to be given life. It already had its own. She and **John** had not been invited to start something. They had been invited in.

SCENE TWO

The Students

The first children entered — and they did not enter quietly. They did not sit quietly. They came like birds: talking, laughing, pushing, some heading directly for the nearest seat, some heading for the one farthest from the front, some apparently heading for no particular seat at all and simply landing wherever the momentum of their morning had carried them.



Thuraya clapped her hands once. Not loud — but strong. The sound of it had a specific quality, the quality of something that has been practised until it no longer requires effort. *"Sit down, please."* Some sat. Some didn't. Some sat, then stood again.



Then came a boy. Small. Thin. Dusty. With eyes full of ideas that no teacher has ever been glad to see. **Thuraya** noticed him immediately. *"**Mansoor**,"* she said — just the name, with the particular weight of someone who has said this name many times and is prepared to say it many more. **Mansoor** smiled. The kind of smile that means **trouble**. He sat — on the wrong chair. Then moved. Then moved again. Then turned around. Then whispered. Then laughed. Then fell from the chair.



John watched all of this like a man watching a film he cannot believe is real. **Sophia** leaned toward him. *"That one will kill us."* **Thuraya** nodded, without looking away from the room. *"Yes. But slowly."*



More children entered. A boy with very straight posture sat in the front row — his back straight, his book straight, his pencil straight. Everything about him arranged with the seriousness of someone who has arrived prepared and intends to remain that way. **Thuraya** smiled. *"Ah... **Abmed**."* **Ahmed** nodded seriously. Next to him sat **Ali** — looking at the board as though it were the most interesting thing in the world, his eyes sharp, his face calm. **Thuraya** said quietly to **John**, *"That one is very clever."*



Then came **Khalil**. He smiled at everyone. Sat. Then stood. Then helped someone. Then whispered something. Then laughed. **Thuraya** knew this type very well. Helpful. But **dangerous**.



Then came the girls. **Noura** entered and immediately said, *"Where do I sit?"* Before anyone answered, she added — *"Is this my book? Is this my chair? Is today a long day?"* **Sophia** blinked. *"She is fast."* Then came **Mathila** — holding papers and pencils, distributing them to other girls without being asked. *"Here. Take."* Then **Salima, Rahma, and Marwa** arrived together, shy, quiet, sitting close to each other as though they had agreed in advance to face whatever this was as a unit.



The classroom was now full. Noisy. Alive — alive in the specific way that rooms become alive when they are full of people who have not yet been asked to be quiet and are using every remaining second of that freedom.



Thuraya went to the front. *"Good morning."* The children answered — in Arabic. She smiled. *"Today... we will learn something new."* **Mansoor** raised his hand immediately. *"Are they the new teachers?"* He pointed at **John** and **Sophia**. *"Yes,"* **Thuraya** said. **Mansoor** looked at them for a long moment. *"They look strange."* The class laughed. **Sophia** put her hand on her chest. *"Thank you?"* **John** laughed. **Thuraya** said — *"This is Mr. John. And this is Ms. Safiya."*



Some children whispered the name back to themselves — "Safiya..." — trying the shape of it, the way children try new words: quietly, privately, before committing to them in public. The children of the village would not call her Sophia. They would call her Safiya. Only John and Thuraya would use the other name. And Sophia — hearing herself become someone slightly different in this particular room, in this particular place — found that she did not mind at all.

SCENE THREE

Good Morning / The First Word

John stepped forward. He picked up the chalk. Wrote on the board — two letters, then more, then a complete word: *HELLO*. He turned and faced them. *"Good morning."*



Silence. The children stared at him. At the word on the board. At the word coming out of his mouth. He said it again. *"Good morning."* **Thuraya** said, in Arabic — *"Say: Good morning."* Some said it. Some said something close to it. Some said something else entirely. And then —



Mansoor raised his voice, with the confidence of a person who is entirely certain they have it right: *"Good mourning!"*



The class laughed. **John** laughed too, the laugh of a teacher who has just been reminded that language is also sometimes very funny. "*Close enough*," he said.



Sophia picked up the chalk. Wrote on the board: *My name is...* She pointed to herself. "*My name is Safiya.*" The children tried. "*My name is...*" "*My name is...*"



Then **Mansoor** stood — with the full dignity of a person making an important announcement — and said: "*My name is monster.*"



Khalil laughed so hard he almost fell off his bench. **Sophia** covered her mouth. Then composed herself. "*No, no, no. Mansoor. Not monster. Mansoor.*" **Mansoor** considered this for a moment — genuinely, as though weighing the options. Then said — "*My name is Mansoor.*" **John** clapped. "*Very good!*"



Then **Ahmed** said perfectly, precisely, with the posture of someone who had been practicing — "*My name is Ahmed.*" **Ali** said, "*My name is Ali.*" **Mathila** said, "*My name is Mathila.*"



And then **Noura** stood — and said: "*My name is Noura. And this is my friend. And this is my book.*" **Sophia** blinked. Then laughed — genuine, surprised. "*Very good. Very... detailed.*"



The lesson continued. "*I am a student.*" "*I am happy.*" "*I am here.*" Some children said it right. Some said it wrong. Some shouted. Some whispered. And **Mansoor** — inevitably, magnificently — stood on his chair and announced, "*I am tall!*" He was not. **John** tried to keep order. **Sophia** tried to smile. **Thuraya** tried to survive.



Then — a sound from the yard. "*Loaaaaaε!*" **Malood** — walking straight into the yard as though he had been expected. He stopped near the students, looked around with his characteristic composure, and then made the sound again. "*Loaaaaaε!*" For one second — silence. Then the students broke into laughter — entirely, completely, with the full-bodied joy of children who have been holding themselves together and have just been given an excellent reason not to.



Sophia blinked. Then laughed with them. **John** shook his head slowly. "*Of course he came.*" **Malood** took a few steps forward. Entirely comfortable. Entirely at home.



Sophia looked at him. Then back at the students. And in the specific way that good teachers are gifted — the ability to find the lesson inside the **chaos** — she knew exactly what to do. She pointed at

Malood. "This..." A deliberate pause. "...is a *goat*."



The laughter made room. The students quieted enough to listen. "Goat," she repeated. Once. Clearly. One boy tried — "Goot." Another followed — "Goat." Then more. The word moved through the rows, uneven at first, then stronger. "Goat!" **Malood** made his sound again at precisely the right moment. The students laughed — and repeated. Louder. "Goat! Goat!" **Thuraya** stepped forward sharply — "مو هوش! مو جاكم!" The students straightened. The smiles didn't disappear. They just moved inward. **John** leaned toward **Sophia**. "Well... that worked." She nodded. "Yes." It was not a perfect start. It was a real one.

SCENE FOUR

The Way to School / Marhoon and Khamis

The path to school was no longer the same path. Not physically — the ground was unchanged, the houses stood where they had always stood. But the path had been filled. Students moved along it in the particular way of children who belong to a direction: some ahead, some behind, some running for no reason and then stopping for no reason, their voices filling the space the way voices fill a space when no one has thought to limit them.



Behind them — **Malood**. Walking. Then stopping. Then suddenly running. "لمااااا ع!" A few boys turned back and laughed. "جاء معنا!" Another shouted — "خلوه يحي!" And **Malood**, receiving this as the invitation it was, followed. Not because he had been claimed. Because he had claimed them. There is a difference, and he understood it completely.



Ahead, near the edge of the path — two figures. **Marhoon**. And beside him, **Khamis**.



***Marhoon** stood with the stillness of a man who has no need to move in order to be present. One hand resting on his *ma'ool*, his eyes moving across the passing students with the careful attention of someone who reads the world through observation rather than conversation. His face carried its usual weight — not anger, something older. The *gravity* of a man who has decided how things should be and has been living that decision long enough to believe it completely.*



Khamis stood just behind him. Same posture. Same stillness. But his eyes moved differently — watching the younger students with something between recognition and restraint. A group of boys ran past them, laughing, their steps uneven and joyful, failing entirely to look serious.



Marhoon's voice came — not loud, but heavy. "شففت؟ يعلموا الصغيرين يجيو كما الهوش." Each word placed carefully. The voice of a man who does not need volume because he has something

stronger than volume. "خطف قدامي... لا نشوف عليهم."



The boys felt it — not the words, but the weight behind them — and adjusted. Their laughter moved inward. Their steps became slightly less chaotic. Slightly less visibly chaotic. Which was the point.



Then **Malood** walked past them. "Loaaaaa!" This time **Khamis** could not hold it. A small laugh escaped — quick, soft, gone almost before it arrived. **Marhoon** turned his head the smallest possible amount. Just enough. **Khamis** straightened instantly. His face returned to something approaching stillness. Approaching — but not quite reaching.



Sophia, John, and Thuraya watched from a distance. "What did he say?" **Thuraya** translated calmly. "He said they are teaching the younger ones to walk like chaos. And he told them to behave."



Sophia looked at the boys — still moving, still carrying their contained energy — and then at Khamis, straightening himself beside his father. This kind of discipline was not loud. It was not performed. It was everywhere — in the path, in the ground, in the way Khamis straightened when his father turned, in the way the boys slowed without being told twice. Everywhere. And entirely invisible to anyone who had not yet learned to look for it.

SCENE FIVE

Malood and the Morning Disaster

The morning arrived wearing the face of peace. This was its first and most significant lie.



Sophia was pulled from sleep not by light, not by the adhan, not by any of the sounds a morning in Al-Qurawashiyah had already taught her to expect — but by a sound that did not belong to morning. Too heavy. Too **deliberate. Unapologetic.**



Chewing. Slow. Rhythmic. *Chrrrkkk... chrrrkkk...* Entirely confident.



"**John...**" He shifted. Did not open his eyes. "Good morning... tea..." "**John.** There is something eating our house." One eye opened, barely, reluctantly. "If it is not a lion, I will sleep." The chewing grew louder. More certain. "**JOHN.**" This time he sat up.



They both turned toward the small table near the wall. And there — balanced on **John's** notebooks with the composure of a creature who has surveyed the available options and arrived at a

decision he is entirely at peace with — stood **Malood**. Chewing. The corner of a page disappeared into his mouth in a slow, **methodical** progression, as though he had a plan for the notebook and intended to see it through.



Silence. The specific silence of two people looking at something they are still in the process of believing.



Sophia broke first. *"No — no, no, no! That is PAPER!"* **Malood** looked at her. Paused — with what could only be described as consideration, as though weighing her objection against his own appetite. Then continued. With increased confidence, if anything.



John moved — out of bed, across the room, hand reaching for the notebook. *"Malood! Stop!"* He grabbed one end. **Malood** pulled the other. The paper tore — cleanly, decisively — half in **John's** hand, the other half completing its journey. **John** stared at what remained. The blank face of a man receiving news he already knew was bad. *"These were my lesson plans."* **Sophia** pressed both hands to her face. *"We are going to die in this village."*



Malood jumped from the table and ran. Naturally. **John** followed immediately. *"Come back! You are not a goat — you are a criminal!"*



They rushed outside — and then **Sophia** stopped. She looked at her hand. Empty in a way it had not been empty before. She looked at the ground. At the room behind her. At **John**.

"John..." "Yes?" "My ring..." He turned. Looked at her hand. The world went very still. *"It is gone."*



They both looked at the ground. At the bed. At the table. At the door. At each other. And then Sophia said the sentence that changes everything — quietly, with the specific calm of someone who has just understood something terrible: "Malood was here." John went very still. There was only one possible explanation. There was only one creature in the vicinity who could be responsible for anything missing, broken, eaten, or otherwise unaccounted for.

SCENE SIX

Commands, Chaos, and Control

They did not walk to find **Thuraya**. They ran — words coming out of **Sophia** in pieces, fast and breaking over each other: *"Malood ate my ring — he destroyed the notebooks — he ran —"* **Thuraya** stood. Her calm tightened — not disappearing, but compressing into something that moved faster. *"First, breathe."* They did not breathe. *"We will find him,"* she said, and moved.



The village was already awake to it. A single word moving between houses faster than anything else — *"The goat!"* They followed it to a neighbour's house, where a man stood at the door with the specific energy of someone for whom the sight before him had exceeded available vocabulary. *"Who owns this goat?!"* Inside — **Malood**. In the center of the room. Continuing. *"He took my food! My clothes! He broke my basket!"*



Sophia whispered, with the eerie calm of someone who has passed through the far side of distress — *"I want to disappear."* **John**, beside her, entirely serious: *"If he eats my passport, I will personally end this friendship."*



Malood saw them. And ran. Again. What followed was a **procession** of disaster. **Malood** led. They followed. Children joined, shouting and laughing, turning the chase into something dangerously close to celebration.



Then **Malood** turned and ran into their own house. Into the kitchen. Toward the large pot — and jumped. The pot fell. Rice spread across the floor. Meat followed. Sauce covered everything. The room froze. **Sophia** sat down first. **John** sat beside her. **Thuraya** closed her eyes, once, slowly. Then **Sophia** said: *"My lunch."* **Malood** looked at her. Chewed what he had. Unbothered. **Victorious**.



Much later — the ring still missing — **Thuraya** chose her words carefully. *"He probably... swallowed it."* Something inside **Sophia** sat down very quietly. That evening she said — not dramatically, not with complaint — *"I love Oman."* **John** nodded. *"We will never be bored."* **Thuraya** smiled. *"Welcome to village life."* And **Malood** slept — not like an animal that had caused everything described above, but like a king who has finished his day's work and found it good.



By the time they reached the classroom again, the story had already arrived — through eyes trying not to show that they knew, through mouths pressing inward with the effort of it. **Sophia** walked in — this time without imagining anything. Simply entering it. The actual room, with its actual students, in the actual aftermath of an actual morning. **John** stood to the side, holding what remained of his notebook: half a lesson plan, and the complete dignity of a man who has decided to find this funny rather than otherwise.



She looked at the students. Took one breath. *"Okay."* They looked at her immediately. She pointed toward the door — firmly. **"Stop."** Silence. They understood the **tone** before the word. She repeated it. **Thuraya** translated. The meaning landed. Then **Sophia** acted it out — a step forward, then a complete stop. *"Stop."* A boy stood. Took a step. Froze. *"Stop."* Others followed — standing, stepping, stopping — the room full of small people discovering the particular pleasure of choosing not to move.



She raised her hand. Shook her head. **"Don't."** A student near the front reached for something. She pointed gently. **"Don't."** He froze. Smiled. The room responded — voices beginning to repeat. **"Don't... Don't..."** **John** watched, impressed despite himself.



Then — **"LaaaaaE."** The class turned as one. **Malood.** At the door. Of course.



Sophia closed her eyes. One second. Then opened them — pointed directly at him — **"STOP."** The class held its breath. **Malood** did not stop. He walked in. The class **erupted.** **Sophia** raised her voice — **"STOP!"** — and the students repeated it, together, loudly, gleefully. **"STOP!"** **Malood** paused. One second. Then continued. **John** turned away. His shoulders moved. **"DON'T!"** — and the students, following — **"DON'T!"** Together. The room full of the word, the students full of it, the word belonging to them in a way it hadn't belonged fifteen minutes ago. **Malood** stopped. Actually stopped. And then — sat.



The class lost what remained of its composure. Laughter everywhere. Joy, full and unmanaged, filling the room to its ceiling. **Sophia** laughed too. Then pointed at the students — across the whole room. **"Good."** They repeated it immediately. **"Good!"** She nodded. **"Yes. Good."**



At the end of that day, the board was full. The floor was full of chalk. The air was full of voices. And everyone was tired — deeply, satisfyingly, completely tired.



When the children left, **John** sat down. **Sophia** sat beside him. They looked at each other. Then laughed. Then laughed more.



Sophia said — *"We are not ready."*

John said — *"Yes we are."*

Thuraya smiled. *"This,"* she said, *"is only the beginning."*



*Three words learned. Not from a textbook. Not from the lesson plan that was currently being digested somewhere in the village. From a goat who had apparently decided that if he was going to disrupt the first English lesson of the year, he might as well contribute to it. Stop. Don't. Good. Three words that had arrived through chaos, through laughter, through the specific combination of disaster and joy that **Malood** seemed to carry with him everywhere he went as his own particular form of pedagogy. The lesson had not gone as planned. It had gone as it went. And sometimes — not always, but sometimes — that is the better outcome.*

Did You Know?

The Flag of Oman

In this chapter, John and Sophia raise the Omani flag in front of the school for the first time. The flag itself is fairly young: Sultan Qaboos bin Said officially declared it on December 17, 1970, just months after taking power, replacing the old traditional plain red banner. White stands for peace, green for the fertile land and the Green Mountain, and red for the battles Omanis fought to defend their country.

Source: en.wikipedia.org · [britannica.com](https://www.britannica.com)

PALM

Palm Four

The Morning Departure to the Souq

SCENE ONE

The Morning Departure

The morning arrived in the village the way mornings here had learned to arrive — not with announcement, not with the noisy machinery of a city waking up, but by small degrees. The light slipped down the mountain first, washing the ridges in a pale gold. Then it reached the roofs. Then the walls. Then, finally, the paths — where it found the first pair of sandals already moving along the dust.



The air was **cool** — the kind of cool that only exists in the village before the sun decides to become itself. It carried the smell of **wet earth** from the places where the falaj had passed in the night, and beneath that, something quieter — the faint, lifting smell of bread being made in a house she could not see.



John stood at the wooden door of their small mud house, adjusting his watch and looking out at the dusty road. The watch kept perfect British time. The road did not. The road kept its own time, which was older, and which had never consulted anyone about how long a morning should take. "**Safiya**?" he called inside. "**Thuraya** said early. I think she meant... this early."



Inside, **Safiya** was bent over a large cloth bag, folding things into it with the particular **concentration** of someone who has been warned, several times, not to forget anything. Her hair was already tied back. Her scarf was already in place. She had been awake, in fact, since before the first of the three calls to prayer — though she would not have admitted this, because some mornings are private.



"I am coming," she said, without looking up. "I am only... confirming." "Confirming what?" "That we have everything." "We don't need everything." "We might." "Have you seen our luggage from the airport?" "That," **Safiya** said calmly, "was **relocating**. This is shopping."



John considered this distinction. He had, he decided, no safe response.



Before he could find one — something small, fast, and entirely without respect for the concept of closed doors shot between his legs and into the house.



"MALOOD." "Not again." "Yes again."



The little goat stood in the middle of the room — his legs slightly apart, his head raised, his entire **posture** the posture of a creature who had already decided, long ago, that this house was his, and that the two humans inside it were his reasonable **tenants**. He **surveyed** the room. He located the bag. He approached it with interest.



"No," **Safiya** said, without raising her voice. *"No, no, no. We are not doing this today."* **Malood** looked at her. Considered the statement. Then sat.



From outside, a woman's voice arrived — bright, exasperated, entirely familiar: *"Maloooood! Ta'al bna, ya majnoon sagbeer!"* *"That's **Azizah**,"* **John** said, recognising the voice of the aunt who lived three houses away and who spent, by **Safiya**'s estimate, approximately seventy percent of her waking hours looking for this particular goat. *"She sounds tired." "She is tired."*



Malood, receiving his name through the wall, stood. Looked at the door. Did not move. *"She sounds close,"* **Safiya** observed. *"She always sounds close,"* **John** said. *"And he always sounds confident."*



*There was something **Safiya** had begun to notice about **Malood** — something she could not yet put into words in any language she owned. He did not act like an animal who had been lost and was looking for home. He acted like an animal who had several homes, all of which were his, and who had not quite decided yet which of them deserved his presence this morning. This was not the **behaviour** of an animal being raised. It was the behaviour of an animal being **shared**. Which meant, **Safiya** was beginning to understand, that he was not anyone's goat. He was everyone's.*



John tied the bag shut. *"Time."* **Safiya** lifted it, tested its weight, accepted the verdict of physics, and handed half of it back to him. *"Share."* *"This is marriage,"* he said, accepting. *"This is arithmetic,"* she corrected.



They stepped out. **Malood** followed — not rushed, not reluctant, simply taking up the position behind them that he had apparently assigned to himself. **Azizah**'s voice came again, further away this

time, no longer hopeful. *"I think she has given up,"* John said. *"She has not given up,"* Safiya replied. *"She has only paused."*



They set off down the road. Three figures and a goat — **unhurried**, unbothered, already entirely part of the landscape they had arrived in only weeks before. And somewhere ahead, at the edge of the village, a pickup truck was waiting — and the morning was about to become something else entirely.

SCENE TWO

Dukkan Al-Hillah

Thuraya was waiting for them on the path — already arranged, already **composed**, looking at them with the patient amusement of a person who has watched foreigners arrive on this road many times before and has, by now, stopped being surprised by anything. *"Good morning."* *"Good morning,"* John returned. *"We brought... supplies."* *"Yes,"* **Thuraya** said, glancing at the bag. *"I see."*



She turned and began to walk. *"First — Dukkan Al-Hillah. We need rope. And a basket. And qit."* *"Qit?"* John repeated, carefully. *"You will see,"* she said — which, he was learning, was **Thuraya's** preferred method of teaching: let the thing itself do the work.



The shop was small. Not small the way a shop in London is small — **apologetically**, conscious of its modesty, its square metres measured and priced. This was small the way a thing is small when it has never considered being anything else. Its door stood open. Its front held wooden boxes of rice, sugar, tea — the **essentials** arranged not decoratively but practically, the way things are arranged when people are going to reach for them many times a day. On one wall hung **baskets** and ropes. In one corner, strung up like dried flowers at a very different kind of harvest — **awal** and **qashie'**, hanging in their salted, sunlit patience.



Behind the wooden counter — **Sadoo**. Smiling the particular smile he always smiled when customers entered: a smile that had nothing to do with commerce and everything to do with the simple, **habitual** pleasure of seeing faces he knew.



And then, before any human had entered — **Malood**. Who had gone ahead. Who had entered first. Who was already inside, examining the shelves with the unhurried, proprietary air of an **inspector** arriving on scheduled rounds.



Sadoo laughed — a full, warm laugh that filled the small shop entirely. *"Malood! shuftak! What do you want today, ya habibi?"* **Malood** looked at him. Did not answer. *"He does not answer,"* **Sadoo** explained, cheerfully, to no one in particular. *"He only takes."*



John, who had been looking for a word to start with, pointed to a bundle of green leaves resting on the counter. *"I... I want this."* A small silence. **Sadoo** looked at **Thuraya**. **Thuraya** looked at the leaves. **Sadoo** laughed again, more quietly this time. *"Tell him — this is **qit**."*



John repeated. *"Qit."* *"Qit,"* **Thuraya** corrected, her smile widening. *"Not 'kit'. **Qit**."* He tried again. The sound was slightly better. *"And what is qit?"* **Safiya** asked. **Thuraya** turned to her. Gentle. Careful. Letting the joke land without cruelty. *"Food for goats."*



Safiya looked at the leaves. At **John**. At **Malood**, who had suddenly become interested in the conversation. *"John. You just **requested** goat food."* *"With confidence,"* **Thuraya** added, generously. *"Which is important in a new language."* **John** took this on the chin. *"Then I will buy it. For **Malood**. So the lesson is not **wasted**."* *"That,"* **Thuraya** said, *"is teacher thinking."*



Sadoo wrapped the qit in string. **John** paid. He lowered the bundle toward **Malood**, who took it with an expression that could only be described as **smug**.



Safiya, meanwhile, had stopped in front of the hanging awal. She tilted her head. She tilted it the other way. The fish did not become more **appetizing** from either angle. *"Thuraya... how do people eat this?"* **Thuraya**'s eyes were patient. *"Slowly."* A pause. *"And with rice."* Another. *"You will like it later."* *"Later when?"* *"Later when you are hungry enough."*



They bought rope. They bought the basket. They carried their purchases out into a morning that had grown slightly warmer, slightly brighter, slightly more itself. **Malood** walked behind them with the qit in his mouth, proudly — as though he, personally, had conducted the transaction and was now **escorting** his purchase home.

SCENE THREE

Uncle Nasser's Pickup

At the end of the road — the truck.



It rested at the edge of the path the way a working animal rests: not **idle**, but **pausing**. The kind of pause that is not absence of motion, but **preparation** for it.



Safiya looked at it, and then looked at it more carefully, because her eyes had arrived faster than her understanding. She had seen old vehicles in England. She had, once or twice, ridden in them. But those had been old in the **sentimental** way — kept because someone loved them, polished, driven on

Sundays. This was old in a **fundamentally** different way. It was old because it worked. It had worked for so long, and through so much, that age had **ceased** to be a thing that could be used against it.



Its **paint** had faded past the point of being paint. It was now a surface — pale, warm, touched by a hundred sun-years — the colour of something that had negotiated, quietly, with weather. Along the doors, rust moved in thin, **deliberate** lines, as though the road had been drawing on it in slow, patient ink. The **mudguards** were bent — not damaged, **shaped**, the way hands become shaped by what they carry for years. And even at rest, the truck made sound — a small, intermittent **tick** from somewhere beneath the hood, a slow **settling** in the suspension, the soft creak of metal that had learned to speak.



And beside it — **Uncle Nasser**.



*He was the kind of man **Safiya** had not seen often, because he was not the kind of man a British girlhood had prepared her for. He was not tall. He was not broad. He was not, in any of the obvious ways, **imposing**. But he had a **density** — she could think of no other word — a quality that made the space around him pay attention. His **dishdasha** was clean but not new, the hem slightly dark from the dust that every Omani hem eventually **accepts**. His **turban** was wound with the tightness of a man whose turban would stay on through **weather**. His eyes, she noticed, rested rather than looked — they **settled** on faces one at a time, gave each one its **portion** of attention, then moved on. This, she thought, was what **authority** looked like when it had stopped needing volume.*



And in his right hand — not raised, not waved, simply **held** — the **bamboo stick**. Smooth at the grip. Dark where years of hands had darkened it. Every child in the yard **registered** it — not with fear, not with **resentment**, but with the same **automatic** awareness that comes with any agreed ritual.



The children were already gathered. **Ali** sat on a low stone, bag between his knees, looking at the truck the way some boys look at horses — with the specific steadiness of someone who **respects** the thing that is about to carry him. **Ahmed** stood behind him — back straight, pencil already in his shirt pocket, as though a pencil were the correct thing to have at the ready on any journey of any kind. **Khalil** was helping **Noura** lift her small cloth bundle into the truck, then helping **Mathila** with hers, then helping **Rahma** — helping without being asked, because helping, for **Khalil**, was not a decision. It was a **reflex**. **Marwa**, **Salima**, and **Rahma** stood in their usual triangle — slightly apart from the others but never from each other, speaking in the low, half-whispered voice of girls who have agreed, without ever discussing it, to face the world as a unit.



And **Mansoor**, inevitably, was **orbiting**. Around the truck. Around the children. Around **Uncle Nasser**, at a calculated, **prudent** distance. Even when he stood still, something about him was already moving — a foot, a shoulder, an eyebrow.



Uncle Nasser lifted the stick. Not high. Not fast. He lifted it the way a **conductor** lifts a baton — to mark a beginning. The children stopped moving. Even **Mansoor** stopped — *partly*. "*Listen*," he said, in Arabic. The word was not loud. It did not need to be. His voice had the same **carrying** quality as the adhan. Not in **tone**. In weight. "*Today, we go to Samail. Today, no trouble. Today — who makes trouble meets this.*"



He did not even lift the stick higher. He only **indicated** it, with the smallest turn of his wrist. The children nodded, as one, with the gravity of people **ratifying** a treaty they had signed many times before. **Mansoor's** eyebrow stopped moving.



Safiya leaned toward **Thuraya**. "*Does he really use it?*" **Thuraya** did not answer immediately. She watched the children. She watched **Uncle Nasser**. Then — without looking at **Safiya**, only at the children — she said quietly: "*He has never needed to.*"



And **Safiya** understood, without having it explained, that this was the **entire** philosophy of the stick. It was not an **instrument** of punishment. It was an instrument of **agreement** — made visible, in wood, so that the agreement did not need to be spoken each morning.



She did not know, at that moment, that she would think about this many times in her life. That she would think about it when she returned to London, years later, and watched teachers trying to explain, through many long sentences, what **Uncle Nasser** had communicated with a single unraised **piece** of bamboo.



John looked at the back of the truck. Then at **Safiya**. Then at the back of the truck again. He did this three times — a small, slow **oscillation** — which was **John's** way, **Safiya** had learned, of **negotiating** with reality when reality had failed, in some small but significant way, to match his expectations.



"Where do we..." "There," **Thuraya** said, indicating the flatbed. "*Hold the metal sides.*" "*There are no seats.*" "Yes." "*There are no... belts.*" "Yes." A long pause, during which **John's** face moved through several distinct **philosophical** stations. "*Is this safe?*" "*It is safer than walking to Samail.*" A longer pause. "*Is walking to Samail prohibitive?*" "Yes."



John turned to **Safiya**. His face had arrived, after its journey, at a kind of **resignation** that was, **Safiya** thought, very **becoming** on him. "*Adventure?*" "*If we die*," she said, and placed one hand on the

side of the flatbed, "tell my mother it was your idea." "That was our **understanding**," John said, and offered her his hand.



She took it. She took it more firmly than she usually did. She climbed into the back of the truck, and the metal was warm — already warm, the sun having spent the morning on it — and the warmth went through her palm into her arm like a small private message.



The children arranged themselves with the **unthinking** grace of passengers who had, between them, made this journey a hundred times. Some at the cab end, close to the window. Some at the back, legs dangling. Some in a small central **cluster**, safest, most shared. **Ahmed** sat beside **Safiya** without discussion — as though he had been **assigned** to her, though nobody had. And **Malood**, last, jumped up onto the tailgate with the **entitlement** of a creature who had decided, long ago, that he was on the **staff**.



"Ob no," **Safiya** said. "Yes yes," the children said, in **unison**, already laughing.



The engine turned over. It did not start cleanly — it started the way an old man stands up: with **complaint**, with a small shudder, and then with the steady **resumption** of a duty long practised. Dust rose from beneath the wheels in a pale, opinionated cloud. **Uncle Nasser** leaned his head out of the cab window, shouted something cheerful to a man leading a camel on the other side of the road, received a shouted answer, laughed — a short, surprised laugh, as though the answer had been a good one — and released the brake.



The truck began to move. **Safiya**'s body understood what was happening before her mind did. Her **grip** on the metal side **tightened** — she had not told it to — and her other hand went, without **consultation**, to the inside of **John**'s elbow. He did not look at her. He only **shifted** slightly, made room for her balance inside his, and held it there.



*The road to Samail was not paved. The road to Samail had never been paved, and had, over the course of many decades, formed a **stubborn** personal opinion about what smoothness was and was not. It did not believe in smoothness. It believed in **honesty**. Every **bump** announced itself in advance, delivered itself fully, and moved on to the next one without apology.*



The first real bump came about forty seconds in. **Safiya** felt it move up through the truck — through the metal, through the boards beneath her, through the base of her spine — and exit somewhere near the top of her skull. Her teeth met. The scarf lifted around her face. The dust **entered** her mouth in a **fine**, **gritty** layer that settled immediately on the back of her tongue.



"Oh," she said. "I see." "It gets worse," **Ahmed** said, quietly, beside her. Not warning. Just **informing**.



"Worse than this?" He nodded — not unkindly. Almost **reassuringly**. "In the valley part."



She laughed. Not because it was funny. Because there was nothing else a person could **reasonably** do, in the back of an unbalanced truck, with dust in her teeth, being warned by a nine-year-old boy about the valley part.



The next bump. And the next. She stopped **flinching**. She began, instead, to **ride** them — to let her knees soften, to let her spine **absorb** what her arms could not brace against. **Ahmed**, beside her, was doing the same thing — had been doing it his whole life, possibly since before he could walk — and had never once thought about it.



She looked up. The mountains were closer than she had expected, and larger, and **redder** — a deep, **iron-coloured** red that she had not seen in any painting, any photograph, any book. The road turned. A small stream — a narrow **wadi** — opened to their right and closed again, briefly, like a page being turned.



"John..." she said. He leaned toward her. "Yes?" "I stopped being afraid." He smiled. "When?" "I don't know. Somewhere around bump eleven."



He laughed. **Ahmed**, listening, understood only the **cadence** of the English, not the words. But the cadence told him enough. He smiled too.



Then **Mansoor** — because the laws of **Mansoor** are eternal — stood up. In the back of a moving truck. At full height. His arms out, like a bird. "I AM FLYING!" **Thuraya**, from the front, turned sharply. "**MANSOOR, IGLUS!**" **Mansoor** sat. Fast. Like a puppet whose string had been **severed**. The children laughed. He laughed at himself — **Mansoor's** one **redeeming** feature, **Safiya** was beginning to realise: he was always the first to laugh at himself.



They passed a man on a donkey. The man raised his hand. **Uncle Nasser**, without turning, raised his hand back — an **economical** gesture, no larger than was needed. A **greeting** that had, by now, been made many thousands of times, and had been **polished** down to the exact size of itself. **Safiya** watched the exchange — one second, no more — and felt, without quite being able to name why, that she had just seen something **sacred**.



They passed palm groves. They passed a **flock** of goats that moved, without urgency, to the edge of the road as though the truck were a **rumour** they had heard but not quite believed. They passed a woman walking with a bundle on her head — perfect balance, perfect **carriage** — and the woman looked up, saw **Thuraya** in the front seat, and waved.



"Who is that?" **Safiya** asked. **Thuraya**, turning, had to raise her voice over the engine. *"Umm Salim. She teaches the girls in Misfah how to make bukboor."* *"From what?"* *"From everything. You will see."*



You will see. **Safiya** was beginning to suspect that this was **Thuraya's national** phrase. *You will see.* Four syllables. Used in place of explanation. Used, in fact, as explanation — because in this country, as she was slowly understanding, seeing was not an extra step after hearing. Seeing was the **primary** method. Words only prepared the eye.



*Somewhere around the twentieth minute — or was it the thirtieth; time in the back of the truck had become **unreliable** — **Safiya** became aware that she had stopped holding the metal side with both hands. One hand was loose at her side. Her body had made a **decision** she had not been consulted about. It had decided to trust. To trust **Uncle Nasser**, who was at the wheel. To trust the children, who were all still in the truck and laughing. To trust the road, which, **against** her every expectation, was becoming, in its honest brutal way, a kind of teacher.*



She looked at **John**. His hair was white with dust. His eyebrows were white. A small **crescent** of dust had settled along his lower lip. He was **beaming**. Completely. Without **reservation**.



"John..." *"Mmm?"* *"I think you have been waiting for this your whole life."* He looked at her. Considered it, seriously. *"I think you might be right."*



Thuraya, from the front, turned her head once and saw them — white with dust, laughing, leaning slightly into each other the way people lean when they are no longer **concerned** with looking like themselves. She smiled — the widest smile **Safiya** had yet seen from her. The smile of a person who had known, from the moment she met these two, that the road would **rearrange** them, and who was now watching the rearrangement happen. *"You are learning,"* she said, over the engine.



The truck rolled forward. The mountains drew closer. The dust behind them **trailed** in a long pale cloud that wrote their direction on the morning air. And **Safiya** — held between a British husband who was beaming, an Omani boy who was calmly balanced, a teacher who knew exactly what she was

doing, and a goat who had no business being here — understood, without quite being able to explain it, that she was no longer a visitor. She was not yet a resident. She was something in between. Something the English language did not quite have a word for. Something the road, perhaps, had just named.

SCENE FOUR

Samail Market

Samail did not arrive. Samail **accumulated**.



First — more walls. Then walls that began to meet at corners, forming something that could be called, if you were generous, streets. Then a small herd of goats being driven along the edge of the road by a boy of maybe seven, who did not look up as the truck passed because he had a far more serious task in front of him. Then a woman carrying water in a metal container balanced on her head, moving with a **stillness** that was not the absence of motion but the **mastery** of it. Then more shops. Then more voices. Then — without anyone having announced it, without any sign — they were in the market.



Uncle Nasser pulled into a patch of dust beside a low wall. The engine protested once, as though it had one more opinion to express, and then went **silent**. The dust did not go silent. The dust continued its slow **descent** onto their clothes, their hair, their skin, with the **unhurried** precision of a thing that had all the time in the world. *"We arrived,"* **Thuraya** said, from the front. *"We **survived**,"* **Safiya** corrected.



The children climbed down first. They did it the way they did most things — without **consultation**, without **ceremony** — and arranged themselves in the loose, flexible shape of a group that already knew, internally, where its edges were. **Safiya** placed both hands on the warm metal side of the truck. She looked down. The ground was a long way below her, in the way ground is always a long way below a person who has been in a moving truck for forty minutes and whose legs now have opinions of their own.



John jumped down first — landing awkwardly, catching himself, laughing. Then he raised his hands to her. *"Come."* She came. Her feet touched the ground and the ground felt, for one very strange second, **suspiciously** still. The body did not believe in stillness yet. The body was still being rattled by a truck that was no longer moving. She stood for a moment, palms flat against her skirt, waiting for her legs to catch up with her arrival.



Then she lifted her head. And stopped.



*Samail market did not open onto her in a single view. It opened in **layers**. First, sound — a complicated, unbroken texture of many voices going in many directions at many speeds, none of them in English, most of them not even in the Arabic she had begun, very slowly, to recognise. Then colour — reds she had never seen on a cloth, yellows she had not thought were available to human pigment, greens that looked less like colour and more like an **argument**. Then smell — and smell arrived last, because smell was the most difficult to **catalogue**. Spice. Bread. Animal. Sweat. Earth. Water on stone. Something burning somewhere that might have been incense and might have been breakfast. Citrus. Goat. Coffee. Dust. And behind all of them, older than all of them, the faint, unmistakable **tang** of salt and cured fish.*



She understood, in a way that could not be put into a sentence, that she was standing inside a piece of time that had not changed in perhaps three hundred years. **Adjustments** had been made, of course — a metal container where once there would have been a clay one, a cloth dyed with a newer red. But the **architecture** — of motion, of exchange, of how a person asked for a thing and how the thing was given — had not moved.



"John..." He was beside her. He had been watching her face, which is to say, he had been watching her **arrive**. "Yes?" "This is not a market." "No?" "This is a country that has been **compressed** into three streets." **Thuraya**, beside them, smiled the quiet smile of a person whose pupil has, without assistance, reached the correct answer.



They began to move through it. **Thuraya** led — not briskly, not as a guide, but at the particular pace of a person who has been here a hundred times and has learned, a hundred times, that there is no advantage in hurrying. The children walked around them in their loose **constellation** — **Khalil** already helping a small girl who was not one of theirs gather something she had dropped, **Ahmed** keeping careful watch over **Mansoor**, **Noura** three steps ahead and asking the first shopkeeper she reached what everything was.



A man passed them carrying a live chicken under each arm. The chickens did not seem to mind. Another man called out a price for dates in a voice so **musical** that for a moment **Safiya** forgot he was selling anything and simply listened. The **intonation** rose and fell like a small verse — his price at the top, his justification at the bottom, and a small, persuasive pause between them. This, she thought, was not selling. This was **persuasion** as a small spoken art form, practised daily, by men who had never heard of the word *art* and who had mastered it anyway.



Safiya stopped, without meaning to, beside a woman with a large mat of **frankincense**. The resin was in piles — different colours, different sizes, different **grades**. A small hand-written card beside

each one, in Arabic, with a number. The woman looked up. She was perhaps seventy — a face **weathered** in the specific way of women who have worked outside, patiently, for decades — and in her eyes was the particular **appraisal** of a merchant who has seen every kind of customer in forty years and has already, in the first second, sorted this one.



The woman picked up a small golden stone between her thumb and forefinger. Crushed it, lightly, with the **confidence** of someone who could tell the grade by smell alone. She held it out to **Safiya**. Not offering to sell. Offering to share.



Safiya leaned down. She did not know why. Something in the gesture had been — a small **invitation**, wordless and complete. She smelled. Her eyes closed involuntarily. The smell was nothing she had smelled in London. Nothing she had smelled in the village. It was **older** than either. Sweet and dry and high in the back of the nose, and underneath, something **resinous** and deep, like a tree giving up its slowest secret.



She opened her eyes. The woman was smiling — a small, private smile. She said something, in Arabic. **Thuraya**, who had paused beside them, translated quietly. *"She says — this one is **hojari**. The best. The frankincense of kings."* "...I smelled frankincense of kings." "Yes." "How much?" **Thuraya** translated the question. The woman named a price. **Safiya** paid it without **bargaining**. **Thuraya** — mildly — said afterwards, *"You could have **haggled**."* "I know." "But you did not." "No." "Why?" **Safiya** thought about it for a long moment. *"Because she let me smell it first. Before she named a price. That is not a **transaction**. That is an offering. You cannot haggle an offering."* **Thuraya** looked at her for a long second. Then nodded — slowly, approvingly. "Good," she said. *"You are reading the market correctly."*



They moved on. **Safiya** placed the small paper parcel of **hojari** into her bag — and noticed that she placed it not in the top, where she would have to find it again, but carefully at the bottom, against the soft folds of her scarf, where it would be **protected**. She did not examine why she was doing this. Some actions, she was learning, arrived before explanation, and did not require any.



A few stalls further on, **John** had stopped. He was standing in front of a small wooden table on which, on a single flat cloth, lay the **formidable** body of a large **awal**. It was perhaps the length of his forearm. It was the colour of old steel. It did not **gleam** in any decorative way. It simply lay there, patient and complete, in the dignity of something that had been a fish and was now, with some dignity, something else.



The fish seller — an older man with enormous, patient hands, and the kind of white beard that begins along the edge of the jaw and **arrives**, eventually, at the chest — looked at **John**. *"Awal?"* "Yes.

Awal. I would like... this one,” **John** said, pointing. The man raised one eyebrow. Not in mockery. In **assessment**. *“Big one?” “Big one.” “For family?” “For...”* **John** glanced at **Thuraya**. *“For experience.”* **Thuraya** translated this. The fish seller laughed — a full, deep laugh, the laugh of a man who has waited his whole working life for a foreigner to give exactly this answer. *“Tayyeb,”* he said. *“Good.”*



He wrapped it. First in a clean paper, then in a cloth, then tied with a piece of palm twine the **economy** of whose motion suggested he had tied perhaps ten thousand such knots in his working life and had no intention of wasting any of them now. He handed the parcel across.



John received it. The weight of it surprised him — heavier than he had expected, more **substantial**. And then the smell. The smell hit him after the weight — a complicated, layered, deeply **unapologetic** smell of fish that had been salted, then dried in direct sun for weeks, then hung patiently in the shade, and had now, after months of this slow **curing**, concentrated the entire ocean into one small, patient, odorous package.



Safiya took one large, thoroughly **diplomatic** step back. *“John.” “Yes?” “It smells.” “I know.” “No. You do not. It smells with conviction.” “I see the distinction.”* The fish seller, understanding the tone if not the words, laughed again — warmer this time. He said something to **Thuraya**. **Thuraya**, smiling, translated. *“He says — the fish has character. Not every fish has character. This one does.” “That is a generous way to describe it,”* **Safiya** said. *“You will get used to it,”* **Thuraya** said. *“When?” “When you stop holding your breath.”*



John, carrying the parcel at arm’s length, looked at it — not the length of his arm, but **almost** — and said to it quietly, as a man might address an animal he is not sure is asleep: *“It is not personal.”* The fish, being dried and salted and entirely beyond the affairs of this world, did not reply.



They moved on. **Safiya** continued walking at a slight, measured distance from **John** and his purchase — a distance that was mostly affectionate, slightly precautionary, and entirely sensible. But her attention had **shifted**. She was no longer reacting to things. She was beginning to **anticipate** them. Which stalls would be crowded. Which sellers would speak first, and which would wait. Where the goods **flowed**, and where they **pooled**. She was, without having learned it, starting to read the market the way **Thuraya** read it — as a **living** organism with **currents** and eddies and rules.



She passed a cloth merchant unrolling a long piece of deep green for a customer. She passed a man **brazing** a small metal pot with a hand-held flame, the specific smell of hot metal joining the market’s other smells without apology. She passed a date seller **arranging** his dates by variety — darker ones on the left, smaller paler ones on the right — each heap a small, shining hill.



A boy of maybe five ran past her, chasing a **tethered** goat kid who did not understand the rules of the race but was running anyway. The boy nearly collided with **Safiya**, stopped short, looked up, said *"sorry"* in very careful English — clearly a word a teacher had taught him — and ran off before she had recovered enough to answer. She stood for a moment. Then laughed. Out loud. Without **reservation**.



It was the laugh of a person who had, without noticing, crossed a small inner **threshold**. She was no longer inside this market as a visitor. She was inside it as a person. The distinction mattered. She did not know why it mattered yet. She only knew that it did.



Thuraya had, very quietly, been watching. She had seen the frankincense moment. She had seen the laugh. She said nothing. She only, for a single second, placed her hand on **Safiya**'s arm — lightly, briefly, without comment — and then let it fall again. Some things, **Safiya** was learning, were **affirmed** not through speech but through small, witnessed gestures.



Thuraya clapped her hands once — lightly, just enough. The children — who had been dispersed across three different stalls, each one making, in their own way, their own small explorations — gathered. **John** turned. **Safiya** turned. Even **Malood** — who had, in the intervening minutes, located someone's cabbage — lifted his head.



"Now," **Thuraya** said, *"we learn."*

SCENE FIVE

I Want

Thuraya looked at the students. *"Today we will learn one sentence."* The children stilled. Even **Mansoor**, momentarily. *"Only one?"* **Noura** asked. *"Only one,"* **Thuraya** confirmed. *"But one that will work a hundred times."*



John took a piece of paper from his pocket. He had folded it very carefully that morning — carefully in the way a teacher folds a thing when he knows the thing will be unfolded in front of children, and children, as every teacher knows, can read creases. He held it up. He wrote, in clear capital letters, what **Thuraya** had asked him to write.



I WANT...



Two words. A pause afterwards. A small, open space where anything in the world could go.



And looking at those two words on that small piece of paper, standing in the middle of the largest, loudest market she had ever tried to be calm inside, **Safiya** felt something that was almost recognition. Not for the sentence — she had known that sentence her whole life. But for the act of teaching it. For the quiet **generosity** of handing someone a sentence they could now use to enter any shop in the country. That, she thought, was what languages really were. Not grammar. Not **vocabulary**. Doors. Given to people. So they could walk through.



Thuraya said — clearly, slowly — “*I want...*” The children tried. “*I want.*” “*I want.*” “*I... want.*” “*Very good,*” **Thuraya** said. “*Now — we use it.*”



She pointed toward a nearby stall. A small pile of dates. A kind but curious shopkeeper, already half-listening. “*Who will go first?*”



Ali stepped forward without hesitation. He walked to the stall. He looked at the dates. He straightened his small back. “*I want... this.*” The shopkeeper blinked — just once. Then smiled, hugely, the smile of a man who has not been spoken to in English in his own market for a long time, and who has been gifted the **novelty** of it by a boy who looks, for all the world, entirely **serious**. “*Tafadbdhal, ya habibi,*” the shopkeeper said, handing him a date. “*Take. Take.*”



The children cheered. **Ali** walked back with the date in his hand — and on his face, the **quiet** pride of a person who has just, for the first time in his life, used a foreign language to acquire an object. “*It worked,*” he said, amazed. “*Yes,*” **Thuraya** said. “*It worked.*”



Mansoor pushed forward. Of course he did. “*Me now! Me me me!*” **Thuraya** placed a gentle hand on his shoulder. “*Say: I want.*” **Mansoor** took a breath — a large, dramatic, **theatrical** breath — walked up to a cloth of oranges, and announced at full volume: “*I WANT THIS! THIS! THIS!*” The orange seller looked at him. Then at **Thuraya**. Then at **John**. Then, with the slow gentleness of a man who has seen everything and has decided not to be surprised by any of it — handed **Mansoor** three oranges. The children **collapsed** into laughter. **Safiya**, who had covered her mouth, uncovered it, and laughed too.



“*He understood,*” **Thuraya** explained, to **Safiya**. “*Three ‘this’ — three oranges.*” “*The grammar was wrong,*” **John** observed. “*The result was three oranges,*” **Thuraya** said. “*The grammar can come later.*”



Noura went next. She had, of course, prepared a speech. “*I want...*” — she paused, she considered, she let the whole market wait for her — “*...to know the name of every fruit in this market.*” The seller

blinked. **Thuraya** translated, softly, in Arabic. The seller roared laughing. And then, patiently — because she was ten years old and she had asked honestly — he began to point to each fruit and say its name, while **Noura** nodded very seriously, as though she were conducting an **interview** for a newspaper no one had asked her to write for.



One by one, the children went. **Ahmed**, precisely. **Khalil**, charmingly. **Mathila**, already **distributing** what she had bought to the others before she had even finished buying it. **Rahma**, **Marwa**, and **Salima**, together — as always — asking, at the same time, for the same small thing, and receiving it in three identical bags.



*And **Safiya** watched. She watched with an attention she had not known she possessed. These were not students **reluctantly** performing a lesson. These were children **discovering** that a sentence was a **key**. That once you had the key, doors opened. That the doors had been there all along. This was not language learning as she had known it in London. This was something older. Something more **immediate**. Something that would stay with these children long after any textbook she could bring would have been forgotten.*



She turned to **John**. "*We have a lot to learn.*" He nodded. "*Not just the children.*" "*No. Not just them.*"

SCENE SIX

Habbabouh Saïf

They were standing near a stall of **textiles** — **Safiya** had become helplessly fascinated by a deep crimson cloth — when a voice arrived from behind her.



It arrived, she would later realise, before she turned. It arrived in the way that certain sounds arrive — not through the ear first but through recognition. The voice spoke **flawless** English. Not careful English. Not the **precise** English of a second-language speaker. Something else. Something fuller. English spoken the way a person speaks a language when it has lived in their mouth for a very long time.



"Good morning. You must be the new teachers."



Safiya turned. **John** turned. **Thuraya** smiled, slightly, as though she had been waiting for this moment.



A man stood in front of them — **aged**, but not frail. The word 'old' did not quite fit him; a better word would have been **settled**. A white beard reached partway down his chest. His eyes were **kind** in a way that seemed to be a structural feature of his face, rather than an expression he was choosing. His dishdasha was simple. His **kummah** was embroidered, and the embroidery was very old.



John's mouth opened. Closed. Opened again. *"You... you speak English."* *"I do."* *"Very well."* *"I had time."*



Safiya, recovering slightly faster, found her voice. *"Where... where did you learn?"* The man smiled. A small, contained smile, the smile of a person who has been asked this question before and has his answer ready, but who still, each time, enjoys delivering it.



*"My name is **Saif**. But here — the people call me **Habbabouh Saif**."* He gestured slightly — not with importance, only with explanation. *"I worked many years with the Omani fleet. And I lived — for many years — in "* *data-m="An island off East Africa that was part of the Omani Empire for centuries; a deep and living part of Oman's international, Swahili-influenced history" data-s="Omani Zanzibar, East Africa island" data-x="Zanzibar was not foreign to Oman. It was Oman, across the sea.">Zanzibar."*



*The word arrived the way words do when they have not been expected. Zanzibar. **Safiya** had read the name on maps. She had, perhaps, seen it written on the side of one or two very old tea boxes in British shops. She had never once thought of it as a place where an old man in a kummah might still live in the **memory**. And yet — here he was. An entire life she had not known existed. An entire **geography** folded inside one person. An Oman she had not yet realised was an Oman of **oceans**, not just mountains.*



*"Zanzibar," she repeated softly. "Yes." "We... I did not know." "Most people who come here do not know," **Habbabouh Saif** said. Kindly, with no judgment. Simply reporting. "But this country is very old. And it has been in many places. Before the places knew they were places."*



John found himself sitting down — on a wooden box beside the stall, without having quite decided to. *"You — you must have stories." "Many." "Will you tell us?" "Yes," **Habbabouh Saif** said. "Slowly."*



And he did. He told them, quietly, with the **patience** of a man who had spent years at sea, about Zanzibar. About the market in Stone Town. About the smell of cloves on ships. About the Swahili he had learned and the English he had **acquired**, slowly, from English captains and Indian clerks and other sailors of a dozen nations who had met, briefly, on decks and then gone their separate ways.

"Language," he said, looking at **John** and **Safiya** very directly, *"is not a thing you carry. It is a thing that carries you. You will see."*



The children had gathered, silently. **Thuraya** had not interrupted. **Malood** — improbably, impossibly — sat at the man's feet, still, **attentive**, as though he, too, understood that the moment did not require any of his usual **interventions**.



The market continued around them. Voices rose and fell. Goods moved. Prices were made and unmade. But inside that small circle, around that wooden box, time did something it rarely did — it paused. It made room. It held itself still for the length of a story.



When **Habbabouh Saif** finally rose and said goodbye — with the same small smile — **Safiya** stood for a long time without moving. "*Thuraya*," she said, *"how many more people like him does this village have?"* **Thuraya** smiled — the slow, long smile of a person who has been waiting for this exact question. *"Every one of them,"* she said. *"You have only met three."*



That evening, as **Uncle Nasser's** truck rumbled back toward Al-Qurawashiyah — slower now, under a sky that was beginning to turn orange, the children quieter, **Mansoor** asleep with his head on **Ahmed's** shoulder, **Malood** tucked against **John's** boot, the day's purchases stacked between them — **Safiya** took out her small notebook. She wrote, in careful handwriting, and not to herself, and not quite to anyone:



*Today, we did not only go to the market.
We learned a sentence.
We met a man with an ocean inside him.
And we began — very quietly, without announcement — to understand that this country is not a small country.
It is simply a country that keeps itself in very small places.*



John read the page over her shoulder. He did not say anything. He only placed his hand, briefly, on hers.



Ahead of them, the mountains of Samail darkened into evening. Behind them, a long trail of dust marked the road they had crossed. And somewhere between — two teachers, one guide, ten children, a goat, and the beginning of a life that no textbook they had brought from London could ever have prepared them for.

 Did You Know?**Oman and Zanzibar**

Habbabouh Saif tells his story in Samail market of years spent with the Omani fleet and life in Zanzibar. This isn't fiction: after Imam Saif bin Sultan's 1698 victory over the Portuguese, Zanzibar became part of the Omani Empire, and Sayyid Said bin Sultan moved his court there in 1832. When he died in 1856, the empire split between his sons — one became Sultan of Muscat, the other Sultan of Zanzibar.

Source: en.wikipedia.org · en.wikipedia.org

PALM

Palm Five

The Souq, the Children, and the First Pickup

SCENE ONE

The Village Before the Village Woke

She had not intended to wake this early.

~

The intention had been to sleep until the light made sleeping impossible — which, in this house, with its small windows and thick clay walls, would have been an hour yet. But something had woken her, and it had woken her **gently**, the way the village woke people who were paying attention.

~

She lay still for a moment, listening. And slowly — one sound at a time — the morning **assembled** itself around her.

~

The first sound, low beneath everything else, was the **falaj**. She had heard it every morning since they arrived, but she had not always **registered** it. It was a **continuous** sound — not quite water, not quite silence, the particular **hush** that moving water makes when it has been moving through the same narrow stone channel for longer than anyone in the village has been alive.

~

Above it — the soft **cooing** of doves from somewhere in the palm grove. A rooster, further off, beginning his long and unpersuaded **argument** with the idea that morning had arrived. A woman's voice, somewhere to the east, humming — not a song exactly, more the **rhythm** of a woman doing something with her hands.

~

She got up. Carefully — **John** was still asleep, his breathing deep and even, his arm across the space where she had been. She tucked the sheet gently around his shoulder and stepped onto the bisat.

~

The floor was cool. The mud walls held their cool carefully, the way they had been holding it since the last hours of the night. She walked to the small window and stood there.

~

*The village was not yet light. It was in the long, in-between time that English did not quite have a word for but that Arabic did — **fajr**. Not night. Not morning. Something in between that was its own thing, with its own colour and its own quality of quiet. The sky was not yet blue. It was not yet pink. It was a pale, **undecided** silver, the colour of a decision that had not yet been made.*



She lifted her shawl from the hook beside the door. She pulled her scarf over her head, quietly, not out of ceremony but because the **pre-dawn** cold in the village had a specific character — it did not hurt, but it **insisted** on a scarf. And then, without quite deciding to, she opened the door and stepped outside.



The air was different from the air inside. Cooler — she had expected that — but also **clearer**, in a way she had no word for. It carried the smell of the falaj more strongly out here. Water on stone. Wet earth. And beneath both of those — distant, carried on the **current** of dawn air — the faint smell of a wood fire beginning somewhere.



She walked, slowly, to the end of the short path that led from their door. And she saw the village awake in a way she had not seen it awake before. Not the **bustling** village of mid-morning. Not the children-running, Sadoo-shouting, market-day village of afternoon. Something earlier. Something the village reserved, perhaps, for itself.



A woman — **Umm Hamad**, she thought, though she was not yet sure of all the names — walked along the narrow path carrying an empty clay jar on her shoulder. She was going toward the falaj. Her steps were **unhurried** and exact, and the empty jar did not rock on her shoulder. It simply sat there, as though it understood its role.



From a house further up the path, the **rhythmic**, dull sound of a woman pounding something in a **mortar**. **Cardamom**, perhaps. Or coffee beans.



A man — she did not know his name — walked past carrying a bundle of qit on his shoulder. He saw her, inclined his head slightly — a greeting that contained no unnecessary motion — and continued past. He did not stare. He did not stop. He simply **acknowledged** her and went on.



From the small mosque near the centre of the village, the **adhan** began. Not loud. Not amplified — there was no loudspeaker here, only a man's voice, steady and clear, **unaccompanied**. The voice rose and fell in the old patterns, carried the old words, and the village, without any single person stopping, seemed to **reorient** itself around the voice.



*She stood and listened. She did not pray — the prayer was not hers — but she understood, standing in that cool pre-dawn air, that she was being given something. Not instruction. Not even **invitation**. Simply **presence**. The right to stand here, at this hour, and witness a village being the version of itself that existed only before the children came out, only before the shops opened, only when the falaj and the doves and the adhan had the air entirely to themselves.*



She heard a soft footstep behind her. She turned.



Thuraya. Already dressed. Already scarved. A small cup of something warm in her hands. She did not look surprised to see **Safiya** standing outside her door at fajr. She looked like a person who had guessed, the evening before, that this might happen.



*"You are up." "I did not mean to be." "The village wakes people sometimes." **Thuraya** held out the cup. "Qabwa." **Safiya** took it. It was warm. It smelled of cardamom and something else she could not name yet. "Thank you." "Drink it slowly." A small pause. "And come. Today I will show you the falaj." "I have seen the falaj." **Thuraya** smiled. "You have seen the surface of it," she said. "Today you will see the rest."*

SCENE TWO

The Women at the Water

By the time they walked toward the main channel, the sky had committed to a colour. It was pink now — not a romantic pink, not a painting pink, but the **working** pink of sunrise, a pink that was going to turn into ordinary blue as soon as it had finished with its brief assignment.



Behind them, the village had begun to properly wake. Men's voices — a short Arabic exchange between two neighbours, the specific low **register** of men who had just finished prayer and were now discussing something about one man's brother's truck. The clinking of a tea glass against a metal tray. The scrape of a wooden door.



And ahead — the falaj. But not the falaj she had seen her first week. Not the falaj of midday, loud with children, with women scrubbing large pots, with the chaos of laundry and life. This was the falaj at its **women's hour** — the first pale hour, when the water was coldest and cleanest, when the village was still a place of women before it became a place of everyone.



Six women were there. **Safiya** had not expected six. She had expected one, perhaps two — the morning was young, and she would not have guessed there would be this much activity already. But here they were, each at her own station along the channel, each doing her own **task**.



The woman nearest them — older, perhaps sixty, with hennaed hands — was filling a clay jar. She lowered it into the channel by a rope, let it sink, let it fill, lifted it, set it on the stone. She did this without watching her hands. She watched, instead, the channel further down — where another woman was washing something, and where the woman below her was washing something else, and where the child at the end was **rinsing** a cloth. The older woman watched to make sure the child's rinsed cloth was not sending anything upstream.



*"**Thuraya**, "**Safiya** said quietly, "how do they know the order?"*



Thuraya looked at her — warmly, without hurry. *"The falaj has laws." "Laws?" "Yes. Old laws. Older than any of us."* She gestured — a small, economical movement of the wrist. *"Drinking water is first. Before anything. Then the water for prayer — for **wudu**. Then the water for cooking. Then washing yourself — and the women have their time, and the men have theirs. Then washing clothes. Then washing pots. Then — last — the water goes to the "* data-m="Plural of falaj; here, the channels that distribute the falaj's water to the individual palm plots and farms" data-s="water channels, irrigation branches" data-x="The aflaj carried the used water to the farms — nothing was ever wasted.">aflaj for the palms and the farms."



Safiya looked at the channel. At the six women. At the ordered, quiet **procession** of water. At the child at the end, rinsing a cloth that had already been washed further up, into a place where the water would flow next to the farms and not backward to the drinking stations.



"So this —" she said, slowly, "is not the same water. It is the same channel. But it is not the same water." **Thuraya** looked at her with the **approval** of a teacher whose student has just answered, on their own, the question that has been stuck in the back of the class for a week. *"Yes." "The water is always moving. So the woman upstream is never drinking what the woman downstream has washed." "Yes." "And the laws — they are not written." "No." "They are just... known." "They are known,"* **Thuraya** agreed. *"By every child, before they are old enough to ask."*



***Safiya** thought back, with something close to **embarrassment**, to her first week here. To the moment she had looked at the falaj in the middle of the day — women scrubbing pots, children splashing, a goat drinking — and had thought, quietly but completely, this is not clean. She had been wrong. She had been wrong in a way that was bigger than being wrong about cleanliness. She had been wrong about what cleanliness was. The falaj was not dirty. The falaj was the single most **disciplined** water system she had ever stood beside. It had laws. Older than any law she had studied. Known by every child, before they were old enough to ask.*



The older woman with the hennaed hands looked up. Saw them. Smiled. Said something.



Thuraya translated, quietly. *"She says — welcome, ya Safiya. She has seen you from her window."* *"She knows my name?"* *"Everyone knows your name."* A pause. *"It is a small village."*



The woman spoke again — longer this time. **Thuraya** translated after, smiling. *"She says — you have English skin but your eyes are like an Omani. You look the way you should. And she says — when you are ready, come and learn to carry water. It is not as easy as it looks."*



Safiya laughed — quietly, so as not to disturb the fajr hour. *"Tell her I would be honoured."* *"She already knows."* *"How?"* **Thuraya** looked at her. *"Because you came here. At fajr. To watch."*



They stood for a while longer in the silver-blue-becoming-pink light. **Safiya** watched — but differently now. She watched the way one woman dipped her cloth. The way another folded hers, wrung it, folded it again. The way the child at the end looked up every minute or so to check with the older woman that she was doing the rinsing correctly — a check that was not anxious, just **reverent**.



And she understood, without **Thuraya** needing to say it, that she had just been given a second **threshold**. The market had been one. This was another. And this one, she thought, was older.

SCENE THREE

John Enters the Water

By mid-morning, the falaj had changed again. The women had gone. The sky was now a plain, committed blue. The children were out — and where children were out, in this village, the falaj was their **kingdom**.



John and **Safiya** walked down the path with **Thuraya**. **John** had, that morning, slept long and thoroughly and well, and had woken with the specific **freshness** of a person who had not been awake at fajr, and who was now **vaguely** aware that his wife had seen something without him. He did not mind. He was, in the morning light, extremely agreeable.



The falaj came into view. And as it came into view, so did the children.



Mansoor. Already in the water. **Khalil**. Already in the water. Three smaller boys she did not know, also in the water. **Ahmed** — predictably, precisely, **Ahmed**-ly — sitting on the stone edge with his feet in the water, reading a small exercise book that he had **evidently** carried down with him for

this purpose. **Noura**, not in the water, standing at the edge with her arms folded, delivering what appeared to be a **lecture** on something. **Mathila**, **Rahma**, **Marwa**, and **Salima**, slightly apart, talking quietly in their usual cluster.



And in the middle of the channel, **propriatorially** — **Malood**. Drinking. Of course.



"Safiya," John said, quietly. "Yes?" "I am about to do something I should probably not do." "Yes." "I would like you to remember," he said, already bending down at the edge of the falaj, "that I have been warned."



"John —"



He dipped both hands into the water.



The water hit him with its **absolute**, uncompromising cold. Not cool. Not refreshing. *Cold* in the way that mountain water is cold when it has spent its whole brief life in stone channels, beneath the shade of palms, and has never once been warmed by anything. The shock went up his wrists and into his shoulders before he had time to decide how to respond. He responded by washing his face.



He lowered his face to his cupped hands and pressed the cold water against his skin. Once. Twice. A third time. The water ran down his chin and his throat and into the collar of his shirt, and he let it, because at that moment he was not capable of deciding anything else.



He looked up. Every child in the falaj was watching him.



The silence lasted exactly one second. Then **Khalil** said something in Arabic — fast, low, and clearly **delighted** — and the children **erupted**.



Mansoor, standing waist-deep in the channel, pointed at **John** and shouted: *"MR. JOHN! YOU ARE ONE OF US!"*



*"What did he say?" John asked, wiping his face. **Thuraya** — who had been about to intervene, and had now decided that the moment was beyond intervention — translated with a small, helpless smile. "He said: You are one of us."*



John looked at the children. At **Mansoor**, waist-deep, grinning. At **Khalil**, already inventing a song about this. At **Ahmed**, looking up from his book with the particular expression of a child whose dignity has survived because he has chosen not to be involved. At **Malood**, still drinking, unmoved.



"**Safiya**," he said, "I feel... fresh." "You feel wet," she corrected. "Those are not the same." "They are," he said, "today."



*And the strange thing was — he was not wrong. There was a **quality** to the water on his skin that tap water had never had. A **mineral** cleanness. The faint, clean taste that water has when it has spent a long time inside mountains, talking to stone. He could feel it on his skin even after he had wiped it off. The skin **tingled**, faintly, the way skin tingles after something that was not cold at all.*



A woman's voice — from further down the path, one he did not recognise — called out a long sentence in Arabic. Then another voice joined. Then a third. The older women on the path had seen him.



"What are they saying?" John asked. **Thuraya** listened. She smiled. Then she **hesitated** — which was unusual for **Thuraya**, who did not hesitate often. "They are saying..." "Yes?" "That the English man is tall. And that you have a kind face. And one of them is asking who is your wife." She paused. "And another is saying — that wife is very lucky, because that man has now washed in our falaj, and a man who washes in the falaj belongs a little to the village, and a little less to his own country."



John went very still. Not from discomfort. From the slow, **sincere** recognition that he had just been given something that was not easy to give. He looked at the women down the path. He raised his hand slightly — not waving, just **acknowledging**. The oldest of the women smiled, nodded once, and walked on.



Safiya, standing beside him, said nothing. She only, very lightly, placed her hand against the small of his back — the way one does, without fanfare, when one has seen that something has happened to a person one loves. He felt her hand. He did not turn.



Thuraya, watching all of this, said nothing for a long time. And then, quietly, more to herself than to either of them — "It is easier after this." "After what?" **Safiya** asked. **Thuraya** turned to her. Her face was entirely open. "After you become someone the village can tell stories about. Before that, you are a stranger. After that, you are a **character**." "And John is now a character?" "John," **Thuraya** said, "is now the man who washed his face in the falaj. The village will tell that story for ten years."



"For ten years." "At least." **John**, still wet, blinked. *"Is that good?" "That is **excellent**,"* **Thuraya** said.

SCENE FOUR

Why We Say Good

The **inevitable** response to all of this — once **John** had dried himself with the cloth **Thuraya**, prepared for anything, had somehow produced from a small basket — was that a lesson must be given. Not because they had planned one. Because the children were now gathered, the morning was beautiful, and to let such a moment pass without teaching something would have been, to **John**, a professional embarrassment.



They moved from the falaj to the large tree that stood a short distance from it. A **ghaf** tree — old, patient, its branches wide enough to hold shade for twenty children. The ground beneath it was packed hard from decades of sitting. It had been, **Safiya** realised, a classroom long before any classroom had a wall.



The children sat. **Mansoor**, damp, sat too close to **Ahmed**. **Ahmed** moved away. **Mansoor** followed. **Ahmed** sighed — the sigh of a nine-year-old scholar who has, once again, been denied the dignity of solitude.



John knelt. He took a small stick from the ground. He looked at **Thuraya**. She nodded — a small, teacherly nod: *go ahead*.



He drew, in the dust, two words.



HELLO
GOOD MORNING



He pointed to the first. *"Hello."* The children repeated. *"Hello."* He pointed to the second. *"Good morning."* *"Good morning."*



Mansoor said it too loud. **Khalil** said it in a funny voice. **Ahmed** said it exactly — as though he had saved up the words and had now chosen to spend them correctly. **Mathila** whispered it to **Rahma** first, to make sure she had it right, and only then said it out loud.



Then **Noura**, who had been waiting — **Noura** always waited, because **Noura** always had a question, and **Noura** always wanted the **spotlight** for the question — raised her hand.

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"Yes, **Noura**?"

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She considered. Her face took on the particular look of a ten-year-old who has thought about a thing long enough to know that the thing is worth asking about. "*Why we say good?*"

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Silence.

و
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John blinked. "*Why...?*" "Yes. *Why we say good? Why not just — morning?*"

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He had, he realised, never been asked this question. He had taught English to adults in London, to children in Sheffield, to two very tired businessmen in Frankfurt. Not one of them had ever asked why one said good morning. It was one of those phrases that survived in the language the way certain stones survive in a wall — nobody remembers who put them there, and everybody has agreed, without agreeing, that the wall needs them. But here was a ten-year-old Omani girl, sitting under a ghaf tree, in the dust, at ten in the morning, asking him the single best question about English that any student had ever asked him. And he did not know the answer.

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He looked at **Thuraya**. **Thuraya** smiled. The smile did not help him. The smile said — *this is your question now.*

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He turned back to **Noura**. "*That is,*" he said, slowly, "*a very good question.*"

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A murmur of appreciation went through the children. **Mansoor** said, "*She asked a good question!*" — and was **gratified** by his own cleverness for noticing it.

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"*But,*" **John** continued, honestly, "*I do not know the answer.*"

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The children went quiet. Teachers, they had been taught, knew answers. Teachers who did not know answers were an unexpected **category**. **Ahmed** looked at him, specifically, with something close to alarm.

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"*But,*" **John** added, "*I will tell you what I think.*"

و
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He looked up — at the tree, at the village, at the water **threading** between the houses, at **Thuraya**, at **Safiya**, at the ten small faces who were now watching him and waiting for him to be honest with them.



"I think," he said, "we say 'good morning' because saying only 'morning' is not enough. Morning is just — a time. A fact. It says: the sun is up. But good morning says: the sun is up, and I am glad about it. And I am glad that you are here too."



He paused. He was not sure if he had done this well. *"So when you say 'good morning' to someone," he continued, "you are not telling them the time. You are **wishing** them something. You are wishing that their morning will be good. You are giving them — a small gift. Just at the beginning of the day. A small wish that things go well for them."*



Silence. **Noura** considered. Her face went through the specific stages of a ten-year-old considering a philosophical answer: first **skeptical**, then thoughtful, then surprised, then — almost against her will — pleased.



"So every morning," she said slowly, "we are giving a small gift?" "Yes." "To everyone we say it to?" "Yes."



She nodded. She turned to the child beside her — a small boy she did not know — and said, very deliberately, *"Good morning."* The boy looked at her. He looked confused. She said it again, more firmly. *"GOOD MORNING."* **Thuraya**, stifling a laugh, translated, in Arabic: *she is giving you a gift; you must take it.* The boy, understanding suddenly, smiled — and said, in careful English, *"Good morning."*



The children went around the circle then — without being asked, without being prompted — saying *good morning* to the child beside them, one by one. Small gifts. Handed around the ghaf tree in the dust, at ten in the morning.



***Safiya**, watching from the edge, realised that she had just watched her husband become a better teacher than he had been twenty minutes earlier. He had not known an answer. He had said so. And then — without panic, without pretending — he had thought about it, and told the children what he actually believed. Which was not a grammatical rule. Which was not a textbook sentence. Which was a small, true thing about how language works, and why people say the things they say. This, she thought, was what teaching was. When it was any good at all. Not the answering of questions. The **honouring** of them.*



She looked at **Thuraya**. **Thuraya** was already looking at her. They did not speak. They did not need to.

SCENE FIVE

Malood Takes the Page

It would have been, by any measure, a good place to end the morning. The children were quiet. **Noura** was still turning the idea of *good morning* over in her head. **John** had, for the first time in weeks, the look of a man who had surprised himself with his own usefulness. **Safiya** had her notebook open and was writing something. **Thuraya** was sitting cross-legged beside **Ahmed**, reading the exercise book over his shoulder — which **Ahmed** permitted, because she was **Thuraya**, but would not have permitted for anyone else.



A breeze moved through the ghaf. The leaves rustled — the small, dry, specific rustle of desert leaves, which sounded like nothing else in the world. Somewhere, a dove **resumed** its call. The morning, having handed over its gifts, settled into its middle hour.



And into all of this — like a small, horned **comet** — **Malood**.



He had been, at some point, drinking in the falaj. Then he had been, apparently, exploring the path. Then he had decided — through whatever mysterious **calculus** governed his small goat brain — that the most interesting object in the entire village was, currently, the paper on **John**'s bag.



He arrived at a **trot**. He jumped — lightly, with improbable grace — onto **John**'s bag. He seized the corner of a piece of paper in his teeth. He ran. The whole operation took perhaps four seconds.



For approximately two of those seconds, nobody moved. The children simply watched — with the specific **stunned** calm of an audience at a play who have just witnessed something unexpected, and who are waiting for the play to tell them how to respond. **John** looked at his bag. Looked at where the paper had been. Looked at **Malood**, now halfway down the path, paper flapping in his mouth.



"**MALOOD**."



The village, as one, came back to life.



Mansoor shouted something. **Khalil** burst into laughter. **Ahmed** sighed — a long, philosophical sigh — and closed his exercise book with the air of a scholar whose research has, once again, been interrupted by the arrival of a goat. **Noura** stood up with great authority. *"I will catch him!"* **Noura**, *no* — But **Noura**, at ten, was already running.



Then **Khalil**. Then the three smaller boys. Then **Mansoor**, who had been, until half a second ago, **reclining**. Then the **Marwa–Rahma–Salima** triangle, still in their triangle but now a moving triangle. Then **Mathila**. Then **Ahmed**, who had decided, with enormous reluctance, that scholarship could not keep him out of this.



John stood. *"Safiya."* *"Yes?"* *"That paper had — I had written — it was my —"* *"Your lesson plan."* *"My lesson plan."* *"For what?"* *"For the afternoon."* **John**. *"Yes?"* *"Did you learn nothing last week?"*



He looked at her. *"Apparently,"* he said, *"I have not."*



And he, too, began to run.



Safiya remained under the tree with **Thuraya**. They watched, the two of them — the goat ahead, the children behind, the Englishman at the rear, all of them in a long **ragged** line disappearing around the bend. The laughter carried back clearly. The sound of small feet. The occasional adult voice — **John's** — shouting, in English, words that **Malood** did not speak and had, by any reasonable measure, no interest in learning.



"Thuraya," **Safiya** said. *"Yes?"* *"How does one small goat **disrupt** an entire village this consistently?"* **Thuraya** smiled. *"He is not one person's small goat."* *"No. I know."* *"He is the village's."* *"And a village's goat is everyone's problem."* *"And everyone's joy."*



They watched the dust settle along the bend where the running crowd had disappeared. In the middle distance, a woman doing something in a doorway had stopped doing it — and was now laughing, hand over her mouth, at the **procession** that had just passed her house.



*Safiya thought about this. About how the day had gone — the pre-dawn falaj, the women, the order of the water, John's cold-water **baptism**, the ghaf tree and the gift of good morning. And now this. A goat carrying an English lesson plan down a village road, pursued by ten children and one red-faced Englishman. There was a **shape** to the day that she had not chosen, that none of them had chosen, that the village had simply provided. And the day's shape was, on reflection, exactly what it should have been.*



From the bend in the path, the first small figure reappeared. It was **Ahmed**. Walking back calmly. Carrying, in both hands, what remained of the paper — which was, admittedly, slightly less paper than it had been when **Malood** had first taken it.



He arrived at the tree. He handed the paper to **John**'s place beneath the tree, without ceremony. He sat back down. He opened his exercise book. He resumed reading, precisely where he had left off.



Safiya and **Thuraya** looked at him. "***Ahmed**,*" **Thuraya** said quietly. "*Yes, teacher?*" "*How did you get it?*" **Ahmed** considered the question. He turned a page of his exercise book. "*I walked,*" he said, "*in the other direction.*"



"*...The other direction?*" "*To where **Malood** was going. Not where he was.*" A pause. "*Goats always go back to qit. There is qit at **Sadoo**'s.*" "*You knew he would go to **Sadoo**'s?*" "*Every time,*" **Ahmed** said, "*he goes to **Sadoo**'s.*"



Thuraya looked at **Safiya**. **Safiya** looked at **Thuraya**. Both looked back at **Ahmed** — who had, without effort, just demonstrated the **fundamental** difference between the children who chased and the child who thought.



"***Ahmed**,*" **Safiya** said. "*Yes?*" "*Will you be a teacher when you are older?*" He considered. "*I will be a teacher now,*" he said, "*sometimes. And I will be a student now, sometimes. Then I will see.*"



Thuraya covered her mouth. **Safiya** shook her head slowly, smiling. And from around the bend came the first of the returning runners — hot, laughing, defeated — explaining in excited Arabic what had happened at **Sadoo**'s shop, which, from the sound of it, had involved **Malood**, a pile of dried dates, an older woman with a broom, and, against all reasonable expectation, a second stolen piece of paper.

SCENE SIX

The River That Is Not a River

The sun had moved. It was now the sun of late afternoon — lower, warmer in colour, slanting in long gold lines through the palm fronds and across the paths. The village, having spent its midday loudly, was entering its quieter hour.



Safiya and **John** walked back toward their house. Slowly. The way two people walk when they have done enough for one day and are looking forward, with quiet urgency, to a chair and a cup of tea.

Thuraya had gone home — to her own mother, to her own rooms, to the private part of her day that **Safiya** had begun to understand she should never ask about but should simply respect.



Their path took them beside the falaj. They passed the spot where the women had been at fajr. They passed the spot where the children had been at mid-morning. They passed the ghaf tree under which the lesson had been given. Each spot, now, held the faint **echo** of the hour it had belonged to. The channel was quieter now. The water still moved — **Safiya** was beginning to understand that the water never, ever stopped moving — but its sound was now the only sound. The late afternoon falaj was the falaj alone with itself.



"John," she said. *"Yes?" "I want to sit here for a moment." "Here?" "Here."*



They sat. On the low stone edge of the channel. Close enough to hear the water, close enough for **Safiya** to dip the tips of her fingers in if she wanted to. She did not, yet.



*The water in the channel had, over the course of one day, been many things. It had been drinking water for a child at fajr. It had been wudu for an old man before prayer. It had been the water a woman filled her kitchen with. It had been the water she bathed in at the majaza. It had been the water she rinsed her clothes in. It had been, briefly, the water in which an English teacher had washed his face and become — by an old village reckoning — a little less English. And it was now the water that would flow, in its last hour, out to the palms and the farms and the small green patches at the edge of the village, to feed the roots that would feed the trees that would feed the people who had, in turn, drunk and washed and prayed with it this morning. Nothing was lost. Nothing was wasted. The water simply **circulated**, patient and ordered, through the lives of everyone it passed.*



"John," she said again. *"Mmm?" "Do you remember what I said the first day we saw this?" "You said — it cannot be clean." "Yes." "And you were wrong." "Yes. But not in the way I thought I was wrong."*



He waited. He knew this voice. This was the voice **Safiya** used when she had understood something that had taken her a while to understand, and she was about to try to say it out loud for the first time, which meant he should be quiet and let her.



"In London," she said, slowly, *"clean means — separated. The drinking water is in one pipe. The washing water is in another. The water for the toilet is in a third. The dirty water goes away, to a place we do not think about. We are clean because we do not see the cycle. We have hidden it."*



She dipped one finger in the water. Lifted it. Watched a drop run back down into the channel.



*"Here, clean means — ordered. The water is the same water. There is only one channel. But there is an order. The drinking comes first. The washing comes after. The farm comes last. And because everyone knows the order, everyone trusts it. The cleanliness is not in the separation. It is in the **agreement**."*



John looked at the water. At the long narrow channel going down toward the palms. At the village at their backs, whose agreement this was.



"It is not dirtier than London," he said, slowly. "No. It is cleaner. Differently cleaner. We just had to learn what clean meant." "And the falaj taught us." "The falaj," she said, "has been teaching people this for three thousand years."



They sat for a while longer. The water moved. The light lowered. Somewhere far off, the first hints of a voice preparing to call **Maghrib** began to warm in the mosque below.



*"John." "Yes?" "I thought we moved to another country." "We did." "No," she said. "We moved to another **world**."*



He did not answer. He only reached for her hand and held it, the way he had held it the afternoon her father had given her the pen, long before any of this had begun — held it with both of his, and held it long enough for something to pass between them that did not need a word.



That night, back in the small clay house, under the single qandeel, **Safiya** opened her notebook. She did not write a list. She did not write a summary. She wrote three sentences. Slowly, carefully, with the Cartier pen her father had given her, in the handwriting she reserved for things she intended to keep:



*Today, I saw a river that is not a river.
I saw children who learn faster than they know.
And I saw a goat who does not belong to us, but lives with us — and who, I am beginning to suspect, lives with the whole village, because the whole village belongs to each other in a way no one has yet explained to me, but which the falaj has already, patiently, begun to teach.*



John read the page over her shoulder. He did not say anything. He only, gently, took the pen from her hand, wrote beneath her three sentences one more, in his own handwriting — and closed the notebook.



What he had written was: *Tomorrow, we teach again.*

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And somewhere, on the bisat in the corner of the room, **Malood** — who had, improbably, been permitted inside for this one evening, and who had **availed** himself of the privilege completely — was already asleep. His small flank rose and fell. One ear **twitched**, once, as though dreaming of qit. The falaj, outside, continued. It would continue, **Safiya** understood now, whether anyone was awake to hear it or not. That was the point of it. That was always the point of it.



Did You Know?

The Ghaf Tree

The classes gather under the ancient ghaf tree, like "a classroom without walls." This tree (*Prosopis cineraria*) has grown in Oman and the Gulf for thousands of years, famous for surviving extreme drought and staying green through brutal heat — some live over 120 years. It has long provided shade, food, and fodder for people and animals alike, which is why it was later chosen as the UAE's national tree.

Source: en.wikipedia.org · cad.gov.ae

PALM

Palm Six

A Fan, A Bird, and a Lesson on Tongues

SCENE ONE

The Dust That Follows

The afternoon in Al-Qurawashiyah had a temperature that words in English did not quite fit. *Warm* was not enough. *Hot* was too **aggressive** — this heat did not attack, it simply arrived and stayed, the way a guest arrives and stays. The sun was high. Even the shadows looked tired, **shortened** beneath the clay houses that threw them, as though even the shadows had decided to wait this hour out.



The small clay houses were sleeping under the heat. That was how **Sophia** thought of it now — *sleeping*, not empty, not abandoned. A house in this country at two in the afternoon was doing what a house was supposed to do in this hour: holding its cool inside its walls, keeping the family quiet, and breathing out through its open door only the low murmur of people who had agreed, collectively, to do nothing until the sun eased.



Only the sound of birds and faraway voices filled the air. **Sophia** stood in front of the simple house she shared with **John**, holding a thin carpet over a low wooden beam, and she was trying — with the particular **persistence** of a woman who had been raised to believe that carpets could be made clean — to beat the dust out of it.



The dust was winning.



Each **strike** of her palm against the carpet released a pale, **opinionated** cloud into the air around her. The cloud rose, **considered** its options, and — as though insulted — settled straight back down onto the carpet from which it had come. Some of it went higher. It found her hair. It found her neck. It found, improbably, the inside of her ear.



She lowered the carpet. She looked at her hands. They were grey-brown where they had been the colour of hands. She turned her palms up, slowly — as though they belonged to someone else, a woman she was meeting for the first time.



"This dust is not normal," she said. Not loudly. Mostly to herself. "I am sure it follows me."



John was sitting on a wooden box against the wall, a shoe between his knees, an **awl** in his hand, and an expression on his face that **Sophia** had come to recognise as the expression he wore when he was doing something that did not require the help of any woman, thank you very much, even if the woman was his wife and the task was clearly going badly.



He looked up. Slowly. With the considered calm of a man who had been waiting for exactly this sentence so that he could deliver his reply.



*"This is not dust," he said. "This is **history**."*



Sophia lowered her hand. She looked at him. She looked at the carpet. She looked at her hands again — which were, by any **objective** measure, dirty.



"John." "Yes." *"I am not,"* she said, with the specific, measured, **wifely** patience of a woman who had been married long enough to know exactly how many seconds **John's** jokes deserved — *"wearing history."*



John considered this. He placed the awl down. He looked at her — at the dust in her hair, at the grey-brown hands, at the carpet that had just mocked her — and, for perhaps the first time that afternoon, made the correct decision. He did not reply.



A breeze moved through the **compound**. It was a hot breeze. It did not cool. It only redistributed the heat, the way a spoon redistributes hot soup without cooling it. From somewhere down the path, a dove called — slowly, with long patience between each call, as though it too was conserving energy.



And then, into this thick, heavy, dust-filled afternoon silence — a sound.



Laughing. Loud. From far away.



Then shouting. Then more laughing. Then someone screaming — a short, bright scream that had nothing injured in it, the **specific** scream that belongs only to play. Then more laughing again.



Sophia lifted her head. She looked down the road — the white road, the dust-road, the road that led from the small cluster of houses toward the open sandy area between the village quarters.



"Something is happening."



John stood up. He set the shoe aside. He brushed his hands on his trousers — which did nothing, since his trousers were also dusty — and looked in the same direction.



"In this village," he said, with the quiet, settled certainty of a man who had lived here now for several weeks and had learned one thing about it beyond question, *"something is always happening."*



He offered her his hand. She took it — dusty hand in dusty hand — and together, slowly, with the specific pace of two people who had not been going anywhere ten seconds ago and were now going somewhere, they walked down the path toward the sound.

SCENE TWO

The Girls Who Were Flying

The sound grew as they walked. It did not grow the way sound grows when you approach a single person speaking — in an even, predictable curve. It grew the way sound grows when you approach a **flock**. In bursts. In overlapping voices. In the particular layered texture of **collective** joy.



They reached the edge of the open sandy area between the houses. **Sophia** stopped.



*Perhaps eight girls — she did not count them accurately; they were moving too fast — between the ages of thirteen and sixteen, she guessed. Their dresses were simple and **colourful** — reds, greens, deep oranges, one a particular shade of saffron that caught the high sun and seemed, for an instant each time its wearer turned, to be on fire. Their hair was tied back in different ways — some in long single braids, some in two, some simply gathered loosely. And their energy was — **Sophia** could think of no other word — **abundant**. It did not fit in the space. It spilled out, loud and long, in every direction.*



Two long lines had been drawn in the sand — simple parallel lines, perhaps five steps apart. One girl stood in the middle between them. The others were moving — running, **pivoting**, jumping, fainting — trying to cross from one side of the lines to the other without being touched by the girl in the middle. The girl in the middle was very fast. She was also laughing. Everyone was laughing.



"Turn! Turn! Jump!" one of the girls shouted — in Arabic, but with a **cadence** so clear that **Sophia**, who did not understand the words, understood the instruction.



Another girl — slightly older, a long green dress, braided hair — ran. She jumped. She almost fell — her body went sideways in a wild, **improvised** recovery — caught herself with a hand on the sand — laughed out loud at her own near-disaster — and sprinted away before the girl in the middle could touch her.



Sophia watched with wide eyes. The game was moving faster than she could **decode** it. She could see the two lines. She could see the girl in the middle. She could see the others crossing. But the **rules** — the specific rules — seemed to be known by everyone except her.



"This looks dangerous," she said.



John, beside her, tilted his head. He watched for several seconds. He watched with the particular quality of attention that **Sophia** knew he reserved for things he was about to call educational — a bad sign, in her experience.



"No," he said. *"This looks educational."*



"John." "Yes?" *"Everything you find educational, I find dangerous."* *"I have noticed."*



Behind them — a small sound. The soft, specific shuffle of **sandals** on packed sand.



Thuraya. A small woven basket on her arm. The same unhurried, composed **arrival** that she had been practising since **Sophia** had known her.



"You found the girls," she said, smiling. The smile had something in it — affection for them, some old memory of her own — that **Sophia** would understand only later.



"They are flying," **Sophia** said. It was the only accurate word she had.



"They are playing Leteg," **Thuraya** said. She said the name with the soft warmth of someone returning a word to a familiar mouth. *"We all played this when we were young."*



The phrase *when we were young* moved through **Sophia** more slowly than **Thuraya** had intended it to. It was not *when I was young*. It was *when we were young*. A plural. A whole generation of women, somewhere in their shared past, running between these same two lines, being told *turn! turn! jump!* by each other. **Thuraya** had been one of them.

~

One of the girls — slightly taller than the others, with a confident face and a **gap** between her front teeth — saw them. She stopped in the middle of the game, unbothered, and called out: "*Come! Come play!*"

~

The other girls paused, turned, and immediately took up the call. "*Come! Come! Come!*" — a small, cheerful **chorus**.

~

Sophia looked left and right as though perhaps they were calling someone else. She pointed at herself.

~

"*Me?*" "*Yes, you!*"

~

She looked at **Thuraya**. A silent, **pleading** look.

~

"*I think this is a bad idea.*"

~

Thuraya considered this. Her face took on the particular **composed** expression of a person who has already decided the matter.

~

"*It is a very good idea.*"

SCENE THREE

The Game is Honest

Sophia bent down and took off her shoes.

~

She did it slowly. She did it with the particular slowness of a woman who has agreed to do something she has not agreed to want to do. The sand was hot against the soles of her feet. Not painfully hot — the hour had passed its worst — but warm enough to **register**, to tell her, every second, exactly where her feet were.

~

"This," she said, straightening, to no one in particular, "is a very bad decision."



The girls laughed. The girl with the gap-tooth smile came forward — **Safiya** did not yet know her name, but she had the clear **bearing** of a girl the other girls looked at first — and took **Sophia** gently by the elbow. She led her to the line. She pointed. She said something in Arabic — fast and warm and absolutely **incomprehensible** — but her hands did most of the work. Stand here. Wait. When she moves, you move. Go there. Do not touch the line.



Sophia nodded. She understood perhaps thirty percent of what had been communicated, and had decided, with a kind of resigned bravery, that thirty percent was more than she had received in most of her interactions in this village and would have to be enough.



"Now jump," one of the girls said — and the word *jump*, in English, landed on **Sophia** like a rescue.



"Oh — yes. Jump. I can jump."



She jumped.



Wrong.



The moment her feet left the ground, seven voices around her shouted at her — not angrily, but with the specific, cheerful **urgency** of people trying to rescue a novice in real time. *"No! No! Not yet!" "Wait!" "Not like that!"*



She landed. She had jumped too early. She had also, somehow, landed on the line — which was apparently a significant offence, the specific gravity of which was not clear to her but was, from the volume of the response, **unambiguous** to everyone else.



She jumped again. Determined this time. Full commitment.



Wrong again.



This time the laughter was unconcealed. The girls around her **collapsed** — into each other's shoulders, onto the sand, one girl actually sat down because she could no longer stand upright. But there was no cruelty in it. Only the specific delighted laughter of girls watching an adult attempt

something a child would do better. It was a tender laughter. **Sophia** understood the **tenderness** even as she understood the laughter.



"This game hates me," she said — not really complaining, more announcing a fact to the sky.



John, from the edge, arms folded, watching with the **insufferable** calm of a man whose wife was losing publicly and who had had the sense to stay off the sand himself, said — with the quiet, settled clarity of a man who had just thought of the correct sentence — *"No. The game is honest."*



Everyone heard it. Even the girls, who understood only half. **Thuraya** looked at **John** with surprise — and then with the small, approving nod of a teacher who has heard her student say something unexpected and correct.



*The game was honest. It did not reward effort alone. It did not reward good intention. It rewarded only the thing it was built to reward — the exact timing, the exact weight of foot, the exact reading of the girl in the middle. Every one of **Sophia's** failures was a completely fair failure. The game had explained itself to her, each time, without words. It was, she understood now, a teacher.*



She tried again. She concentrated this time. She watched the girl in the middle — not the line, not her own feet, but the middle girl. She watched the middle girl's eyes, her weight, the **tilt** of her shoulder. The middle girl leaned left. **Sophia** went right.



Her foot cleared the first line. Her body turned. Her other foot landed cleanly between the lines. She **pivoted** — not gracefully, but genuinely — and her third step crossed the second line.



She had done it. She had, against any reasonable probability, crossed the lines without being touched, without touching the line itself, and without falling over.



She stopped. She looked down. She looked up.



She raised both her hands.



"I did it!"



The girls clapped. Not politely — **genuinely**, loudly, the way children clap when a child younger than them succeeds. The girl with the gap-tooth smile came forward and placed her hand briefly on **Sophia's** arm. "*Good. Good.*"



Sophia looked at **John**. **John** was smiling — not insufferably this time, but plainly. **Thuraya** was smiling the particular **proud** smile of a teacher.



And **Sophia**, standing in the sand, her hair coming loose, a thin line of sweat along her hairline, dust on her skirt — understood, not in her head but somewhere lower, that she had just been **admitted** to something.

SCENE FOUR

Darwazat Mutrah

Then one of the girls — a smaller one, perhaps thirteen, with very quick feet — shouted into the **aftermath** of **Sophia's** triumph:



*"Now we play **Darwazat Mutrah!**"*



The name entered the afternoon like a **starting pistol**. Before **Sophia** could ask what that was, the girls were already moving.



They began to run — in no direction that a newcomer could follow. One girl ran toward a house. One ran toward a tree. Two ran in the opposite direction from each other and then, apparently, from themselves. Someone shouted something. Someone else answered. The middle girl — who had a moment ago been between the Leteg lines — suddenly had the role of **pursuer**.



Someone fell.



Someone screamed.



Someone laughed.



All three of these things happened to three different girls, **simultaneously**, with no apparent connection between them.



And then, from nowhere — **Mansoor**.



***Sophia** did not see where he had come from. He had not been in the sandy area. He had not been walking down the path behind them. He had been somewhere else in the village, presumably, moments ago, and now, without any **intermediate** step — no approaching, no calling out — he was among them, already running, already shouting, already **integrated** into the game as though he had always been part of it.*



"***I AM FAST!***" he shouted, to no one and everyone.



He ran perhaps three seconds. The sand was deep. His feet were small. His **enthusiasm** exceeded his **coordination** by a clear margin. On the fourth second, he fell — **spectacularly**, sideways, with his arms out, landing in the sand in a small soft explosion of dust and shouting.



Two of the girls rushed to him — not worried, just checking. He sat up. There was sand in his hair. There was sand in his mouth. He spat — dramatically — and then laughed at himself, which was, **Sophia** had noticed before, his one **reliable** grace.



The game continued around him. He rejoined it. He fell again. Nobody was particularly surprised.



Sophia, meanwhile, had made a tactical decision. She had seen the direction of the running — seen the chaos spreading outward — and she had, with the good sense of a forty-year-old woman who had already that afternoon won a game by reading another girl's shoulder — decided not to run anywhere in particular.



She ran to a tree at the edge of the sandy area. She put her back against it. She folded her arms.



"*I am not a teacher today,*" she announced, in the general direction of the game. "*I am a tree.*"



The game stopped. Every girl stopped. **Mansoor** stopped. Even the dust **paused**, briefly, in the air around her.



And then — very slowly at first, then completely — every person in the sandy area burst out laughing. The laughter was not at her. It was with her. It was a specific kind of laughter that welcomed the joke into the game. The girl with the gap-tooth smile said something in Arabic that **Thuraya**, standing at the edge, translated an instant later — "*she said: then we will play around the tree.*"



And they did. They played around her. **Sophia** stood against the trunk with her arms folded, and the girls and **Mansoor** wove around her, past her, almost *through* her, running and shouting and falling and laughing, and she — still — did not move.



She had become part of the game without playing it. She had found, without meaning to, the **exemption** the game always secretly has. She was the tree.



After what felt like a long time — and had probably been ten minutes — the girls' energy finally began to ebb. One by one, they slowed. One by one, they walked to the edges of the sandy area and sat down on the warm ground. **Mansoor** sat last, on his back, his arms and legs out like a small dusty star. The game was over — because the **afternoon** itself had decided it was over.



Sophia detached herself from the tree. She walked, slowly, to the edge where the girls sat, and lowered herself onto the ground beside them. Her dress, when she sat, **puffed** a small cloud of pale dust into the air.



She looked at it. She looked at her hands. She looked at her legs, which were — it was clear now — thoroughly, **comprehensively** dirty.



"I am not a tree," she announced, to the same audience, with the same dry delivery. *"I am a very dirty tree."*



The girls laughed again. One of them — she had not seen which — said, in clear, practical English: *"You must wash."*



"Where?" **Sophia** asked — because she lived, after all, in a mud house with a jug of water and a small basin, and none of those had the power to solve what had happened to her.



The girls all turned and pointed, as one, in the same direction.



"In the falaj."

SCENE FIVE

The Majaza

Sophia's eyes — despite the dust, despite the heat, despite the small tiredness settling into her legs — **shone**.

~

"Nice! I want to swim!"

~

The response was immediate. Instant. Total. Every girl, as one, in one unified voice of **horror**:

~

"NOOOOO!"

~

Even **Mansoor**, still on his back, lifted his head and contributed an *"Ooooh!"* of his own, though he was clearly not sure why.

~

Sophia, taken aback, turned to **Thuraya** — who had, as she so often did, arrived at exactly the moment her services were needed. **Thuraya** was laughing. She laughed properly — head tipped slightly, hand over her mouth, the small shoulders shaking.

~

"Not like that," she said, when she had recovered. *"Women do not swim in the falaj. Women go to the majaza."*

~

"The majaza." "Yes." "What is it?" "You will see."

~

And **Sophia**, who by now had learned what *you will see* meant in this country — that no explanation was going to be offered, that the thing itself would do the explaining — put on her shoes, said goodbye to the tree, and followed.

~

They walked — **Thuraya**, **Sophia**, and three or four of the older girls who had **elected** themselves her escort — along a path that ran beside the falaj, past houses that **Sophia** had never quite looked at properly before. The path was narrow. It ended at a **low**, unassuming stone building — small, windowless at first glance, with a single wooden door painted a deep blue.

~

One of the girls pushed the door open. She gestured for **Sophia** to enter.

~

***Sophia** stepped inside — and stopped. The room was not a room, exactly. It was a **chamber**, perhaps four steps wide, four steps long. The walls were made of the same warm clay as every other wall in the village. But the floor — the floor was stone. And running through the centre of the floor, in a shallow*

trough, was a small, **swift** channel of clear water. It entered at one wall, crossed the floor, and exited at the other. The falaj itself, **routed** through the room. And above — the roof was open. Not entirely — a low wall ran around the top for privacy — but open enough that the sky, still pale with the afternoon, was visible directly above.



It was, in a single elegant **design**, a women's bath-house older than any plumbing she had ever known.



Inside were three women. One was older — perhaps sixty. Two were younger — perhaps her own age, or slightly younger. They looked up. They did not seem startled. One of them said something to **Thuraya** — short, warm, the **familiar** exchange of women who had shared this space more than once before.



Then they turned to **Sophia**. They smiled.



And the older woman said, in Arabic — **Thuraya** translated in a soft murmur — “*Come. We will help.*”



And **Sophia**, for the first time in several weeks, found that she did not know how to protest. She did not know how to be polite. She did not know how to say *no, no, I can manage*. The women were already moving — unhurried, practical — and they were moving with the quiet certainty of women who had done this for other women many times before.



They helped her wash.



They used **sidr**. The older woman had a small bowl of it — crushed, dried, pale green, smelling of something faintly floral and faintly medicinal. She worked it into **Sophia**'s hands, into her arms, across the back of her neck. The sidr foamed gently — not like soap, more like a gentle, **herbal** lather that smelled like a garden more than a bathroom.



They used **sandal**. Small chips of sandalwood, ground to a fragrant paste, applied in a small circle to the inside of each wrist. Once it was on, the smell was there for the rest of the day. **Sophia** could feel it moving past her nose — deep and warm and sweet — every time she turned her head.



And then — while she was still holding her arms a little away from her body, not quite sure what came next — the older woman produced a small stick of **kohl** and held it up, questioningly.



Sophia looked at it. She looked at the women. She looked at **Thuraya**. They were all waiting — quietly, patiently — to see what she would say.



She nodded.



The older woman leaned in. She was very close. **Sophia** could see the small lines around her eyes, the **steadiness** of her hand. She drew the kohl, very carefully, along **Sophia's** lower eyelid. Then the upper. Then the other eye.



When she was done, one of the younger women produced a small mirror — a round hand-held mirror with a cloth-backed frame — and held it up.



Sophia looked.



A different woman looked back. Her eyes were **darker** — not in colour, but in **presence**. They had become the main thing in her face. The kohl ran in a thin clean line along each lid, slightly thicker at the outer corners, and the result was — **Sophia** did not quite know how to describe it — ancient. She looked like someone who might have lived in this village a hundred years ago and known exactly what she was doing.



"Do I look beautiful?" she asked.



The women looked at each other. Then smiled — in a strange, knowing, slightly **ambiguous** way that **Sophia**, even in the moment, felt she should perhaps have paid more attention to.



But they did not say anything.

SCENE SIX

The Bee, the Kohl, and the Goat

Outside the majaza, **John** was waiting.



He had been waiting for some time. He had exhausted his patience for standing, had exhausted his patience for sitting, had exhausted his patience for leaning, and had arrived at a state that could only

be described as **idle**. He was standing under a small tree — a **neem**, perhaps — watching the path, picking up a small stone from the ground, throwing it against a wall, picking up another.

~

Then, without warning —

~

"AAAAAA!"

~

The scream came from **John**. It was not a **dignified** scream. It was a **stripped**, unprepared, animal scream — the scream of a man who has just discovered, without warning, that something small and fast has found the inside of his trouser leg.

~

He began to run. Not toward anything. Not away from anything. Simply *running*, in a loose circle, slapping at his own leg, jumping occasionally, uttering a **sequence** of English sounds that had long since left any language he had taught.

~

He fell.

~

He stood.

~

He ran again.

~

A small **nest** — it had been there, apparently, all along, close to the ground, near the base of the neem tree — had been **disturbed** by his idle wandering. And a bee — possibly a wasp; the distinction, in that moment, was entirely academic — had disagreed with him, firmly, on the inside of his calf.

~

"MY LEG! MY LEG!" he shouted.

~

Thuraya, hearing this from inside the majaza, came out at a full run. "*A bee! A bee? A wasp?*" "*I don't KNOW!*" "*Is it still in the trouser?*" "*IT IS NOT IN THE TROUSER. I HOPE.*" "*You need the hospital!*" "*I am fine!*" A pause. "*I think.*"

~

He was, in fact, not fine. But he was attempting a kind of **Britishness** about it, which involved standing very still, pretending the leg did not hurt, and looking, with increasing urgency, at the door of the majaza.

~

At precisely this moment — the door opened.

۞

Sophia came out.

۞

John stopped.

۞

Thuraya stopped.

۞

Every girl on the path, every woman, every goat — everyone in any line of sight — stopped.

۞

*The kohl, which had been applied with such **precision** by the older woman in the majaza, had met the beat of the afternoon — and the beat of the beat — and the faint, fine sheen of sweat that **Sophia** had not yet wiped from her own forehead and cheeks. It had melted. Not a little. Completely. Two long dark streaks ran from the corners of her eyes down her cheeks. Two more thinner lines ran down toward her chin. The upper lines had been disturbed by her own hand — she had, unthinkingly, rubbed her eye — and now ran in a smudged dark mask across her forehead and the bridge of her nose.*

۞

She did not know this.

۞

She stood in the doorway of the majaza in her washed dress, her sandal-scented wrists, her clean hair — entirely proud, faintly expectant, waiting for her husband's response.

۞

She looked like a very angry **ghost**.

۞

Or possibly a very tired **monster**.

۞

John looked at her.

۞

For one beat, his face held the question: *is something wrong? Is she unwell?*

۞

Then he laughed.

۞

Then he laughed harder. He laughed until he could not stand. The bee-stung leg, the burning pain, the whole question of the hospital — all of it, **temporarily** erased from his body — disappeared

into the laughing. He sat down on the ground. He fell backward. He lay in the dust, laughing with his whole chest, laughing so hard that **Thuraya**, concerned about the bee sting, had to kneel beside him and check that this was not some new, laughter-related medical crisis.

~

Thuraya looked at **Sophia**. She looked at the kohl. She looked at **John**, wheezing on the ground.

~

Then she laughed too.

~

Sophia, alarmed, touched her own face. She looked at her fingers. They came away black.

~

One of the girls, quickly — kindly — produced the small mirror from the majaza.

~

Sophia looked.

~

She screamed.

~

"I am going back to wash! I wash my face! I wash my hands! I wash EVERYTHING!"

~

She turned, marched back through the blue door, and disappeared into the majaza for what **Thuraya** would later estimate to be approximately twenty additional minutes of **thorough** washing.

~

Later — much later, when **Sophia** had emerged, de-kohled, re-composed, and the afternoon had begun to tilt into evening — they walked home. Slowly. Past the falaj, which was quieter now. A small boy — they did not know him — was splashing in the open channel, entirely at home, supremely unworried about germs or the specific order of water or anything else.

~

John looked at him. *"He swims in the falaj."*

~

Sophia looked at the boy. She touched her clean face. She looked at her clean hands.

~

"I wash my hands in the falaj," she said, very firmly. *"I do not swim."*

~

They walked on.

~

They reached their house. The sun was lowering now — that specific long-gold hour that this country did so well. They opened the door. They stepped inside.



And into their small clean house, through the still-open door, ran a small horned body — fast, determined, and unmistakable.



"MALOOD."



John, forgetting even his bee-stung leg, spun on his heel. *"WHY does this goat love our house?!"*



Malood did not answer. **Malood** had already reached the small wooden table. **Malood** was already — with the practised efficiency of a thief who had done this before, and would do it again, and who had, apparently, no intention of ever explaining himself — eating a piece of paper.



Sophia ran after him. *"MALOOD!"* The goat, with the paper still half in his mouth, **evaded** her neatly and left the house the way he had entered it, trailing a small torn edge of paper behind him as he went.



Sophia stood in the doorway, hands on her hips, watching him go.



"This village," she said, to no one, *"is not normal."*



That night, after they had eaten — a simple dinner, mostly rice, mostly quiet — **John** lay on the bisat with his leg slightly raised on a folded cloth, and said: *"Today we learned new words."*



Sophia, across the room, brushing out her still-damp hair, nodded slowly. *"Yes. Wash. Swim. Hospital. Bee."*



John, wincing slightly as he touched the small red swelling on his calf, looked at the ceiling.



"And pain."

Did You Know?

The Sidr Plant

At the majaza, Sophia's hands are rubbed with green sidr paste before kohl and sandalwood. This tradition is real and ancient: leaves of the sidr tree (*Ziziphus spina-christi*) have been dried and ground for centuries across Arabia and Persia as a natural shampoo, prized for cleansing the scalp and fighting dandruff thanks to their saponin compounds with antibacterial properties. This traditional hair care is still practiced today.

Source: babyheerb.com · thehujajistore.com

PALM

Palm Seven

The Three Letters of John

SCENE ONE

Mr. John and the Invisible Pillow

Mr. **John** walked into the classroom the way a brave man walks — with his shoulders back, his chin forward, and the specific **composure** of a man who had very recently, very completely, lost a fight with a very small enemy.

~

His shirt was neat. It had been pressed that morning with **Sophia's** particular brand of evening-before precision, and it sat across his shoulders in a way that suggested no mishap had ever befallen the man who wore it. His hair was tidy. His trousers were the correct length. His shoes, although not polished — no shoes in this village survived polishing — were at least matched. His smile **strained** itself into position. It tried. It tried very hard.

~

But his eyes?

~

One eye looked normal. Mild. English. The eye of a man who had slept adequately and was here to teach grammar.

~

The other looked like it was wearing a tiny invisible pillow.

~

*The wasp — the one from yesterday, the one that had risen from the small nest by the neem tree outside the majaza, the one whose memory **John** would carry in his leg for several days — had apparently not been satisfied with the leg alone. Something else had found him in the night. Something had located him in his sleep, in his sleeping face, and had left its mark along the **socket** of his right eye. The swelling had not been there when he went to bed. It had been there when he woke up — fully formed, fully committed, fully **magnificent** — as though an artist had spent the night working on it.*

~

The students stared.



This is the specific silence a classroom makes when the teacher has entered the room with a **visible** injury. Pencils stop. Notebooks stop. Conversations stop. Even **Mansoor**, at the back, for one full second, stopped.



Then **Mansoor** did what **Mansoor** always did. He stood up.



Not beside his desk. On it. He climbed onto his small wooden desk in one smooth, confident motion — in the way a small man climbs onto a stage he has been rehearsing for — and pointed at Mr. **John**'s eye with the full, **ceremonial** gravity of a herald announcing the arrival of something important — a royal wedding, perhaps, or the outbreak of a war.



"Teacher! Your eye is... BOOM!"



The class **exploded**.



It was not laughter that built. It was laughter that arrived — complete and full, as though every child had been saving it since the moment Mr. **John** had opened the door. Desks shook. Two boys at the back slid off their bench. One girl put her head down on her notebook and did not lift it for nearly a minute.



Noura, from her seat in the front, clapped her hands — twice, in small staccato celebration — and delivered her **verdict** with the crisp **clarity** of a small judge who had already reached her decision. *"It's true! It's big!"*



Khalil leaned forward with a serious face — a face so serious that everyone else in the classroom knew, immediately, that Khalil was about to be very funny. He placed one elbow on the desk. He held his chin in his hand. He looked at Mr. **John** with the thoughtful, **sympathetic** expression of a village elder diagnosing a long-suffering neighbour.



"Maybe," he said, in careful English, *"he cried all night."*



The class, which had been recovering, went down again.



Mr. **John** blinked slowly — carefully — as though blinking, if performed with enough delicacy, might persuade the swelling to change its mind. It did not. Blinking, in fact, made it worse. He felt the

small **tightness** of the eyelid. He felt the throb — low, patient — in the bone around the eye.

~

Ms. **Thuraya** walked in behind him.

~

She was carrying a piece of chalk and a thick notebook. She was, by all appearances, prepared for a normal morning of teaching. She had not yet seen Mr. **John**'s face.

~

She saw the faces of the students first. She saw the pointing fingers. She saw the wide grins, the half-covered mouths, the boy at the back making — with both hands — the precise *BOOM* gesture that had now, evidently, become the official gesture of the morning.

~

She stopped. She turned her head, slowly, toward Mr. **John**.

~

She saw the eye.

~

Her face — for one-quarter of a second — betrayed her. It was the small, **involuntary** widening of a teacher's eyes when a teacher has just understood, in a single glance, exactly how the next hour is going to go. Then she composed herself. She tapped the board twice — the small, specific taps that every student in every village in Oman understood.

~

"Good morning, everyone."

~

The students tried to behave. They tried with genuine effort. They tried for exactly two seconds.

~

Then **Mansoor**, still not entirely down from the desk, said — in a loud whisper to **Ali** — *"He looks like he slept inside a beehive."*

~

Mr. **John**, whose hearing was sharper than his swollen eye suggested, caught the word. His remaining eyebrow went up.

~

"Beehive?"

~

Ms. **Thuraya** did not answer. She was already writing on the board.

~

She wrote, in clear capital letters, two words:

~
€

WASP
STING

~
€

She turned to the class. "*Class — what do we say when Mr. **John** comes?*"

~
€

They remembered yesterday's lesson. They remembered the small gift. They remembered that *good morning* was something you gave a person at the beginning of the day. Some of them said it correctly. Some of them attacked it like a wild animal.

~
€

"*Good morning, Mister Jhon!*" "*Good morning, Teacher!*" "*Good morning... and... sorry for your eye!*"

~
€

Mr. **John** gave a small, courteous bow. "*Good morning.*"

~
€

It was not, he thought, the start to the teaching week he had imagined. But he was — he had to admit — among friends.

SCENE TWO

Yesterday I Felt Pain

Ms. **Thuraya** tapped the board again. The two words waited. She pointed to the first.

~
€

"*Repeat after me.*"

~
€

"*Wasp,*" the class said.

~
€

The word came out in many different ways. **Ahmed** said it with the clean precision of a boy who had been studying the shape of English mouths in a pocket mirror. **Noura** said it with her usual slight **flourish**, as though the word were part of a small speech. **Mansoor** said it with three extra syllables that English did not recognise but that he clearly felt were improvements.

~
€

"*Sting,*" she said again — pointing at the second word — "*louder.*"

~
€

The class shouted "*STING!*" with such enthusiasm that a small lizard on the outer wall of the classroom darted up and out of sight.

~

Mr. **John** pointed — carefully — to his swollen eye. He said, slowly, with the deliberate cadence of a man modeling a sentence for children: "*Yesterday... a wasp... stung me.*"

~

Ms. **Thuraya** nodded, approvingly. "*Good. Past tense.*"

~

She wrote on the board, in her clear hand — the two halves of the same room, present and past, lined up beside each other like mirrors:

~

Today: I feel pain.
Yesterday: I felt pain.
Today: My eye is swollen.
Yesterday: My eye was swollen.

~

The children copied the sentences into their notebooks. **Ahmed**, of course, copied them with **meticulous** care, each letter formed slowly. **Khalil** copied them at an angle that suggested either a **rebellion** against lines or a general unconcern with them. **Mansoor**, predictably, drew a small wasp in the margin.

~

Khalil raised his hand. He raised it with the specific **sweetness** that tells experienced teachers to prepare for a trap.

~

"Yes, **Khalil**?"

~

"Teacher," he said, "*your eye is swollen... or was swollen?*"

~

Mr. **John** sighed. The sigh was not theatrical. It was the specific sigh of a man whose **grammar** had just been used against him by a ten-year-old boy.

~

"*It is swollen,*" he said, carefully, "*and it was swollen.*"

~

The class laughed again — a smaller, warmer laugh this time, a laugh that knew what it had just witnessed.



Ms. **Thuraya** smiled. Her smile was kind. But her eyes held a **warning**. The eyes said — *enjoy this for one more moment. Then we work.*



"Okay," she said. "Today, we practice past simple. Everyone will tell a funny story. From yesterday. Or from any yesterday."



The students made small, excited sounds. The idea of telling a funny story was, to any ten-year-old in any country in any century, approximately the best news that a classroom could contain.



Ali sat up straight, like a ruler. **Ahmed** sat even straighter — like a ruler that wanted a **promotion**. **Khalil** arranged his face into the expression of a boy who was ready to perform. **Mansoor** adopted the expression of a boy who was ready to destroy the world, and possibly the floor, and possibly both.



Ms. **Thuraya** surveyed her class. She considered her options. She pointed at **Ahmed**.



"Ahmed. You start."

SCENE THREE

The Mijz

Ahmed stood up slowly. He held his hands behind his back — the small, serious posture of a man at a meeting who has been asked to address his superiors, and who has decided to rise to the occasion completely.



He spoke carefully. He used the English words he knew, and he filled the gaps between them with Omani **confidence** — which is a different kind of confidence than English confidence, and which believes, with unshaken certainty, that the **listener** will do half the work of the meaning.



"Yesterday," he said, "I... um... I went... to the farm."



Ms. **Thuraya** nodded. *"Good. Went is past."*



Ahmed continued. His voice gained a small **momentum**. *"I played with my cousins. I ran. I climbed. I fell."*



Khalil, who could not resist a good opportunity, whispered to the boy next to him — loudly enough to be heard by the whole front row — *"He fell because he is too straight."*

~

Ahmed ignored him with the dignity of a professional public speaker. He continued.

~

"Then... I got pain in my stomach."

~

Noura gasped. She could not help herself. She gasped **loudly** and fully, as though a very important piece of information had just been disclosed.

~

"Oh no!"

~

Ahmed lifted his chin. He was pleased with the reaction. He was, **Thuraya** realised, about to deliver the part of his story that he had, without question, been planning since the moment she had said the word *yesterday*.

~

"My grandmother said," he declaimed, "You eat too fast. 'My mother said, 'You eat too much.' My uncle said, 'You need...'"

~

Ahmed paused. He paused for a very long time — long enough for the pause itself to become part of the story. He looked at Ms. **Thuraya**. His face contained a small question. She knew the question. She had known this question was coming since the sentence began.

~

Ms. **Thuraya** sighed — once, quietly, almost **imperceptibly**. It was the sigh of a teacher who loved her culture, and who also loved peace, and who had just realised, in this specific moment, that the two were about to come into conflict.

~

Ahmed said it anyway.

~

"You need... mijz."

~

The class made a sound — a long, collective *"Ooooooh!"* — as though **Ahmed** had just spoken a **spell**. Every child in that classroom knew the word. Every child had, at some point, heard a relative speak of the *mijz*, either in warning or in memory.

~

Mr. **John** leaned — carefully, because of the eye — toward Ms. **Thuraya**. *"What is... mijz?"*

٢٧
ع

Ms. **Thuraya**'s smile became small. Careful. The smile of a teacher choosing her words.

٢٨
ع

"It is... an old treatment. Traditional."

٢٩
ع

Ahmed, before she could add any useful softening, lifted one finger like a small **lecturer**.

٣٠
ع

"They beated it."

٣١
ع

Mr. **John**'s eyebrows jumped. The good one, at least. The other was **immobilised**.

٣٢
ع

"They beated... what?"

٣٣
ع

Ahmed's eyes shone with the specific brightness of a storyteller reaching the **choice** part.

٣٤
ع

"The mijz."

٣٥
ع

Ms. **Thuraya**, realising that the story was going to continue regardless, did what any good teacher would do. She **absorbed** the story into the lesson. She turned to the board. She wrote, in clear English:

٣٦
ع

*beat
burn
treat
hurt
cure (old belief)
traditional medicine*

٣٧
ع

Ahmed, receiving this as encouragement, continued. He was enjoying himself now. Every second of telling the story was delivering him the full attention of fifteen other children — and, for the first time in his academic career, the full attention of two actual English people.

٣٨
ع

"My uncle made fire. He put the mijz in the fire. It became red."

٣٩
ع

Khalil, incapable of silence, whispered to **Ali** — *"Like **Mansoor**'s face when he lies."*

~
ع

Mansoor sat up immediately. *"I don't lie!"* A small, indignant pause. *"I just... change the truth!"*

~
ع

The class laughed. Ms. **Thuraya** did not — quite — laugh, but something moved across her face that was not unrelated to laughter.

~
ع

Ahmed went on. He was not about to lose his audience now. *"My grandmother said, 'Be strong.' I said, 'I am strong.'"*

~
ع

He looked at the boys around him with the specific expression of a small **hero** who had, in the past tense, been very brave.

~
ع

"I sat. I closed my eyes. I said... 'Ready.'"

~
ع

Mr. **John** — one good eye wide, one swollen eye doing its best — slowly began to shake his head. *"No, no, no..."*

~
ع

Ahmed, at this exact moment, delivered the climax. He acted it out. He raised one hand, pinched fingers together as though holding a small heated rod, and brought it down toward his own stomach — and, instead of naming the moment, produced the sound of it.

~
ع

"Then... TSSSSS!"

~
ع

The students shouted. They laughed. **Noura** covered her mouth. **Khalil** fell off his bench — slightly, not fully, enough to be funny but not enough to be **reprimanded**. **Mansoor** pretended to collapse onto his desk in sympathetic agony.

~
ع

Ahmed, unbothered, held his stomach — leaning back in his chair — like a man remembering the exact location of an old pain.

~
ع

"I felt like..." he paused, searching, searching — and landed, in his triumphant English, on the best possible comparison — *"...I became a chicken."*

~
ع

The class **roared**.

٢٧
ع

Ms. **Thuraya** pressed her lips together. She tried not to laugh. She failed — a little. A small smile broke through, and she **corralled** the class back with a single raised hand.

٢٨
ع

"Ahmed. Use past verbs."

٢٩
ع

Ahmed nodded seriously. He had been waiting for this instruction. He had prepared the exact past verb for the exact moment.

٣٠
ع

"I screamed."

٣١
ع

Noura clapped. *"Good verb!"*

٣٢
ع

Ahmed concluded his story with the **satisfied** cadence of a storyteller approaching his final line. *"After that... my stomach felt better. My uncle said, 'See? Good!' My mother said, 'Next time... eat slowly.'"*

٣٣
ع

He sat down. The class applauded — not quietly.

٣٤
ع

Mr. **John**, still processing the entire **sequence** of events that had just been described to him, raised his hand like a student.

٣٥
ع

*"Wait. This is **real**? You burned him?"*

٣٦
ع

Ms. **Thuraya** spoke gently. She chose her words with care, the way she chose all her words when she was explaining her country to someone who had not grown up inside it.

٣٧
ع

"Many people used it in the past. They believed it helped. Now we have hospitals. Doctors. Medicine. But in the 1970s — in villages — traditional ways were used. Some people still trust them."

٣٨
ع

Mr. **John** touched his swollen eye. Gently. *"I prefer,"* he said, with quiet **sincerity**, *"hospital."*

SCENE FOUR

One Sentence, Mansoor

The word *hospital* had barely left Mr. **John**'s mouth when **Mansoor** was already on his feet.

~

He had leapt from his chair with the particular speed of a boy who had been holding onto a piece of personal information for approximately forty seconds and could no longer survive without releasing it into the classroom.

~

"Teacher! I went hospital one time!"

~

Ms. **Thuraya** — who had, across the course of her teaching career, developed a very specific radar for **Mansoor**'s *I have a story* voice — turned immediately. She pointed at him with the exact **authority** that every student in the village had learned, by the age of six, not to argue with.

~

"Sit. One sentence only."

~

Mansoor sat. But his mouth did not sit. His mouth kept moving, as though his body had been given one instruction and his mouth had been given another, and the mouth was pretending not to have heard.

~

"Okay okay... I went hospital... I cried... I ran away..."

~

Ms. **Thuraya**'s voice became sweeter. It also became, **Safiya** noticed from the back of the room, much more dangerous — the specific **sweet-dangerous** voice that teachers use when a child is about to be managed, firmly, with complete public grace.

~

"ONE sentence," she repeated.

~

Mansoor froze mid-sentence. He considered his options. He considered them with the genuine, visible **gravity** of a small boy who has been told he has only one sentence of a story he wants to tell in six.

~

He looked at the ceiling. He looked at the floor. He looked at Ms. **Thuraya**. Then, with the small decisive air of a boy who had just arrived at his final answer — he chose the sentence. He chose the best one.

~

"I cried."



The class laughed — completely, delighted, **disarmed** — by the elegant, **devastating** economy of one sentence. It was, they all agreed later, a better sentence than the full story would have been.



Ms. **Thuraya** clapped once — a small, efficient **punctuation** — and brought the room back under her command.



*"Now. We fix **Ahmed**'s grammar."*



She turned to the board. She wrote, in clear capital letters, with a small  beside each line:



-  *Yesterday, I went to the farm.*
-  *My uncle heated the mijz.*
-  *I felt pain.*
-  *I screamed.*
-  *After that, I felt better.*



The class read the sentences together, in the unified, rising voice of children reading from a board.
"Yesterday, I went to the farm..."



*Safiya, watching from the back, saw how **Thuraya** had done it. She had taken the chaos — **Ahmed**'s story, the branding iron, **Mansoor**'s one sentence, **John**'s visible discomfort with the entire cultural conversation — and **distilled** it, without spilling a drop, into five correct English sentences. Past tense. Clean verbs. The lesson she had come into the room to teach. **Thuraya** was, she thought, an extraordinary teacher. And an even better **diplomat**.*



Ms. **Thuraya** turned from the board. She looked at Mr. **John**. *"Your turn. One sentence about yesterday."*



Mr. **John** cleared his throat. He looked at the class — at the many small faces, each of them waiting for him to deliver something they could laugh at or learn from or, ideally, both.



He composed his sentence. Slowly. Carefully.



*"Yesterday," he said, "I walked near a tree. A wasp stung me. I ran like **Mansoor**."*



Mansoor, who had just fallen silent in honour of his *I cried* sentence, sat up straight with immediate delight. He whispered to **Ali**, proudly — loud enough for Mr. **John** to hear, which was entirely the point — *"See? I teach him."*



Ms. **Thuraya** laughed — openly this time, without embarrassment. *"Good. Past verbs — walked, stung, ran."*



Noura raised her hand. Because of course she did.



"Teacher — can we say... 'He looked scary'?"



Mr. **John** blinked. His one good eye widened, which made the other eye look, by contrast, even smaller. *"I looked scary?"*



Khalil nodded. Seriously. With the specific, committed **gravity** of a boy who had considered the comparison carefully and now wished to offer his **professional** opinion.



"Like a tired camel."



The class burst again. This time Mr. **John** joined them — briefly, helplessly. His smile, however, came out crooked. Half of his face could smile. The other half was, at the moment, on **leave**.



"Thank you," he said, with as much dignity as the remaining functional half of his face would allow.

SCENE FIVE

The Ghoul

The class was beginning to settle. **Ahmed** was rereading his own story in his notebook with visible pride. **Noura** was adding a small decorative border to her sentence about *yesterday*. **Mansoor** was still, impressively, using his one sentence to its full **capacity**, by mentioning it, at careful intervals, to everyone within hearing. *"Hey — yesterday, I cried." "Hey — yesterday, I cried."*



The classroom was returning to its working **rhythm** — the sound of children thinking, of pencils moving against paper, of low talk about who had written what. Ms. **Thuraya** moved between the desks, checking, correcting, occasionally tapping a page to point out a missing past-tense verb.



Mr. **John**, eye still swollen but considerably more **settled** now — the class had absorbed his disfigurement into the day and moved on — wrote, slowly, his own sentence on a clean page. He was beginning to enjoy himself. He was, in fact, just about to ask **Thuraya** about the past tense of *forget*, a small grammatical curiosity that had just occurred to him, when —



Khalil leaned forward over his desk. His face was entirely casual. His voice was entirely calm. His manner was the manner of a man sharing **weather** news.



*"Teacher," he said, "last night... we saw a **ghoul**."*



The room went quiet.



Even **Mansoor** — an event of great statistical rarity — stopped. Stopped talking. Stopped moving. Stopped breathing, briefly, for approximately two seconds. Every child had turned to Mr. **John** to see how this information would land.



Mr. **John** froze.



The English word *ghoul* — which is what he had heard — entered his English imagination with the full **catalogue** of everything that word meant in English. A grave-robbing spirit. A monster from the stories of his boyhood. A **creature** from the dark pages of *Arabian Nights*, which he had, in fact, read, and which had, in fact, frightened him more than he had ever admitted to anyone.



"A... what?"



Ms. **Thuraya**, realising immediately what was happening — the gap between the Omani *ghoul* (snake) and the English *ghoul* (monster) was about to swallow her entire lesson — turned to **Khalil**.



*"**Khalil**," she said, carefully, "do you mean snake?"*



Khalil nodded. Entirely cheerfully. *"Yes. Ghoul."*



Mr. **John**'s face — what remained of it that was still capable of expression — lost all colour. His one working eye grew more worried. The swollen eye attempted to grow more worried, but was

prevented by its structural circumstances, and simply looked, instead, **permanently** worried.

~
€

"A snake?" he whispered. "In the village?"

~
€

Ali, proud of his English and eager to contribute, spoke up. *"Yes. It came near the water."*

~
€

Noura added — helpfully — *"It moved like this."* She waved her arm up and down in a long, **ribbon**-like motion. The demonstration was, unfortunately, extremely accurate.

~
€

Mr. **John**, without thinking, took one step back — and bumped the blackboard. A small cloud of chalk dust rose around him. He did not notice.

~
€

Ms. **Thuraya** did what good teachers do in a small **crisis**. She pretended not to be in one.

~
€

"Okay," she said, smoothly. "New vocabulary."

~
€

She turned to the board. She wrote:

~
€

snake
afraid
dangerous
near
outside
inside

~
€

Mr. **John** read the words. He read them carefully. His eye — the good one — stopped at the last two. He swallowed.

~
€

"Inside?"

~
€

Ms. **Thuraya** paused. She considered her options. She **calibrated** — precisely — how much honesty this situation deserved.

~
€

And then — because she was Ms. **Thuraya**, and because she enjoyed tiny, surgical jokes, and because the morning had earned one more small moment of **mischief** — she said, calmly:



"Sometimes... yes."



The students watched Mr. **John**'s face as though it were a film. His single working expression shifted through several **phases**. Disbelief. Calculation. **Resignation**.



He spoke slowly. With the **considered** calm of a man summarising his own situation for the record.



"So," he said, "yesterday... I was stung. Today... I am swollen. And tonight... I will be eaten."



Ms. **Thuraya** laughed — openly, warmly, the specific laugh of a teacher who has been waiting for the whole morning to crystallise into one perfect sentence, and has just been handed it by her **victim**.



"Not eaten," she said, kindly. "Just... frightened."

SCENE SIX

Animals Do Not Knock

The bell rang.



It was not a modern electric bell. It was a small brass one that **Abu Salim**, the caretaker, rang by hand from the school yard, with the specific steady **cadence** that he had been using for roughly twenty years, and which every child in Al-Qurawashiyah recognised before its third chime.



The students rushed out of the classroom like small **storms**, their voices overlapping in the specific half-English, half-Omani excitement that end-of-lesson had developed in this classroom over the last several weeks.



"Bye, teacher!" "See tomorrow!" "Mansoor, your bag!" "I forgot! I forgot!" "Ahmed, wait!" "Good — morning!" — this last from a smaller boy who had apparently decided that *good morning* was the best English phrase he owned and intended to use it at all times of day, regardless of context.



And then, as quickly as they had entered, they were gone. The sound of small feet faded down the path. The yard, which had been full of shouting, held, for a long second, only the specific pause that classrooms hold when their children have just left and the dust has not yet settled.

Mr. **John** did not move.

He stood at the front of the classroom with the board still full of past-tense verbs and the chalk dust still faintly visible on the back of his shirt from his earlier encounter with the blackboard. He looked at Ms. **Thuraya**, who was, with the calm precision of a person closing one day and preparing for the next, gathering her chalk bag.

He looked at her with the **beseeking** expression of a man who is asking — without quite asking — for the secret of survival.

"Ms. **Thuraya**," he said, carefully.

"Yes, Mr. **John**."

He chose his words. He chose them as a man chooses his final sentence before a very important exam.

"*In your village...*" he began. He paused. He considered his phrasing. "*...do snakes... come inside houses?*"

Ms. **Thuraya** lifted her chalk bag. She hooked its small strap over her shoulder. She adjusted her scarf. She moved — unhurriedly — toward the door. And at the door, she turned.

She smiled.

"Mr. **John**," she said, kindly, "*you live near farms. Near the falaj. Near trees. Sometimes... animals visit.*"

He nodded. Weakly. "*Animals. Yes.*"

She opened the door. Then — just before she stepped out — she added, with a small **grin**:

"*And sometimes... they don't knock.*"

Then she was gone. The door closed softly behind her. Mr. **John** stood for a long moment in the empty classroom. The sound of the falaj came faintly through the open window. Somewhere outside, a bird was calling. Somewhere outside, a child was laughing. Somewhere outside — his imagination unhelpfully supplied — an animal was, perhaps, on its way to his door. Not knocking.



He walked home slowly. The sun was still high, but **John** did not fully notice it. His mind was full of long, thin, ribbon-like shapes.



That night, in their simple house, Mr. **John** lay on his bisat and stared at the ceiling.



It was a simple ceiling. Wooden beams. Packed palm fronds. A single **qandeel** in the corner, its small flame moving slowly as the evening breeze entered through the open window.



*The problem with a ceiling made of palm fronds, when one has just been told that animals visit houses in this country and sometimes do not knock, is that a ceiling made of palm fronds is full of very small sounds. The "data-m="The long feather-like leaves of a palm tree; the structure that makes palm roofs" data-s="palm leaves, fronds" data-x="The fronds shifted in the breeze — a small, entirely innocent sound that, at this moment, was not innocent at all.">fronds shifted, occasionally, in the breeze. A small insect moved somewhere in the wood. A larger insect — possibly a lizard; possibly something worse — moved in the corner. And every one of these sounds, to a man who was now **primed** to think about snakes, became a story.*



Every small sound became a story.



A soft *tick* in the rafters became a small body moving across a beam. A distant rustle became something **slithering** along the outer wall. The gentle creak of the wooden door became, at one point, a small animal **testing** the latch.



Sophia, beside him, turned over. "**John**." "Yes." "Why are you not sleeping?" "I am thinking." "About what?" A pause. "About animals." A longer pause. "And knocking." "And knocking?" "Or not knocking."



She opened one eye. She looked at him across the small distance of the bisat.



"**John**." "Yes." "Go to sleep." "I am trying." "Try harder."



She closed her eye. Within two minutes, her breathing was slow and even. The specific, unfair deep sleep of women who did not know the Arabic word for *snake*.

٢٥

Mr. **John** lay awake.

٢٥

He lay awake for a long time. He listened to the ceiling. He listened to the breeze. He listened to the falaj, which, in the distance, continued its long, old, unbroken hush.

٢٥

And every small sound — just as the narrator of his evening had truthfully observed — became, in its own small way, a story.

٢٥



Did You Know?

Cauterization (Al-Kaiy) as Folk Medicine

Remember Ahmed's story about "mijz" and his grandfather treating his stomach pain with a hot iron rod? That's not story exaggeration — it's a real folk medical practice called "al-kaiy" (cauterization), used by Arabs and Bedouins for centuries to treat stomach pain and other ailments by burning the skin with hot metal. This traditional practice still survives in parts of the Arabian Peninsula today, despite the rise of modern medicine.

Source: [sciencedirect.com](https://www.sciencedirect.com) · [researchgate.net](https://www.researchgate.net)

PALM

Palm Eight

A Goat Named Malood

SCENE ONE

The Morning Walk to School

The morning sun was already warm — not yet hot, not yet the flat unforgiving brightness of midday, but warm enough, even at this early hour, to remind every person walking along the road that this country did not believe in gentle mornings.

~

Mr. **John** walked slowly toward the small school in Samail. He carried his bag in one hand — a **canvas** bag that had come with him from London, and which, in this dusty road, was beginning to take on the **patina** of a bag that had started a second life — and he rubbed his eyes with the other.

~

His eye, for the record, was still slightly swollen. The wasp had left a small, patient memory along the bone. It was a memory he intended to live with for a few more days.

~

"Why," he said, half to himself, half to the path, *"does everything here wake up so early?"*

~

Behind him, **Sophia** — **Safiya**, as everyone in the village now called her, with the specific warmth of a name that had been adopted, not imposed — was fixing her scarf. Her scarf had, by now, become a small daily negotiation. It was never quite in the position she had last left it. The village had a wind that worked against scarves. And her feet — which had been born in leather shoes and raised in them — were still learning what a sandy path required.

~

"This place is beautiful," she said, smiling — with genuine affection now, not the strained cheerfulness of her first weeks — *"but my feet are not happy."*

~

Ms. **Thuraya**, walking a step ahead, laughed without turning.

~

"Your feet will learn," she said. *"Everything learns here."*



*And **Safiya**, walking behind her, felt the weight of the sentence settle. Everything learns here. She understood, without needing to ask, that **Thuraya** had not meant only the feet. She had meant the eyes, which were learning to read light differently. She had meant the ears, which were learning to separate the adhan from the breeze from the falaj. She had meant the skin, which was learning to accept dust as a cosmetic rather than an insult. And she had meant whatever part of a person was deeper than all of those — the part that, without being asked, had already begun to rearrange itself around this road, this village, this morning.*



The school appeared at the end of the path. It was a simple building — white walls, a wooden door painted the specific deep Omani blue that doorways across Samail shared, a blackboard visible through the open window, a small collection of **chalk** on a small shelf by the door. No fans. No electricity. Only open windows and, through them, the sound of birds and the distant bleat of goats somewhere beyond the farm wall.



When they arrived, the children were already there. They were always already there. **Safiya** had begun to suspect, half seriously, that some of them slept at the school.



Ahmed sat straight like a ruler — bag on his knees, slate held at the exact correct angle, the posture of a boy who believed, with deep personal conviction, that good posture contributed to good grammar.



Ali was drawing something instead of writing. He was often drawing something instead of writing. He had the specific gift of a boy whose pencil, given any choice between a letter and a small animal, would choose the animal. Ms. **Thuraya** had, with the wisdom of experience, stopped fighting this.



Khalil was whispering and laughing — in that precise rhythm, whisper then laugh, that said a joke had been invented, had been delivered, and was now waiting to be improved. **Noura** was asking **Salima** a question. Knowing **Noura**, **Salima** had answered one and been immediately asked three more. **Marwa** and **Rahma** were sharing one pencil — a shared object that had, at this point, become the shared possession of everyone in their small triangle.



And **Mansoor** — because it would not have been a morning in Al-Qurawashiyah otherwise — was standing on his chair.



"Sit down, **Mansoor**," **Thuraya** said — not even loudly, not even as a command, more as a **ritual**. She knew the sentence. He knew the sentence. Neither of them expected the sentence to permanently alter his behaviour.

~

Mansoor sat down.

~

Five seconds later, he stood up again.

~

Mr. **John** clapped his hands — twice, sharply, the teacher's way of opening a morning. "*Good morning, everyone!*"

~

"*Good morning, teacher!*" they answered — in the layered, imperfectly-timed chorus of children who had learned the greeting but had not yet learned to arrive at it together.

~

"*Today*," Mr. **John** said, happily — the eye did not quite smile with him, but the rest of his face tried — "*we will learn how to talk about people. We say: He is... She is... He has... She has...*"

~

He did not get any further.

~

The classroom door slammed.

~

BANG.

SCENE TWO

The Shadow on the Wall

All the children jumped.

~

Khalil's eyes became big — the specific round alertness of a child who has not, in fact, been frightened, but who has understood, in the same second as the rest of the class, that *now is the time to be frightened*. **Mansoor**, who had just stood up for the second time, **relocated** behind **Ahmed** with an efficiency that suggested he had, in his short life, practised this.

~

Noura, whose voice was usually the first voice in any situation, lowered it to a whisper — a whisper that carried, somehow, more weight than any of her earlier questions.

~

"It's him..."

~
ع

Safiya looked at **Thuraya**. *"Who?"*

~
ع

Thuraya's face — the face that was, by now, **Safiya's** main way of reading the village — changed a little. Not with fear. Not with alarm. With the small **composure** of a person who has just heard a familiar footstep on a day when she had hoped not to.

~
ع

"Stay calm," she said quietly. *"Stay calm."*

~
ع

Outside — heavy footsteps passed near the window.

~
ع

THUMP.

~
ع

THUMP.

~
ع

They were not the footsteps of a child. They were not the footsteps of a small woman carrying water. They had **weight**, and the specific **deliberation** of a stride that had never been in a hurry in its life.

~
ع

A shadow appeared on the wall. A long one. The shadow of something tall, thin, passing slowly across the open window — and then, without pausing, continuing on.

~
ع

Ali said, in a small voice — the voice of a boy offering a piece of information he had not intended to offer in public — *"The old man..."*

~
ع

Marwa whispered, from the triangle, *"The magic man..."*

~
ع

Rahma, her voice very small, *"My mother says he is scary."*

~
ع

And **Mansoor** — from somewhere behind **Ahmed's** shoulder, so that his voice seemed to come from **Ahmed** himself, which **Ahmed** found deeply **objectionable** — added, with the full **gravity** of a report from his own father's mouth:

~
ع

"My father says he can talk to goats."

~
¶

Mr. **John** blinked. His one good eye widened. The other eye, doing its best, **strained** upward.

~
¶

"Talk to... goats?"

~
¶

Khalil, who had by now recovered enough to speak, supplied the name. *"Teacher... it is **Khalaf**."*

~
¶

*"Who is **Khalaf**?"* **Safiya** asked — and the answer that came was not one answer but many, all delivered at the same time, overlapping, interrupting, each child contributing the piece of the legend that they had inherited.

~
¶

*"He is scary!" "He lives alone!" "He has a big stick!" "He walks at night!" "He makes smoke!" "He is a **magician**!"*

~
¶

Mr. **John** attempted, with the specific courage of a teacher who has not yet been defeated by a morning, a smile.

~
¶

"There are no magicians," he said, firmly. *"Only teachers."*

~
¶

It was a good sentence. Calm. Rational. The kind of sentence that would have ended the conversation in a classroom in London.

~
¶

Just then, something fell outside.

~
¶

CRASH.

~
¶

The children screamed.

~
¶

"ABOOYAAAAAH!" — the specific, unlearnable Omani exclamation that means *oh my father*, and which emerges, unbidden, from the small chest of any village child who has just been genuinely startled.

~
¶

Some of them ran under the desks. **Mansoor**, now fully **committed** to the hiding strategy, pulled **Ahmed**'s bag over his own head. **Ahmed**, to his small credit, did not object. **Noura**'s three questions briefly became one question — "*WHAT WAS THAT?*" — at a volume that overturned her earlier whisper.

~

Safiya — without having made any decision to do so — had grabbed Mr. **John**'s arm.

~

"What was that?!"

~

Thuraya — calm in the way that teachers become calm precisely when their students cannot be — walked to the window. She looked out. She considered what she saw. Then — unexpectedly, in the middle of the small **crisis** — she started to laugh.

~

*"It's just **Khalaf**,"* she said.

~

"JUST?" Mr. **John** said — with the specific **incredulity** of a man who has just been told that the source of a village-wide legend is, in fact, not significant enough to justify the legend.

~

She opened the door.

SCENE THREE

The Man in the Doorway

Outside stood an old man.

~

He was very thin. He was very tall. And he was, in a way that **Safiya** would find herself still thinking about a week later, very **quiet** — and his quietness was not the absence of sound. It was a presence. A thing he carried. An **atmosphere** around him in which sounds — even small ones, even birds — seemed to step back out of politeness.

~

A long white beard reached halfway down his chest. His clothes were old — not ragged, but well-used, the clothes of a man who had long since stopped buying new ones because his old ones had become part of him. In his hand was a stick. Near his feet, on the dust, was a small cloth bag. Through its open neck, **Safiya** could see **herbs** — bundles of them, leaves she did not recognise, small brown stems tied with string — and, beside the herbs, a few old tools she could not immediately name.

~

He looked at **Thuraya**. His voice, when it came, was **dry**, flat, and completely calm.

~

"Your goat," he said, "is eating my plants again."

~

Behind him — visible now through the open door, chewing happily, entirely **unrepentant** — stood **Malood**.

~

Safiya's eyes became big. *"Oh no. Not again."*

~

Thuraya lowered her head slightly — the small, formal lowering of respect that **Safiya** had begun to notice among younger people when they spoke to older ones.

~

*"Sorry, **Uncle Khalaf**. We will keep him away."*

~

Khalaf did not nod. He did not wave the apology off. He simply accepted it, and allowed his gaze to move — slowly, unhurriedly — from **Thuraya**, past her, into the room, to the two foreigners standing behind her.

~

He looked at Mr. **John**.

~

He looked at **Safiya**.

~

He looked at them with the specific calm **attentiveness** of a man who had lived long enough to read a face once and not need to read it a second time.

~

"You are the new teachers," he said. Slowly. It was a statement, not a question. He already knew.

~

*"Yes," Mr. **John** said. He cleared his throat. He found, to his own small surprise, that he was using his careful teacher-voice — the voice he used when a student was waiting for a correct sentence. "I am **John**. This is my wife, **Sophia**."*

~

Khalaf's eyes moved to **Sophia**'s face. They stayed there for a long time — not intrusively, not uncomfortably, but with the same careful reading he had offered Mr. **John**. It was the look of a man who had decided, quietly, to see who these people were.

~

Then — the smallest softening around the mouth, not quite a smile.

۞

"You look afraid," he said.

۞

Sophia laughed — nervously, the laugh of a woman who has just been seen more clearly than she had prepared to be seen.

۞

"No... just... surprised."

۞

He did not reply to this. He did not challenge it. He simply nodded, once, as though *surprised* were an answer he had heard before and found acceptable. He picked up his cloth bag. He turned. He walked away — with the same heavy, unhurried stride that had announced his arrival — and disappeared around the corner of the school wall.

۞

The moment he was out of sight, the children came out.

۞

Not carefully. Not cautiously. *Explosively* — in the way that children, who have been pretending to be terrified for approximately two minutes, now pretend to be entirely recovered. **Mansoor** emerged from under **Ahmed's** bag with the triumphant air of a **survivor**. **Khalil**, recovered from his initial alarm, immediately began to talk.

۞

"See? He is strange!" "He doesn't smile!" "He talks to himself!" "My cousin says he makes medicine!" "My brother says he makes smoke!"

۞

Mr. **John** — who was, by training and by temperament, constitutionally **opposed** to myth — walked to the board and picked up his chalk.

۞

*"Look," he said. "Look. We can **describe** him."*

۞

He wrote on the board, clearly, in the same capitals he always used:

۞

He is old.

He is thin.

He has a stick.

He walks slowly.

٧٧
ع

He turned back to the class.

٧٨
ع

Ahmed — the boy whose seriousness had been his identity since the first day — raised his hand. His face was composed. His posture was, as always, a monument to good spinal habits.

٧٩
ع

"Teacher," he said, in his careful, measured English. *"He is not a magician. He is just... quiet."*

٨٠
ع

Every head in the classroom turned toward him. **Ahmed's verdicts** were rare. When they came, they counted.

٨١
ع

Khalil, slightly uncertain — challenged in his own mythology — said, *"Are you sure?"*

٨٢
ع

Ahmed nodded. Once. Without **elaboration**.

٨٣
ع

"My grandfather knows him."

٨٤
ع

Silence. The specific silence of a myth being slightly, gently **punctured**.

٨٥
ع

Mansoor, unwilling to let go of an excellent story without a fight, offered — *"But he is still scary."*

٨٦
ع

Sophia — **Safiya**, in this room, from this day on — laughed. Not at him. With him.

٨٧
ع

"Sometimes," she said, *"people look scary. But they are not."*

SCENE FOUR

The Missing Ring

That afternoon, in the small clay house at the edge of the village, **Safiya** could not find her ring.

٨٨
ع

She had been wearing it, she was certain, that morning. It was her mother's ring — a small band of gold, nothing showy, the kind of ring that a woman wears so long that she stops noticing it in the same way that a person stops noticing the weight of their own hand. She had worn it in London. She had worn it on the plane. She had worn it on the first day here and the second and every day since.

٨٩
ع

Now, looking down at her hand — her hand that was, she realised, slightly **lighter** than it had been at breakfast — she understood what had been bothering her, faintly, for the last half hour without being named.



"My ring!" she said, standing up abruptly. *"It's not here!"*



Mr. **John**, who had been half-asleep on the bisat, came fully awake in the way that husbands come fully awake when their wives produce that specific kind of sentence.



They searched the house. They searched every surface that a ring could **plausibly** be. The table. The small wooden shelf where **Safiya** kept her few books. Her bag. Another bag. The bed. Under the bed. Inside the bed. The small stone bowl where she sometimes placed keys. The corner where her scarf had been hung that morning. The floor of the kitchen, which they swept, twice.



Nothing.



"Oh no," **Safiya** said. She sat down on the bisat. The particular **hollow** where the ring had been felt, now, very noticeable. *"It's gone."*



Outside, on the path that ran past their door, two small figures were passing by — **Khalil** and **Ali**, carrying something that had clearly just been stolen from somebody's orchard. They heard **Safiya's** voice through the open door. They stopped.



Khalil — because his mind, like every ten-year-old mind, ran on a very particular **logic** inherited from his mother, from his grandmother, from every auntie who had ever told a story in the village — leaned in and whispered to **Ali**:



*"Maybe **Khalaf** took it."*



Ali's eyes became big. *"The magician!"*



And that was all it took. Within ten minutes — the village was small, and a theory moved through it at the speed of footsteps — every child was **animated** by the same story.



*"He took it!" "He uses it for magic!" "He will make **smoke**!" "He will turn it into a **frog**!"*



Mr. **John**, hearing all of this through the open door, **sighed** — the sigh of a rational Englishman being **outnumbered** — and went to the door.



"No one," he announced, carefully, to the assembled children, *"is turning anything into a frog."*



But his voice — **Safiya** noticed, coming up behind him — was not entirely as confident as the sentence required. Even **John**, she understood, was not, at this moment, *entirely* sure.



Thuraya had been summoned. She arrived within minutes — the village's speed being, once again, remarkable — and took the whole situation in with a single glance. The worried wife. The unsure husband. The children, already gathered outside, loudly organising themselves into a small expedition.



"We will go to his house," she said, simply. *"We will ask."*



"Do you know where he lives?" **Safiya** asked. *"Yes."* *"Does everyone?"* *"Everyone."*



They walked. **Thuraya** in front — slightly ahead, at the pace of a person who did not want to arrive too fast or too slow. Then **Safiya** and **John**. Then — because the village always came too — a small trail of children, keeping a **prudent** distance behind them.



The house was a small mud house near the farms. Simple. Low. Older than many of the houses **Safiya** had walked past. The door was a plain wooden door, painted the same blue that every door in this village wore, but faded — more than any other door she had seen.



Safiya, without meaning to, reached for **Thuraya's** hand. **Thuraya** took it without looking down.



"Thuraya," **Safiya** whispered. *"Why is my heart beating like this?"*



Thuraya looked at her. Her face was, as always, composed. But the answer she gave was one **Safiya** would remember for the rest of her life.



"Because stories are stronger than truth."



They knocked.

٧٥

KNOCK.

٧٦

KNOCK.

٧٧

The door opened — slowly — as all good doors in a village do. **Khalaf** stood inside it. He had not been expecting them. He was also not, it seemed, surprised.

٧٨

"Yes?"

SCENE FIVE

The Open Hand

Thuraya spoke first. In the calm, polite Arabic that one uses with elders — and which **Safiya**, standing beside her, could now recognise even when she could not fully translate.

٧٩

*"Sorry to disturb you, Uncle **Khalaf**. **Sophia** lost her ring."*

٨٠

Khalaf looked at them. He looked at them for a moment — not **suspiciously**, not defensively, simply *looked*, in the same careful way he had looked at them that morning through the classroom door. He did not ask them to come inside. He did not invite them to wait.

٨١

He turned. He walked back into the small dark interior of his house. The children behind them, who had been whispering, went silent.

٨٢

He was gone for perhaps fifteen seconds.

٨٣

He came back.

٨٤

He stood in the doorway. And he **opened** his hand.

٨٥

Inside it — bright and small and entirely impossible — was the ring.

٨٦

*For a long second, nobody spoke. **Safiya** looked at her ring. She looked at **Khalaf's** hand — thin, **weathered**, with knuckles that had seen many winters in a country that had very few. The ring sat in*

the centre of his palm, small and gold, exactly as she had last seen it that morning. She had been wearing it when she left the house. She had not noticed when it had left her. But it had, and now it was here — inside the hand of the man the children had, an hour ago, accused of stealing it.



And **Khalaf**, without any change of expression, explained.



"It was near my plants," he said — calmly, without pride, without reproach. "Your goat likes shiny things."



All of them — every human being present — looked at **Malood**.



Malood had arrived, at some point during the walk, without anyone noticing, and had positioned himself — with the specific **proprietary** air he applied to every place he entered — near the door of **Khalaf**'s small house. He was currently chewing something. He looked up at the humans who had all, at the same instant, turned toward him. He **considered** them. Then he continued chewing.



He said nothing. He never said anything. He simply kept eating — whatever it was, whatever had once belonged to whoever — with the full, serene self-**possession** of a creature who had, a long time ago, decided that he was not going to be embarrassed by anyone.



Safiya laughed — the laugh of a woman whose afternoon had, in a single second, been re-explained to her from beginning to end.



*"Oh..." she said. "**Malood**."*



Khalaf, meanwhile, had placed the ring — carefully, precisely — into her palm. He did not **linger**. He did not smile.



He met her eyes. Just once. And delivered the only **counsel** he offered.



"Next time," he said, "close your door."



Then he stepped back. He closed the door — slowly, without **emphasis**, simply closing it — and went back inside.



The small group outside stood for a moment, unmoving. **Safiya** looked down at the ring in her palm. She slid it back onto her finger. The small hollow that had been there all afternoon closed up.

~

They turned, slowly, and began to walk home.

~

The children — who had been watching the whole exchange from a **respectful** distance — were, for the first time that afternoon, silent.

~

Finally, **Mansoor** spoke.

~

"He is not a magician."

~

Khalil, a few steps behind, added — quietly, as though admitting something — *"He is just... an old man."*

~

Ali, the last to speak, offered the sentence that **Safiya** would later write in her notebook.

~

"A kind old man."

SCENE SIX

The Notebook and the Thump

That night, in the small clay house at the edge of the village, Mr. **John** sat at the small wooden table with his notebook open in front of him.

~

The oil lamp burned low — its flame steady, its light the specific warm yellow that had, over the past weeks, become the light that **John** now **associated** with thinking. Outside, the village had gone quiet. The falaj continued, as always. A dog barked once, somewhere very far away, and then was still.

~

He picked up the Parker pen he had brought from London — a gift, years ago, from a student who had since become a professor somewhere — and opened the notebook to a fresh page.

~

He thought for a moment. He **composed** carefully. And then, in his even, slightly slanted English teacher's handwriting, he wrote:

~

Today, we learned something important.
Not every scary story is true.
And not every quiet man is bad.



He read it back. He read it twice. He underlined, almost unconsciously, the word *quiet*. Then he closed the notebook.



He stood. He **stretched**. He blew out the small flame of the oil lamp — and the room became, for one complete second, fully dark, until his eyes adjusted to the softer moonlight coming in through the open window.



He walked toward the bisat — toward **Sophia**, who was already lying down, who had pulled the light cloth up to her shoulder in the specific way of women who had decided that the day was over.



Then — he stopped.



He had heard a sound.



THUMP.



THUMP.



Outside. Near the path. Slow. Heavy. The specific **weight** of a stride he had, this very morning, heard pass beneath the classroom window.



A shadow passed the edge of the window — tall, thin, unhurried — and continued on.



Mr. **John** sat up. Not fully. Just enough to hear, more clearly, the rhythm of the footsteps receding — *thump*, a pause, *thump*, a longer pause, and then only the sound of the falaj and the breeze and the small night.



"Sophia..."



"Yes?" She did not open her eyes. Her voice carried the specific slowness of a woman being pulled back from the edge of sleep, and who was not going to be pulled back very far.

☪

He considered his question. He considered it with the care of a man who had promised himself, just that afternoon, that he had learned his lesson. He had written it down. *Not every scary story is true. Not every quiet man is bad.* He had signed his name, in effect, to that idea.

☪

And yet.

☪

"...you don't think he really makes smoke, right?"

☪

Sophia, eyes still closed, smiled — a smile **John** could hear, even in the dark. Her voice, when it came, was patient, **wifely**, and entirely unafraid.

☪

"No."

☪

A small pause. The smile, he could still hear, was growing.

☪

"But if he does," she said, *"please go and talk to him."*

☪

Mr. **John** pulled the blanket up to his chin. He considered the night. He considered the village. He considered the small, dry, unsmiling man who had, that afternoon, returned his wife's mother's ring without ceremony and without comment — and who was now, apparently, walking past their house at some late hour, carrying, for all he knew, herbs, or tools, or nothing at all.

☪

"I will talk to him," he said, slowly, *"tomorrow."*

☪

Outside, the second *thump* — the last one — faded, and the village returned to the steady **hush** of the falaj and the night.

☪

Mr. **John** did not, for some time, sleep.

☪

But when he finally did — and this was a small, important victory — he slept, for the first time in three nights, **without** dreams of ghouls, without dreams of snakes, and without any particular fear of his own ceiling.

...

 Did You Know?**Goats' Curious Mouths**

Remember Malood being accused of swallowing Sophia's ring? In reality, goats are extremely curious animals that explore their surroundings with their mouths, much like toddlers use their hands. They'll chew any strange or shiny object out of curiosity, not necessarily to eat it. This is exactly why goats have a worldwide reputation for "eating everything," even though it's usually curiosity rather than real hunger.

Source: kids.spcaceducation.org.nz

PALM

Palm Nine

The Smoke and the Sahir

SCENE ONE

The Truck at the School

The sun was still soft when everyone started to gather near the small school in Samail.

☪

It was the specific kind of early morning that this country did so well — the sun had crossed the **threshold** into morning but had not yet committed to its full brightness, and every surface it touched came back in the colour of honey rather than gold. The air had the cleanness that it held only for these brief hours. The village was, for one small window, possible to breathe.

☪

The pickup truck of **Uncle Nasser** was already there.

☪

*It was old. It was noisy — even sitting still, it made a small, dry **settling** noise, like an old animal getting comfortable on the ground. And it was strong. Its paint had been white once, perhaps — perhaps green — but the years and the dust and the wadi beds had settled onto it a uniform dun colour that was the colour of the roads themselves. It looked, unmistakably, like a truck that had carried half the village many times before. **Safiya** could see, just by looking at it, that its bed had held sheep, goats, wedding parties, men returning from market, women going to weddings, children going to wadis, firewood, furniture, and — today — a small expedition of schoolchildren and two English teachers.*

☪

The children were excited. They were, at eight in the morning, at a level of excitement that most adults could not have sustained for more than three minutes.

☪

Mansoor was jumping — not toward anything, not away from anything, just *jumping*, the way small boys jump when the instruction they have been given (*wait here*) has proven, within seconds, to be **incompatible** with his body's plans for the morning.

☪

Khalil — in the corner of her eye, because he was always in the corner of her eye — was already planning trouble. She could see it in his posture. He had that small, focused, **scheming** look, and the

Ali-beside-him was listening to the scheme with the small happy face of a boy who had just been included.



Ahmed was holding his bag carefully. He had, **Safiya** had noticed, a specific way of holding bags — with both hands, close to his chest, as though the bag contained something important. The bag contained, she had once discovered, three pencils, a slate, a cloth, and a small round pebble he had found the previous year and had no intention of ever losing.



Noura was asking ten questions at the same time. **Thuraya**, to whom most of the questions were being addressed, was answering them in the specific **rotation** of a teacher who has learned not to panic when ten questions arrive at once.



"Where are we going?" "Al-Lajal." "Is it far?" "A little." "Will there be food?" "Yes." "What food?" "You will see." "Is there a falaj?" "Yes." "Can we swim?" "That depends."



Marwa, **Rahma**, and **Salima** were sharing dates from a small paper twist. They were sharing with the ritual care of girls who had been sharing food with each other since they had been small enough for dates to be a significant event in the day — one date for **Marwa**, one for **Rahma**, one for **Salima**, then the whole rotation again, without any of them needing to say whose turn it was.



Ali was trying to climb into the truck first. He had, by the look of him, already tried twice. The first time, he had not been able to reach the high side. The second time, a larger boy had lifted him partway and then, deciding the joke was over, had put him down. He was now, on his third attempt, recruiting a small stool from beside the wall.



Safiya — dressed in her longest skirt, with the scarf she had learned to tie properly, and carrying the small cloth bag that **Thuraya**'s mother had given her last week — was fixing her scarf again. It had slipped slightly in the walk from the house. She was getting better at it. Not expert. But better.



She was smiling. She was, she realised as she caught sight of her own face in the dusty truck window, genuinely smiling — the small, unforced smile of a woman who had woken up that morning and been looking forward to this.



She looked at the back of the pickup. At the high metal sides. At the bare, open bed with no seats, no belts, no anything except the sky above.



"Are you sure this is safe?" she asked.

﴿

Thuraya laughed — the clean, warm laugh she always laughed when **Safiya**'s English concept of safety collided with the Omani concept of how things actually worked.

﴿

"Very safe," she said. "You just hold tight... and don't fly away."

﴿

"Fly away," **Safiya** repeated, slowly, as though trying out the phrase in her mouth. "That is my new concern."

﴿

Mr. **John**, meanwhile — who had been standing beside the front tyre, hands on his hips — was looking at the truck with shining eyes. Actually shining. His eye was mostly **recovered** now, and he was using its full expression with the delight of a man who had, for many days, been limited to half his face.

﴿

"**Adventure!**" he announced. "I love adventure."

﴿

Thuraya looked at him. She smiled in a particular way — a smile **Safiya** had, in her weeks here, begun to identify as *the Thuraya-knows-something-that-John-does-not* smile. It was small. It was patient. It was waiting.

﴿

"Yes," she said. "You love it."

﴿

Uncle Nasser — a broad man with a sun-dark face, a generous laugh, and the specific, settled **competence** of a man who had been driving village trucks since before half the children in his bed were born — clapped his hands once.

﴿

"Yalla! Everyone up!"

﴿

The word *yalla* — **Safiya** had learned — contained, in its two small syllables, the entire Omani concept of *let us go, quickly, but also gently, but also now*. It was a word that did the work of several English sentences.

﴿

The children began to climb. **Ahmed**, composed. **Mansoor**, too fast, and nearly over the far side. **Noura**, still asking questions. **Ali**, with his small stool. **Khalil**, with a small, private, scheming

satisfaction.

~
ع

Soon, they were all in the back of the pickup — the children holding the high sides, **John** and **Safiya** sitting on the metal floor with them, trying not to fall. **Thuraya** — being **Thuraya**, who was not to be argued with — took the front seat next to **Uncle Nasser**.

~
ع

The engine started. It was the loud, asthmatic, wholehearted cough of an old truck being asked, one more time, to do what it had always done. It caught. It held. It began to move.

SCENE TWO

Al-Naabi and the Fenzuz

The pickup rolled forward, and dust rose behind them in a long, soft **plume** that did not settle quickly. The road out of Samail was long, brown, and full of stones. It was not the London concept of a road. It was the Omani concept — a path that had been worn into the **earth** by the decades of feet and hooves and tyres that had gone the same way before them.

~
ع

Mansoor, from his spot near the side of the pickup, shouted — as though the noise of the engine required him to shout, and possibly also because he was **Mansoor** —

~
ع

"Where are we going?"

~
ع

Thuraya turned in her seat. She had to half-lean out of the window to make herself heard.

~
ع

"To Al-Lajal. In Wadi Al-Maawil."

~
ع

"What is Al-Lajal?" Ali asked.

~
ع

Thuraya turned — not quite fully, because the road was rough, but enough to meet **Ali's** eyes. And she said the next sentence with the specific, quiet **pride** of a person who had been waiting for the question.

~
ع

"It is a village. And it is full of my family. The Al-Naabi tribe."

~
ع

"The tribe?" John asked. The word had surfaced in him with the mild **puzzlement** that he always carried when an Arabic-English word appeared. *"What is a tribe?"*



Thuraya smiled. The smile had affection in it — not the affection of correcting a mistake, but the affection of **opening** a door that she was happy to open.



"In Oman," she said, "people belong to tribes. Big families. Old families. We say: this is my tribe. This is my name. This is my history."



She said each of those three sentences slowly. With a small pause after each. As though handing over three pieces of the same picture, one at a time, so that **John** could hold them one at a time.



*And **Safiya**, sitting in the back with her hands braced against the side of the pickup, felt the sentences land. They were three sentences that English, in its economical way, would have **compressed** into one. Arabic had decided, long ago, that they were three different sentences. And now, bearing them separated, **Safiya** understood why. My tribe was one thing. My name was another. My history was a third. They belonged together, yes, but they were also — each of them — its own kind of gift.*



The truck bumped over a particularly deep ridge. Every child in the back rose, briefly, into the air, and came down again laughing. **Safiya** grabbed the side of the truck. **John**'s bag slid across the metal floor and came to rest against **Ahmed**'s feet — **Ahmed**, predictably, picked it up and held it carefully until **John** could reach for it again.



*"In Oman," **Thuraya** continued, raising her voice a little over the engine, "we also have something called **tagbeera**."*



Safiya looked up. *"Tagbeera?"*



*"Yes," **Thuraya** said. She was warming to the subject now — her voice had the specific clarity that she used when she was teaching. "It is like... a family symbol. A sign. Every tribe has one."*



She paused. A small, satisfied pause — the pause of a person who has arrived at the name they most wanted to say.



She smiled.



"For Al-Naabi, the tagbeera is " data-m="The traditional tagbeera of the Al-Naabi tribe; a word passed down through generations as the Al-Naabi's sign and call" data-s="Al-Naabi's call, tribal-word'

data-x="Fenzuz was the Al-Naabi's word. It belonged to them the way a name belongs to a family.">fenzuz."

٢٧

The word landed in the back of the pickup and — as words sometimes do — **rearranged** the air around it. The children who were old enough to know it looked up, nodding small **nods**. The ones who were younger were watching **Thuraya's** face for clues about how the word should be received.

٢٨

John tried it. He tried it carefully, the way he tried every new Arabic word — sounding it out slowly, with his English mouth, which was forever a little too polite for this language.

٢٩

"Fen... zoz?"

٣٠

Mansoor — who had been silent for an unprecedented forty seconds, and who could bear the silence no longer — corrected him. Loudly. With the specific grave authority of a boy who had just been given, by the mispronunciation of a foreigner, the chance to be the expert.

٣١

"Fenzuz," he said — precisely, as though he were pronouncing the name of his own grandfather.

٣٢

Everyone laughed.

٣٣

John, with the good **humour** of a man who had accepted, some weeks ago, that his linguistic dignity was, in this village, permanently **expendable**, bowed his head to **Mansoor**.

٣٤

"Thank you, teacher."

٣٥

Mansoor, beaming, sat down with the satisfaction of a boy who had just been publicly promoted.

SCENE THREE

My Name Is, I Am From, I Belong To

The truck jounced on. Mountains rose on the left. Farms appeared on the right — long narrow plots of palm trees and green, each one edged by its own small falaj, each one working quietly as the pickup rolled past.

٣٦

Thuraya, turning in her seat — holding the side of the open window with one hand to keep her balance — said,

٢٧
ع

"Today, we will practice something very important."

٢٨
ع

She produced, from her small cloth bag, a piece of paper. She had prepared it the night before — **Safiya** could see the evenness of the writing, the care of the three lines — and she held it up so that the children could read it.

٢٩
ع

My name is...

I am from...

I belong to...

٣٠
ع

Safiya clapped her hands — a small, delighted clap, the kind teachers give when they have just been handed, by another teacher, the exact lesson they would have chosen themselves.

٣١
ع

"Great! Let's practice!"

٣٢
ع

She turned to the boy nearest her — who, of course, was **Ahmed**, because **Ahmed** had positioned himself, **Safiya** had noticed, in the exact place he judged most likely to be called on first.

٣٣
ع

"You first."

٣٤
ع

Ahmed sat up straight — which, in a bumping truck, was a minor feat of posture. He adjusted his bag on his lap. He cleared his throat. He spoke slowly, with deliberation, pronouncing each word the way he had been practising pronouncing English words since the day Mr. **John** had first walked into the school.

٣٥
ع

*"My name is **Ahmed**. I am from Samail. I belong to... my family."*

٣٦
ع

Thuraya smiled. *"Good. Very good."*

٣٧
ع

Khalil, who had been **waiting** for his turn with the specific **restlessness** of a boy whose joke needed to be delivered while it was still fresh, spoke next.

٣٨
ع

*"My name is **Khalil**. I am from here. I belong to... **trouble**."*

٣٩
ع

Everyone laughed. **Thuraya** laughed too — with the small, resigned laugh of a teacher who had been waiting for exactly that sentence and could not, in all honesty, disagree with it.

﴿

Noura went next. **Noura** always volunteered. **Noura** had an opinion about this **format** and was going to honour it.

﴿

*"My name is **Noura**. I am from Samail. I belong to my mother."*

﴿

Safiya watched **Thuraya's** face as **Noura** said this. A small softness came into **Thuraya's** expression. *I belong to my mother* was, for a ten-year-old Omani girl, the specific, correct, most honest sentence. It was where she truly, physically, emotionally belonged. Every mother in the village **owned**, in this specific way, her small daughter. And the small daughter knew it.

﴿

Marwa — softer voice — *"My name is **Marwa**. I am from the farms."*

﴿

Rahma — even softer — *"My name is **Rahma**. I belong to my grandmother."*

﴿

Another small softness crossed **Thuraya's** face. **Rahma's** grandmother — **Safiya** did not know her story, but **Thuraya** evidently did — was the person who, in **Rahma's** world, held the central space.

﴿

Then **Mansoor**.

﴿

Mansoor stood up in the truck — which was dangerous, and which **Safiya** would have corrected, except that the sentence he was about to deliver was so obviously a performance that correction would have been beside the point — and shouted, over the noise of the engine:

﴿

*"My name is **Mansoor**. I am from everywhere!"*

﴿

John laughed — the real laugh, the tired-happy laugh that had been building since the truck had started. *"Everywhere,"* he said, *"is a big place."*

﴿

Mansoor bowed. And sat down.

﴿

Then — quietly, in the middle of this lesson that she had orchestrated, without calling attention to herself, **Thuraya** said her own.



"My name is **Thuraya**. I am from Al-Lajal. I belong to Al-Naabi."



The three sentences landed in the back of the pickup with the weight of a small personal **testimony**. She had said them the way a person says their own name at a gathering — plainly, completely, without ornament. My name is. I am from. I belong to. Three different kinds of knowing. All of them true.



Mr. **John** looked at her. Looked at her differently, **Safiya** thought, than he had looked at her ten minutes ago.



"**Thuraya**," he said, quietly, "that is a beautiful name."



Thuraya smiled. It was a soft smile — softer than her teacher-smile, softer than the smile she used for jokes. It was the smile of a person being told something about herself that she had inherited.



"My grandmother's name was also **Thuraya**."



Safiya looked up. Genuinely surprised. "Really?"



"Yes," **Thuraya** said. And then, as the truck moved between two sharp hills and the light shifted across her face, she told them the story that she had, perhaps, been saving for this exact ride — on the road to the exact village — with a small cargo of children and two English teachers who had now, finally, earned the story.



"My grandfather, **Ali**, was a teacher of **fiqh**. He taught in the mosque in Samail. That is why he stayed there."



She paused — not uncertainly. Just with the small, deliberate pause of a person telling a family story and giving each sentence its space.



"He married my grandmother. And her name was **Thuraya**."



John's eyes became big. Both of them. The swollen one had fully, finally, recovered — which was a small, cosmic gift, because what he was hearing deserved two working eyes.



"So... your name is the same as your grandmother's."

~
ع

"Yes," **Thuraya** said.

~
ع

She looked out at the road. The mountains were closer now. A falaj, somewhere in the middle distance, caught the sun and sent back a small bright line.

~
ع

"Names have stories here."

SCENE FOUR

Falaj Al-Lajal

The car moved between mountains and green places. Palm trees appeared. Farms appeared. The light — which had been the honey-light of early morning — was, by now, the full **working** light of late morning. Every leaf showed. Every stone on the path was visible.

~
ع

Suddenly, **John** pointed.

~
ع

"Is that the falaj?"

~
ع

Below them, curving along the edge of the palms, was a long, bright ribbon of water. It ran between stone banks. It caught the sun. It moved with the specific, **purposeful** flow of water that had been moving along this same course for longer than the village had been measuring.

~
ع

Thuraya turned. *"Yes. **Falaj Al-Lajal.**"*

~
ع

John grinned. His grin was the grin of a man who had, very recently, washed his face in the cold falaj of Al-Qurawashiyah and survived, and who now believed — with the specific confidence of a man who had survived something once — that he was equipped for any falaj that this country could produce.

~
ع

"Swimming!"

~
ع

Thuraya looked at him.

~
ع

It was the same small strange smile she had produced that morning — the *Thuraya-knows-something-that-John-does-not* smile — only larger now, because the moment it had been preparing for was arriving.



"Don't be too excited," she said. "Not every falaj is... friendly."



John did not, it was clear, hear the warning properly. He was already **measuring** the water with his eyes. He was planning his jump.



The truck slowed. **Uncle Nasser** pulled it off the road onto a flat patch of hard earth beside a grove of palms. He cut the engine. The specific, sudden quiet that follows the cutting of a loud engine — when the ear, released, hears the small sounds again — arrived. Palm leaves. The falaj. A bird somewhere. Everything else that had been waiting.



When they arrived — when they climbed down out of the pickup and looked around — the place was beautiful. Green trees. Old houses — older than the houses in Samail, in that specific way older houses are *older*, with walls that had settled a little further into the earth, with doorways that had been patched and re-patched over generations. Water moving between stones.



The children ran. Of course they ran. They did not need to be told where to go — they were all young enough that water was, fundamentally, the thing one ran toward when one arrived at a new place with water.



"Wait!" Safiya shouted. "Careful!"



But **John** — **John** — was already taking off his shoes. He was taking them off with the brisk, cheerful efficiency of a man who had, at some point in the preceding three minutes, decided that *this* was the moment he had been waiting for since London.



"Cold water!" he announced, to no one in particular, his shoes now paired neatly on a flat stone. *"I am ready!"*



Thuraya opened her mouth.



"John —"



Too late.

٢٧

John jumped.

٢٨

He jumped with the **abandon** of a tall Englishman who had been waiting, all morning, for the exact moment when he could fling himself into a clear cold falaj and cool himself completely.

٢٩

The falaj was not cold.

٣٠

The falaj was not even *cool*.

٣١

The falaj was *bot*.

٣٢

For approximately one-third of a second, **John's** body processed this new fact in silence. The water closed around his ankles, his calves, his thighs. His brain, working at the speed of light, compared *expected temperature* to *actual temperature* and produced, as its reply, a single Arabic-adjacent syllable that he had not previously known he possessed.

٣٣

"AAAAAAAAAAAA! **WAF AQRIYA!**"

٣٤

He **launched** himself out of the falaj like a man who had just discovered, mid-flight, that he was on fire. Both feet cleared the water. He landed, staggering, on the stone bank. He raised his arms. His face, which was still turning red for unrelated reasons — the heat of the water, the embarrassment of the situation, the sudden flood of adrenaline — settled into the specific expression of a man who had just been betrayed, at a deep level, by a **country** he had been learning to trust.

٣٥

"*It's HOT!*" he shouted. "*The water is HOT!*"

٣٦

The children, who had been standing a careful distance away — their mothers and aunts had, for generations, taught them about this falaj, and they had known, unlike **John**, exactly what would happen — fell on the ground laughing.

٣٧

Not metaphorically. *Literally*. **Mansoor** — of course **Mansoor** — sat down first, rocked backward, and disappeared into the long grass by the falaj in a **paroxysm** of laughter that would last, by **Safiya's** estimation, approximately four minutes. **Khalil** followed him down. **Noura** put her hand

over her mouth and giggled helplessly. **Ahmed** — **Ahmed** — allowed himself a single, undignified snort.

~

Mansoor, from the grass, managed to speak.

~

*"Teacher is **cooked**."*

~

Khalil, finding breath for exactly one sentence, added — *"**Falaj soup**."*

~

Thuraya — who had been watching the whole sequence from the stone bank with her arms **crossed**, and with the small satisfied patience of a person whose warning had been completely ignored — said, calmly:

~

"I told you not to be too excited."

~

John — dripping, red-faced, still hopping slightly on one foot — looked at her.

~

"You knew."

~

"Yes," **Thuraya** said. The smile she had been holding all morning finally arrived at its full size. *"Falaj Al-Lajal is warm."*

~

"Warm," **John** repeated, with the quiet emphasis of a man who felt that *warm* was an inadequate, possibly **diplomatic** word for what he had just experienced. *"It is warm."*

~

"Warm," she agreed. *"Very warm."*

SCENE FIVE

Tell Me About Yourself

Safiya — laughing, dry, still seated on the truck bed where she had sensibly stayed during her husband's **immersion** — climbed down now. She crossed to where the children had gathered. She arranged her skirt beneath her and sat on the stone bank by the water.

~

"Okay," she said, with the warm decisiveness of a teacher reclaiming her morning. *"Lesson time!"*



The children, still **subsiding** from their laughter at Mr. **John**, turned to her. They arranged themselves around her in the specific loose semicircle that children make around a sitting adult — a **formation** that required no discussion.



John, still standing on the stone bank, slowly put his shoes back on. He joined them — somewhat gingerly — and sat at the edge of the group, his dignity in slightly better condition than his feet.



*"Now," **Safiya** said, her eyes bright, "tell me about yourself."*



She looked around. She was going to choose someone. She needed — **Thuraya's** practice had produced a beautiful set of sentences, but they had cycled through the usual performers. **Safiya** wanted to hear the ones who had not yet spoken.



She pointed — gently — to the boy who had been the quietest in the pickup. The boy with the small stool that morning. The boy who had tried three times to climb into the truck and had, in the end, used engineering.



"You."



Ali — the small, careful **Ali**, the one who drew instead of writing — looked up. He had not expected to be chosen. He had been **braced** for **Safiya** to pick, as teachers usually did, one of the louder children.



He took a breath. He sat up — not as straight as **Ahmed**, because no one could sit as straight as **Ahmed**, but straight enough to honour the moment.



He spoke — slowly. Carefully. In the specific measured English of a boy whose mouth was still learning the shapes of a language that had, until recently, not been in it.



*"My name is **Ali**. I am from Samail. I belong to my family."*



He looked at **Safiya**. His eyes had the small, careful watchfulness of a child who has just done something difficult and wants to know if he has done it right.



"Good!" **Safiya** said. The word came out warmer than she had planned. The boy's small English had hit her more squarely than she had expected. She had, without meaning to, allowed her voice to **brighten**.

~

Ali smiled. Small. Relieved. Proud.

~

And then, around him, the others took their turns.

~

*They practiced again. And again. **Safiya** went around the small circle and heard each sentence. My name is. I am from. I belong to. The sentences arrived in different voices — small voices, loud voices, Mansoor's definite voice, Ahmed's precise voice, Noura's rapid voice — and each sentence, with each repetition, became a little steadier in the child's mouth. Each time, something small was put right. Each time, a new mouth shaped the English of I belong to more **confidently**. And each time, another small piece of the Omani world made its way, politely, through three English sentences.*

~

My name is Marwa. I am from Samail. I belong to the farms.

~

My name is Rahma. I am from Al-Qurawashiyah. I belong to my grandmother.

~

My name is Salima. I am from Samail. I belong to my father.

~

*My name is Khalil. I am from here. I belong to trouble. (Again. He could not resist. **Safiya** let him.)*

~

My name is Ahmed. I am from Samail. I belong to my family.

~

My name is Mansoor. I am from everywhere. (Also again. Also let through.)

~

And then, after a long, contented silence — in which the falaj continued its soft *hush*, in which somewhere nearby a small bird called in an unfamiliar pattern, in which a distant woman somewhere in the village was humming, faintly, in a rhythm that was not quite a song — **Mr. John** spoke.

~

He had been, for some time, quiet. His feet had dried. His dignity had, with the dignity of time, partially returned. He cleared his throat.

~

*"My name is **John**. I am from London."*

٢٧
ع

He paused. A long pause. A pause in which the children, and **Thuraya**, and **Safiya**, all looked at him — waiting for his third sentence.

٢٨
ع

He considered.

٢٩
ع

He looked around the circle of small faces. At **Mansoor**, grass in his hair. At **Ahmed**, bag still on his lap. At **Noura**, already preparing her next question. At **Ali**, still quietly proud of his three correct sentences.

٣٠
ع

At **Thuraya**. At **Safiya**.

٣١
ع

And then — with the small, specific smile of a man who had, less than twenty minutes earlier, been boiled by a falaj, and who had somehow, since then, come out the other side into a clearer kind of day — he finished.

٣٢
ع

"I belong to... this lesson."

٣٣
ع

Thuraya laughed. **Safiya** laughed. The children laughed — **Mansoor** the loudest, because he did not fully understand the joke but was unwilling to be excluded from any laughter.

٣٤
ع

And somewhere, behind the truck, in the shade of a palm tree at the edge of the farm — a small, white, horned head appeared. **Malood** — whom no one had seen climb into the truck that morning, but who had, in the way of **Malood**, evidently done so — stepped out of the shade. He walked, with the exact, unhurried, **proprietary** stride that was his **signature**, into the middle of the circle.

٣٥
ع

He looked at the children. He looked at **Safiya**. He looked at **John**. He looked — unmistakably — at the stone bank, where **John**'s small bag was open, and where a piece of paper was visible.

٣٦
ع

He began to walk toward it.

٣٧
ع

"MALOOD —"

٣٨
ع

But the children were already laughing again. And **Safiya**, watching — dry, safe, seated in the warm sun beside the warm falaj, in a village her grandmother would never have imagined her

granddaughter visiting — understood that some things travel with you, and that the goat was apparently one of them.



The lesson continued, but with one extra student.

SCENE SIX

The Practice That Did Not End

They practiced again and again.



That was the **texture** of the afternoon. Not one lesson that ended. A lesson that kept returning — in new mouths, with new variations, with small Arabic interruptions, with **Mansoor** standing up and sitting down and standing up again, with **Malood** being politely **escorted** away from **John**'s bag on approximately four separate occasions — and with the falaj, the warm falaj, the kind, **patient** hot falaj of Al-Lajal, continuing its small hush beside them the whole time.



The sentences came out different each time.



*My name is **Abmed**. I am from Samail. I belong to my family.*



*My name is **Noura**. I am from Samail. I belong to my mother. And my father. And my grandmother.* (She had, on the second pass, added people to her list. **Safiya**, who understood what she was doing, did not correct her.)



*My name is **Ali**. I am from Samail. I belong to my family. And today... I belong to Al-Lajal a little.*



That sentence — **Safiya** caught it. It was **Ali**'s own. She had not fed it to him. He had **extended** the template on his own. She looked at **Thuraya**. **Thuraya**, watching, gave her the very smallest nod.



*My name is **Marwa**. I am from Samail. I belong to the farms. And to my sisters.*



*My name is **Rahma**. I am from Al-Qurawashiyah. I belong to my grandmother. Who is sick this week.*



Safiya's heart tightened slightly. **Rahma** had said this sentence without drama, without asking for sympathy, simply **including** her grandmother in the sentence about herself, because the sentence

about herself would have been incomplete without her. **Safiya** did not correct her. She only said, gently, *"I hope she is better soon."*

﴿

"Thank you, teacher."

﴿

*My name is **Salima**. I am from Samail. I belong to my father. And my mother. And my brother who is a fisherman in Sur.*

﴿

*My name is **Khalil**. I am from here. I belong to trouble.*

﴿

*"**Khalil**," **Safiya** said, with mock severity. "Can you try a new third sentence?"*

﴿

Khalil considered this. He considered it for a long time. He was, behind the scheming, a thoughtful boy — **Safiya** had begun to notice — and he was now, visibly, trying to think of a better third sentence.

﴿

Finally —

﴿

*"My name is **Khalil**. I am from here. I belong to... my friends."*

﴿

He said it with the specific, slightly embarrassed voice of a boy who had surprised himself by meaning it. The other children, for one soft second, went quiet. **Ali** looked up at him. **Khalil**, noticing, went immediately red and looked away.

﴿

*"Beautiful," **Safiya** said, with deliberate lightness — giving him back his room to be himself. "That is a beautiful third sentence."*

﴿

*My name is **Mansoor**. I am from everywhere. I belong to the truck.*

﴿

That one got a laugh. **Mansoor** beamed again.

﴿

And **John**, on his second pass — hair dry now, shoes firmly on, dignity fully restored — said:

﴿

*"My name is **John**. I am from London. I belong to... this country, a little, now."*



He said it shyly. The way a man says a sentence he has not yet earned but hopes to earn. **Thuraya** looked at him — the long, considered look she gave to sentences that were, in her judgment, true enough to **honour**.



She nodded once.



She did not correct the grammar. The grammar was, in any case, fine.



*The afternoon moved on. **Uncle Nasser** — who had disappeared, at some point, toward a relative's house in the village — returned with a cloth bundle of bread and dates and cold yoghurt, which he laid out on the stone bank beside the falaj. The children ate. **John** ate. **Safiya**, who had been hungry and had not known it, ate slowly and completely. **Thuraya** ate looking at the water. The water continued. The sun moved, slowly, across the palm fronds above them.*



And at some point — **Safiya** did not know quite when — the lesson became something else. **Mansoor** was telling **Ali** about a cousin of his who had once fallen into this exact falaj. **Ahmed** was writing — yes, writing — the sentence *I belong to my family* in his slate, with three different decorative underlinings. **Noura** was asking **Thuraya**, quietly, about her grandmother — the grandmother who had also been called **Thuraya**, the one who had married the **fiqh**-teacher in the mosque. **Thuraya** was telling her. **Noura** was, for once, listening more than asking.



Safiya sat with her back against the warm stone bank. She let the afternoon be whatever it wanted to be. She did not pull out her notebook. She did not translate the moment into a lesson plan. She simply — for the first time since arriving in this country — let a whole afternoon pass through her without trying to catch it.



When the sun had lowered, and **Uncle Nasser** had tapped the side of the pickup, and the children — reluctantly, slowly — had climbed back in, **Safiya** walked to the falaj, knelt beside it, and — very carefully, fully aware this time of what she was doing — dipped her fingers into the warm water.



It was warm. Genuinely warm. Like a bath, but older. She held her fingers there for a long second, and felt the specific warmth that came, **Thuraya** had later explained, from somewhere deep in the earth.



She lifted her hand. She stood.



She walked back to the truck.



She climbed in. The children were, at last, quiet — the specific quiet of children who have had a full day and are now beginning to understand, in their small bodies, that they are going to sleep on the ride home.



The engine started. The truck rolled forward. The dust rose behind them, as always. Al-Lajal disappeared around a bend.



In the back of the pickup, **Safiya** — without meaning to, without planning to, because the day had earned it from her — leaned her head against the warm metal side of the truck and, quietly, to no one in particular, said her own:



*"My name is **Safiya**. I am from London. I belong to..."*



She did not finish the sentence. Not because she did not know. Because she did not yet want to decide.



Thuraya, in the front seat, heard her — somehow, over the engine — and turned, briefly, to look at her through the small back window.



She did not say anything.



She only — very slightly — **smiled**.

Did You Know?

The Falaj System

Remember John's surprise when he jumped into the Al-Lajjal falaj expecting cold water and found it warm instead? The falaj is a time-honored Omani irrigation system that uses gravity to carry water from underground sources to farms and villages, with evidence of use dating back roughly 1,500 years or more. In 2006, UNESCO listed five Omani falaj systems as World Heritage Sites in recognition of their engineering brilliance and continued use today.

Source: whc.unesco.org · en.wikipedia.org

PALM

Palm Ten

Smoke, Truck, and an Englishman Speaking Arabic

SCENE ONE

Before the Bell

The morning bell did not ring yet, but Samail already felt awake.

و

That was how this village worked. The bell was a **formality**, not an announcement. By the time its brass rang out of **Abu Salim**'s hand, the houses had already turned over, the doorways had already exhaled their first people, the small lanes had already collected the first soft arguments of the day between mothers and the children they were trying to dress.

و

A pale sun climbed slowly behind the mountains. The air smelled like dust, like the farms waking up on the far side of the wall, and — **Safiya** could catch it, faintly, on the edge of the breeze — like something warm being cooked far away. A stew, perhaps. Someone's mother, generous in her kitchen.

و

Mr. **John** stepped out of the simple house, holding a small notebook.

و

He was **squinting** at the pale sun like a man who had misplaced his glasses somewhere in his sleep and had not yet gathered the energy to find them — though **John**, in fact, did not wear glasses. He simply had the specific face of a man who, in this country, was always *almost* about to.

و

Safiya — and she was **Safiya** now, properly, completely, everyone in the village called her that and she had stopped correcting them some time ago — stood behind him at the doorway, tying her scarf.

و

She tied it neatly. Carefully. With the specific small satisfaction of a woman who had, after several weeks of daily failure, finally learned a skill that her neighbours had been doing since they were six. She tied it, and then — unable to help herself — glanced down at the edges to make sure they sat right, in the way a child checks their shoelaces for the third time in the first week of school. She looked proud of it. Like it was a new rule she had finally learned perfectly on the first try.



Ms. **Thuraya** appeared at the end of the neighbour's path. Her steps were quick and confident. In one hand she carried a cloth bag. Behind her ear — held there the way carpenters hold pencils — was a small piece of chalk.



"Good morning," she said, in English, smiling.



John grinned. *"Good morning! Today is... Monday?"*



Thuraya laughed. It was her small, indulgent, teacher-laugh — the laugh she reserved for Mr. **John**'s hopeful attempts at confidence.



*"Mr. **John**,"* she said, *"you still need to learn the days."*



Then — before anyone could quite decide who would answer next — something small and white hopped into the yard.



It hopped like a **sneaky cloud with legs**.



It was, of course, **Malood**.



He marched — there was no other word for it — straight to **John**'s bag. He stopped. He **sniffed** it seriously — the specific, unhurried, professional sniff of a goat who had, in his short life, learned that bags often contained interesting things. Then he tried to bite the corner.



"Hey! No! That is my teaching bag!"



John waved his hands — waved them the way airport men waved at planes, broad and slow and very important. The airport gesture had no effect on goats. This had been, by now, well established in the scientific record of the village.



Malood didn't care. **Malood** never cared.



Thuraya bent down. She did it easily — it was the specific low crouch of a village woman who had been **squatting** since she could walk. She patted **Malood** on the flank.



*"He belongs to Aunt **Azizah** next door," she said. "But he loves your house like it is his own."*



Safiya whispered, mostly to **John** — *"He is... too confident."*



Then came a sound that made the village shift its attention — the specific small shift of an entire place that has been, until that moment, reading its own page, and has now, all together, **turned** the page at the same time.



A loud engine. A truck. A man's voice calling from far away — calling the way a voice calls when it is used to a **loudspeaker**, even when it is not currently using one.



Thuraya's eyes narrowed. The small, quick **narrowing** of a person who had identified the sound before her mind had finished naming it.



*"Oh no. The **municipality** truck."*



John blinked. *"The what?"*



Before she could explain, the pickup appeared at the end of the dusty road. It moved slowly — slowly in the way a large insect moves slowly — like a **giant beetle** that knew exactly where it was going and had no interest in arriving quickly.



Two men sat in the back with a large metal tank. And behind them — rolling slowly outward, filling the dusty street with a pale foggy cloud — was the smoke.



Safiya's eyebrows jumped. *"Is that... smoke?"*



Thuraya pulled her scarf a little tighter across her face — the small, practised gesture of a woman who had seen this truck many times in her childhood and knew the correct response.



*"**Pesticide**," she said. "They spray it to kill insects. People used to do it a lot."*



Malood made a tiny noise — a small, **disgruntled** noise that sounded like a complaint — and then, for emphasis, coughed once.

John stepped forward, concerned. *"Is it safe?"*

Thuraya opened her mouth.

She did not get the chance to answer.

Because the children had arrived.

SCENE TWO

The Smoke Chase

A group of boys came running behind the truck. They were yelling. They were laughing. They were chasing the smoke — chasing it as though it were a game that had been invented, specifically, for their benefit.

One of them was **Mansoor**.

Of course it was **Mansoor**.

He ran like he was being chased by a lion. His small legs were moving at a speed that his body could not quite **sustain**, and his face — his face was pure joy. Not the joy of winning a game. The older, simpler joy of running through a cloud of chemical smoke in a village street with his friends and pretending he was somewhere else entirely.

Thuraya shouted — the specific teacher-shout that carried across open spaces with a precision that surprised people who did not know her —

"MANSOOR! STOP!"

He didn't stop.

John jumped forward. The jump was sudden, entire, and had nothing English in it — the specific instant **activation** of teacher-mode that happens, in good teachers, without any decision being made.

He grabbed a thin stick from the fence — **Safiya** would later try to remember where the stick had come from, and would fail — and lifted it like a **traffic sign**.

٢٧
ع

"**STOP!**" he shouted, in full English. "**GO INSIDE!**"

٢٨
ع

The boys froze — for half a second, no longer — and then yelled back happily. They did not understand the English. They understood that the English teacher had joined the game, which was, **categorically**, even better than the game had been thirty seconds earlier.

٢٩
ع

One boy shouted something in Omani Arabic — short, fast, the specific teasing cadence of a ten-year-old who has just thought of an excellent insult. Another boy laughed. **Mansoor**, from the middle of the cloud, waved — waved the way fans wave to favourite actors in a play — as though **John** were now part of the show.

٣٠
ع

"**NOOO!**" **John** shouted again, louder. "**INSIDE! INSIDE!**"

٣١
ع

Safiya covered her mouth with her hand. She was laughing. She was laughing properly — the **undignified** laugh that a wife permits herself only when her husband is, in her view, being magnificent at something and wrong about something at the same time.

٣٢
ع

"**John**," she managed, "*you look like a British police officer.*"

٣٣
ع

John, ignoring her, took one firm step toward the smoke.

٣٤
ع

And slipped.

٣٥
ع

His shoe hit a wet patch — one of the small overflow trails from the falaj channel that crossed the path every few metres. His foot slid. His other foot, attempting a rescue, arrived too late. His arms went up. His notebook — the small, professional notebook that had been in his hand all morning — **sailed**, in a clean arc, into a small patch of dust and palm leaves.

٣٦
ع

Malood, from beside the door, jumped sideways with the specific **self-preserving** quickness of a goat who wanted, very clearly, no part of this. His posture said, *Not my problem*.

٣٧
ع

John fell.



Face-first. Into the dusty ground.



And then, as though the morning had been waiting for exactly this **composition** — the smoke rolled over him.



The pale fog passed across his body. Slowly. Completely. It filled the air around him. It settled on his shoulders. It settled on his hair. It settled in the long thin lines where his face had, a second earlier, been a healthy English colour.



When the cloud passed — when the air cleared, and the truck's tail-lights were receding down the road — **John** stood up slowly.



He looked... **terrifying**.



His hair was full of dust. His face was a pale, even grey — the grey of old walls, of old tombs, of plaster that had lost its paint decades ago. His eyes, watering from the chemical, were **bloodshot** and wide.



He looked, exactly, like a ghost that had lost a fight.



Safiya screamed. Then she laughed — so hard that she had to catch herself against the clay wall of their house, one hand flat against the mud, the other over her stomach.



Thuraya covered her mouth. She was attempting to be polite. She was failing. *"Oh my..."*



The children screamed too. But the children did not scream from fear of the smoke.



They screamed from fear of **John**.



"Abooooyaaah!" **Mansoor** shouted, **dramatically** — and half the kids ran away as though the ghost were real.



John wiped his eyes. He coughed. He coughed again.



"*I am... fine*," he said.



He was not fine. He was standing in a grey cloud of his own dust, with a split lip he had not yet noticed, in a village street, while a municipality truck disappeared around a corner. But he was upright. And for a man who had just been face-first in the ground, upright was a position he was prepared to defend.

SCENE THREE

Shayb Khalaf

Then a shadow moved at the edge of the smoke.



Not dramatically — no village shadow ever moved dramatically. This one simply *moved*, the slow deliberate movement of a tall thin person emerging from a thinning fog. A walking stick. A worn shoulder. A white beard, partly visible first, then fully, then the whole man.



A thin old man. Wrinkled face — wrinkled like the earth after summer, like the specific deep cracks that formed in the wadis when the last rain had long since disappeared. Eyes that were, despite everything else, sharp.



The children saw him and froze.



It was a different kind of freezing than the freezing they had done when **John** had become a ghost. That earlier freezing had been fun. This freezing was not fun. This freezing had the specific **reverent** quality of children who had been told, since they were very small, about exactly this man.



Some whispered — not loud enough to be a sentence, just loud enough to be shared — "**Khalaf**..."



Someone hissed, "*The wizard!*"



Safiya leaned toward **Thuraya**. Quietly. She was not alarmed — she knew **Khalaf** now, she had met him, she had accepted her ring from his hand — but the children's reaction was its own kind of information.



"*Why*," she whispered, "*do they look like they saw a monster?*"

٢٧

Thuraya whispered back, keeping her voice low and easy — the tone of a woman **demystifying** the whole village mythology in one sentence.

٢٨

*"They think he is a **sorcerer**. He lives alone in an old clay house. People fear him."*

٢٩

The old man — **Shayb Khalaf** — walked straight to **John**.

٣٠

He did not stop. He did not slow. He crossed the small patch of dusty ground between where he had been and where **John** was standing, and he grabbed **John's** arm — not kindly, not unkindly, just *grabbed*, the way an old farmer would steady a small animal that had gotten turned around.

٣١

"Stand up properly," he said. Rough — but not cruel.

٣٢

John, still dizzy, his head still thick with dust, his mouth still full of the chemical taste of the pesticide, **suddenly** — and without any decision that his English-trained mind could later account for — spoke in Arabic.

٣٣

*The Arabic that came out of him was not textbook Arabic. It was not the polite formal Arabic of the phrasebook Mr. **John** had carried on the plane. It was local Arabic — the specific Samaili phrasing of a man who had somehow, in the last few seconds, become a villager.*

٣٤

!يح... حسبك جني! خوفتني... الله يصرفك صرفة

٣٥

Safiya gasped. **Thuraya's** mouth dropped open.

٣٦

Khalaf stared at **John**. For a long second. Then — without warning, because **Khalaf** did not warn people — gave a short laugh.

٣٧

واحليلك باه... تفزع؟ خليك رجّال.

٣٨

He lifted his stick a little. Just a little. A small, amused raising.

٣٩

والأبدي الخيزرانة ع ظهرك!

٤٠

John's eyes widened.

٢٤

And out of his mouth — still not English — came the answer. Fast. Almost polite. A villager's answer.

٢٥

هاهه... الشيمة تجمل.

٢٦

Then **John** stopped.

٢٧

He blinked. Several times. Like his brain had just finished a process it had not been consulted about and was now — only now — arriving at the meeting to find out what had been decided.

٢٨

He turned to **Safiya**. He whispered, in English, in the small, confused voice of a man who had just heard his own mouth say something his mind had not prepared —

٢٩

"How did I... say that? I don't know those sentences."

٣٠

Safiya collapsed — again, the wall, the stomach, the complete giving-way of a woman whose morning had produced, in fifteen minutes, more comic material than the previous three weeks combined.

٣١

"John," she managed, *"you just threatened-corrected yourself in Arabic!"*

٣٢

Thuraya tried to look serious. Her shoulders shook with the effort. The **effort** was not sustainable.

٣٣

"Mr. John," she said, with admirable composure, *"you surprise me."*

٣٤

Malood, meanwhile — having noticed that no one was looking at him for the first time in forty seconds — was coughing, dramatically, once, twice, a third time, leaning his small body against the wall like an actor in a sad movie. Nobody paid attention.

٣٥

The municipality truck moved on. The smoke thinned. The children, still partially scattered, returned carefully — peeking, first, from behind fences.

٣٦

Mansoor stepped forward. Proud. "*Teacher **John**... you are... ghost!*"

~

John, still grey, still slightly unsteady, pointed at him with the firmness of a man who had decided that he had accepted enough indignity for one morning.

~

"*No. I am teacher.*"

~

Thuraya clapped once. "*Okay! Everyone... to school.*"

SCENE FOUR

The New Teachers

John walked into the classroom, later that day, with red, puffy eyes. He had washed — briefly, carelessly — but some of the grey was still **lodged** in his hair, and his eyes still carried the small chemical redness of a man who had been, very recently, face-to-face with a cloud.

~

The classroom was its usual self. The chalkboard was old and dusty — with the specific, faint ghost of yesterday's lesson still visible beneath the attempts to wipe it. The room smelled, as it always did, of chalk, of heat, and of the small, secret lunches hidden in pockets — dates, a piece of bread, a small twist of salt.

~

Near the door — and this was new — stood two teachers **Safiya** had never seen before.

~

A strong Egyptian man. Sharp **moustache**. Serious face. The specific upright stillness of a man who, in any country, could be instantly identified as *the kind of man who does not tolerate nonsense*.

~

"*I am **Mohammadeen**,*" he said. Loud. Each syllable given its full weight. "*Math teacher.*"

~

Beside him stood his wife — sporty, confident, wearing a **tracksuit** that had clearly never belonged to anyone but her.

~

"*And I am **Fatkat**,*" she said. Equally loud. Equally unafraid. "*Sports teacher.*"

~

The students sat straighter immediately. Not because anyone had told them to. Because the air in the room had, in the space of two sentences, shifted — and their small bodies had read the shift correctly.



Mohammadeen lifted a thin stick — not in anger, not as a threat, just as a **symbol**. A small, dry, clean statement of authority.



"Any noise," he said, "and I make you quiet faster than lightning."



Mansoor swallowed.



Visibly. Audibly. The specific swallow of a small boy who had just recalculated the morning's likely budget of mischief and found it considerably reduced.



Safiya whispered to **Thuraya**. *"They look scared. And respectful. At the same time."*



Thuraya whispered back. Matter-of-factly. Not judgmentally.



"That's how it was."



*Three small words. That's how it was. **Safiya** felt the sentence settle. It was not — she understood — **Thuraya** defending a practice. It was **Thuraya** giving her a historical fact. A village school in 1973, in rural Oman, was a place where a stick on a desk was a **convention**, not a cruelty. It was what English classrooms had also been, once. And the children who sat up straighter when the stick appeared were not, in their own minds, being terrorised. They were being given the dignity of being taken seriously. That's how it was.*



John cleared his throat — wincing slightly, because the cough from the pesticide had not yet fully left his chest.



"Today," he said, "we talk about... what happened."



He wrote on the board, in big careful letters:



PAST SIMPLE: Yesterday, I... / He... / They...



He turned around. *"Repeat: Yesterday, I walked."*



The class echoed — twelve small voices, **layered**, not quite perfectly together — *"Yesterday, I walked."*

~
~

John pointed at **Mansoor**. *"Mansoor. Yesterday, you...?"*

~
~

Mansoor stood up proudly. His small bodily re-calibration of five minutes ago had not survived the sight of his own name being called.

~
~

"Yesterday, I run."

~
~

John smiled. The smile was, for the first time that morning, unreserved. *"Good! Say: I ran."*

~
~

Mansoor frowned. The past tense of *run* was one of English's small betrayals — a verb that refused to follow the rule. He considered. He tried it.

~
~

"I ran."

~
~

John nodded. *"Excellent."*

~
~

Then — with the clean, ceremonial **self-deprecation** of a teacher who had decided to use his own disaster as the lesson material — **John** pointed at himself.

~
~

"Yesterday, I... fell."

~
~

The class burst into laughter.

~
~

Safiya, from the back — unable to resist — added: *"And yesterday, Mr. **John** looked like a ghost."*

~
~

John sighed. The sigh of a husband whose wife had, once again, been correct. *"Yes. He looked like a ghost."*

~
~

Thuraya raised one eyebrow. *"He looked like a very **dramatic** ghost."*

~
~

Mohammadeen watched — trying not to smile. **Fatkat** did not attempt the same discipline. She laughed openly. Her laugh was large, warm, and entirely **unapologetic**.

~

Then **John** lowered his voice. Teacher-serious again. The atmosphere of the room returned — almost — to **lesson tone**.

~

"Yesterday, the truck sprayed pesticide. What do we say?"

~

Safiya — who had, by now, become a regular part of the class — stepped in with hand gestures. She spoke slowly. Clearly. The way mothers speak when they are telling children the *important* words.

~

"We say: Don't run behind the truck. Go inside. Close the door."

~

Thuraya nodded. *"Safety English."*

~

John wrote more on the board:

~

Don't + verb

Don't run. Don't breathe the smoke. Don't touch the spray.

~

Mansoor raised his hand. *"Teacher... Malood... yesterday... Malood... cough?"*

~

Safiya beamed. *"Yes! Say: Malood coughed."*

~

The students repeated. *"Malood coughed."*

~

John tapped the board. *"Perfect."*

~

He paused. He turned, slowly, toward **Thuraya**. His eyes had narrowed. Not with anger. With the specific investigative narrowness of a man who had not forgotten, despite the lesson, despite the smoke, despite the ghost, that something had happened that morning that had not yet been explained.

~

"I will ask you something," he said, *"after class."*

~

Thuraya's smile turned too innocent. The specific too-innocent smile of a woman who had been waiting for this conversation all morning.

~

"Of course."

~

John muttered to himself, in English, just loud enough for **Safiya** to catch — "*Something strange is happening here.*"

~

And from the back of the class — from the seat against the far wall, the seat that was, **Safiya** had begun to notice, always occupied by the same quiet child — a boy watched everything with bright eyes.

~

Not speaking. Not joining. Just watching.

~

His name was **Saced**.

~

And he was — she would only understand this later — already collecting secrets like they were treasure.

SCENE FIVE

The Forest of Fenzuz

*Note: this scene belongs to Palm Nine — Al-Lajal — and is placed here because in the original manuscript it continues directly from the "practiced again and again" sentence at the end of that chapter. It shows what Mr. **John** was doing while **Safiya** taught the children their names. It is included now so that the full day at Al-Lajal is complete.*

~

While **Safiya** had been sitting by the warm falaj teaching the children *my name is, I am from, I belong to* — over and over, in small patient rotations — Mr. **John**, some distance away, had been walking.

~

He was still, quietly, angry at the falaj.

~

The anger had the specific small **flatness** of anger that had been **outlived** by its own heat — reduced now to a small, patient, unreasonable grumpiness that had settled into his walking. Every step

said: *warm falaj*. Every second step said: *warm falaj*. The word *warm* had acquired, for **John**, an entirely new and **sinister** meaning.



He walked between the palms at the edge of the grove. The light there was **dappled**. The ground was softer here — old fallen fronds, dry earth, the occasional small piece of — he stopped.



He had seen something in the trees.



He crouched. He examined. On the ground, half-hidden in the fronds, lay a scattering of small, **distinctive** shapes. Small. Particular. Exactly the shape of what **Thuraya** had shown them earlier, in the truck, when she had explained the Al-Naabi tagheera.



"Fenzuz," he whispered — to himself, because there was no one else.



His face **illuminated**. The grumpiness of the warm falaj, temporarily, departed.



He began to collect.



Quietly. One. Two. Three. Many. He moved around the fronds, **methodically**. He put them in his bag — the same bag that **Malood** had tried to eat that morning, the same bag whose paper **Malood** would also, later, eat.



*"I will surprise **Thuraya**,"* he said to himself. *"She will be pleased."*



He was imagining, in his head, the small **ceremonial** moment of presenting her with the fenzuz. *Look, Thuraya — I have brought you the mark of your tribe*. It was, he felt, the kind of cultural gesture that would confirm, once and for all, that he was paying attention. That he had listened. That he understood.



When he walked back to the falaj, the children were beginning to finish their sentences. **Mansoor** was on his fourth *I am from everywhere*. **Safiya** was clapping, warm and tired. **Thuraya** was sitting cross-legged on the stone bank, her teacher-satisfaction visible.



John arrived with the specific quiet pleasure of a man about to present a gift.



He opened his bag. He held it toward her.

~
ع

"Look!"

~
ع

Thuraya looked inside.

~
ع

For one full second, her face did nothing. Then the expression moved — through surprise, through recognition, through the specific **amused disbelief** of a woman who has just been given, by a well-meaning foreigner, exactly the *wrong* gift.

~
ع

She laughed. A lot.

~
ع

Not at him — with him. With that specific warm **Thuraya**-laugh that meant: *you have done a thing so perfectly mistaken that I must, now, explain it to you, but I want you to understand first how much I appreciate the intention.*

~
ع

"You collected my tagheera," she said.

~
ع

"Yes!" **John** said. Proudly. The specific proud tone of a man who had still not yet understood his own joke.

~
ع

Thuraya shook her head. The head-shake was soft. It carried its own warmth.

~
ع

"Only Al-Naabi," she said, "*can use it.*"

~
ع

John looked at the bag.

~
ع

He looked at the small, distinctive, Al-Naabi-only shapes he had, with great care, for the last twenty minutes, been collecting for a woman who was the only person at the falaj who was, in fact, entitled to them.

~
ع

"Oh."

~
ع

The children — who had, in the last ten seconds, realised what had happened — laughed. Again. The specific laughter they had been laughing all day, at this tall Englishman who had, once again, found the most **culturally** inappropriate gift available in a fifty-metre radius.

~

John, with the **weary** grace of a man who had now been laughed at twice in one day by the same audience, bowed his head slightly.

~

"I will put them back," he said, "where I found them."

~

And later, as the sun lowered, and **Uncle Nasser** drove the truck slowly back along the dusty road, **Mansoor** — unable to let a whole afternoon of excellent material pass unused — leaned toward **John**.

~

"Teacher... will you swim again?"

~

John said, quickly — a sentence he had evidently prepared — "No."

~

Safiya smiled. Softly. *"But you learned something today."*

~

"Yes," John said. "Always ask before you jump."

~

Thuraya laughed. *"And always listen to Omani teachers."*

~

That night, at the small wooden table in their simple house, **John** wrote in his notebook. He wrote slowly, the specific slowness of a man committing a lesson to paper properly, so that he could not, later, pretend he had not learned it.

~

*Today, I learned about names, tribes, and hot falaj.
And I learned that not all water is friendly.*

~

He paused. He looked at the sentence. Then — with the small amused honesty of a man who was, finally, finding his place — he added one more line, beneath the first two:

~

Also — never trust Thuraya's smile.

SCENE SIX

The Boy Who Collected Secrets

Back in the classroom, on the day of the smoke, the lesson had ended. The bell — **Abu Salim's** bell, the brass bell that every child in the village had learned to answer — had rung. The small storms had rushed out, half-English, half-Omani, shouting about ghosts and lightning and **Mohammadeen's** stick and **Malood's** cough.

☪

The classroom was, once again, that specific kind of empty that classrooms become when their children have just left — the air still holding the shape of them, the desks still warm, the chalk dust slowly settling.

☪

John stood at the front, tapping the board once, idly, with the flat edge of his chalk. **Safiya** was gathering papers. **Thuraya** was cleaning the smaller slate by the wall.

☪

Mohammadeen and **Fatkat** had already gone — to the teachers' small shared room where, **Safiya** had by now understood, the four adults in the school were going to have to share their tea and their working space for the foreseeable future.

☪

John, with the specific seriousness of a man returning to an unfinished conversation, turned.

☪

"Thuraya."

☪

"Yes, Mr. John."

☪

He pointed at his own mouth. His own English mouth, which had — that morning — produced Arabic sentences that his own English mind did not know.

☪

"Explain."

☪

Thuraya set down her slate. She sat on the small stool at the front. She considered her answer. Then she answered — simply, honestly, in the way that **Thuraya** always answered the questions she was not going to evade.

☪

"You have been listening," she said. *"More than you know."*

☪

"Listening to what?"



"Listening to us. Every day. In the market. At the falaj. In the street. In the classroom. When the children speak to each other. When Aunt Azizah shouts at Malood. When Uncle Nasser calls for passengers. When the women at the water scold each other. When the old men at the mosque greet each other."



She paused. She smiled — the small teacher-smile, not the mischievous one.



"Your ears," she said, "are smarter than your mouth. They have been collecting sentences. Today — when you were shocked, when your mind was somewhere else — your mouth finally used them."



John stared at her. He considered this. It was, he realised, a completely plausible explanation — and also, somehow, not entirely reassuring.



"So I will," he said, slowly, "keep doing that?"



*"If you are lucky," **Thuraya** said, "yes. If you are lucky, every week, without noticing, you will speak a little more Arabic. And your wife," she added, turning to **Safiya**, "will too."*



Safiya, who had been listening, smiled. *"Good."*



Outside, the village was settling into its afternoon hour. The bell had been rung. The children were scattered. Some had gone home. Some had gone to the falaj. Some had, without any particular plan, gathered in small groups near the mosque wall, where the shade was best, to continue talking about whatever it was that ten-year-olds in 1973 continued talking about when school ended.



One of those small groups was under a ghaf tree near the old wall.



Three boys. Two small. One — slightly older, slightly quieter — sitting between them, cross-legged, in the specific composed posture of a storyteller.



Saeed.



The quiet boy. The boy from the back of the classroom. The boy who did not speak, did not play, did not join — but who, all morning, had been watching.

٧٤

He was not playing now. He was *talking*. Quietly.

٧٥

The two smaller boys were listening — leaning forward, eyes already bigger than normal, ears fully committed to the reception of whatever it was that **Saeed** was telling them.

٧٦

"*Teacher John*," **Saeed** said — his voice low, even, **measured** — "*went into the smoke.*"

٧٧

One of the boys whispered, "*We saw.*"

٧٨

"*And*," **Saeed** continued, "*when he came out, he was grey. Like a ghost.*"

٧٩

"*We saw.*"

٨٠

"*And then*," **Saeed** said — his voice dropping just enough to signal the important part — "*Shayb Khalaf came. And grabbed him. And Teacher John... spoke Arabic.*"

٨١

The other boy — the smaller one, the one with the gap-toothed seriousness — whispered, "*An English man? Speaking Arabic?*"

٨٢

Saeed looked at the two of them. He looked at them with the specific **authority** of a boy who had been *watching*, all morning, while everyone else had been panicking or laughing or running, and who had therefore accumulated a small **private** archive of the day's mysterious facts.

٨٣

"*Something*," he said, quietly, "*happened when Shayb Khalaf touched him.*"

٨٤

The two boys went very still.

٨٥

Saeed said nothing else. He did not need to. He had — with the precise, small **economy** of a natural storyteller — left the sentence **unfinished**. And the unfinished sentence, once it had been delivered, would now do its own work. It would spread. It would multiply. By evening, every child in Samail would be telling their mother a slightly different version of the same thing — *Teacher John went into the smoke and came out speaking Arabic.*

٧٤

Inside the classroom, **John** did not yet know this.

٧٥

He was looking at **Thuraya**. He was frowning slightly.

٧٦

"Thuraya."

٧٧

"Yes?"

٧٨

*"The old man. **Khalaf**. Tell me..."* He hesitated. *"Tell me about him."*

٧٩

Thuraya met his eyes. The small mischievous smile returned — the *Thuraya-knows-something-that-John-does-not* smile. The same one **John** had, in his notebook that afternoon, written the instruction *never trust* beside.

٨٠

"Tomorrow," she said. *"I will tell you tomorrow."*

٨١

"Why not now?"

٨٢

"Because," she said, *"tomorrow, you will be ready to hear it."*

٨٣

And outside, beneath the ghaf tree, **Saeed** — eight years old, patient, quiet, holding the day's secrets in both hands like small stones — stood up. He brushed his robe. And he walked, without hurry, toward the next small group of children whose day needed, in his view, to be improved with the correct version of the story.

٨٤

 Did You Know?**Wusum — Tribal Branding Marks**

Remember John's embarrassment when he collected the "fenzuz" symbols belonging to the Al-Naabi tribe, thinking they were just natural shapes? This resembles a real, ancient Arab custom called "wusum" — a distinctive mark for each tribe, used to brand camels and livestock and mark ownership, working much like a family or clan's signature. These marks go back thousands of years, and traces are still carved into rocks across the Arabian Peninsula today.

Source: jordantimes.com · [researchgate.net](https://www.researchgate.net)

PALM

Palm Eleven

Maghsob — And the Boy Who Watches

SCENE ONE

The Night That Would Not Sleep

John did not sleep well that night.

~

The night air in Samail, in October of 1973, was warm and still. It was the kind of night that, on any other evening, would have been a blessing — the specific warm stillness that makes the **bisat** feel generous, and the breeze through the window feel deliberate, and the distant sound of the falaj feel like a lullaby.

~

Tonight, it was none of those things.

~

Every time **John** closed his eyes, he saw smoke.

~

Or a stick. Or a thin old man with sharp eyes. Or — in the **unhelpful** way that tired minds combine images — all of them together, at the end of a dark path, standing in a small row, saying something he could not quite understand.

~

He turned, in his simple bed. He looked at the ceiling.

~

The ceiling, he was reminded for the second time in two weeks, was made of palm fronds. The fronds, he was also reminded, contained small shifting things. Small shifting things, at night, when the mind was already occupied with smoke and old men and sticks, were not the soothing presence they had been three weeks ago.

~

"This place," he whispered, in English — quietly, because **Safiya** was sleeping beside him — *"is doing something to my brain."*

~

Beside him, **Safiya** was asleep. Breathing peacefully. Her scarf folded neatly near the pillow — folded the way **Thuraya's** mother had taught her, the small triangular fold that had to be done exactly right for the scarf to sit correctly again in the morning.



She had, **John** noted with some resentment, entirely the **peaceful** sleep of a woman who did not know the Arabic word *maghsoob*, and who had not, that morning, threatened-corrected herself in a language she did not speak.



Outside, the village of Samail was quiet. Somewhere far away, a dog barked — once, twice, then stopped, having decided the thing it had been barking at did not deserve the effort. Somewhere closer — from the small yard of Aunt **Azizah's** house — **Malood** made a small unhappy sound, the specific small sound of a goat **arguing** with his own dreams.



John closed his eyes again.



And immediately, he saw **Shayb Khalaf**.



Not a **menacing Khalaf**. Not a **Khalaf** with a stick raised. Just the old man, standing near a clay wall, holding his **kheyzaran**, looking exactly — exactly — like he had that morning.



The voice came, inside **John's** head, in the old man's Arabic.



"kballik rijal."



Be a man, the voice said. In **John's** own head. In perfect Arabic.



John opened his eyes.



"No. Enough," he said to himself. Out loud. In English. As though English itself would act as a kind of protection, a small firm sentence his mind could hold onto.



"Tomorrow," he said, *"I will ask **Thuraya**. Everything."*



He turned onto his side. He watched the soft outline of **Safiya's** breathing. He tried to match his breath to hers. He failed. He tried again. He failed again.



Somewhere, the dog barked once more. The goat made its small argument. The village continued its ancient **hush**.



And **John** lay awake. For a long time.

SCENE TWO

Two Missions

The next morning, **John** walked to school with two clear missions.



One: teach English.



Two: understand why he had, the previous morning, suddenly spoken Arabic like a confused poet.



He had arranged the two missions in his head as a **numbered** list. He had considered writing them down. He had decided, on reflection, that writing down *understand why I suddenly spoke Arabic like a confused poet* was the kind of sentence that — if found by anyone in a notebook — would be very difficult to explain.



Safiya, walking beside him, noticed his serious face immediately. His face had, she had come to learn, three settings — the *normal teacher* setting, the *amused-at-Mansoor* setting, and the *something specific is happening in my head and I am not going to tell anyone about it yet* setting.



This morning, it was the third.



"*You look,*" she said, with the affectionate teasing that had become the natural shape of their morning walks, "*like you are going to arrest someone.*"



John did not smile.



"*I am,*" he said. "*A mystery.*"



Thuraya was already at the school. She entered the classroom a few seconds after them — cheerful, as always, carrying books and her small piece of chalk.



"Good morning," she said.

~

John looked at her carefully. The look was the same detective-look he had given **Safiya** on the path.
"Good morning. We need to talk."

~

Thuraya's face — without any surprise, because she had been expecting exactly this — arranged itself into a smile. She set her books on the desk. She adjusted, very slightly, the chalk behind her ear.

~

"About your *flying lesson* yesterday?"

~

"About the old man," **John** said. His voice was flat. It had the specific flatness of a man who did not intend to be **deflected**. "And about what you did not tell me."

~

Thuraya raised her eyebrows — the small precise raise of a teacher who had been asked a broad question and had decided, strategically, to narrow it.

~

"I did not tell you many things," she said. "You must be more specific."

~

Before **John** could refine his question — and he had been refining it in his head since six in the morning — the door **burst** open and the students ran in. Filling the room with noise and dust and the specific energy of ten small bodies that had been, for approximately fifteen minutes, unsupervised on the path.

~

Mansoor came first. Of course he did. He nearly crashed into a desk — *nearly*, because he had developed a small instinct for missing desks at the last possible moment, a village skill whose origin **Safiya** had not yet traced.

~

Ahmed walked in quietly, in his usual careful way, and sat straight like a ruler.

~

Khalil whispered something to **Ali**. Both of them laughed the laugh of boys who were going to be, within three minutes, in some small form of trouble.

~

The girls — **Noura**, **Marwa**, **Rahma**, **Salima**, and **Mathila** — came in together. They were talking about something *serious*, and *secret*, and **Safiya** understood that she was not going to learn

what it was. Girl secrets, in this classroom, had a specific **protected** quality that the boys' secrets — **Saeed's** aside — did not have.

~

And in the back, near the door, stood one boy.

~

He did not sit immediately. He stood for a moment first — as though he were, briefly, surveying the room before committing to a seat. Then he walked, calmly, to the far-back desk and sat down.

~

Saeed.

~

He did not talk much. He did not play much. He watched.

~

Always watched.

SCENE THREE

Telling Stories

John, returning himself to mission one — which he had promised he would — turned to the board. He wrote, in careful large letters:

~

Today's Topic: Telling Stories

~

He turned back to the class. He had, in fact, planned this lesson before yesterday's smoke had happened, and he had kept it today because a lesson on *telling stories* had, for reasons he was beginning to understand, a very specific relevance to this particular village.

~

"In English," he said, "when we tell a story, we use special words. Small words. But they help us move through time."

~

He wrote:

~

First
Then
After that
Finally

~

Safiya — from her usual spot near the back — clapped her hands, the warm teacher-clap that she had been adopting more and more without noticing.

~

"Good!" she said. *"Today, we talk about... yesterday."*

~

The class reacted immediately.

~

"Teacher **John** fell!" **Mansoor** announced — proudly, with the specific triumphant **announcement** voice of a boy who had been waiting since dawn to reintroduce yesterday's disaster into the classroom record.

~

John closed his eyes. Just for one second. The specific one-second closure of a teacher accepting that a personal **humiliation** had now become, **officially**, part of the syllabus.

~

"Yes," he said. *"Thank you, **Mansoor**. The village will never forget."*

~

Thuraya smiled. *"Okay. Who wants to tell the story?"*

~

Ahmed — the boy who was always prepared — raised his hand. He had, **Safiya** could see, been composing this sentence in his head for the last two minutes. He had been waiting for his moment.

~

He stood up. He placed his hands behind his back in his usual small-man-at-a-meeting way. He spoke.

~

"Yesterday," he said, *"first, the truck came. Then, we ran. After that, Teacher **John** fell. Finally, he became a ghost."*

~

The class laughed.

~

John sighed. *"Excellent grammar. Terrible story."*

~

Safiya pointed at **Noura**. *"Your turn."*

~

Noura thought. Her face went through its usual stages — the serious consideration, the small arranging, the decision. Then she spoke, slowly, **mixing** her two languages the way all the children mixed them.

~

*"Yesterday, first, smoke come. Then, **Mansoor** run like crazy. After that, **Malood** cough. Finally... teacher **John**... grey."*

~

Safiya nodded happily. *"Good! Very good!"*

~

She did not correct the grammar. The grammar would become, with each telling, slightly better. The *story* itself — that was the point. The child had, for the first time in her short English life, successfully used three sequential time markers and arrived, correctly, at the ending.

~

The lesson continued. **Khalil** told a version in which he, himself, had personally rescued a small bird from the smoke — a version which nobody else remembered but which **Khalil** delivered with full **conviction**. **Ali** — quietly — told a version in which he had stayed inside with his mother. **Mathila** told one in which the pesticide man had waved at her, which was probably true.

~

And **Saeed**, in the back, was silent.

~

Watching.

~

Listening.

~

Collecting.

SCENE FOUR

The Maghsoob

After the class ended, **John** did not leave.

~

He waited.

~

When the last student had run out the door — **Mansoor**, predictably, shouting something down the corridor that was not strictly inside-voice — **John** turned to **Thuraya**.

~

"Now," he said. *"Tell me the truth."*



Thuraya smiled sweetly. The **sweet** smile. The one that, as **John** had written in his own notebook, should *never* be trusted.



"About what?"



*"About **Shayb Khalaf**," John said. "And about me. And about why I spoke Arabic."*



She looked at him. For a long second. Considering.



Then — with the small decisive nod of a woman who had decided, after all, to indulge him — she said, *"Come. Let's walk."*



They walked outside. Past the falaj. Past the trees. **Safiya**, knowing the conversation was not for her, stayed behind to organise books. She understood that **Thuraya** was going to tell **John** something specific, in the specific way **Thuraya** told things, and that the walk was part of how the telling would work.



They came to an old wall. The wall of someone's very old clay house — the kind of wall that had been patched so many times that the patches had their own patches. **Thuraya** stopped.



She leaned, lightly, against it. She looked at the ground. Then she looked at **John**.



"People here," she said, "love stories."



John nodded. *"I noticed."*



"And people here," she continued, her voice dropping just slightly, "love fear."



John did not like where this was going.



She lowered her voice further. The specific lowering that told a listener: *what comes next is not for everyone, so listen carefully.*

"Some say *Shayb Khalaf* is a *sabir*."

John blinked. "A... what?"

"A sorcerer," she said. Clearly. Slowly.

John laughed. It was not a confident laugh. It was the small, too-fast laugh of a person trying very hard not to take something seriously.

"That is not funny."

"I am not joking," **Thuraya** said. Her voice was **serious**. Too serious. He felt his spine make a small, involuntary adjustment.

"The story says: to become a great sorcerer — a strong one — a man must give one of his own children to the devils. He must hand the child over. The child disappears."

She paused. The pause was specific. Measured. A storyteller's pause.

"Years later..." she continued, "the child comes back. But not as a child. As a **maghsoob**."

John felt cold.

Not metaphorically. A real, small, specific cold that passed across the back of his neck and down his shoulders — the particular way that a body registers a story it does not want to be registering.

"They say the maghsoob comes back like a dead man," **Thuraya** continued, her voice even quieter now. "Dirty. His clothes are old. His mind is gone. The devils ate his mind. People do not accept him, because... he already died in their hearts, the day the father gave him away. So the maghsoob wanders. Between houses. Alone. For the rest of his life. A walking sign of what his father did to buy his **sibr**."

John swallowed.

*"And they say **Khalaf**..." John whispered, "has one of these children?"*

~

"That is what they say. A son. Given, long ago. And now — somewhere in the next village, or perhaps further — a maghsoob walks. Dusty. Silent. Recognised by nobody."

~

She lowered her voice one more notch.

~

*"And they say that a sabir like **Khalaf**... sometimes... can put words in your mouth."*

~

John stared at her.

~

He considered, for one full second, what he was being told. He considered, for a second second, the Arabic sentences that had come out of his own mouth the previous morning — sentences he did not know, conjugated correctly, delivered with the cadence of a village. He considered, for a third second, the possibility that the two things were connected.

~

Then he **rallied**. With the full force of his English rationalism, he rallied.

~

"... You are joking," he said.

~

Thuraya looked at him.

~

Her face, for a long moment, gave nothing.

~

Then — slowly, **mercilessly** — she smiled.

~

"Yes," she said. *"Of course I am joking."*

~

He did not relax.

~

His shoulders, which had been up near his ears for the last three sentences, did not come down. His breath, which had been shallow for the last thirty seconds, did not fully return. The problem with a joke told in a **low**, serious voice, against an old clay wall, about a village myth you had never heard before, is that the body receives it before the mind has had a chance to vote.

۷
ع

She laughed — properly now. The full warm **Thuraya**-laugh. "*Mr. **Jobn**, your face! You look like you saw the ghost again.*"

۷
ع

"You told me that on purpose," he said.

۷
ع

She nodded. Proudly.

۷
ع

"Yes."

SCENE FIVE

Meanwhile, Under the Trees

Not far away — near the trees, in the specific cool patch of shade behind the small school yard — **Saeed** was sitting with two smaller boys.

۷
ع

He was not playing.

۷
ع

He was talking.

۷
ع

Quietly.

۷
ع

The two smaller boys sat cross-legged in front of him. They were watching his face. They had the specific full attention of children who had been promised a *story*, and who had learned — by approximately the age of six — that adults in a village gave you news, but children of **Saeed**'s particular kind gave you *secrets*, which were much more valuable.

۷
ع

"They say," **Saeed** said — beginning, as all good tellers of stories did, with the *they say* that **relieved** the teller of any personal responsibility for the claim — *"that **Shayb Kbalaf** is a **sabir**. A strong one."*

۷
ع

The boys' eyes grew big.

۷
ع

"They say," **Saeed** continued, *"that a long time ago... he gave one of his sons."*

۷
ع

One boy whispered, *"Gave him where?"*



"To the devils," **Saeed** said. **Serenely**. "So he could become strong. A strong *sahir*."



The boys stared.



"And the son," **Saeed** continued, "came back. But not as a son. As a **maghsoob**. Dusty. Empty. His mind eaten."



"Where is he now?" whispered the smaller boy.



"Walking," **Saeed** said. "Somewhere. He never stops walking."



A pause. Then — the embellishment that **Saeed** had been preparing, his own **invention**, because **Thuraya** had not said this exact thing — "and some say, when a *sahir* like **Khalaf** touches you... he can put Arabic words into your mouth. Words you do not know."



One of the boys — the smaller one, the one with the wide alarmed face — whispered, "Did he put words in Teacher **John**'s mouth?"



Saeed considered this question.



He considered it with the specific small **deliberation** of a storyteller weighing how committed he wanted to be to the claim. If he said *yes*, the story would be bigger. If he said *maybe*, the story would last longer.



He chose the more **durable** option.



He smiled. A small, clever smile. "*Maybe*."



And the two boys — nodding slowly, eyes still wide — sat with the *maybe* in their laps like a small, glowing, living thing. A *maybe* that would, by the end of the day, have travelled through their mothers to their mothers' neighbours to their fathers at the mosque to their cousins in the far fields.



Under the trees, **Saeed** sat back against the trunk. He closed his eyes briefly. He was eight years old. He was already — though no one in the village had yet said this — quite a good writer. He had not

been taught to write stories, exactly. He had been taught to *watch*. But watching, done long enough and patiently enough, produced stories of its own.

~

He opened his eyes.

~

He looked at the two smaller boys. He considered what to add next. He had a small **instinct**, by now, for when a story had received exactly enough **weight**.

~

He stood up. He brushed his robe. He walked — without hurry, without announcement — out from under the trees and down the path toward the next group of children whose day, in his view, would benefit from the correct version of what had happened the day before.

SCENE SIX

The Afternoon of Shadows

That day, **John** was... nervous.

~

The *maghsob* story, despite having been officially **retracted** by **Thuraya** in the following sentence, had **lodged**. In his chest. Behind his breastbone. In the specific small place where stories, once they have entered at the correct angle, are very difficult to dislodge.

~

Every shadow, that afternoon, looked suspicious.

~

Every sound looked dangerous.

~

When **Malood** — who had, in the specific goat-magic way of **Malood**, positioned himself behind a water bucket in the school yard without **John** noticing — suddenly jumped out, **John** jumped like he had seen a lion.

~

An actual lion. The full, full jump. Both feet off the ground.

~

Safiya, who had seen the whole thing, laughed. "*You are becoming very local.*"

~

"*I am becoming.*" **John** answered, without pleasure, "*very scared.*"

~

When they walked home — along the usual path, past the usual walls, past the usual trees — **John** looked at every old man.

٢٧
ع

Every wall.

٢٨
ع

Every tree.

٢٩
ع

It was exhausting, **Safiya** noted. She said nothing. A husband, she had long since learned, was owed the dignity of his own small, unnecessary fears, at least until the fear had given up on its own.

٣٠
ع

Then **John** saw someone, sitting near the road.

٣١
ع

Old. Thin. Holding a stick.

٣٢
ع

Shayb Khalaf.

٣٣
ع

John stopped walking.

٣٤
ع

He did not stop with a plan. He stopped because his feet had simply stopped — without consulting him, without asking, without any permission from the English part of his brain. They had, it seemed, made a decision on his behalf.

٣٥
ع

Safiya continued walking a few steps. Then she noticed.

٣٦
ع

"John?"

٣٧
ع

She turned. She followed his gaze. She saw the old man. She understood, in a single second, the *entire* situation — the sleepless night, the Arabic sentences, the muttered *maghsoob*, and now this — and she had, silently, the small, unseen wife-thought of *oh, John, really.*

٣٨
ع

The old man looked up.

٣٩
ع

Their eyes met.

٤٠
ع

Khalaf said nothing. He simply watched.

۞

Not hostile. Not welcoming. Just — watching — in the specific calm way that **Khalaf** had, that **Safiya** had already noticed was the only way he ever watched anything at all.

۞

John nodded. Very politely. The small, restrained, English nod of a man who had been told a ghost story about someone and was now standing on a public road and had decided, in the space of two seconds, that he was going to be polite about it regardless.

۞

Khalaf nodded back.

۞

Nothing happened.

۞

No words came into **John**'s mouth. No Arabic. No prophecy. No ancient phrase rising from a place he did not remember having. His mouth stayed **obedient**. His feet agreed — after their small, unauthorised stop — to start walking again.

۞

They walked away.

۞

John did not breathe until they turned the corner.

۞

Then, properly, at the corner, he exhaled — a long, complete exhale, the specific exhale of a man who had just survived an entirely **imaginary** encounter with an entirely imaginary danger.

۞

Safiya put her arm through his. "*Home*," she said, gently.

۞

"*Home*," **John** agreed.

۞

That night, **John** could not sleep.

۞

Again.

۞

He looked at the ceiling. Then at the door. Then at the window.

۞

"*Thuraya*, " he whispered, to no one, "*is enjoying this too much.*"

۞

Outside, the village was quiet. Inside, his imagination was not.

۞

He closed his eyes. And, somewhere in the small fold between waking and sleep, he dreamed.

۞

*He dreamed of a man made of dust, walking out of a grave at the end of a long path — the specific long path that ran from the edge of the village toward the farms. The man was tall. Thin. Holding a stick. His clothes were old. His face was exactly the face of **Shayb Khalaf**, only paler — only dustier — only, in the way of dreams, more present than real people are when they are actually there. And the man, in the dream, was **speaking**. Speaking calmly. In perfect English. "Good morning, teacher **John**. I have been waiting. I have something to tell you."*

۞

John woke up.

۞

He sat up in the bed.

۞

He looked at **Safiya**. Sleeping peacefully. Scarf still folded.

۞

He lay back down. He stared at the ceiling. He watched the slow shifts of the palm fronds above him until the first call of fajr came from the mosque — and even then, he did not sleep.

۞

The next day at school, **John** walked in with a small cup of coffee in his hand and red eyes.

۞

Ahmed noticed immediately. "*Teacher... you tired?*"

۞

"Yes," **John** said. "*Very.*"

۞

Mansoor grinned. The specific, knowing grin of an eight-year-old who had, somehow, already heard a version of yesterday's *maghsob* conversation through the village information channels that no adult could quite map.

۞

"*You afraid?*"

۞

"No," **John** lied.

~

And in the back, near the door, **Saeed** — the boy who collected secrets like treasure, the boy whose *maybe* was, by now, travelling through the village in small glowing pieces — watched.

~

And smiled.

~

Just a little.

..

Did You Know?

Jinn and Sorcerer Beliefs in Arab Folklore

Remember the frightening "maghsoob" story the children told about Sheikh Khalaf? Belief in jinn is a genuine part of Arab folklore predating Islam, holding that they are beings created from smokeless fire capable of influencing humans — which is why sorcerer tales often involve summoning jinn for magic or harm. These beliefs remain alive in the oral heritage of Gulf villages today.

Source: britannica.com · en.wikipedia.org

PALM

Palm Twelve

A Ring, a Goat, and an Apology

SCENE ONE

Too Quiet a Morning

The day began quietly.

~

Too quietly.

~

John noticed this first, and that alone made him **suspicious**.

~

*The village of Samail usually woke up with noise. It woke up with the specific **layered** noise of children running on sand, of goats arguing with the low walls that tried to contain them, of someone shouting for someone else from one courtyard to another, of women pounding grain, of doors opening and closing, and — always, reliably, without fail — **Mansoor** doing something, somewhere, that he was not supposed to be doing.*

~

But this morning, there was only the sound of birds and the soft, continuous hush of the falaj water.

~

Nothing else.

~

Safiya was sitting near the small mirror, fixing her scarf. She was moving slowly. Calmly. The way a person moves when they want the day to **stay** peaceful — as though peacefulness were a small bird that might fly away if one moved too suddenly.

~

John was writing something in his notebook. He was writing the small observations of a man who had begun, **inadvertently**, to keep a journal. He had not planned this. The village had quietly, without asking, turned him into a person who wrote things down at breakfast.

~

Thuraya arrived a few minutes later, carrying books and smiling.

~

"Good morning," she said. Her eyes moved, briefly, from **Safiya's** careful scarf to **John's** half-filled notebook. "*You both look... too relaxed.*"

~

John looked up. "*Yes. And that worries me.*"

~

Safiya laughed. "*You are becoming very local.*"

~

It had become, she realised, a small running joke between them. *You are becoming very local.* She had been using it for two weeks now. Each time, it meant something slightly different. Today it meant: *you are now suspicious of peace itself.* Which was, she had to admit, a very Samaili attitude.

~

They walked to school together.

~

Malood, the baby goat — who had, by some unexplained agreement that had never been formally signed, become the small fourth member of their walking group — followed them like a small white cloud with legs.

~

No one had invited him.

~

No one could stop him.

~

The road was quieter than usual. A woman greeted them from a doorway. A boy **dashed** past with bread in his hands, heading home. The falaj, as always, continued its hush. But the usual dense overlapping morning — the thing the village did every morning — was not happening.

~

And the quietness, for reasons **John** could not articulate but was beginning to accept, continued to feel like a promise of something.

SCENE TWO

The Discovery

The first two lessons passed normally.

~

Too normally.

۞

The students did their work. Even **Mansoor** only caused two small problems — a number so low that **Safiya**, when she noticed, actually kept a small count of them in her head, the way a doctor might count a patient's low pulse. *One: he flipped his slate. Two: he told Ali that Ali's handwriting looked like an ant's argument.* That was all. By **Mansoor's** standards, it was almost good behaviour.

۞

Then, during the break, **Safiya** stood up to wash her hands near the water pot in the corner of the classroom.

۞

She stopped.

۞

She looked at her hand.

۞

She looked again.

۞

Then she froze — with the specific, small stillness of a person whose morning has, in the space of one glance, stopped being an ordinary morning.

۞

"*My ring,*" she said. Slowly. Each word separate.

۞

Thuraya turned. "*What?*"

۞

"*My ring. It is not here.*"

۞

Safiya checked her other hand. The fingers were there. The finger was there. The small, pale, slightly **indented** ring of skin, paler than the rest, was there. But the actual ring — the gold band — was not.

۞

She checked her pocket. Then her bag. Then, with the specific small panic of a woman who had already lost this same ring once, she checked her bag *again*.

۞

Nothing.

۞

John stood up immediately. *"What ring?"*

~
~

"My ring," Safiya said. "The one from my mother."

~
~

Silence.

~
~

Even **Mansoor** felt it was serious. He had been, a second ago, preparing to offer a joke — **Safiya** could see the joke forming on his small mouth — and he swallowed it back down. The specific swallow of a ten-year-old who had, for once in his life, read the room correctly.

~
~

Thuraya walked closer. *"Are you sure you wore it today?"*

~
~

"Yes," Safiya said. "I remember. I fixed my scarf. I looked at it in the mirror."

~
~

She remembered the exact moment. She remembered thinking, as she had so many mornings since her mother's death, *the ring. Still there. Good.* It was one of those small **registrations** that happened under the surface of her mornings, every morning, automatically.

~
~

John's face changed. Not into panic. Into the specific investigative **focus** of a man who had, in another life, been quite good at finding things people had lost. *"Okay. Nobody panic. We will find it."*

~
~

Mansoor raised his hand. Slowly. Almost reluctantly. The gesture of a boy who had just thought of a solution he knew nobody wanted to hear.

~
~

"Teacher... maybe Malood eat it?"

~
~

Everyone turned. Slowly.

~
~

Malood was standing near the classroom door. In the small triangle of sun that came through the gap at the bottom. His posture was the posture of a goat who had been, all morning, **minding** his own business.

~
~

Chewing.

~
~

Something.

~
~

Everyone stared.

~
~

Safiya's heart jumped. "*Malood! No, no, no...*"

~
~

She walked toward him. Slowly. The specific slow approach of a woman trying not to **spook** a small animal whose cooperation she suddenly urgently needed.

~
~

Malood stopped chewing.

~
~

Then — with the specific, practised, unregrettable decision-making of a goat who had decided that *safety* was something other goats and other people could worry about — he ran.

SCENE THREE

The Chase

Malood ran like he had stolen the **crown** of the king.

~
~

He did not run in a straight line. He ran in the specific **zigzag** that a small hunted thing runs when it wants, urgently, not to be caught.

~
~

The children ran after him.

~
~

All of them. As one. With the specific **collective** instinct of a classroom that had, in its pocket, every morning for two months, been secretly hoping that *exactly this* would one day happen.

~
~

"*Catch him!*"

~
~

"*He ate the ring!*"

~
~

"*Stop, Malood!*"

~
~

John ran too. He ran holding his trousers — because **John**'s trousers, in the warm village climate, had a small, reliable tendency to **loosen** at the worst possible moments — and he was not, at this

particular moment, about to be remembered in the village as the English teacher who had chased a goat with no trousers.

٧٧
ع

Thuraya shouted, from further back — her voice the specific calm teacher-shout that was heard clearly over any chaos — *"Careful!"*

٧٨
ع

Malood jumped over a small wall.

٧٩
ع

The children jumped too. Effortlessly. The specific short-legged leap of boys and girls who had been leaping over exactly these walls since the moment they could walk, and who had, long ago, absorbed the art into their bodies.

٨٠
ع

John tried.

٨١
ع

He did not jump.

٨٢
ع

He climbed.

٨٣
ع

Slowly.

٨٤
ع

Carefully.

٨٥
ع

With the specific, dignified, **cautious** climbing of a tall adult Englishman who had, finally, accepted that his body was not a village body and that certain walls were, for him, mountains.

٨٦
ع

By the time he reached the other side — panting, sweating, trousers still technically in position — **Malood** was gone.

٨٧
ع

They searched near the trees.

٨٨
ع

Near the falaj.

٨٩
ع

Near the small fields at the edge of the village where **Aunt Azizah's** vegetables grew in small patient rows.

و

Nothing.

و

No white cloud. No chewing sound. No small **proprietary** silhouette on any wall.

و

Safiya looked like she wanted to cry. Not quite. Almost. The specific small **pre-cry** tightness of a woman whose one important inherited object was in the **digestive** system of a small horned thief.

و

Thuraya put a hand on **Safiya**'s shoulder. The firm, warm, specific hand of a friend. *"We will find it."*

و

Then a small voice said — very quietly, from somewhere near the cluster of children standing at the edge of the path —

و

"...Maybe Shayb Khalaf."

و

Everyone turned.

و

It was one of the smaller boys. One **Safiya** did not yet know by name — a small round-eyed child with a solemn face and a dusty robe.

و

Mansoor's eyes became big. *"Yes! Shayb Khalaf!"*

و

Another boy whispered, *"He likes shiny things."*

و

A girl said, almost without meaning to, the word — *"He is... **sabir**..."*

و

Another girl added, *"His son is **maghsoob**."*

و

John felt cold.

و

The specific small cold he had felt the first time **Thuraya** had mentioned the word *maghsoob* along the old wall. The cold that was not really about the truth of anything — that was, at the end,

Thuraya's joke — but about the way stories, once they had entered a small body, did not quite leave again.

٢١٤

Safiya looked at **Thuraya**. Quickly. *"They don't really mean that... right?"*

٢١٤

Thuraya hesitated.

٢١٤

Just a little.

٢١٤

The smallest **hesitation** in the world. A quarter of a second. Less.

٢١٤

John noticed.

٢١٤

That made everything worse.

SCENE FOUR

The Rumour

By lunchtime, the story was everywhere.

٢١٤

It had **migrated** — through the small channels that carried all important village information, which were the children's mouths, the mothers' doorways, the men's tea at **Sadoo**'s shop, the women's conversations at the falaj — until the whole village had, by around half past twelve, the same set of sentences available in four or five slightly different versions.

٢١٤

"Shayb Khalaf took the ring."

٢١٤

"Malood works for him."

٢١٤

"He uses magic."

٢١٤

"His son is maghsoob. He sold him for sibr long ago."

٢١٤

Saeed did not say anything.

٢١٤

He only listened.

~
~

And remembered.

~
~

He was, once again, sitting in his usual quiet spot — this time beneath the small ghaf tree behind the school yard, with his bag on his knees and his eyes moving between the groups of other children as they rearranged the story, one small retelling at a time. He was, **Safiya** was beginning to understand, not just a collector of secrets. He was a **cataloguer** of them. He remembered, it seemed, every version.

~
~

Safiya tried to stay calm. She kept her face composed. She helped **Thuraya** continue the lesson. She even, once, smiled at **Mansoor** — a small quiet smile that required, in that moment, an actual effort.

~
~

But **John** could see she was worried.

~
~

Not panicked. Worried. The specific **contained** worry of a woman who was doing her best to perform composure while, underneath, privately measuring how badly she felt about the loss.

~
~

And **John**, meanwhile — **John** was **incensed**.

~
~

"This is crazy," he said, quietly, to **Thuraya**, as they stood at the edge of the yard. *"We are accusing an old man because a goat is stupid."*

~
~

Malood — who had, at some point in the last hour, returned, and was now sitting in the shade of the low wall with the specific complacent air of a goat who had nothing to confess — **sneezed**.

~
~

"See?" **John** pointed at the goat. *"Even he agrees."*

~
~

Thuraya sighed. It was a long sigh. Older than the morning. The specific sigh of a village teacher who had been watching this exact pattern — *thing lost* → *old man blamed* — all her life.

~
~

"People here," she said, *"when something is lost... they look for stories before they look for facts."*

~
~

Safiya, who had been listening, stood up.

~
~

"Then," she said, quietly but firmly, "let us look for facts."

SCENE FIVE

The Visit

They walked to the edge of the village.

~

The children did not come close.

~

They stayed far. Watching. Gathered in a loose, **cautious** line at the end of the path — **Mansoor**, **Khalil**, **Ali**, the small boys, the girls' triangle, **Saeed** at the back — all of them committed, as an audience commits to a play it has already heard the plot of, to witnessing the confrontation.

~

Shayb Khalaf's house was small.

~

Made of clay. The specific quiet clay of old Omani houses — the mud mixed with straw, the walls patched and re-patched, the door a plain worn blue that was, after many years, more grey than blue.

~

Quiet.

~

John felt his heart beating faster.

~

He did not want to be here. He **actively** did not want to be here. He had spent the walk over telling himself, with increasing firmness, that he was not afraid of old men. That he was an English teacher. That he had come to this country with his wife. That the ring belonged, in all probability, to the small pale village criminal sleeping by the low wall, not to an old man they had spent the morning **slandering**.

~

Thuraya knocked.

~

Nothing.

~

She knocked again.

~

The door opened — slowly. With the same quiet unhurriedness it had opened the last time. **Khalaf** stood there.

٢٧

Thin. Quiet. Holding his stick.

٢٨

"Yes?" he said.

٢٩

Thuraya spoke gently. The specific careful Arabic voice of a younger person addressing an elder whose patience had already been, in her view, asked for more than enough today.

٣٠

"Good afternoon, uncle. We are sorry to disturb you."

٣١

He looked at **John**.

٣٢

Then at **Safiya**.

٣٣

Then at **Malood** — who had, without permission, followed them, and who was now sitting, composed and unconcerned, beside **John's** ankle.

٣٤

His eyes stopped at **Malood**.

٣٥

"...This goat," **Khalaf** said. Flatly. "Always hungry."

٣٦

John swallowed.

٣٧

There was, he thought, something specific in the old man's voice — not annoyance, not blame, just the **weary** recognition of a man who had already, several times in his long life, traced a small problem in his yard back to a small white animal who did not belong to him.

٣٨

Thuraya explained — carefully, respectfully. "**Sophia** lost her ring. The children... are afraid it came here."

٣٩

Khalaf's face changed.

٤٠

Not angry. Not scared. Not surprised.

﴿

Just... tired.

﴿

The specific, **inherited** tiredness of a man who had — **Safiya** understood, with a sudden, complete, painful clarity — been accused of many things over many years, for many items lost by many people in a village that had decided, a long time ago, that when *something-went-missing* happened, the first name to be **reached for** was his.

﴿

"I did not take anything," he said.

﴿

The sentence was calm. It was also, **Safiya** noticed, a sentence he had said before. Perhaps many times. A sentence that had, for him, the worn smoothness of a stone turned over and over in a pocket.

﴿

Safiya felt **ashamed**.

﴿

"We are sorry," she said quickly. *"We only... wanted to ask."*

﴿

Khalaf nodded. Once.

﴿

"You can look."

﴿

He stepped aside, without ceremony, and let them see inside.

﴿

They looked.

﴿

*The house was simple. A mat on the packed earth floor — the bisat, worn smooth in the specific places where a tall thin man had sat on it for many years. A pot. A small collection of clothes hung on a hook. A clay jar of water. A small shelf with three books — **Safiya** could see, on the spine of one, the specific gold-threaded binding of an old Qur'an. Nothing else. No shiny things. No jewellery. No ring.*

﴿

No ring.

﴿

John felt relief.

و
ع

And guilt.

و
ع

Both at once — the specific mixed feeling of a person who had, in the last four hours, been at least partially convinced by a story, and who now, standing in the calm, quiet room of the man the story had been about, was discovering that the room was just — a room.

و
ع

An old man's room. With a mat, and a pot, and three books, and no ring.

SCENE SIX

The Truth and the Apology

When they walked back along the path, **Saeed** was waiting.

و
ع

He had not been with the main group of children. He had been, somehow, ahead of them — sitting on a low wall at the turn in the path, with his bag on his knees, watching the approach of the three adults with his usual **composed** quiet.

و
ع

He did not smile. He did not joke. He did not — unlike **Mansoor**, who would have — demand attention.

و
ع

He simply stood up. He waited until they had reached him. Then he spoke.

و
ع

"Malood," Saeed said, "was chewing something white this morning."

و
ع

Everyone froze.

و
ع

John turned slowly.

و
ع

"White?"

و
ع

Saeed nodded. *"Near the big stone. Then he ran."*

و
ع

Safiya and **John** and **Thuraya** looked at each other. For one full second, nobody spoke. Then all three of them, without consultation, without a word, turned and walked — quickly — in the

direction of the big stone.

۞

They ran.

۞

They found **Malood**.

۞

Sleeping. Very happily. In the specific **after-lunch** sleep of a small animal who had consumed, not long ago, something he had very much enjoyed.

۞

John lifted him.

۞

"Sorry, my friend," he said — and the word *friend*, applied to a goat, came out of his mouth with a small note of surprise, as though his vocabulary had made a choice without consulting him — *"this is... an investigation."*

۞

They waited.

۞

And waited.

۞

And waited.

۞

It was, **Safiya** would later recall, the longest fifteen minutes of her day. They had gathered in a small ceremonial circle around **Malood** — who was now awake, and who had been set down on the packed ground, and who was, with the air of a goat who had no idea what was happening around him and no intention of finding out, nibbling a dry leaf.

۞

Finally —

۞

Safiya screamed.

۞

"MYRING!"

۞

It was dirty. Very dirty. It had been — through processes **Safiya** would not describe in any letter home — thoroughly **transformed** by its passage through **Malood**. But it was there. It was,

unmistakably, her ring.

~
ع

John closed his eyes. His face held the expression of a man who had been, for the last four hours, privately writing, cancelling, and re-writing a new personal **philosophy** about goats, and who had, at this moment, arrived at its final draft.

~
ع

"I," he said, quietly, with deep conviction, *"will never say anything bad about goats again."*

~
ع

Malood looked proud.

~
ع

He stood. He stretched. He walked, without hurry, in a small dignified circle. He looked, **Safiya** thought, like a small war hero receiving a medal.

~
ع

The children had gathered. They had heard the scream. They were now standing in a cautious arc, watching.

~
ع

No one laughed.

~
ع

Not even **Mansoor**.

~
ع

Safiya held the ring in her palm. She looked at **Thuraya**.

~
ع

"We almost blamed an innocent man."

~
ع

Thuraya nodded. Quietly. *"That happens a lot."*

~
ع

John said, **low** — *"We need to fix this."*

~
ع

*They walked back, the three of them, to **Shayb Khalaf's** house. **Safiya** had, in her palm, the cleaned ring. She had washed it twice. She had washed it, unnecessarily, a third time. It was bright again. And it sat on her finger, where it belonged, and her hand was no longer lighter than usual.*

~
ع

They knocked.

~
ع

Khalaf opened the door. His face, when he saw them, was the same face he had shown them two hours earlier — tired, quiet, entirely unsurprised.

~

Safiya spoke first.

~

"We are very sorry."

~

John added — clearly, carefully, so that the sentence would land — *"We believed a story. Not the truth."*

~

Khalaf looked at them for a long moment. The specific, calm long moment of an old man deciding what to say.

~

Then he said, *"People always do."*

~

He turned. He was, they understood, about to close the door. But — at the last moment, with the specific, small, surprising softening of a man who had not planned to give them anything further — he paused.

~

He turned back.

~

"But you came back." He met **Safiya's** eyes. Then **John's**. Then **Thuraya's**. *"That is... something."*

~

He closed the door. Gently.

~

That evening, **John** was quiet. **Safiya** was quiet. **Thuraya** was thoughtful. The village, around them, was normal again — the falaj continuing its hush, the evening settling into its gold hour, the small sounds of the dinners beginning in the other houses.

~

But something had changed.

~

That night, at the small wooden table, **John** wrote in his notebook. He wrote, in his careful teacher's hand, a single sentence:

~

Today, we learned something more important than English.



In another part of the village — under the same ghaf tree where he had delivered yesterday's stories — **Saeed** was sitting with the same two small boys who had, that morning, listened to his *maybe*. He was telling them something different now. He was telling them the correction. He was telling them, in the quiet voice he used for all his important sentences —



"Stories are strong. But truth is stronger."



And **Malood**? **Malood** slept.



Dreaming, **Safiya** imagined, of his next meal.



Did You Know?

Sulh — Arab Conflict Resolution

Remember how John and Sophia went back to Sheikh Khalaf to apologize after wrongly accusing him? This reflects a genuine Arab tradition called "sulh" — a traditional way of resolving tribal disputes built on admitting fault, publicly apologizing, and restoring both parties' dignity, often mediated by elders. The custom aims to repair social relationships, not just end a conflict, and remains practiced across many Arab communities.

Source: en.wikipedia.org · businessconflictmanagement.com

PALM

Palm Thirteen

The Yellow Mask Disaster

SCENE ONE

A Personal Attack from the Sky

The sun in Samail did not wake up gently.

☪
☪

It **attacked**.

☪
☪

By eight in the morning, the village was already glowing — glowing, shining, and, in the specific soft menacing way that only a desert sun manages, quietly threatening everyone who had forgotten a hat, or a scarf, or common sense.

☪
☪

Safiya — and by this point in the story of her life, she was **Safiya** completely, everywhere, even in her own head — stood in front of the small mirror in their simple house, touching her face carefully.

☪
☪

She was investigating. Her fingertips moved from her forehead to her cheeks to the tender patch of skin just beneath her eyes. Each small touch produced a small small flinch. Her face, she realised, was no longer the face of a woman who lived indoors.

☪
☪

"*I think*," she said — slowly, to her own reflection, because **John** was outside — "*my face is... cooking*."

☪
☪

The word *cooking* was generous. Her face, in the small mirror, was the specific shade of red that tomatoes achieved only after they had been **deliberately** left in a pan on low heat for longer than anyone had intended.

☪
☪

Outside, **John** was already sweating and pretending he was not. It was a specific English talent — the art of **pretending** that one was not sweating when one was, in fact, sweating through the back of

one's shirt. He stood in the small patch of shade beside the door and attempted, without success, to look cool.

~

"This is not sun," he said. Seriously. As though he were addressing a board. "This is a personal attack from the sky."

~

At the school yard, **Thuraya** arrived as usual. Calm. Prepared. Unbothered. As though — and it was impossible to confirm this, but **Safiya** had begun to suspect it — the sun had, at some point in the last forty years, signed a small private peace agreement with her, and had agreed to leave her alone.

~

Behind her came **Fatkat** — full of energy, wearing her sports clothes, carrying her **whistle** around her neck like a weapon of considerable importance.

~

"Ya binti," Fatkat said loudly, fanning herself with her free hand, "this sun is not normal. This sun needs discipline."

~

Safiya looked at her. Her own hand had drifted up, again, to her own cheek.

~

"My face feels like fire."

~

Fatkat touched her own cheek. Then, as though confirming a diagnosis, she did it a second time.

~

"Mine too. Look." She **inclined** her face toward **Safiya**. *"We are... red."*

~

They stood together in the small patch of shade beside the school wall. They inspected each other's cheeks — earnestly, **gravely** — like doctors without a single degree between them and a great willingness to diagnose regardless.

~

John passed by. He looked at them. He considered, briefly, whether to say something. He said it anyway.

~

"You both," he offered, "look like tomatoes that went to the beach."

~

Thuraya laughed. *"You need,"* she said — to **Safiya**, helpfully — *"something for your skin."*

~

Fatkat's eyes shone — the specific sudden brightness of a woman who had been waiting for exactly this opening and had had her recommendation ready for approximately the last fifteen minutes.

~

*"There is **Marhoona**. She makes good masks. Real traditional."*

~

Safiya clapped. *"Skin care!"*

~

John raised one eyebrow. The specific eyebrow of an Englishman who had, at several prior moments in his life, **witnessed** his wife's enthusiasm for a new village beauty treatment and had reasons to be concerned.

~

"Be careful," he said. *"The skin may not agree."*

~

They ignored him.

~

That, it would turn out, was a mistake.

SCENE TWO

The Salon of Marhoona

Marhoona's place was not really a salon.

~

It was a small room. In a small house. At the end of a small path on the far side of the village, just past the house of **Aunt Azizah** and just before the road turned toward the farms. The door was the same painted blue that every door in Samail wore. The room behind the door was the kind of room that had never been called a salon in its life, and had, until recently, been called a storage room, and had, before that, been called a back room, and had, at some very old point, been a corner of somebody's grandmother's kitchen.

~

Inside: a mat. A small round mirror with a silver frame that had lost most of its silver. And a lot of **confidence**.

~

Marhoona herself was a woman of about fifty — short, sturdy, with henna-darkened fingertips and the specific calm **authority** of a woman who had, for approximately thirty years, been the final word in the village about any matter involving hair, skin, bridal preparation, or the removal of **unwanted** hair.

۞

She looked at **Safiya**'s face. Then at **Fatkat**'s face. She nodded — slowly — like a wise judge arriving at his verdict.

۞

"Sun," she said. "Too much."

۞

It was, **Safiya** would later note, not an incorrect diagnosis.

۞

Marhoona began to mix things in a small clay bowl. She moved quickly — the specific practised quickness of a woman who had done this many times — and she named her ingredients as she dropped them in, the way a chef might name his spices for a visitor.

۞

"Sandalwood. Saffron."

۞

She smiled.

۞

"Very good for skin."

۞

She put the mask on **Safiya**'s face — spreading it with the warm steady pressure of fingers that had applied this exact mixture hundreds of times. Then on **Fatkat**'s face. They were instructed to keep their eyes closed. They were instructed to wait.

۞

They closed their eyes.

۞

They waited.

۞

And waited.

۞

And waited.

۞

The smell was pleasant. The sandalwood warmed **Safiya**'s skin. The saffron — she had not smelled saffron so strongly before outside a kitchen — was deep and **aromatic**. She could feel, she thought, the mask *working* — the small tightening of her skin, the small cooling effect, the small sensation of being *treated*.

۞

After what seemed to be the correct length of time — **Marhoona** was keeping track of it by some internal clock that had no visible mechanism — **Marhoona** wiped the mask off.

۞

She handed **Safiya** the small, silver-less mirror.

۞

Safiya opened her eyes.

۞

She looked.

۞

She screamed.

۞

Fatkat opened her own eyes. She looked at **Safiya**. "*Ya rab*," she said — quietly, with genuine awe. Then she grabbed the mirror herself. She looked. "*Ya rab!*"

۞

Their faces were...

۞

Yellow.

۞

Very yellow.

۞

Like lemons.

۞

Like — **Safiya** would later refine the description in her head — very *sad* lemons. The kind of lemons that had been, at some point, enthusiastic about their lemon-career, and had then been informed that they were not going to be used in a cake, or a drink, or a marinade, but would instead be **juiced** and left in a bowl on a counter and forgotten for several hours.

۞

Safiya touched her cheek. "*Why*," she said, slowly, to no one in particular, "*am I the colour of a banana?*"

۞

Fatkat was louder. "*Ya rab! I look like a warning sign!*"

۞

Marhoona said calmly, "*It will go.*"

۞

That did not help.

SCENE THREE

The Return

They walked back to school.

~
~

Carefully.

~
~

Slowly.

~
~

Hoping nobody would see them.

~
~

This hope was, **Safiya** realised only after they had taken their first fifty steps, **foolish**. Everybody saw them. The village, in the middle of the day, in 1973, in a small agricultural settlement where the most interesting piece of news in any given week was usually *whose cow gave more milk*, was not the kind of place where two yellow women could pass unnoticed.

~
~

A woman at a doorway saw them. She did not speak. She only paused in her sweeping, leaned her broom against the wall, and watched them go past with the specific unblinking interest of a person mentally writing, in real time, the story she was about to tell her sister that afternoon.

~
~

A boy carrying bread saw them. He stopped walking entirely. He stared. He **forgot** about the bread. The bread dangled from his hand at a worried angle.

~
~

An old man, sitting on the low wall that marked the edge of the farms, watched them approach. He watched them pass. He watched them recede. Then, when they had turned the corner, he — without turning his head — called something to his neighbour in the next yard, a sentence that contained the word *banana* and a small interrogative **inflection**.

~
~

John was the first person at the school to see them. He was the first, as it happened, because he had been standing in the doorway of the classroom, waiting for them to come back, drinking a small cup of lukewarm water, and feeling — because his wife was at a skincare appointment with the sports teacher — an unusual sense of calm.

~
~

The calm lasted until the yellow appeared around the corner.



He stopped.



He looked.



He set the cup down very carefully on the windowsill. He did not want, if he were about to do what he was about to do, to spill it.



Then he fell into a chair laughing.



Not metaphorically. He walked two steps, located the nearest wooden teacher's chair, sat down in it, and laughed with his whole body — the specific full laugh of a man who had been holding in, for several weeks now, the accumulated comic material of living in a village that produced, on a regular schedule, situations that no English training had prepared him for.



"I am sorry," he said, between laughs — and he was, in some part of him, genuinely sorry, but not nearly sorry enough to stop — *"I am really sorry... but you look like... a school bus and a lemon had a baby."*



Thuraya came.



She looked.



She tried to be polite.



She failed.



The **failure** was dignified, at first. She pressed her lips together. She looked at the ceiling. She looked at the floor. She tried, visibly, to compose her face. Then she looked back at the two yellow faces in front of her, and the composure — like the mask — came off.



"This," she said, pointing at their faces, *"is called... skin care?"*



John wiped his eyes. *"Yes. But..."*



He stood up. With the specific dramatic posture of a man who had just been handed, by the comic gods themselves, the perfect sentence — and who intended, now, to deliver it.

٢٧
ع

"Some of you," he said, "do a lot of skin care... but the skin doesn't care."

٢٨
ع

Even **Malood** — who had wandered into the yard at some point, who had watched the whole return, who had then, for his own reasons, decided that the yellow women deserved closer inspection — made a small sound. A sound that, with the specific **generosity** a listener could grant him, could be interpreted as a laugh.

SCENE FOUR

Mohammadeen Arrives

Then **Mohammadeen** arrived.

٢٩
ع

The arrival of **Mohammadeen** was, as it always was, an *event*. He did not enter rooms. He arrived in them. The specific **operatic** way an Egyptian math teacher could arrive at a village school and, without lifting his voice, make it entirely clear that he had arrived.

٣٠
ع

He came through the gate. He saw his wife. He **froze** — mid-stride, one foot still lifted. His moustache, which normally had a confident upward cant, drooped slightly. His eyes travelled from the top of his wife's yellow forehead to the bottom of her yellow chin.

٣١
ع

Then he said — in the strong, rich, unmistakable Egyptian Arabic that he used when his feelings had exceeded his ability to contain them —

٣٢
ع

الله! إيه ده اللي في وشك يا فتكات؟ عاملة زي لون الليمون كده ليه؟

٣٣
ع

*(God! What is this on your face, ya **Fatkat**? Why are you the colour of a lemon like this?)*

٣٤
ع

Fatkat put her hands on her hips. The specific stance of a wife who had not asked for her husband's opinion and did not, at this moment, desire it.

٣٥
ع

"Don't," she said, in English — clearly, firmly, in the universal international language of an annoyed wife — "talk to me."

٣٦
ع

The students arrived.

ۛ

In their small usual wave — **Ahmed** composed, **Khalil** already mid-laugh with **Ali**, the girls in their triangle, **Saeed** at the back — they came through the gate.

ۛ

Then **Mansoor** arrived.

ۛ

Mansoor saw.

ۛ

Mansoor pointed.

ۛ

Mansoor laughed.

ۛ

Very loudly. With the full **abandon** that was **Mansoor's** one unshakeable personal talent. "*Teacher Fatkat! Teacher Safiya! You are... YELLOW!*"

ۛ

The class laughed.

ۛ

Every single child. Even **Ahmed** permitted himself a small dignified exhale that, in another child, would have been a giggle.

ۛ

Safiya tried to stay calm. She attempted a small teacher-smile. It came out as something closer to the specific tight smile of a woman who had, that morning, agreed to have saffron applied to her face and was now, publicly, paying the price.

ۛ

Fatkat, on the other hand, did not try to stay calm. **Fatkat** had never, in her life, tried to stay calm when she had been laughed at in public.

ۛ

"*OUT!*" she shouted. "*YOU! OUTSIDE!*"

ۛ

Mansoor stood there. His face went through several stages — first triumph, then slight confusion, then a small flicker of **protest**.

ۛ

"*But teacher,*" he said, "*I just—*"

20
€

"OUT!"

20
€

Mansoor went out.

20
€

Sad. But — because he was, and would always be, **Mansoor** — still smiling.

SCENE FIVE

In the Classroom

John walked to the blackboard. With the specific small **ceremonial** movement of a teacher who had, in that specific moment, just thought of exactly the lesson the day required.

20
€

He took a piece of chalk. He wrote, in his careful teacher's capitals:

20
€

Today's Topic: SKIN, SOAP, AND THE SUN

20
€

He turned around. "*Today*," he said, with the quiet satisfaction of a man using his wife's small disaster as pedagogical material, "*we talk about... what not to do.*"

20
€

Safiya — from her seat, face still yellow, cheeks slightly flushed beneath the yellow — touched her own face one more time. "*And what not to put.*"

20
€

Thuraya smiled. "*Let's learn.*"

20
€

John wrote a list on the board. A simple list. The specific list that any English teacher in any country would write when he had decided to turn today's material into tomorrow's **vocabulary**.

20
€

skin

face

soap

water

clean

dirty

sun

burn

wash
care

٢٧
ع

He pointed to **Safiya**. "*Say: My skin is...*"

٢٨
ع

Safiya — composing her face into the specific solemn teacher-composure that she had developed over the last few months — said, "*My skin is... yellow.*"

٢٩
ع

The class laughed. Again.

٣٠
ع

John nodded. "*Good sentence. Sad, but good.*"

٣١
ع

He pointed to a student — one of the smaller boys, a child **Safiya** did not yet know by name. "*You. Say: I wash my...*"

٣٢
ع

The boy — with the specific concentration of a child preparing a short English sentence — said, "*I wash my face.*"

٣٣
ع

"*Good.*"

٣٤
ع

Safiya added — using gestures, because she had long ago learned that her English sentences landed more reliably when accompanied by small mime —

٣٥
ع

"*I wash my hands. I wash my face. I use soap.*"

٣٦
ع

Each sentence came with its own small performance. For *wash my hands*, she rubbed her palms together. For *wash my face*, she made small circular motions at her yellow cheeks. For *use soap*, she mimed — carefully, deliberately — the lathering of imaginary soap between her fingers.

٣٧
ع

Thuraya said, "*The sun is hot.*"

٣٨
ع

The class repeated, in their layered village-chorus voice — "*The sun is hot.*"

٣٩
ع

John wrote on the board:

و
ع

*The sun is hot.
My skin is red.
I wash my face.
I use soap.
I take care of my skin.*

و
ع

The children copied. Quietly. **Ahmed's** copying was, as always, a small act of calligraphy. **Noura's** was decorated, by the time she had finished, with a small flower beside the sun. **Mansoor's** copying — which was happening through the open window, because he had not been allowed back inside — was loud, **laboured**, and accompanied by loud whispered readings of each word as he wrote it.

و
ع

Then — when the copying had mostly subsided — there was a knock on the door.

و
ع

Very quietly.

و
ع

Very **humbly**.

و
ع

Every head in the room turned toward the door. They knew whose knock it was. There were not, after all, many candidates.

و
ع

Fatkat crossed her arms. *"Say sorry."*

و
ع

The door opened, just a crack. **Mansoor's** small face appeared. He looked at the yellow faces — now slightly less yellow than they had been, but still significantly yellow. He looked at them gravely. Then, with the specific serious tone of a boy who had been preparing his apology for the last fifteen minutes, he said —

و
ع

"I am sorry."

و
ع

A silence. In which **Fatkat**, perhaps, let herself believe that the apology was done.

و
ع

Then **Mansoor**, after thinking, added — with the specific honest **frankness** of a boy who could not, in a single apology, betray the truth —

و
ع

"But... you still look funny."

~
ℳ

Fatkat pointed at the door.

~
ℳ

"Outside again."

~
ℳ

Mansoor — with the specific sad acceptance of a small boy who had known, in his heart, that this was how the sentence would end — went out.

SCENE SIX

The Skin That Didn't Care

By the end of the day, the yellow started to become... less yellow.

~
ℳ

Not gone. Not yet. But **fading**. The specific soft retreat of a stain that was, like all stains, eventually persuaded by time.

~
ℳ

Safiya touched her face, cautiously, in the afternoon light of the classroom — the late afternoon light, which came in low across the desks and gave everything the specific gold-warm colour of a day nearing its close.

~
ℳ

"I think," she said, quietly, to **Fatkat**, *"it is leaving."*

~
ℳ

Fatkat — whose yellow was retreating at the same rate as **Safiya's**, though **Fatkat** had spent considerable energy **hurrying** it through three separate washings during the lunch break — sighed the long sigh of a woman who had learned a lesson.

~
ℳ

"Next time," she said, with the **weary finality** of a person who had seen the truth, *"we use water. Only water."*

~
ℳ

John smiled. The specific small peaceful smile of a man whose earlier warning had been, by the course of the day, magnificently confirmed — and who had, to his credit, decided not to say *I told you so*.

~
ℳ

"And maybe," he said, *"a hat."*

~
ℳ

That evening, at the small wooden table in their simple house, **John** wrote in his notebook. His face — no longer the ghost-grey of the smoke day, no longer the bloodshot-red of the wasp day, just the plain pale-pink of a tired English teacher — was settled in the specific calm of a man who had lived through another small village comedy and was, as always, making notes.

~

He wrote:

~

*Today we learned:
The sun is strong.
Soap is useful.
And not all "skin care" cares about skin.*

~

He paused. He looked at the last line. He smiled at it, privately — the specific private smile that a writer gives to a sentence he suspects might, one day, be quoted back at him.

~

He closed the notebook.

~

Safiya, sitting across from him, was — with the specific slow patient movements of a woman whose face still carried the faint suggestion of saffron — applying a small amount of plain water to her cheeks. No soap. No sandalwood. No anything else.

~

Malood, who had — through processes **Safiya** did not want to examine — somehow found his way into the house again, wandered over to **Safiya**. He considered her hand — the hand with the water on it — and, with the specific **earnest** concentration of a small goat who had decided that the hand looked interesting, tried to lick it.

~

Safiya moved her hand. Fast.

~

"No," she said — firmly, with the quiet authority of a woman whose morning had been expensive enough. "*You already did enough.*"

~

Malood considered this. He considered it for perhaps two seconds — the specific two seconds a goat needed to weigh whether to press his case. Then, apparently accepting the ruling, he turned. He walked with the small injured dignity of an unappreciated guest to the corner of the bisat. He lay down.

~

He closed his eyes.

~

He slept.

~

And outside the small clay house, the sun — which had, that morning, launched its personal attack from the sky — finally, as it always did, lowered itself toward the mountains. The village air cooled. The falaj continued. Somewhere, a woman was beginning her evening cooking, and the faint smell of onions and ghee began to travel, lightly, along the path.

~

And **Safiya** — **Safiya**, with her fading-yellow face, with her clean ring back on her finger, with the village having, in the last two days, forgiven her, and having, in the last two hours, once again laughed with her — understood that she was becoming a person she had not been before.

~

Not yellow. Not English. Not Omani.

~

Something in between. Something the village was, slowly, steadily, patiently — without ever having been asked — in the process of **making**.

..

Did You Know?

Traditional Sandalwood and Saffron Skincare

Remember Marhoona's golden mask that turned Safiya's and Fatima's faces yellow? A sandalwood paste (often mixed with rosewater) is genuinely one of the oldest Omani women's skincare recipes, traditionally used to protect the face from sun damage and dryness. Saffron, too, is deeply present in Omani heritage — though more often in Omani coffee than in face masks!

Source: omanobserver.om

PALM

Palm Fourteen

Sadou Climbs the Palm

SCENE ONE

The Man in the Sky

The morning in Samail was already warm — even before the sun had climbed properly high — with the specific early warmth of a day that had decided, in advance, that it was not going to be merciful.

⸱

The mountains looked sleepy. The village did not. Roosters were loud. Doors were opening. And somewhere — a sound that was, by now, simply part of the soundtrack of Samail mornings — someone was already shouting at a goat.

⸱

John and **Safiya** walked with **Thuraya** along the dusty road toward the school. **Malood**, the baby goat, followed them for a few steps — and then stopped. A leaf, to his left, had looked, for reasons **Safiya** could not **ascertain**, more interesting than they were.

⸱

Safiya fixed her scarf. *"I still can't believe how quiet this place is in the morning."*

⸱

John smiled. *"Quiet is good. I hope the class is quiet today too."*

⸱

Thuraya laughed — the specific warm laugh she reserved for **John's** most **optimistic** predictions about his classroom. *"You always hope."*

⸱

They were just passing near the farms — the small narrow plots of palm trees that ran along the edge of the village — when **Safiya** suddenly stopped walking.

⸱

"Wait... what is that?"

⸱

John followed her eyes — up.

٢٧
ع

On the tall palm tree near the road, a man was climbing. Not slowly. Not carefully. Not with the specific **cautious** technique of a person who had thought, even briefly, about gravity.

٢٨
ع

He was *flying*.

٢٩
ع

*Up, up, up — using his hands and feet as though the tree were a ladder, as though the tree were his own staircase, as though the tree were, in fact, a floor on which he was merely walking in an **unconventional** direction. His small body moved in a rhythm **Safiya** could not follow. Her eye wanted to catch each placement of the foot, each grip of the hand, and her eye failed. By the time she was still finding his second position, he was on his fifth. The tree was, perhaps, fifteen metres tall. It did not seem to matter.*

٣٠
ع

It was **Sadoo**.

٣١
ع

The shop owner.

٣٢
ع

The man who sold potatoes, and sweets, and an **unclassifiable** assortment of small strange things that nobody had ever asked for and which, somehow, always sold.

٣٣
ع

And now he was on top of a palm tree.

٣٤
ع

John opened his mouth. "*Is... is that **Sadoo**?*"

٣٥
ع

Thuraya nodded. Calmly. As though this were, in fact, perfectly normal. As though everybody who ran a shop in Samail also climbed palm trees on Wednesday mornings — which, **Safiya** was starting to suspect, might be true.

٣٦
ع

"Yes."

٣٧
ع

Safiya blinked. "*Why*," she asked — genuinely, sincerely, the way one asks children questions about things in picture books — "*is he in the sky?*"

٣٨
ع

Thuraya smiled. "*He is " data-bbox="121 857 880 896" data-label="Text">

Thuraya smiled. "*He is " data-bbox="121 857 880 896" data-label="Text">

Thuraya smiled. "*He is "* data-m="Gathering a crop; here, cutting dates from the tree at the point where they are ripe" data-s="gathering, picking, collecting" data-x="Harvesting dates was a technical**

skill. You needed to know which fruit was ready. Sadoo knew.">harvesting dates. This is how people collect fresh dates. They climb. And cut."

☪

John was impressed. His face had moved, over the last twenty seconds, through several phases — disbelief, admiration, cultural **awe**, and had now settled into the specific wide-eyed English expression that meant *I am going to have to revise several of my opinions*.

☪

"So..." he said, slowly, carefully, "**Sadoo** sells things in a shop... and he climbs palm trees?"

☪

"Of course," **Thuraya** said.

☪

The *of course* was, in its specific gentle simplicity, more surprising than the climbing itself.

☪

They watched **Sadoo** cut a cluster of dates. They watched him — improbably, **casually** — *jump down* with the bag of dates, as though the descent from a fifteen-metre palm tree were the kind of thing a small man did between errands. He landed easily. He brushed his trousers. He looked up toward the three observers at the road with the specific delighted awareness of a village man who had noticed his audience and was about to address it.

SCENE TWO

The Multi-Talented Superhero

John shook his head slowly. He said, in English, with the specific **ceremonial** voice of a man pronouncing a formal title: "**Sadoo** is... a multi-talented superhero."

☪

Thuraya laughed.

☪

"You haven't seen anything yet."

☪

She paused. The specific small pause she used when she was about to deliver information that would **delight John**.

☪

"He also has a sewing shop."

☪

John froze.

☪

His brain — **Safiya** could see — stopped working for one second. The full second. A small, complete English pause while the sentence *he also has a sewing shop* made its way, through the dust and the sunlight and the still-settling fact of the palm-tree descent, into his already-overloaded understanding of what **Sadoo** was.

٢٧

"A... what?"

٢٨

"A sewing shop," **Thuraya** said. "He fixes clothes."

٢٩

John looked at **Sadoo** — who was now walking toward them, bag of dates over his shoulder, shirt slightly dusty — the way one looks at a **legend** who had just been revealed to be three different legends in one.

٣٠

Sadoo saw them. He smiled — a broad, **unreserved** village-shopkeeper smile. He hit his chest with the flat of his palm — the specific gesture of a man making a claim about himself — and called out to them, in his full Samaili Arabic:

٣١

!فكر ما في معلوم أنا... سادو! أنا... سادو يعرف كل شي مني

٣٢

(Think there's nothing I don't know! I am Sadoo! I, Sadoo, know every single thing!)

٣٣

And **John** — without thinking, without permission, without any **consultation** with the English part of his brain — answered. In Arabic. Once again.

٣٤

!أبوي، ما نرومه صوبنا

٣٥

(Father, we can't reach where you are!)

٣٦

Safiya and **Thuraya** both stopped walking.

٣٧

They looked at **John**.

٣٨

Slowly. Carefully. The specific slow **scrutiny** reserved for men whose mouths had, for the second time in two weeks, produced Arabic sentences that their mouths had no business producing.

٣٩

Safiya said, *"What... did you just say?"*

﴿

John blinked. The genuine, confused blink of a man whose own ears were catching up with his own mouth. *"Did I say something?"*

﴿

Thuraya crossed her arms. *"Yes. In Arabic."*

﴿

John suddenly felt cold. Again. The specific cold that had, over the last fortnight, become a **familiar** sensation along his back. The cold that came when he had, once again, found Arabic coming out of his mouth without ever having put it there.

﴿

"Oh."

﴿

He looked at the ground. Then at the sky. Then at **Sadoo**.

﴿

He pretended, with the specific **dignified** pretending of a man who had just embarrassed himself in front of his wife for the seventh time that month, that he had not heard anything. He walked faster.

﴿

In his head, meanwhile, a small anxious argument was taking place.

﴿

How did I say that? I don't know that sentence. Am I... learning Arabic in my sleep? Or... is this that maghsoob thing again? No. No. Don't think. Just walk.

﴿

Sadoo laughed behind them. A big, friendly, completely unconcerned laugh. He waved. They waved back. They continued to school.

SCENE THREE

I Can, He Can, She Can

The classroom was noisy before the lesson even started.

﴿

Mansoor was making a paper airplane.

﴿

Khalil was — with the specific small **patience** of a boy who believed, deeply, that everything was better when stolen — trying to steal it.

٢٤

Noura was talking. She had started talking before she entered the room, and she was continuing to talk at the same speed, with the same energy, to a slightly different audience.

٢٥

Ahmed was sitting straight like a ruler. His ruler — his actual ruler — was out. He had aligned it, on his desk, parallel to the edge.

٢٦

Mathila was sharing a pencil. It was, somehow, the same pencil that had been the shared pencil of the **Marwa–Rahma–Salima** triangle for three weeks.

٢٧

And **Saeed** — the quiet boy at the back — was sitting in his usual position, watching everything. As always.

٢٨

John entered. He cleared his throat.

٢٩

"Good morning!"

٣٠

"Good morning, teacher!"

٣١

He wrote on the board, in clear capitals:

٣٢

Today's Lesson: TALENTS

I can... / He can... / She can...

٣٣

Safiya clapped her hands. *"Okay! Today we talk about what you can do."*

٣٤

Thuraya smiled. *"Your skills. Your **talents**."*

٣٥

Mansoor raised his hand — without waiting to be called on, with the specific **irrepressible** certainty of a boy who had already identified the best answer.

٣٦

"I can run!"

٣٧

John nodded. *"Good. Say: I can run."*

٢٤

"*I can run!*"

٢٥

Khalil, not to be outdone — "*I can climb!*"

٢٦

Safiya smiled. "*I can climb.*"

٢٧

Ahmed — quietly, with the specific **understated** dignity he applied to all his contributions — "*I can read.*"

٢٨

The room went a little quieter. *I can read*. It was the sentence, **Safiya** understood, that was — of all the sentences in that classroom, of all the sentences in that village — the most **consequential**. A nine-year-old Omani boy saying *I can read* in English, in 1973, in a village where most of his grandparents could not, was a small revolution disguised as a grammar exercise.

٢٩

Mathila — proudly — "*I can help.*"

٣٠

Noura — with the small satisfied air of a girl reporting what everyone had been wanting to hear — "*I can talk.*"

٣١

The class laughed. It was not cruelty. It was recognition.

٣٢

John wrote on the board:

٣٣

I can run.
I can climb.
I can read.
I can help.

SCENE FOUR

Sadoo Can Climb

Then **John** did something he had not planned. He took a fresh piece of chalk, and drew — quickly, with a small amateur **flourish** — a palm tree on the board. Tall. A few curved lines for fronds.

٣٤

On the trunk, halfway up, he drew a small man. Also amateur. Also charming. Also, unmistakably, **Sadoo**.

۞

He wrote beneath it:

۞

Sadoo can climb a palm tree.

۞

The class laughed. Happily. They had all seen it — some of them that morning, all of them at some point — and the specific pleasure of having your own village shopkeeper put on the board as a *grammar example* was a pleasure no textbook could have given them.

۞

Mansoor shouted — because **Mansoor** always shouted — "*Yes! Sadoo climb like monkey!*"

۞

John corrected him. Gently. With the specific small patient correction of a teacher who had decided not to fight the noun.

۞

"Sadoo can climb."

۞

"Sadoo can climb!" the class repeated.

۞

Safiya pointed at **John**. "*Teacher John — what can you do?*"

۞

John smiled. The specific small modest teacher-smile that he had been practising since he was twenty-two. "*I can... teach.*"

۞

The class clapped.

۞

Thuraya — from her corner — "*And I can explain.*"

۞

Safiya — "*And I can organise.*"

۞

Mansoor — not to be left out, and never willing to allow a good sentence to pass without contributing — "*And I can... make noise!*"

۞

At exactly that moment, **Mohammadeen** — who had been walking past the open door on his way to his own classroom, carrying his math books and his specific expression of Egyptian professional purpose — paused.

ⲁⲩⲓⲛⲓ

He looked inside. He **surveyed** the room.

ⲁⲩⲓⲛⲓ

He said, in his strong Egyptian voice — the specific voice that required, structurally, obedience — *"No. You cannot."*

ⲁⲩⲓⲛⲓ

The class went quiet immediately.

ⲁⲩⲓⲛⲓ

The silence was surgical. Not gradual. One full second of full complete classroom silence. Even **Mansoor's** mouth closed.

ⲁⲩⲓⲛⲓ

Safiya whispered to **Thuraya**, *"Wow. He doesn't need English."*

ⲁⲩⲓⲛⲓ

John laughed — softly, under his breath. *"He is **universal**."*

SCENE FIVE

The Quiet Challenge

John turned back to the class. He looked at **Mansoor** — still, for the first time that morning, quiet.

ⲁⲩⲓⲛⲓ

*"**Mansoor**. Can you be quiet?"*

ⲁⲩⲓⲛⲓ

Mansoor stood up. Proudly. The specific proud standing of a boy who had just been asked if he could do something, and had decided, with the full commitment of his small eight-year-old chest, to *say yes*.

ⲁⲩⲓⲛⲓ

"Yes. I can."

ⲁⲩⲓⲛⲓ

Thuraya raised one eyebrow. *"Let's see."*

ⲁⲩⲓⲛⲓ

Safiya looked at her watch. The small silver watch her father had given her on her twenty-first birthday. She had not needed it often, in this village, where time was measured by prayers and the falaj.

But it still worked.

~

"Let's try. Two minutes."

~

John said, "Okay. **Mansoor**. Sit. Be quiet."

~

Mansoor sat.

~

He was quiet.

~

For ten seconds.

~

*He was quiet in the specific **concentrated** way that small boys are quiet when they have decided that quiet is a thing they can win at. His hands were flat on the desk. His face was forward. His eyes were on a specific small mark on the blackboard that he had, in the last three seconds, decided would be his anchor. He was, for the first time since **Safiya** had met him, performing stillness.*

~

Then — his foot began to move.

~

Small. Involuntary. The foot tapping, very lightly, against the leg of the desk.

~

Then his hand. A single finger, moving in a small rhythm on the wood.

~

Then he whispered to **Khalil**.

~

John looked at him.

~

Mansoor closed his mouth. **Abruptly**. Mid-whisper. Like a gate.

~

Thirty seconds.

~

He started, very quietly, making airplane noises. *Brrrrrrrm. Brrrrrrrm.* Small. Under his breath. As though the airplane were very far away.

~

Safiya said — calm, teacher-firm — "**Mansoor...**"

~

He stopped.

~

One minute.

~

He was — **Safiya** noticed with a small twinge of affection — shaking. Actually shaking. The specific small **tremor** of a small body holding back its own natural state.

~

Thuraya said, kindly — "*You can do it.*"

~

Mansoor nodded. Seriously. Gratefully.

~

One minute and thirty seconds.

~

Then — all at once, in a small explosion of honesty that **Safiya** would later remember as one of the truest moments of her teaching year — he **broke**.

~

"Teacher, I CAN'T!"

~

The class laughed.

~

John laughed too. The specific warm teacher-laugh that said: *you have given me something honest, and I accept it.*

~

"It's okay," he said. *"You can try again tomorrow."*

~

And he turned to the board. He picked up the chalk. And — with the specific considered care of a teacher giving a class its real, final sentence of the day — he wrote, beneath the list of talents, one more line:

~

I can try.

~

The class repeated it. In full layered village chorus. Including **Mansoor** — who said it loudest of all, because he had, in the last ninety seconds, discovered that *trying* was a kind of *can* he could, in fact, manage.

~

"I can try."

SCENE SIX

The Sewing Shop

When the bell rang, **Safiya** said, *"Today was good."*

~

John nodded. *"Very good."*

~

They walked out.

~

Near the road — the small stretch that passed the edge of the market and ran toward the houses — they saw **Sadoo** again.

~

This time, he was not in a tree. This time, he was sitting on a low wooden stool outside the small front door of his shop. And he was sewing.

~

*Not just mending. Not just poking a needle through a tear. He was sewing — the specific careful, practised, entirely **artisan** sewing of a man whose hands had, for many years, been restoring shirts. His small dark-eyed face was bent over the cloth. A long piece of white thread ran from his needle to the spool. Beside him, on the step, sat two more shirts, folded, waiting their turn.*

~

Safiya's mouth opened.

~

"He really does everything."

~

John smiled. The specific settled smile of a man who had, in one morning, rebuilt his entire concept of the village economy.

~

*"**Sadoo** can climb. **Sadoo** can sew. **Sadoo** can sell. **Sadoo** can..."*

~

He paused — because he was about to continue, and because he had realised, even as he said it, that he could not possibly finish the list. **Sadoo** could, as far as **John** was now concerned, do *everything*. The list had no end.

~

Sadoo looked up. He saw them. He smiled — proudly, with the specific **self-satisfaction** of a man whose list of skills had just been the subject of classroom instruction.

~

John almost said something in Arabic again.

~

He could feel it. The small rising sentence. The specific tightening at the back of his throat that meant his mouth had prepared a phrase his brain did not recognise.

~

He stopped himself.

~

Deliberately. With the specific small **discipline** of a man who had now decided to be a witness to his own mouth rather than a victim of it. He closed his lips. He nodded at **Sadoo**. In English. With only English.

~

*"Good work, **Sadoo**."*

~

Sadoo beamed. He held up the shirt he was working on, as though to show it. He gave a small polite inclination of the head.

~

Safiya looked at **John**. She looked **suspiciously** at **John**.

~

"You're thinking in Arabic again," she said, flatly. "Aren't you?"

~

John considered the question. He considered it honestly, as a man who had, over the last several weeks, developed a new relationship with his own mouth.

~

"No," he said. A pause. "Maybe." Another pause. "I don't know."

~

Thuraya laughed. Warmly. The specific teacherly laugh she used when she was about to deliver a sentence that was both a joke and, underneath the joke, a true observation.

~

*"Don't worry, Mr. **John**. Slowly, slowly, Oman is teaching you."*

~

John looked up.

~

He looked at the palm trees along the road. He looked at the mountains, low and brown-blue, holding their ancient line against the sky. He looked at the school, small and white, already empty for the afternoon. He looked at **Sadoo**, sewing his small shirt on his small stool, the man who could do, apparently, every single thing this village required.

~

He looked at his wife. At **Thuraya**. At the small dusty road home.

~

And he said, quietly — as much to himself as to anyone listening — *"Maybe I can learn more than I think."*

~

Malood, somewhere, invisible but **present**, chose that exact moment to kick something small over in someone's yard. A small crash. A small bleat. The distant shout of **Aunt Azizah** calling his name.

~

John did not even flinch.

~

He was, **Safiya** realised — quietly, in the pink-gold late afternoon — becoming a man who flinched less.

..



Did You Know?

Climbing Palms and Date Harvest (Tabseel)

Remember Sadou climbing the palm tree so nimbly to gather dates? This scene is entirely real in Oman, where men and boys pass down the skill of climbing palm trunks barefoot across generations, especially during the "tabseel" season that begins in the hottest days of summer. The date palm is known in Oman as the "tree of life" for having provided food, income, and shelter to village communities for centuries.

Source: muscatdaily.com · ich.unesco.org

PALM

Palm Fifteen

When Marhoon Lifted His Hand

SCENE ONE

The Missing Things

Some days in Samail started quietly.

~

And some days... waited for trouble — the way trouble waited, sometimes, in the cool hour before the sun climbed — like something hiding behind the palm trees.

~

That day started with fear.

~

Not the large fear. The small, ordinary, lost-object fear of the village schoolyard. It began there — at the small low wall where the children usually gathered before the bell, where the dust lay soft against the clay, where most of the village's lost-and-found-and-lost-again objects passed through at some point in any given week.

~

Ali was jumping. Not happily. On one foot. Angry, and confused, with the specific narrow-browed urgency of a boy whose morning had just acquired a **crisis**.

~

*"My **zanoubah** is GONE!"* he shouted. *"My mother will KILL me!"*

~

Rahma was crying. Not the small crying of a small wound. *Big* crying. The specific full-chested crying of a small girl whose new, freshly-given, buckle-equipped **sandals** — the sandals her father had bought her from Samail market only three days earlier — had, somehow, been taken by the universe.

~

"My new sandals!" she wept. *"I just got them! With a BUCKLE!"*

~

Mansoor — because **Mansoor** considered every small village drama to be, in some sense, *his* drama — looked around with wide, theatrical eyes. He composed his face into the specific low-browed

seriousness of a boy about to deliver a terrible explanation. He lowered his voice. He let the sentence **carry**.

﴿

*"It is," he said, "the work of **Shayb Khalaf**."*

﴿

The children froze.

﴿

Khalil whispered — with the small anxious awe that the village's favourite **sahir**-theory produced — *"The wizard?"*

﴿

Mansoor nodded, seriously. *"He makes **bura**. Things disappear."*

﴿

Noura grabbed **Salima**'s arm. *"Maybe he took them to his clay house..."*

﴿

Ahmed — the only voice of order in a schoolyard that was, once again, about to go myth-first — adjusted his books. His small wise face took on the specific patient weariness of a boy who had, by the age of nine, understood that the only reliable pleasure of being rational was watching everyone else be otherwise.

﴿

"That," he said, "doesn't make sense."

﴿

But nobody listened.

﴿

Only one boy knew the truth.

﴿

Saeed.

SCENE TWO

What Saeed Saw

Saeed had seen it all.

﴿

He had seen **Ali**, earlier that morning, playing near the falaj — the specific small loud splashing game he played with the younger boys, in which one's zanoubah had a tendency to end up somewhere on the stone bank, and sometimes, if one were not careful, very near the edge.

He had seen **Rahma**, crossing the yard earlier, with her new buckled sandals — had seen her, in the specific careless way of a small girl whose shoes were still new, leave them near the tree while she played with **Salima**.

And he had seen **Malood**.

Yes.

Malood.

The baby goat. Moving — with the specific casual, **acquisitive**, entirely unbothered air of a goat who had been stealing small pieces of the village for weeks — toward both items. Taking them. Quietly. In his mouth. Disappearing behind the low wall with them, one at a time.

Saeed had seen all of it.

But **Saeed** said nothing.

He just watched.

*He watched, as he watched everything, from the specific quiet place he had carved for himself at the edge of the group. He watched the children panic. He watched **Mansoor** deliver his sahir-theory. He watched **Khalil** absorb it. He watched **Noura** grip **Salima**'s arm. He watched **Ahmed** try to be reasonable. And he watched, as he had so many mornings, the small pattern repeat itself: thing lost → old man blamed. It happened, as **Thuraya** had once said, a lot.*

He could have spoken.

He did not.

And then — all at once, like the small punch of an old memory returning — he remembered.

He should be at the mal.

The small farm. His father's small strip of date palms, at the edge of the village, where the falaj channel crossed the stony patch of ground they had been renting for two years.

و

Watering.

و

He should have been watering an hour ago.

و

His stomach **turned**. It turned the way a child's stomach turns when the child has remembered, too late, something important. The specific dropping feeling — low, interior — that is the first form fear takes in a nine-year-old body.

و

He stood up. He did not run. He did not yet. He walked — briskly, the way a small boy walks when he is pretending he is not in a hurry — away from the school, down the small road, toward the farms.

و

He had, perhaps, ten minutes of walking between the schoolyard and the mal. His father, **Marhoon**, might not have arrived yet. He might have another half hour. He might make it.

و

He was not going to make it.

SCENE THREE

At the Mal

The sun was high when **Marhoon**, **Saeed**'s father, arrived at the " data-m="Omani Arabic: a small farm or piece of agricultural land, typically with palm trees and fed by a falaj channel" data-s="small-farm, date-plot" data-x="The mal was the family's small piece of earth. Every family in Samail had — or hoped to have — a mal.">mal.

و

He was a tall man. Thin. Sun-weathered, in the specific **accumulated** way of a man who had been working outside every day since he was twelve. He wore a plain dishdasha. He carried, over his shoulder, a small cloth pouch with his tobacco and the small rolled-up paper he used when he needed to smoke.

و

He stood in the middle of the small farm. He looked at the dry ground.

و

The channels were empty.

و
ع

The plants were thirsty.

و
ع

The small curved earth-banks that he had, himself, over several years, dug to bring the falaj water evenly to the base of each young date palm — those banks were dry. Bone-dry. The specific pale-cracked dry of ground that had not felt water since yesterday afternoon, at the earliest, and more likely the day before that.

و
ع

His face became dark.

و
ع

Not the dark of rage, not yet — the dark, rather, of a man whose entire investment in the patient future of his family was, at that moment, being evaluated in front of him, and found, in the most **elementary** way, to have been betrayed.

و
ع

"SAEED!"

و
ع

No answer.

و
ع

He walked around the mal. Past the dry channels. Past the small rope that hung from the wooden frame over the water source. Past the iron bucket — the one **Saeed** was supposed to have been using, dipping down and pulling up, twenty, thirty, forty times by now, until the channels had filled and the water could find, by its own slow **gravity**, its way to the thirsty roots.

و
ع

Nothing.

و
ع

Then he saw it.

و
ع

The rope. The bucket. Untouched.

و
ع

The rope, in fact — he noticed — had been coiled, neatly, the way **Saeed** had coiled it the night before. Nobody had touched it since.

و
ع

His jaw tightened. The specific small hardening of a man who had, in that instant, moved from the dark of concern to the dark of **understanding**.

و
ع

"He went," he said — quietly, not to anyone, only to the dry earth and the hot air — "*to watch those school children again.*"

ۛ

He said it with the specific heavy disappointment of a father who had had this exact argument with his son before. The specific small tiredness of a man who had, many times, tried to explain that the mal was *real* and the school was *for other boys*.

ۛ

He picked up a thin stick from the ground.

ۛ

A kheyzaran. Like most fathers in the village carried, if they needed it. Like most fathers had been carried by their own fathers, if they had needed it. A thin piece of cane. Light. **Flexible**.

ۛ

He walked.

ۛ

Fast.

ۛ

In the direction of the school.

SCENE FOUR

The Road

Saeed was sitting near the school road.

ۛ

He had not, in the end, made it to the mal. He had made it halfway — then turned, drawn, as he always was, to the sound of the children. He had found his usual spot: a low stone wall beside a small ghaf tree, near the last bend before the school, where he could see the children at play through the low openings of the wall, without being seen by them.

ۛ

He always watched.

ۛ

He did not come close.

ۛ

He just sat.

ۛ

*He was nine. He had never been inside a classroom. His father had, three years earlier, when the village had first built its school, forbidden him to go. His father had reasons. His father had, like most men of his generation, inherited them — the belief that formal school would make a son **soft**, would make him **unfit** for the *mal*, would teach him to say yes and no in a foreign tongue and forget the language of the *falaj* and the land. His father had not been wrong, exactly. He had simply been, about this one particular boy, misreading what the boy had been born to do. **Saeed** was born to collect. Not things. Stories.*

٢٥٤

Then he heard footsteps.

٢٥٥

Heavy footsteps.

٢٥٦

He turned.

٢٥٧

His father.

٢٥٨

Marhoon.

٢٥٩

Saeed stood up. Slowly. The slowness of a small boy who had not yet decided whether to run or to face it, and who was, in that moment, deciding — with the specific small resignation of a child who had done this calculation before — to face it.

٢٦٠

"Why are you HERE?" **Marhoon** shouted. *"Why is the mal DRY?"*

٢٦١

Saeed looked at the ground. The specific small looking-at-the-ground of a boy who was about to speak, and who knew, even before he spoke, that the sentence would not be enough.

٢٦٢

"I just..." he said, *"wanted to see..."*

٢٦٣

He did not finish.

٢٦٤

The stick came down.

٢٦٥

Once.

٢٦٦

Twice.

و

Saeed cried out. He fell to his knees. The fall was not dramatic. It was the small, **collapsed** fall of a small body whose instinct was to curl.

و

Marhoon was shaking with anger. His whole tall thin frame was shaking. Not with the shake of a man losing control — with the shake of a man holding himself in place, against a current of something older than the morning.

و

كما الكفار؟ تباني أربطك في ذي النخلة؟ no و أهالك باه! تبأ تتعلم

و

(Damn you! You want to learn "yes" and "no" like the unbelievers? You want me to tie you to this palm tree?!)

و

The children at the end of the road had stopped.

و

They had heard the shouting. They had stepped out from the schoolyard. They had gathered at the edge of the path — a small loose group of seven, eight, ten children — and they were watching, frozen, from far away.

و

Nobody moved.

و

Then — a voice, from further back along the road, came like **thunder**.

و

"STOP!"

و

It was **Thuraya**.

و

She was running forward — running in her long abaya, running with the specific full-body urgency of a woman who had seen something she was not going to allow — and **Safiya** was running behind her, and **John** was running behind **Safiya**, and the three of them crossed the space in a specific **compressed** several seconds that seemed, to everyone present, to last much longer.

و

Thuraya stood between **Marhoon** and **Saeed**. Like a wall.

و

"That is enough!"

~
ع

Safiya — without any decision — knelt on the dust. She pulled **Saeed** into her. She held him the way one holds any small wounded thing: with a full, protective, entirely **unnegotiable** grip. He was shaking against her shoulder.

~
ع

John looked at **Marhoon**. Angry. Confused. The specific English confusion of a man who had not yet had the Arabic word translated for him.

~
ع

Then **John** asked, in English — carefully, because he did not want to be wrong — *"What does koffār mean?"*

~
ع

Thuraya turned to him. Her face was tight. Her voice was level. *"It means... unbelievers."*

SCENE FIVE

The Arabic That Came

Thuraya took a deep breath. The specific long breath of a teacher gathering herself before entering a conversation she had not, at breakfast, expected to be in.

~
ع

"Let me," she said, "talk to him."

~
ع

John raised his hand. *"Sabriiii!"*

~
ع

Everyone looked at him.

~
ع

Sabri — **wait** — was, for a man like **John** who had been in the country only two months, a surprisingly confident request.

~
ع

Then **John** started speaking.

~
ع

In Arabic.

~
ع

Without knowing.

~
ع

Again.

٢٧

Except this time, the Arabic was different. It was not the small shocked exclamation he had produced for **Khalaf**. It was not the small respectful reply he had offered at Sadoo's feet. This was a *defence*. A whole small speech, forming itself, syllable by syllable, out of his English mouth:

٢٧

أوووي، هااا! ما كفار جنوه! احنا مسلمين! نصلِّي ونصوم كماكم باه! لا تحسب

٢٧

(Whoa, hey! We are not unbelievers! We are Muslims! We pray and we fast just like you! Don't think otherwise!)

٢٧

Silence.

٢٧

Pure silence. The specific layered silence of a road where every mouth was, simultaneously, closed in shock.

٢٧

Marhoon's mouth opened. Not to speak. Simply to hang there — the specific physical shock of a man who had just been addressed, by a tall Englishman, in the full **vernacular** Arabic of his own village, claiming a religion that the Englishman did not, in strict fact, have.

٢٧

The children's eyes became huge.

٢٧

Safiya — still kneeling on the dust, still holding **Saeed** — whispered, in English, mostly to herself, in the specific small baffled tone of a wife who had just been included, without her consent, in a religious claim she had no memory of acquiring —

٢٧

"When did we pray? Or fast?"

٢٧

Then — arriving at a run, with **Fatkat** beside him — **Mohammadeen**.

٢٧

He had heard. The Egyptian math teacher had heard the specific sound of an Englishman producing village Arabic, and had arrived at full speed to witness it. He took in the scene in one professional scan — the stick, the father, the shaking boy, the kneeling English woman, the standing English man, the frozen children.

٢٧

He pointed at **John**. He shouted in his full, rich, unmistakable Egyptian:

مش انتو يا أختي! ده الجنّي اللي فيه! يا خرابي، الواد اتلبس

(It's not you, my sister! It's the jinni in him! Oh ruin of mine — the fellow has been possessed!)

Fatkat screamed.

Not the small scream of surprise. The big, committed, operatic scream of a woman who had, a second earlier, decided that the situation required a full reaction and had, in the specific Egyptian way, produced one.

And then — she fainted.

She fell like a sack of rice.

Everyone jumped.

Safiya screamed, "*Oh no!*" — one hand still on **Saeed's** back, one hand reaching toward **Fatkat**.

Thuraya — **Thuraya**, in a moment that would, for decades afterwards, live in the private memory of everyone present — tried not to laugh. She tried with the specific full-body discipline of a teacher who understood that laughter, at this exact moment, was **inappropriate**. She failed. A small laugh — muffled — escaped her.

John blinked. He looked around — at his shaking wife, at the fainted sports teacher, at the frozen Egyptian husband, at the frozen village father, at the frozen children, at the kneeling boy.

"*Why*," he said, quietly, in English, "*is everyone looking at me?*"

Marhoon sat down. Slowly. Very slowly. The specific slow sitting-down of a man whose legs had, all at once, stopped agreeing to hold him.

He did not speak. He did not shout.

٢٧
ع

He just stared.

٢٨
ع

At **John**. At **Saeed**. At the world — the small piece of it he had, this morning, thought he understood.

SCENE SIX

The Goat, and What Changed

It was **Saeed** who broke the silence.

٢٩
ع

He was still kneeling in the dust, inside **Safiya**'s arm. He was still shaking — the small, **receding** shake of a body returning, slowly, to itself. His voice, when it came, was very small.

٣٠
ع

"I didn't steal anything..." he whispered. *"Malood took them..."*

٣١
ع

They all turned.

٣٢
ع

Malood stood near the tree.

٣٣
ع

He had, at some point during the commotion — nobody had seen when — arrived. He had positioned himself, with the specific unconcerned **proprietary** air he brought to every scene, in the small strip of shade beneath the ghaf tree. And he was holding — visibly, without shame, without any **comprehension** of what he had just caused — **Ali**'s zanoubah in his mouth.

٣٤
ع

And beside him, on the ground: **Rahma**'s buckled sandal. Slightly chewed.

٣٥
ع

The children screamed.

٣٦
ع

"THE GOAT!"

٣٧
ع

Thuraya closed her eyes. The specific long weary closing of a woman who had, in her teaching career, witnessed the village blame a great many old men for a great many things, and who had now — yet again — seen one of her favourite small truths confirmed: that the guilty party, in this village, was almost always small, horned, and entirely unrepentant.

٣٨
ع

"Of course."



Later, when they walked back to the school — **Saeed** between **Safiya** and **Thuraya**, his small arm looped through **Safiya**'s, his face streaked but calm — **Marhoon** did not follow them. He sat, for a long time, on the dusty patch of ground where he had landed. He did not pick the stick back up. He did not go to the mal. He simply sat.



And it was, **Thuraya** would tell **Safiya** that night, the specific sitting of a father who had just been shown, **unmistakably**, the gap between what he had believed and what had actually been true.



*Back at school, **Fatkat** had woken up. She had been revived with water and a great deal of fanning by the other women. She was now drinking sweet tea and explaining, at high volume, to anyone who would listen, that she had known, she had known, that the English teacher's mouth was not normal. **Mohammadeen**, beside her, was still quietly telling everyone the boy was **possessed**. The classroom had divided, by now, into the pro-possession camp and the pro-confused-miracle camp, and the debate was, on **Fatkat**'s side, lively.*



John sat in the corner of the classroom. Holding his head.



Safiya looked at him. Quietly. With the specific small warm **affection** of a wife whose husband had, in the space of one morning, saved a boy and **terrified** the village, without quite knowing how he had done either.



"You," she said, "are dangerous in Arabic."



John whispered — into his palms, the specific muffled whisper of a man who had not yet decided how to feel about himself —



"I don't remember anything."



Thuraya looked across the classroom — past **John**, past **Fatkat**, past **Mohammadeen** — to the door.



Saeed was sitting there.



He was sitting quietly, on the small wooden step just inside the door. His arms around his knees. His face calm now, the small tear-tracks drying in the afternoon light. His eyes open. Watching.

٢٧
ع

Not a student.

٢٨
ع

Not a guest.

٢٩
ع

But — for the first time — not invisible anymore.

٣٠
ع

Thuraya watched him for a long moment. Then — very quietly, almost to herself — she said, "*Tomorrow.*"

٣١
ع

Safiya looked at her. "*Tomorrow, what?*"

٣٢
ع

Thuraya did not take her eyes off the boy.

٣٣
ع

"*Tomorrow,*" she said, "*we will go to the Sheikh's house. And we will fix this.*"

٣٤
ع

She paused. A small, considered, entirely **settled** pause.

٣٥
ع

"*Not just for **Saeed**. For all of them.*"



Did You Know?

The Falaj Irrigation Turn System

Remember the plot ("maal") that Saeed was supposed to water? Oman's falaj irrigation system has been on UNESCO's World Heritage list since 2006, with roots going back nearly 2500 years. The word "afaj" in classical Arabic means "division into shares" — water is distributed among farmers on a precise schedule, historically timed by the position of the sun and stars.

Source: whc.unesco.org · web.astronomicalheritage.net

PALM

Palm Sixteen

The Sheikh's House and the Mandoos

SCENE ONE

The Invitation

In Samail, when something big happened, people did not talk about it in the street.

و

They talked about it in the **Sheikh's house**.

و

And that day, something big had happened.

و

***Safiya** had understood, over the course of the afternoon — slowly, the way she now understood most village matters, through the small layered **sediment** of small glances and half-translations — that the morning had shifted something. **Marboon's** stick. **John's** uncontrolled Arabic. **Fatkat** fainting. **Thuraya** standing between a father and a son. The village had absorbed it all by noon. By afternoon, the village had begun to **metabolise** it. And by evening — as it turned out — the village had decided.*

و

The message came in the afternoon.

و

A boy ran from house to house — the specific house-to-house small boy that every Omani village of that period kept in supply — saying the same sentence at each doorway.

و

"After Maghrib prayer. Everyone to the Sheikh's house."

و

He did not explain. He did not need to. The village already knew. By the time the boy reached the third doorway, the reason had travelled ahead of him.

و

Thuraya had been sitting on the low wooden bench outside the small clay house, folding a piece of cloth. She looked up when the boy arrived at the gate. She heard the sentence. She returned to her folding.



But her hands — **Safiya** noticed — had stopped.



She stood, quietly. She set the cloth aside. She said, without ceremony, with the specific calm voice she used when she was giving a piece of information that had **weight** —



*"They will talk about **Saeed**. And about school."*



John closed his notebook. He had been, all afternoon, writing nothing — holding the pen over the page without letting it touch down. His mind had not been settled enough to produce a sentence.



"Is that," he asked, carefully, "good or bad?"



Thuraya looked at him. She did not smile. She did not frown. She gave him, instead, the specific even honest look she gave **John** when she was about to translate a village concept into English and knew, in advance, that the English version would not quite capture it.



*"In Samail," she said, "it is **serious**."*



The word *serious* — in the specific way **Thuraya** used it — covered both *good* and *bad*. It covered every outcome that a village meeting was capable of producing. It was the correct word. **John**, hearing it, did not ask further.



Safiya looked up. *"Do we need to prepare something?"*



Thuraya smiled — a small, careful smile. *"Just your hearts. And maybe... empty stomachs."*



Safiya, who did not yet understand why empty stomachs would be useful, nodded anyway. She had, by now, learned that **Thuraya's** sentences usually explained themselves an hour or two later.

SCENE TWO

The House of the Sheikh

The Sheikh's house was not small.



It was not fancy either.

~
ع

It was, **Safiya** realised as they approached it in the last gold light after Maghrib, a house that had been built, **deliberately**, to be the house where large quantities of people could sit on the floor at the same time without knocking into each other.

~
ع

It had a long front room. A wide low **sitting-room** along one wall. Incense smoke was already rising, in soft slow **columns**, from two **censers** at the two ends of the room.

~
ع

But it was *full*.

~
ع

Men sat on carpets.

~
ع

Old men — the silver-bearded men of the village, the ones who no longer worked the farms but who *weighed in*, when it was time to weigh in. Young men — fathers of young children, men in their thirties and forties, men who still had skin in the game. Fathers. Uncles. A few men **Safiya** recognised from the school gate. A few she did not recognise at all.

~
ع

The air smelled like coffee — the fresh cardamom-heavy coffee that had just been prepared in a room at the back — and incense, and the specific layered smell of *serious talk* that men's gatherings everywhere produce.

~
ع

At the side of the compound, through a low open doorway, women were busy.

~
ع

Very busy.

~
ع

Big pots. Big **cauldrons**. Big plates. And big plans, already **underway**, for lunch — or rather, for dinner — after the meeting.

~
ع

Safiya whispered to **Thuraya**, "*Why is there so much food?*"

~
ع

Thuraya answered, without hesitation, with the specific calm certainty of a village truth —

~
ع

"*Because no Omani meeting ends without food.*"

~
ع

Safiya nodded. *"Important rule."*

~

It was, she realised, an actual rule. Not just a custom. A *rule*. In the way that *the falaj has laws* was a rule. Every significant village gathering ended, no matter what else had happened, with the full communal meal — and the meal was, in itself, the ratification of the gathering.

SCENE THREE

The Food Fear

Safiya looked around at the kitchen end of the compound. Her eye moved — idly at first — from the pots, to the plates, to the rising steam, to the faint **aromatic** cloud of cooking meat.

~

Then — without warning — her face changed.

~

"Thuraya..."

~

"Yes?"

~

*"Where is **Malood**?"*

~

Thuraya blinked. She had, like everyone else, been focused on the gathering, and had not thought about the goat in — she considered — perhaps the last hour and a half. *"He was outside."*

~

Safiya's eyes became big.

~

"Outside," she said, slowly, the specific slow English of a wife approaching a dreadful hypothesis, *"or... in the kitchen?"*

~

She looked at the big knives.

~

At the big pots.

~

At the big plates.

~

The logic, in **Safiya**'s head, assembled itself with **terrible** speed. A village meeting. A big meal. Lamb, presumably. Where did lamb come from, on a day of no warning, with no time to go to the butcher? From a goat, presumably. A goat available locally. A small, horned, white goat who had, for the last two months, been making himself **conspicuous** in every courtyard of the village.

﴿

"Ob no," she whispered. "They killed **Malood**."

﴿

She held her heart. Literally. Her hand went, without her planning it, to her chest.

﴿

"The goat..."

﴿

At exactly that moment — the specific timing that only village comedy produces — **Fatkat** came around the corner. She was laughing. She had heard the last sentence.

﴿

She cupped her hands around her mouth — as though **Safiya** were across a courtyard instead of three metres away — and shouted, in her full Egyptian Arabic:

﴿

إيه بس بقى يا أختي! مالود إيه اللي يتدبح؟ ده بره مع الحريم! قاعد ياكل ويعمل دوشة عند أم مثلى!

﴿

(What are you on about, my sister! Malood — who would slaughter him? He is outside with the women! Sitting and eating and making noise at Umm Mathila's!)

﴿

Safiya froze. "He is... alive?"

﴿

Fatkat nodded. She put her hands on her hips — the specific wide-set stance of a woman who had just been asked a question that had a very satisfying answer. "More than alive."

﴿

Outside, as though he had heard — and as though he had decided, from wherever he was, to make himself audible — **Malood**'s bell rang loudly. The specific bright small bell that **Aunt Azizah** had tied to his neck two weeks ago in an attempt to **track** him.

﴿

And someone, from the courtyard, shouted —

﴿

"STOP EATING THAT!"

﴿

Safiya almost cried. From happiness. From the specific full relief of a woman whose small adopted animal had not, after all, been **sacrificed** for the communal meal.

~

She sat down. On a small wooden stool. She held her heart again — this time in **gratitude** rather than grief.

SCENE FOUR

The Meeting Begins

Inside, the meeting had begun to gather itself.

~

The Sheikh sat in the middle — at the far end of the majlis, on a small raised **cushion** that raised him, by the width of a hand, above the rest of the room. He was, **Safiya** saw now — looking at him properly for the first time — an older man, perhaps seventy, with a white beard neatly combed, calm eyes, and the specific **settled** presence of a man who had spent forty years listening to villagers argue with each other and who had, at some point, stopped needing to raise his own voice.

~

Marhoon — **Saeed**'s father — sat near the wall.

~

Quiet.

~

Not angry.

~

Just... heavy.

~

The specific heaviness of a man who had, that morning, been publicly shown the gap between what he had believed and what was actually true, and who had been carrying that gap around, inside his body, for the whole afternoon.

~

Saeed sat behind a pillar. Half hidden. The specific small half-hidden sitting of a boy who had been brought to the gathering, had been told he could stay, and who had chosen the exact seat that offered both **attendance** and, if needed, **concealment**.

~

John, **Safiya**, and **Thuraya** sat together. Near the door. In the specific slightly-set-apart way that was reserved for guests who were part of the conversation but not part of the lineage.

~

The Sheikh cleared his throat.

و

The room quieted. Immediately.

و

"We are here," he said — speaking in Arabic, slowly, with the specific practised clarity of a man who knew that his words would be translated in several heads around the room — *"to talk about our children. And about learning."*

و

A voice, from somewhere along the carpet, said: *"School is new."*

و

Someone else: *"Work is more important."*

و

Small nods. Small head-shakes. The specific small motion of a room in which several opinions had just silently **surfaced**.

و

Marhoon looked at the floor.

و

He did not speak.

و

He simply, for the first time in that long afternoon, looked down — and did not look up.

و

Thuraya stood up.

و

She did not shout.

و

She did not cry.

و

She just spoke — in her clear, clean, village-teacher Arabic, the specific Arabic she had developed over six years of working in a school, the Arabic that carried the dignity of having been used, many times, to translate small English words for small Omani ears.

و

"Knowledge," she said, *"does not take your sons away from you. It gives them a way."*

و

The sentence landed.

Not loudly. Not dramatically. But it landed, the way certain sentences land when they have been waiting, for a long time, for exactly the right room to be said in.

John wanted to help. **Safiya** could see him, beside her, the specific small tightening of a man whose mouth had, twice that day, gone off without his permission. He took in a small breath. He was about to speak.

Safiya held his arm. Firmly. Under the sleeve, her fingers closed around his wrist.

"No Arabic today."

He nodded. Slowly. With the specific, grateful, **managed** nod of a man who had, after three separate unauthorised Arabic episodes, begun to trust his wife's grip more than his own mouth.

Men talked.

Argued.

Listened.

The specific rotation of a majlis in action — one man giving his view, pausing, another man picking up the thread, the Sheikh inclining his head at intervals, a small interruption from a younger uncle, a small correction from an older one. **Safiya** could not follow all of it. But she could follow the **shape**.

And then, from somewhere near the wall, came a voice she did not, at first, recognise.

"I was afraid," it said — quietly, in simple Arabic that even **John**, leaning forward, could partially follow. *"I thought school will change him."*

Safiya turned her head.

Marhoon.

He had spoken. His head was still partly down. His voice was not loud. But every man in the room had heard the sentence.

~

The Sheikh nodded. Slowly. The specific slow nod of a man who had been waiting — patiently, without expecting — for this exact sentence.

~

"It will," he said. "But not in a bad way."

~

*And across the room, behind the pillar, **Saeed** — the quiet boy, the collector of secrets, the nine-year-old who had, that morning, carried bruises from his own father's stick — looked up. For the first time. His eyes met the Sheikh's. Then they met his father's. Then — very slowly — they came to rest on **Thuraya**.*

SCENE FIVE

And Then — Lunch

And like magic...

~

The serious faces changed.

~

It was the specific small wonder of Omani gatherings, which **Safiya** was witnessing for the first time — the instant at which the *talking* phase was understood to have ended, and the *eating* phase was understood to have begun, without anyone announcing the **transition** out loud.

~

Plates came.

~

The specific enormous **communal** plates of Omani hospitality, each carried by two people, each the size of a small table on its own.

~

Rice — the specific **long-grain** rice of the village, cooked with cardamom pods and saffron strands that had turned the grains a pale gold, with small slivers of fried almond and sweet raisins scattered across the top.

~

Meat.

~

More rice.

~

More meat.

~
ع

And the men — in the specific coordinated way of men who had done this together many times — moved closer to the plates, tucked the edges of their dishdashas under their knees, washed their right hands in the small basins that had been passed around, and began, without announcement, to eat.

~
ع

John looked at the food.

~
ع

He looked at it the way a man looks at a thing he has, until this moment, not understood the scale of. His eyes were wide. His face was, **Safiya** noted, the specific face of an Englishman who had just recognised that the civilised portion sizes of his upbringing were, in the larger **grammar** of global hospitality, a **modest** dialect.

~
ع

He ate.

~
ع

And ate.

~
ع

And ate.

~
ع

Safiya, beside him, watched him work his way through a small mountain of rice and a generous layer of lamb, with the specific **sustained** appetite of a man who had decided, at some early point in the meal, that not to eat fully would be culturally rude.

~
ع

After some time — **John** having now reached what **Safiya** would later describe to her sister as *the fifth plateau* — she stopped him. Quietly. With her hand on his wrist. Again.

~
ع

"John..."

~
ع

He said — with a full mouth, with the specific **cheerful** muffled delivery of a man who had, that evening, found his proper vocation — *"This is history. I must respect history."*

~
ع

After the meal, the specific slow after-meal arrangement began. The tall young men collected the plates. The old men leaned back on cushions. **John** did not lean back. **John** had already leaned back, and was now holding his stomach with both hands, and was, **Safiya** could see, in a state of physical wonder at what had just happened to him.

٢٧
ع

He said — loudly, in English, with the specific small philosophical clarity that came to him after he had eaten far too much —

٢٨
ع

"Now I understand why Omani men have big belly."

٢٩
ع

Silence.

٣٠
ع

A small, **appalled** silence, on **Safiya's** side, at having a husband who said such things at such moments.

٣١
ع

Then **Thuraya** — **Thuraya**, from across the room, laughing before she had even spoken — shouted back:

٣٢
ع

*"It's good for wearing **khanjar**!"*

٣٣
ع

The men laughed. Loudly. The specific warm, forgiving, **welcoming** laughter of a majlis that had just, collectively, agreed to take **John's** rudeness as a compliment.

٣٤
ع

Safiya blinked. *"What is... **khanjar**?"*

٣٥
ع

Thuraya smiled — the specific *Thuraya-knows-something* smile.

٣٦
ع

"You will see. Very soon."

SCENE SIX

Outside, and That Night

Outside, **Malood** was still alive.

٣٧
ع

Very alive.

٣٨
ع

He was, by some combination of goat-cunning and lucky circumstance, in the back courtyard with the women and the children. He was eating. He was stealing food. He was making children scream —

both from delight and from the specific fear of having their own small portion taken by a small white thief.



And next to him — close enough that his small hand, once or twice, settled on **Malood's** warm flank — sat **Saeed**.



Smiling.



Not widely. Not loudly. But — for the first time that **Safiya** had ever seen — smiling.



*The specific quiet smile of a nine-year-old who had just, in his own small way, been inside a village decision. Had heard his father speak. Had heard the Sheikh reply. Had heard the room not reject him. Had watched his father, across the room, not look at him with anger — and, eventually, not look at him at all, because the matter had been, in the unspoken village way, **resolved**.*



Tomorrow, **Saeed** would, at long last, come to school.



Nobody had said it in those words. Nobody had put it on paper. But it had been, somewhere between **Thuraya's** sentence and the Sheikh's nod and **Marhoon's** quiet admission, *decided*. And every person in that majlis knew it.



That night, in their simple house, **John** lay on the bisat with his hand on his stomach. He was still feeling, faintly, the weight of the rice. He would, he had announced at the door, not eat again for two days. **Safiya** had smiled at this — the small, knowing smile of a wife who had heard that exact declaration before, and who knew, with complete confidence, how long it would last.



He reached for his notebook.



He had been writing more, over the last week. The notebook was now perhaps a third full. He had, without planning, begun to keep a kind of **journal** — not a professional record, not a teaching log, but the specific accumulated personal record of a man being **quietly**, steadily, *made* by a village.



He wrote, slowly:



Today, a village talked. And something changed.



Safiya, sitting across from him on her own small part of the bisat, had her own notebook open. She was, she had decided some weeks earlier, going to keep her own record. She wrote her sentence beneath his — in her smaller, rounder English hand:



Also, Malood is not food.



John read the sentence. He laughed — the specific quiet full-stomach laugh of a man who had been **worn out** by the day and was now, at the end of it, content.



Outside, **Thuraya** stood in the small courtyard of her parents' house, looking at the stars.



The stars in Samail, in October of 1973, were a specific dense pattern that the village had been watching since long before there had been a village. They had watched, that evening, as the village reasoned with itself. They had watched the Sheikh nod. They had watched **Marhoon** admit his fear. They had watched **Saeed** look up.



Thuraya looked at them for a long time. And then she said — quietly, to no one, only to the stars — the specific small sentence a teacher says when she is, in private, admitting to herself that something she has been hoping for has finally happened:



"Tomorrow," she said, "we start something new."



Did You Know?

The Omani Majlis and Hospitality Traditions

Remember Thuraya's line, "No Omani gathering ever ends without food"? That's genuinely true — the "majlis" is the heart of Omani social life, where people gather to discuss and make important decisions, like the one about accepting Saeed into school. Serving Omani coffee with cardamom and rosewater to guests is part of a hospitality ritual rooted deep in traditional Bedouin culture.

Source: the-expat-edit.com · allaboutoman.com

PALM

Palm Seventeen

Spicy Food and Saeed's First English Sentences

SCENE ONE

The Visit

Some houses in Samail had secrets.

و

Not bad secrets.

و

Beautiful ones.

و

And most of them lived inside a **mandoos**.

و

That morning, **Thuraya** invited **John** and **Safiya** to her parents' house.

و

"My mother wants to show you something," she said, smiling in the specific way that — **Safiya** had learned to read — meant *many* somethings.

و

Safiya was excited. *"Is it food?"*

و

Thuraya laughed. *"Not this time."*

و

John looked suspicious. The specific **wary** look of a man who had, by now, been surprised enough times by Omani invitations to know that the word *something* carried weight.

و

"Is it," he asked, *"something that will make me eat again?"*

و

His stomach — from the previous night's meal at the Sheikh's house — had, he would later admit, still not fully recovered. He had eaten, in fact, only a single small piece of bread for breakfast, in an

attempt to let his body reach a **neutral** state.

~

*"Maybe," **Thuraya** said. The specific teasing *maybe*. "But first... culture."*

~

They walked together to **Thuraya's** parents' house — along the small path that ran behind the school, past two palm groves, past the old well that had not been used since the falaj had been extended in 1968, to the low clay house with its blue door and its small front yard swept clean every morning.

~

The house was simple and warm. The walls were light-coloured — the specific warm pale ochre of unpainted village clay — and the rooms smelled of **oud** — burning quietly in a small clay censer by the door — and of coffee.

~

Thuraya's mother welcomed them kindly. She was a small sturdy woman with hennaed fingertips and the specific steady warmth of a village woman who had, by her sixties, become entirely at home with strangers.

~

"Come, come," she said. "Sit."

~

They sat on the low cushions arranged along the wall. She brought coffee — in the small traditional cups, the specific finjans of Omani hospitality — and a small dish of dates. She spoke to them, through **Thuraya's** gentle translation, about the weather, about their health, about **John's** leg, which had, by now, fully recovered from the wasp.

~

Then she disappeared into another room.

~

She came back — moving slowly, careful — with something held in both arms.

~

A big wooden box.

~

Old.

~

Heavy.

~

Beautiful.



*It was perhaps the size of a small coffee table. Its dark wood had been polished, over decades, by the specific careful weekly rubbing of someone's hands. Its front and sides were **studded** with small brass nails — dozens and dozens of them, arranged in geometric patterns, in the specific **traditional** designs that **Safiya** had begun to recognise on door lintels and cupboard fronts around the village.*



The lid had a small brass lock. The key — a heavy, old, **ornate** key — hung on a thin silver chain from **Thuraya's** mother's wrist.



*"What is that?" **Safiya** asked. Her voice had gone quiet. The specific quiet voice of a woman who had recognised, in advance of knowing anything else, that she was about to be shown something important.*



Thuraya said — proudly, warmly, with the specific affection of a daughter referring to a family object — *"That is the mandoos."*



John reached forward. He touched it — carefully, with two fingers, on one of the brass studs. *"It looks like a pirate treasure box."*



Thuraya's mother, when this was translated for her, smiled. The specific small proud smile of a woman who had heard her own beloved chest compared to a pirate's box, and who had, with immediate amused grace, decided to accept the compliment and improve it.



"Better," she said.

SCENE TWO

The Treasure Inside

The mandoos opened with a slow, **dramatic** sound — the specific soft creak of wood that has been closed for a long time, of old hinges, of a lock that had been turned by only a few specific hands over several decades.



Inside...



Light.



Silver.

~
ع

Gold.

~
ع

Stories.

~
ع

Safiya, without meaning to, leaned forward. Her breath caught. The inside of the mandoos was not just a container. It was, as she would write in her notebook that night, *a whole small museum of someone's life*.

~
ع

Thuraya's mother took out the first thing.

~
ع

A khanjar.

~
ع

John's eyes became round. The specific round-eyed look of a man who had, in one week, heard the word *khanjar* several times, and was now — finally — seeing it in the actual hand of an actual Omani woman.

~
ع

"Ob! The curved knife!"

~
ع

Thuraya looked at him. Seriously. With the specific patient seriousness she used when she was about to correct a foreign visitor's understanding of a national symbol.

~
ع

"It is not just a knife."

~
ع

She paused. To let the correction land.

~
ع

"It is a symbol."

~
ع

*The khanjar was perhaps thirty centimetres from the curved tip of its sheath to the top of its **hilt**. The sheath itself was curved upward in the specific **crescent** shape that was the national signature of Oman. Fine silver wire, worked in intricate patterns, wrapped the sheath from its tip almost to its mouth. Small hand-hammered rosettes decorated the silver. The belt that came with it was a wide leather strap, **embossed** with further silver threads.*

~
ع

Safiya asked, quietly, "*Can I touch it?*"



Thuraya's mother nodded.



Safiya held it. She held it the way one holds a thing that might, at any moment, turn out to be made of glass. Her hands, she noticed, had gone very careful.



"It's beautiful."



Then came the silver jewellery.



The specific silver jewellery of old Oman, the kind that had been made, piece by piece, by small specialist silversmiths in the markets of Nizwa and Muscat and Rustaq over the last sixty years, and which **Thuraya's** grandmother had, over the course of her married life, collected.



Big necklaces — the specific wide **pectoral** necklaces that women wore at weddings, with long silver pendants that hung down the chest and reached almost to the waist.



Heavy bracelets — **Safiya** lifted one and was surprised by its weight. A single bracelet, worn on a wrist for a day, would remind its wearer of its presence every time she raised her arm.



Shiny earrings — small and large, some with drops of silver, some with tiny coloured stones, some with the specific cone-shaped silver ornaments that had been made in Nizwa for perhaps two hundred years.



And — something else. Something that, when **Thuraya's** mother lifted it from the mandos, *moved*.



A small, very specific, cascading movement. And a sound. The small soft **shimmer** of small silver pieces moving against each other.



Thuraya smiled. "*That,*" she said, "*is martaasha.*"



Safiya said the word slowly, carefully. "*Mar... ta... asha.*"



The jewel moved in **Thuraya**'s mother's hand. It made the small soft sound again.

٢٧
ع

"*Oh!*" **Safiya** laughed — the specific small delighted laugh of a woman who had just understood. "*It is shaking!*"

٢٨
ع

Thuraya nodded. "*That's why.*"

٢٩
ع

Then came the **banjari**.

٣٠
ع

Safiya looked confused. "*What is this?*"

٣١
ع

Thuraya's mother showed her. "*Bracelets. Many of them.*"

٣٢
ع

She gestured for **Safiya**'s arm. **Safiya**, slightly hesitant, extended it. **Thuraya**'s mother slid the banjari, one at a time, onto her wrist.

٣٣
ع

One.

٣٤
ع

Cling.

٣٥
ع

Two.

٣٦
ع

Cling. Cling.

٣٧
ع

Three.

٣٨
ع

Cling. Cling. Cling.

٣٩
ع

By the time she had finished, **Safiya**'s wrist carried perhaps twelve thin silver bracelets. She moved her hand. They all moved with her.

٤٠
ع

It sounded like music.

٤١
ع

John clapped. "You," he said, "*are now a walking instrument.*"

SCENE THREE

Silver or Gold?

Thuraya took out two necklaces from the mandoos. She laid them, carefully, on a small white cloth on the low table in front of them.

~
~

"*One is silver,*" she said. "*One is gold.*"

~
~

John, inspecting both, said — with the specific careful observation of a man trying to contribute meaningfully to a culture lesson — "*Silver is... **gray**. Gold is... **yellow**.*"

~
~

Safiya, across from him, could not resist.

~
~

"*Like **John**,*" she said — with the specific small warm teasing of a wife who had been, all week, saving up this observation — "*after lunch, and **John** before lunch.*"

~
~

John ignored her. The specific **dignified** English ignoring that had been, over the course of his marriage, refined into a small art form.

~
~

Thuraya smiled. She had heard the joke. She would, she decided, let **John** keep his dignity.

~
~

"*In Oman,*" she said — shifting back to her teacher voice, the specific voice she used when she was about to explain something with cultural **weight** — "*silver is very important. Especially for women.*"

~
~

She lifted the silver necklace. The pieces of it caught the light from the small high window — the light had reached, by this hour, the **oblique** mid-morning angle that was, **Safiya** thought, the exact right angle for showing silver off.

~
~

The silver had a different quality to it than the silver she had known in London. It was **handmade** silver — the kind that had small inconsistencies, small hammer marks, small visible signs of the specific hand that had shaped it. It was not polished to factory brightness. It was polished to the softer shine of a thing that had been loved and used.

~
~

Safiya looked at the jewelry on the table.

۞

"*They are heavy,*" she said.

۞

Heavy was the word. A single necklace, if worn, would sit on a woman's chest with real, sustained, remembering weight. You would not forget you were wearing it.

۞

Thuraya's mother nodded — the specific calm confirming nod of a woman who had, many times, worn exactly these pieces.

۞

"*Yes. But beautiful.*"

۞

John — holding one of the larger necklaces across his own palm, **testing** the weight — said, with genuine wonder, "*I think, if I wear this, I will fall.*"

۞

Thuraya laughed. "*We don't put everything on one person.*"

۞

The jewelry, she explained — as her mother began lifting out smaller items, one by one, placing them on the cloth — was distributed across a woman's body on the specific day of her wedding. The martaasha at the throat. The banjari at the wrist. The earrings. The rings. The belt. The headpiece. The whole thing, together, had its own name, its own order, its own meaning.

۞

A bride, dressed in all of it, was — for one day — carrying her own family's entire saved history on her body.

SCENE FOUR

Trying Clothes

Then **Thuraya's** mother brought traditional clothes.

۞

She came out from the inner room carrying them carefully over both arms — the specific reverent carrying of clothes that have been, for years, waiting in a dark cupboard for exactly this kind of morning.

۞

A dress for **Safiya**. The specific **embroidered** wedding dress of an Omani woman, with gold threadwork along the cuffs and across the chest, in the specific geometric patterns that had been, in this region, woven for perhaps a hundred years.

۞

A **dishdasha** for **John**. Plain white. Freshly pressed. The specific clean cotton whiteness of a dishdasha that had been saved for guests.

۞

And a belt.

۞

And something long and shiny.

۞

John pointed — with the specific careful pointing of a man who had understood, the instant it appeared, what the long shiny thing was, and who wanted — but had not quite dared — to ask.

۞

"Is that... for me?"

۞

Thuraya smiled. Slowly. The specific slow smile of a woman about to give a tall Englishman, for the first time in his life, a **khanjar**.

۞

"Yes."

۞

John wore the dishdasha.

۞

It fell to his ankles. It was, **Safiya** noted, surprisingly flattering — the loose white cotton hung from his tall thin frame the way that a dishdasha was designed to hang, and the effect was to make him look, for the first time since they had arrived in the country, not like a foreigner but like a **recognisable** kind of man.

۞

Then **Thuraya** helped him with the belt. She wound it twice around his waist, adjusted the buckle, tightened it in the specific correct way. Then she picked up the khanjar. She attached it to the front of the belt — at the specific angle, tipped slightly outward, that Omani men had been attaching their khanjars for several centuries.

۞

John looked at himself — in a small mirror that **Thuraya's** mother had brought out specifically for this.

۞

Straight.

۞

Serious.

~
~

Important.

~
~

The specific **transformation** that a khanjar produced, on the body of a man who had never worn one before, was not subtle. He stood differently. His shoulders had **squared**. His chin had lifted.

~
~

Safiya clapped. She could not help herself.

~
~

"*You look,*" she said, "*like a very hungry sultan.*"

~
~

John stood taller. He had decided to accept the title. "*I feel powerful.*"

~
~

Thuraya laughed. "*Be careful. Power,*" she said — with the specific small wisdom of a sentence her mother had probably said to her when she was ten — "*comes with responsibility.*"

~
~

Safiya tried the dress. And then — piece by piece — the jewelry.

~
~

Banjari. Twelve of them. Cling. Cling. Cling.

~
~

Necklace.

~
~

Earrings.

~
~

Martaasha.

~
~

She walked. Carefully. The specific slow walk of a woman who was, for the first time in her life, wearing enough metal on her body to be audibly visible from ten metres away.

~
~

Cling cling cling.

~
~

She turned. She looked at herself in the same small mirror.

~
~

"Do I," she asked, softly, "look Omani?"

~

Thuraya smiled warmly. The specific small warm smile of a woman who had, many times, imagined this exact moment — the English teacher's wife, in her mother's **bridal** silver, in the specific soft oblique light of her mother's small living room.

~

"Very."

SCENE FIVE

The Lesson Idea

Later, they sat back down on the cushions. **Thuraya's** mother brought fresh coffee. The specific small ceremonial refill that happened, in every Omani household, at the exact point in a visit when the conversation had moved from formal **hospitality** into genuine companionship.

~

John, still in his dishdasha, had reached for his notebook. He was, **Safiya** could see, doing that specific small thing he did when he had found a lesson — the small **furrowed-brow** concentration of a teacher converting lived experience into classroom material.

~

"We can," he said, slowly, writing, "make this a lesson."

~

Safiya nodded. "Yes! Clothes. And jewelry."

~

Thuraya said — with the specific calm certainty of a teacher who had already, in her head, seen the lesson plan — "Vocabulary."

~

She took a small piece of paper. She wrote, in her clear Arabic-and-English hand:

~

Gold
Silver
Wearing
Necklace
Bracelet
Khanjar
Dress

~

Safiya leaned forward. *"We can teach them: 'I am wearing...' 'She is wearing...'"*



John added — with a small teacher-satisfaction — *"And: 'It is made of silver.' 'It is made of gold.'"*



Thuraya nodded. *"Good."*



They sat for a while longer in the warm small room. The oud continued to burn. **Thuraya's** mother, who had been watching them with the specific slow contentment of a woman whose household had just delivered a small cultural success, lifted the mandoos — now slightly lighter than it had been — and carried it back into the inner room.



They walked home through the afternoon light. **Safiya** was, by now, unadorned again — her own ordinary ring back on her finger, her own ordinary scarf around her neck. But she moved, for the rest of the afternoon, with a small specific awareness of her own wrists. As though some part of her still carried, faintly, the memory of the banjari.



*And **John** — who had, with great reluctance, given back the dishdasha and the belt and the khanjar at the door — walked a little straighter all the way home. His shoulders, **Safiya** would later note, stayed squared for approximately three more hours, until the cumulative effect of teaching, lunch, and being tall finally returned him to his ordinary English **slouch**.*

SCENE SIX

At School: I Am Wearing

The next day, the classroom was full of whispers.



Safiya came in wearing only one bracelet — a single silver banjari that **Thuraya's** mother had, that morning, gently slipped onto her wrist at the door and refused to accept back.



John came in with only the belt. Not the khanjar — **Thuraya** had said, very firmly, that the khanjar itself should not be brought into the classroom; a khanjar was a *thing*, not a *teaching aid* — but the belt, with its beautiful silver work, he was permitted to wear.



Thuraya carried a small cloth bag.



She opened it on her desk.



And the children gasped.



The specific full collective gasp of twelve small Omani children who had, for most of their lives, seen their own mothers wear such jewelry only at weddings — at **distance**, from across a crowded hall, on special occasions — and who had never, until this exact moment, seen the same pieces laid out carefully on a teacher's desk.



Mansoor shouted, "*Wow!*"



Mathila smiled. "*Pretty!*"



Ahmed — studying one of the pieces, with the specific careful attention of a boy who considered himself an expert in most household objects — "*Is that real silver?*"



Thuraya smiled. She did not answer directly. Instead, she turned to the board and wrote, in her clear capitals:



I am wearing...



She pointed to **Safiya**. "***Sophia**. What are you wearing?*"



Safiya, lifting her wrist — the single silver banjari catching the morning light — said slowly, "*I am wearing... a bracelet.*"



The class repeated. In their usual layered chorus.



"I am wearing a bracelet."



John pointed to himself. To the silver-worked belt. "*I am wearing... a belt.*"



The class repeated. **Ahmed** — **Safiya** noticed — wrote the sentence down twice, with two different decorative **underlinings**.



Then **Thuraya** held up the large silver necklace. The one that had, the day before, hung on her own mother's hand.

٧٥

"What is this?"

٧٦

Noura — first, as always — said, *"Necklace."*

٧٧

"Good. And what is it made of?"

٧٨

Silence.

٧٩

The specific small classroom silence of a set of children who had, for years, seen this exact material on their mothers' necks and chests, and who knew — absolutely knew — what it was, but who had never been asked to *name* it in English.

٨٠

Thuraya said, helpfully, *"It is made of... silver."*

٨١

The class repeated. *"It is made of silver."*

٨٢

Then **Thuraya** held up another piece — a small gold ring that her mother had, specifically for this lesson, lent to the day.

٨٣

"And this?"

٨٤

Khalil shouted — immediately, with the confidence of a boy who had, this time, not had to think

—

٨٥

"Gold!"

٨٦

Thuraya smiled. *"Yes. It is made of gold."*

٨٧

Mansoor raised his hand. *"Teacher... you are wearing... many things?"*

٨٨

Thuraya laughed. The specific warm laugh of a teacher whose best student of pragmatics had just shown, once again, his gift for asking the exact question she had been hoping someone would ask.

~
ع

"Not today."

~
ع

At the back of the class, **Saeed** was sitting quietly.

~
ع

He was new. Still careful. He had arrived that morning — following the meeting at the Sheikh's house, following the evening's decisions — and had taken a seat at the back, near the door, where the light was cool and where he could, as always, watch without being watched.

~
ع

He looked at the jewelry on the desk as though it had come from another world.

~
ع

In a sense, it had. His family did not have such pieces. His mother's wrists were bare. His grandmother's had been, at the end of her life, also bare. The *having* of a mandoos full of silver required, as a precondition, several generations of modest prosperity — which his family had been, for one reason and another, steadily missing.

~
ع

Safiya noticed. She walked — quietly, without fuss — to the back of the classroom. She knelt beside his small desk. She held out her wrist. The single silver banjari caught the morning light.

~
ع

"Saeed," she asked, gently, in the specific careful English of a teacher who had chosen a simple sentence, *"what am I wearing?"*

~
ع

Saeed thought.

~
ع

His small serious face concentrated. His eyes — still the eyes of a boy who had, two days earlier, been hit with a stick — now had, across them, the specific small clarity of a child being asked, for the first time in his life, to produce a sentence in English.

~
ع

He said — slowly, carefully — *"You... are wearing... bracelet."*

~
ع

Safiya smiled. Warmly. The specific warm teacher-smile she had been waiting all week to produce.

~
ع

"Good!"

۞

John — who had come over to stand behind her — added, equally gently, *"And what is it made of?"*

۞

Saeed whispered — the specific small shy whisper of a boy trying out a new word — *"Silver."*

۞

John nodded. *"Excellent."*

۞

The word — *excellent* — was not one **Saeed** had heard applied to himself before. He sat very still. His shoulders, almost without his permission, squared slightly.

۞

From two desks away, **Mansoor** — who could not, even now, manage more than thirty seconds of uninterrupted attention — whispered to **Khalil**, *"One day, I will wear khanjar."*

۞

Khalil — without hesitation, with the specific small affectionate **cruelty** of a nine-year-old friend — whispered back, *"One day, you will lose it."*

۞

That evening, in their simple house, **John** wrote in his notebook:

۞

Today, we taught silver and gold. Also, I want my own khanjar.

۞

Safiya, without looking up, said flatly — *"No."*

۞

Thuraya, who had come over for tea, laughed.

۞

Outside, in the small yard, **Malood** — who had, for reasons of his own, decided that today's **target** would be a piece of cloth drying on the washing line — was attempting to pull it down.

۞

Thuraya saw, through the window. She shouted — in her full teacher-voice — *"NO, MALOOD!"*

۞

Malood ignored her.

۞

As always.

..

 Did You Know?**The Omani Khanjar as a National Symbol**

Remember the khanjar John wore, from the “mandooos” chest? The Omani khanjar is far more than a weapon — it's a national symbol appearing on Oman's official emblem and on the Omani rial coin since the 18th century. Its curved, J-shaped blade symbolizes a crescent moon, and it's traditionally gifted to a young man coming of age, or as a wedding present.

Source: en.wikipedia.org · en.wikipedia.org

PALM

Palm Eighteen

Mountains, Sea, and the Magic Box of Muttrah

SCENE ONE

The Tired Fan

The classroom was already hot before the sun reached the middle of the sky.

~

*This was a specific kind of Samaili hot. Not the hot of an English summer afternoon, which came and went and permitted one to take a jacket off and feel immediately better. Not the hot of a hotel room in August. This was the accumulated hot of an October morning in the interior of Oman — a hot that began in the walls, that had been saved inside the clay all night long from yesterday's sun, that **radiated** quietly out of the packed mud and made everything — the desks, the chalkboard, the small piles of notebooks, **Safiya's** own chair — feel as though they had been, for a long time, **bathed** in a warmth they would not be letting go of any time soon.*

~

The fan on the ceiling turned slowly. It turned, **Safiya** thought, the way a tired workhorse turned — not because it believed in the turning, but because nobody had released it from the job.

~

It made a dry, weak sound.

~

Tak... tak... tak...

~

The specific dry mechanical clack of a metal bearing that had been, for several years, quietly **petitioning** for the small amount of oil that nobody had ever thought to give it. The fan, **Safiya** realised, was in much the same state as most of the village's small machines — serving faithfully, undermaintained, **uncomplaining**.

~

But the air did not change its mind.

~

It stayed warm. It stayed heavy. It stayed full of the specific dust-and-chalk smell of a classroom that had been, for some months now, **Safiya's** second home — full of chalk from the board, dust from the packed earth floor, and the faint small sweetness of the dates that some of the children had tucked into their pockets for their morning break.



John stood near the window, blinking. His eyes were still a little red from yesterday — the residue of the saffron, the smoke, the accumulated small indignities of a week in which his face had been, by his own later count, the target of at least four separate local hazards.



Safiya sat on the teacher's chair, fanning herself with a notebook.



The notebook was doing, in her hand, what the ceiling fan had failed to do all morning. Its small rapid paper movements, an inch from her warm face, produced the *memory* of cool air, if not cool air itself.



"Next time," she said — with the specific flat dry delivery of a wife who had, in the last hour, stopped pretending to be a professional — *"we teach English in the fridge."*



Thuraya smiled. The specific settled smile of a woman whose country had been, for several thousand years, exactly this hot. *"Welcome to Samail."*



The students were already inside — or, more accurately, the students had been inside before the adults had arrived, which was **Safiya** had come to understand, the usual order of things in a village where children had no commutes, no traffic, no schedules other than *the bell is about to ring*.



Ahmed sat straight — the specific straight of a ruler laid along a page. He had, **Safiya** noticed, developed over the last few weeks a small **posture** that she associated with Omani boys who had decided, early, that they were going to be doctors.



Mansoor was not sitting straight at all. **Mansoor** was in a specific curved, half-slumped, partly-kneeling configuration that suggested his body had been, in the last ten minutes, several different configurations.



Khalil was whispering something to **Ali**. Whatever he was whispering was funny — **Ali's** shoulders were shaking, silently, in the specific restrained shake of a boy who knew he was not supposed to be laughing.

و

Rahma and **Salima** shared a pencil. The specific peaceful pencil-sharing of two girls whose friendship required no words.

و

Marwa was drawing small flowers in the corner of her book. **Noura** raised her hand even before the lesson had started — the specific **pre-emptive** hand-raising of a girl who wanted to ensure she would be the first one called on, even if the teacher had not yet asked a question.

و

And at the back of the class — in his new, still-tentative, officially-his seat, the seat the Sheikh's house had, two days earlier, given him — a boy sat quietly, watching everything.

و

Saeed.

و

He did not sit with the others. He did not talk. He just watched.

و

But the watching was *different* now. **Safiya** could see it. It had moved — subtly, over two days — from the specific collector's watching of an outsider to the slightly different watching of a boy who was, now, legally and publicly *inside*. The village had decided. The Sheikh had nodded. His father had, in a room full of other fathers, spoken the hardest sentence of his life. And **Saeed**, this morning, was still learning how to hold his new status inside his small nine-year-old body.

SCENE TWO

We Ate Lamb

Under the desk, something small moved.

و

Malood.

و

The baby goat had decided — in the specific **unilateral** way that **Malood** made all his decisions — that the classroom was *also* his classroom. He had, by now, established a small **territorial** arrangement beneath the second row — a patch of cooler floor, partly hidden by the shadow of the desk, from which he could exit and re-enter the classroom at his own discretion.

و

Safiya looked down at him. She whispered — to **John**, mostly — "*We really need to talk about your student.*"

و

Malood answered her — without looking up, without apology — by chewing, *audibly*, a piece of paper. The specific small wet chewing sound of a goat who had, again, made a contribution to the early-morning **deficit** of small pieces of paper in the classroom.

~

Before **John** could start the lesson, **Mansoor** suddenly stood up.

~

The standing up was not gradual. **Mansoor** did not *rise*. **Mansoor** *launched*. In the space of half a second, his small body was upright, both arms already up, the specific **urgent** announcement-posture of a boy who had, in the last four seconds, remembered the single most important thing about his own life.

~

"Teacher! Teacher!"

~

"Yes, Mansoor?"

~

"We eat lamb yesterday."

~

John blinked. The specific small blink of a teacher translating tense in real time. *"You... ate lamb."*

~

"Yes! And with chili."

~

The word *chili* — when **Mansoor** said it, with the specific breath of a boy who had, over his short life, developed a very serious relationship with the pod — **triggered** the class.

~

At exactly the same moment — in the specific **overlapping** chorus that a village classroom produced when a shared experience had just been named aloud —

~

"Hot!"

~

"Very hot!"

~

"My mouth burn!"

~

"I cry!"

٢٧
ع

Khalil added, proudly — the specific small proud contribution of a boy whose pride lay in his ability to survive things other boys did not — *"I eat more."*

٢٨
ع

Ali shook his head. He shook it with the specific small unmoved scepticism of a boy who considered himself too **rational** to compete in chili-eating contests.

٢٩
ع

"You crazy."

٣٠
ع

Safiya laughed. *"So... everyone ate spicy food?"*

٣١
ع

The students nodded. Collectively. The specific layered-nodding of twelve small heads confirming, simultaneously, that yes — a shared cultural experience had, the previous evening, taken place across the entire village.

٣٢
ع

John smiled. Slowly.

٣٣
ع

A teacher's smile. The specific dangerous kind — the small private smile that meant *the lesson has just walked through the door on its own legs and volunteered for duty.*

٣٤
ع

"Good," he said. *"Very good. Today... we talk about taste."*

SCENE THREE

The Five Senses

He turned to the board. He wrote — in his clear large capitals —

٣٥
ع

THE FIVE SENSES

٣٦
ع

Then, underneath, with a smaller flourish:

٣٧
ع

TASTE

٣٨
ع

He looked at the class. *"Repeat after me. Taste."*

٣٩
ع

"*Taaaste*," the class said. Layered. A little stretched. The specific elongated vowel that village children produced when they were giving a new English word the full respect of being, for the first time, actually tasted in the mouth.

~
~

"*Good. Now... what words do we use for taste?*"

~
~

He wrote, one under the other, in a neat vertical column:

~
~

Sweet
Sour
Salty
Spicy

~
~

He pointed at each word, in order, and the class — with the specific delight of a class learning four new adjectives they could *actually use* — repeated.

~
~

"*Sweet.*"

~
~

"*Sweet.*"

~
~

"*Sour.*"

~
~

"*Sour.*"

~
~

"*Salty.*"

~
~

"*Salty.*"

~
~

"*Spicy.*"

~
~

"*Spaiiiicy*," **Mansoor** said — with the specific too-much emphasis of a boy who had decided that *his* version of the word was going to be the correct version.

~
~

John nodded. Patiently. "*Yes. Spicy.*"

٢٧
ع

Safiya clapped her hands. *"Okay! Examples! Who can give me an example?"*

٢٨
ع

Noura's hand went up like a rocket. It had been, in fact, already up for about two minutes — but it now went up *higher*, the specific further-up-hand-raise of a girl who felt her existing hand-raise was at risk of being missed.

٢٩
ع

"Yes, Noura."

٣٠
ع

"Sugar is sweet."

٣١
ع

"Excellent!"

٣٢
ع

Ahmed raised his hand — carefully, at exactly the correct height, neither too high nor too low. The specific calibrated hand-raise of a boy who had, by the age of nine, understood that the dignity of one's contribution was partly determined by the restraint of one's arm.

٣٣
ع

"Lemon is sour."

٣٤
ع

"Perfect."

٣٥
ع

Khalil, not to be outdone — *"Fish is salty."*

٣٦
ع

"Good."

٣٧
ع

And then — because **Mansoor** had been, for two and a half minutes, trying to find a way into the sentence — **Mansoor** jumped from his seat. The jump had no warning. It had no apparent reason. It was simply, **Safiya** had begun to understand, what **Mansoor** did when his contribution could no longer be held inside his body.

٣٨
ع

"Chili is... spicy and KILL YOU!"

٣٩
ع

The class laughed.

٤٠
ع

John laughed too. *"Yes. Chili is spicy. But it does not kill you."*

~
ع

Under the desk, **Malood** — who had been, up to this point, invisible — made a sound. A small sad sound. The specific small *hub*-sound that he had been producing, at intervals, since the previous morning.

~
ع

Safiya looked down. She saw him properly, for the first time that morning. He was, she realised, somewhat **subdued**. His usual proprietary sparkle was missing. His eyes, when he looked up at her, had the specific small suffering of a goat who had recently regretted a food choice.

~
ع

"Unless," Safiya added, softly, "you are a small goat."

~
ع

Thuraya laughed. *"Malood learned the lesson the hard way yesterday."*

~
ع

The details — as **Safiya** would later piece together — involved a red pepper left unattended on a low windowsill at **Aunt Azizah's** house, and a small goat who had, as always, confused *everything* with *food*.

SCENE FOUR

I Like, I Don't Like — And Saeed Speaks

John turned back to the board. He wrote, beneath the four taste-words, in slightly different lettering:

~
ع

I like...
I don't like...

~
ع

"Repeat," he said. "I like sweet."

~
ع

"I like sweet."

~
ع

"I don't like spicy."

~
ع

"I don't like spicy," said half the class — very seriously, with the specific small conviction of children declaring a **personal truth** they had been waiting for permission to speak.

~
ع

Mansoor crossed his arms. He crossed them across his small proud chest, in the specific wide stance of a boy preparing to register a public disagreement.

٧٧
ع

"I like spicy."

٧٧
ع

"Of course you do," said **Khalil**.

٧٧
ع

Safiya walked between the desks. She walked the specific slow teacher-walk she had, over the last two months, been practising — the walk that let her pause, without interrupting, at each small desk, and make her presence available to the shy children as well as the loud ones.

٧٧
ع

"Okay. You. Ali."

٧٧
ع

Ali stood. *"I like salty."*

٧٧
ع

"Good. Rahma?"

٧٧
ع

Rahma smiled — the specific small satisfied smile of a girl who had been, in her head, composing this exact sentence for forty seconds.

٧٧
ع

"I like sweet."

٧٧
ع

"Marwa?"

٧٧
ع

"I don't like sour."

٧٧
ع

"Excellent!"

٧٧
ع

And then — because **Safiya**'s slow walk had, without announcement, brought her to the back of the classroom — she looked up.

٧٧
ع

To the back seat.

٧٧
ع

To the quiet boy.

وَعَلَىٰ

"*And you...*" she said — gently, without fuss, in the specific gentle way she had been waiting for exactly this moment — "*what is your name?*"

وَعَلَىٰ

The quiet boy froze.

وَعَلَىٰ

The class turned. Slowly. Every small head. The specific slow collective turn of twelve children who had just registered, **simultaneously**, that something significant was about to happen.

وَعَلَىٰ

Thuraya looked surprised — and then, a fraction of a second later, looked *moved*. The specific small settling of a face as it understood what was happening.

وَعَلَىٰ

"*His name,*" she said, quietly, "*is Saeed.*"

وَعَلَىٰ

She said it the way **Safiya** herself might have said, in another life, *this is our son*. Not loudly. Just — with the specific warm **claim** of a teacher who was, at last, saying his name for the record.

وَعَلَىٰ

Saeed stood up.

وَعَلَىٰ

Slowly.

وَعَلَىٰ

The specific slow small standing-up of a boy who had never, in his life, had to stand up in a classroom before — who was, in fact, trying to *copy*, in his body, the standing-up he had seen **Ali** do thirty seconds earlier, the standing-up he had watched for weeks from his seat on the low wall outside.

وَعَلَىٰ

His voice was small.

وَعَلَىٰ

But clear.

وَعَلَىٰ

"*I...*" he said, "*I like sweet.*"

وَعَلَىٰ

The room went quiet for one second.

وَعَلَىٰ

One full second of the specific small silence that sometimes settles over a classroom when something ordinary has just happened in an extraordinary way. A boy had stood. He had spoken. In English. For the first time. The sentence itself was nothing — I like sweet, the kind of sentence any six-year-old could manage — but the saying of it, in that small careful voice, in that specific back-of-the-room posture, in this specific boy, was everything. Safiya, standing in the middle aisle, felt her throat tighten. She felt, somewhere behind her sternum, the specific small physical warmth that she had learned, over a teaching career that had been, until this moment, relatively ordinary, to recognise as the reason she had become a teacher in the first place.



Then **Safiya** smiled. Warmly. She said — with the specific full careful warmth she had been saving for exactly this answer — *"Very good, Saeed."*



Saeed sat down again. His heart — **Safiya** could see it from where she stood, in the small way his small shirt moved — was beating fast. The specific fast beat of a boy who had, in one sentence, crossed a threshold he had been watching from the other side for three years.



Mansoor whispered — the specific loud village-whisper that reached the whole room — *"He talk!"*



Khalil whispered back — with a small amazement that **Safiya** would, for the rest of her life, remember — *"He talk ENGLISH!"*

SCENE FIVE

The Window

Under the desk, **Malood** moved again.



Not his usual restless move. A different move. A small distressed shuffle. The specific shuffle of a small animal whose nose had detected something that his body, without consulting him, had decided to **react to**.



Suddenly, **John** felt something strange.



A small, specific, unfamiliar *presence* in the air. Not a smell exactly — or not yet. The first whisper of a smell. The faint **forerunner** of a smell. Something sharp, something red, something that had been, somewhere nearby, very recently **opened**.



"Why," **John** said, carefully — the specific slow careful investigation-voice he used when he suspected something — "*do I smell chili?*"

~

Safiya's eyes widened. The specific wide-eye of a wife who had, at the exact same moment, registered the same faint sharp chemical on her own tongue.

~

"Oh no."

~

She turned to the window.

~

Outside, in the school yard — through the small gap between the classroom wall and the low outer wall that marked the edge of the compound — another class was eating.

~

Lamb.

~

With chili.

~

Very red chili — the specific deep arterial red of Samaili chili that had been, the previous afternoon, dried in the sun, crushed by hand, mixed with oil, and was now, this very moment, being spread on pieces of warm lamb by small hands **Safiya** could not see but could — in her head — perfectly imagine.

~

And the smell was coming inside.

~

Slowly. Deliberately. In the specific way that capsaicin in warm oil travels — not straight, but **insinuating** itself into a room through any small opening available, and by the time a person had registered its presence the air was already full of it.

~

John's eyes started to water.

~

Not dramatically. Just the small involuntary water of tear ducts that had decided, without his permission, to begin defending themselves.

~

Mansoor smiled. The specific small amused smile of a boy who was having a good morning. "*Teacher... smell is spicy.*"

٢٧
ع

"Yes," **John** said — slowly, as though confirming a diagnosis — "*the smell is... spicy.*"

٢٨
ع

He was — **Safiya** could see — **committing** to the lesson. The specific commitment of a teacher who had just realised that the airborne chemical now invading his classroom was, in fact, pedagogical material.

٢٩
ع

Malood — who could not commit to the lesson, because he was a goat with a very sensitive nose — suddenly stood up. He walked, proudly, in the specific small businesslike walk of an animal who had decided that a situation required immediate management.

٣٠
ع

He walked to the door. He stopped.

٣١
ع

He sneezed.

٣٢
ع

Then coughed.

٣٣
ع

Then made a very sad sound — the specific small despairing bleat of a goat who had, in two consecutive days, been ambushed by chili in two different ways, and who was beginning to **suspect** that the universe had something specific against him.

٣٤
ع

Safiya rushed. "*Oh no, Malood!*"

٣٥
ع

The students laughed.

٣٦
ع

But then — something worse happened.

٣٧
ع

John — because **John** had not yet learned, and would require several more such moments before he *did* learn, that curiosity in this country had a specific tax — walked to the window.

٣٨
ع

He said, "*Let me see.*"

٣٩
ع

It was, **Safiya** would later reflect — *for many years* later, every time she told this story — a big mistake.

٤٠
ع

A wave of chili air hit his face.

~
~

Not a smell. A wave. The specific hot chemical wave of capsaicin-soaked air that had been, for the last forty seconds, pooling just outside the window, waiting for a foreigner to lean into it.

~
~

His eyes closed — involuntarily, the specific protective snap of eyelids that had, in all their prior English life, never encountered anything this **aggressive**.

~
~

His mouth opened.

~
~

He inhaled.

~
~

Then —

~
~

"AAAAAA!"

~
~

He jumped back. Both hands to his face. The specific backward-stumble of a tall Englishman whose entire **respiratory** system had just filed, simultaneously, several complaints.

~
~

"*My mouth*," he managed, "*is ON FIRE!*"

SCENE SIX

The News from Dhofar

Safiya rushed to help him. But then — as she reached him — she smelled it too. The specific small moment of wifely **solidarity** in chili.

~
~

"*Oh no—*"

~
~

She coughed.

~
~

Thuraya tried to be strong. She tried — she really tried — with the full professional discipline of an Omani teacher. But even she started to laugh and cough at the same time. The specific uncontrolled double-action of a woman whose village pride had finally met a situation her village pride could not contain.

٢٧
ع

The class exploded.

٢٨
ع

Mansoor laughed so much that he fell from his chair — actually fell, sideways, onto the packed-earth floor, where he lay laughing for a full eight seconds before **Ahmed** quietly helped him up.

٢٩
ع

Khalil held his stomach.

٣٠
ع

Ahmed tried to stay serious. He failed. The specific rare failure of **Ahmed**'s composure — the failure that happened, perhaps, once a month — **crumbled** his normal straight-ruler posture and produced, for a full ten seconds, a small wheezing laugh.

٣١
ع

Malood ran in a circle. Then — having re-evaluated his strategy — hid under the desk again.

٣٢
ع

John grabbed the water bottle. He drank. Not a sip. A long commitment of a drink — the specific emergency-hydration of a man attempting to **extinguish** his own mouth from the inside.

٣٣
ع

"It is..." he said, crying actual small tears, *"spicy air."*

٣٤
ع

Safiya — seeing, even through her own coughing, that a classroom had just produced the exact conditions for a perfect English lesson — stepped to the board. She wrote, fast, still laughing:

٣٥
ع

Hot

Burn

My mouth is burning!

٣٦
ع

She turned to the class. *"Repeat!"*

٣٧
ع

"My mouth is burning!"

٣٨
ع

John pointed at himself — the specific clear indicative point of a teacher using his own suffering as instructional material. *"My mouth is burning!"*

٣٩
ع

Mansoor shouted — because of course he did — *"TEACHER JOHN IS BURNING!"*

٤٠
ع

John looked at him. With the specific flat-faced gratitude of a man whose own student had just **correctly** used the present continuous.

٢١
ع

"Thank you, **Mansoor**. Very helpful."

٢١
ع

Then he looked back at the board. "Okay. New sentence."

٢١
ع

He wrote: *It is too spicy.*

٢١
ع

"Repeat."

٢١
ع

"*It is too spicy.*"

٢١
ع

"Good."

٢١
ع

He wiped his eyes. "*Today... we learn English. And we learn... not to open windows near chili.*"

٢١
ع

The class laughed again.

٢١
ع

Then **John** clapped his hands. "*Now. Past simple.*"

٢١
ع

He wrote: *Yesterday, I ate...*

٢١
ع

He pointed at **Mansoor**. "*Mansoor.*"

٢١
ع

Mansoor stood proudly. "*Yesterday, I eat lamb.*"

٢١
ع

John smiled. "*Say: I ate.*"

٢١
ع

"*Yesterday, I ate lamb.*"

٢١
ع

"*With chili!*"

٢١
ع

"*With chili*," the class added.

٢٧
ع

John pointed at **Malood**. "*Yesterday, Malood...*"

٢٨
ع

Khalil, quick — "*Yesterday, Malood ate paper.*"

٢٩
ع

Safiya laughed. "*Say: Malood ate paper.*"

٣٠
ع

"*Malood ate paper.*"

٣١
ع

Then **John** pointed to himself.

٣٢
ع

"*Yesterday, I...*"

٣٣
ع

He thought for a second. The specific small teacher's pause of a man realising that *yesterday he had done many things, but only one of them made a good sentence.*

٣٤
ع

"*...I opened the window.*"

٣٥
ع

Safiya added, quietly — "*And today, you learned a big lesson.*"

٣٦
ع

John nodded. The specific full accepting nod of a husband who had, once again, been summarised by his wife. "*Yes. Today, I learned a big lesson.*"

٣٧
ع

At the back of the class, a small hand went up.

٣٨
ع

Everyone turned.

٣٩
ع

Saced.

٤٠
ع

For the second time that morning.

٤١
ع

"Yes, Saeed?" **John** said, gently — the specific gentle teacher-voice he used when he understood that the next sentence out of a student's mouth was, for that student, historic.

~

"Yesterday..." **Saeed** said, slowly, carefully, "I ate... dates. Sweet."

~

John smiled. Warmly. The specific warm full smile of a teacher whose day had just, quietly, without announcement, become the best day of his teaching career.

~

"Excellent sentence."

~

Saeed sat down. His face was a little brighter. The specific small internal brightness of a boy who had, in the course of one English lesson, produced two complete sentences in a language he had, four days ago, never used.

~

Thuraya watched him quietly.

~

She did not speak. She did not clap. She did not, in any visible way, react. She only watched — the specific still watching of a teacher who was, at that exact moment, witnessing the small slow beginning of the reason she had entered her profession.

~

The fan kept turning.

~

Tak... tak... tak...

~

The heat stayed.

~

The lesson continued.

~

*At the end of the class, **John** wrote on the board — under the day's heading — the full accumulated vocabulary list. Taste. Sweet. Sour. Salty. Spicy. Hot. Burn. I like... I don't like... Yesterday, I ate... Ten items. The specific honest vocabulary of a morning that had produced every one of those words through lived experience rather than through a textbook. **Safiya** announced homework: "Write three sentences about what you like and what you don't like." **Mansoor** sighed, dramatically, as he always did — the specific theatrical sigh of a boy who had, over his school career, cultivated the small art of visible suffering at the assignment of any homework.*

٢٧
ع

Then — something changed.

٢٨
ع

From outside — from the small school office where **Abu Salim** the caretaker kept the one shared radio that served the whole school — a sound came. A sound that had not been present ten seconds earlier. It had been turned on. Someone had, in the office, decided it was time.

٢٩
ع

Low. Old. Serious.

٣٠
ع

A man's voice. In Arabic. The specific formal careful Arabic of state radio.

٣١
ع

*"...this is the latest news from **Dhofar**..."*

٣٢
ع

The class did not understand the words.

٣٣
ع

But they felt the tone.

٣٤
ع

It was not funny.

٣٥
ع

Not light.

٣٦
ع

Not like chili.

٣٧
ع

Safiya slowly looked at **John**.

٣٨
ع

John looked back at her.

٣٩
ع

For one moment, the classroom was quiet.

٤٠
ع

Even the fan — even *Tak... tak... tak...* — sounded smaller, somehow. As though the fan itself had recognised the shift in the air.

٤١
ع

Even **Malood** stopped moving.

٤٢
ع

*Oman was not only a place of funny stories. It was not only a village where Englishmen fell into falaj channels and were saffron-painted by well-meaning women and bitten by wasps and ambushed by chili-air. It was also a country — in that October, in that particular year — in the middle of a long quiet war, far to the south, that every family in the village had a relative in or a neighbour who was connected to. A war that had been, for eight years now, eating the country's young men. A war the radio spoke of each morning at this hour, always in the same level serious voice, always in the same careful official words. **Safiya** had not, until this moment, fully understood that the village knew. That every adult in that small compound around her had, this morning, already heard the earlier broadcast. That the children who would, eventually, run home to their mothers, would pass men on the road whose faces would be serious in the specific way that a piece of news made a face serious.*

و
ع

Oman was also a place of *big* stories.

و
ع

John closed his notebook. Slowly.

و
ع

"Okay," he said softly. "*Class is over.*"

و
ع

The children stood. The specific small orderly standing of children who had understood, without needing to be told, that the morning had shifted into something *else*.

و
ع

They collected their notebooks.

و
ع

They walked out.

و
ع

Quietly.

و
ع

Saeed, at the back, stood up too. He lifted his small bag. He did not hurry. He did not speak. But as he passed **Safiya** at the front of the room, he looked up at her — briefly, just the one look — and his eyes said, *thank you*.

و
ع

He walked out into the hot late-morning yard. Where the other class was, by now, finishing its lamb and chili. Where the radio, from the office, was still speaking quietly in its level serious voice about a war that was, for all of them, the specific heavy shadow that sat at the edge of every ordinary day.

 Did You Know?

Dhofar in Modern Omani History

Remember the serious Dhofar news that suddenly ended class? Dhofar governorate, home to Salalah, was the setting of the Dhofar Rebellion (1965-1975), a military campaign fought by the Sultan's forces against insurgents backed by communist South Yemen — a pivotal event in unifying modern Oman. Dhofar itself was historically famous as a major source of frankincense, once exported as far as China.

Source: en.wikipedia.org · en.wikipedia.org

PALM

Palm Nineteen

The Zanzibari Trader and the Saffron Mask

SCENE ONE

An Honest Morning

The sky was still sleepy when **Aunt Azizah**'s rooster shouted his opinion to the whole village.

~

*It was the specific opinion that he shouted every morning — a long, declarative, **unapologetic** announcement that the night was over, that the neighbours should get up, that the world was not going to wait for them to be **ready**. There was no negotiation in this rooster's voice. There was no suggestion. There was only the old village certainty that morning had come and anyone still asleep was behind schedule.*

~

John opened his eyes slowly — as if the morning itself had pushed a heavy door on his face.

~

He listened for a second. He was still, even after weeks of this, listening on the old English frequency — listening for the quiet polite mornings of a Norwich suburb, for the distant soft whirr of an early milk van, for the absent sound of birds that had been, in his English childhood, the only thing you heard before eight.

~

But Samail did not do polite mornings.

~

Samail did *honest* mornings.

~

Outside, the specific dense sound-layer of a village already awake — the rooster, of course, and a small urgent **clang** of metal pans being arranged on a hearth, and — underneath it all — the specific soft *tssss* of something beginning to fry in oil.

~

Then — the smell.

~

Fresh bread. The specific warm yeast-and-smoke smell of khubz being made, three courtyards away, on a hot metal pan over small coals — the bread whose smell, in any Omani village, functioned as a kind of village **alarm-clock** — soft, warm, impossible to ignore, making every person within smelling-distance remember, at exactly the same moment, that they were hungry.

~

Safiya sat up. She fixed her scarf. She smiled quietly — the specific dreamy morning-smile of a woman whose first sensation of the day had been a good one.

~

"Something," she whispered, "smells amazing."

~

John sniffed the air. *"I think your neighbour is making breakfast for the entire planet."*

~

Thuraya knocked on the wooden door frame and walked in — without waiting — because in the seventies, in villages, people did not knock on doors the way they knocked on doors of museums. They knocked the way a friend knocks: as a **courtesy**, not as a request.

~

"Good morning," she said, brightly. "Are you ready?"

~

John looked around their simple home. The walls were plain — clay, unpainted, warm in tone. Their bags were still half-open. A corner of **Safiya's** dress hung from a single nail — as though the house itself were trying to help them unpack, by offering, free of charge, all the small hooks and nails it had been collecting for the last forty years.

~

"I'm ready," he said — pretending, unconvincingly, that he was not nervous. "Where are we going again?"

~

Thuraya's eyes sparkled. *"Muscat. **Muttrab Souq**."*

~

Safiya's mouth opened. *"A real souq?"*

~

*"A real souq," **Thuraya** confirmed.*

~

John rubbed his hands. The specific small professional hand-rub of a teacher preparing to turn a day out into classroom material. *"Okay. New vocabulary. New adventure."*

SCENE TWO

The Pickup and the Mountains

Behind **Thuraya**, something tiny and **determined** slipped through the doorway like a thief with hooves.

~

Malood.

~

He walked in as if the house belonged to him. He sniffed **John**'s shoe. He considered the shoe. He decided the shoe was not interesting. He aimed — directly, without any further investigation — for **Safiya**'s cloth bag.

~

"No," **Safiya** said. Gently. Pulling her bag up out of his reach. "*Not today.*"

~

Malood stared at her — as though he had understood the word *today* and was, internally, calculating whether this specific morning made him a genuine exception to the rule — and then tried again.

~

John pointed at him. The specific strict teacher-point of a man who had, by now, had enough personal experience with **Malood** to know that strictness was his only available defence.

~

"*Malood. You are not invited.*"

~

Malood's ears flicked. He was clearly offended.

~

Thuraya laughed. "*He is coming from the neighbour's yard every morning. He thinks you are his family now.*"

~

Safiya sighed — the specific small sighing of a woman who had, at some point, given up on the question of whether **Malood** was or was not their goat. "*He is too confident.*"

~

Thuraya clapped her hands once — business mode. "*Come. Uncle Nasser is waiting.*"

~

Outside, the pickup truck waited — like a strong old animal. It was one of those boxy, tough, slightly-battered pickup models of that period — dusty, proud, the specific Japanese pickup that had,

Safiya was coming to understand, become the workhorse of every interior Omani village in the years since the roads had begun.



Uncle Nasser sat behind the steering wheel. The specific calm face of a man who had driven, in his life, on roads that were sometimes *roads* and sometimes — when the **wadi** had decided otherwise — only *hopes*.



In the back of the truck there was a wooden bench and a rope tied neatly, ready for passengers to hold. **Uncle Nasser** did not say much. He did not need to. His bamboo stick — the long thin **driver-stick** that rested beside him — was, in its way, an extra seat.



John climbed into the back first — trying to look confident. The pickup moved, just a little, under his weight. He grabbed the side. Fast.



Safiya climbed in more carefully — holding her scarf, laughing at **John's** earlier panic, settling onto the bench with the specific careful movement of a woman whose Omani clothes were not yet fully natural to her body.



Thuraya jumped in — as though she had done this, literally, a thousand times. Which, **Safiya** realised, she almost certainly had.



"Hold tight," **Thuraya** said. *"And don't scream. Like Mansoor."*



John blinked. *"Mansoor screams?"*



Thuraya smiled. *"Mansoor screams when the wind touches him."*



The pickup rolled forward — a slow, heavy, accepting start — and the village opened behind them like a storybook. Palm shadows. Small paths. A woman at a doorway lifting her water pot. Two goats watching them from the top of a low wall, with the specific assessing gaze of village security.



Then the land began to change.



Mountains appeared.



Not polite hills. Not the gentle slopes of southern England. Not the green rolling kindnesses that Safiya's English geography books had prepared her for. Real mountains. Tall and bold, rising like giant brown walls around them. The specific layered brown-on-brown stone of the Hajar range — the range that had, for tens of millions of years, been slowly pushed up out of the ancient sea floor by the collision of tectonic plates, the range that carried, in its specific red-brown colour, the literal fossils of the ocean that Oman had once been. They rose from the plain not at a gentle angle, but at cliff. They rose like they had been, a long time ago, extremely angry — and had frozen, mid-rage, into stone.

~

John leaned forward. His eyes wide.

~

"Safiya. Look."

~

Safiya stared.

~

"John. I've never seen mountains like this."

~

Thuraya glanced at them both. She smiled — the specific small patient smile of an Omani woman who had just seen two English faces undergo the specific small overwhelm that all visitors' faces underwent on their first sighting of the Hajar.

~

"You don't have mountains in Britain?"

~

"We have..." **John** admitted — carefully, because he did not want to betray his own homeland *too* obviously — *"small ones."*

~

He paused. He was thinking of Snowdon, which he had climbed once as a student. He was thinking of the Scottish Highlands, which he had seen in photographs. He was comparing them, honestly, in his head, to the silent brown giants currently sliding past the side of the pickup.

~

"But these," he said, *"these look like they belong in a movie."*

~

Safiya whispered — almost reverently, almost against her will — *"They look **ancient**."*

SCENE THREE

The First Glimpse of the Sea

As the road continued, the air changed.



It became salty. The specific unmistakable **maritime** salt that had been, since **Safiya** was a child in an English coastal town, the specific smell she most associated with *freedom*. A different kind of wind than the inland wind of Samail. A different smell.



Cooler. More — in some specific way she could not yet name — *mobile*.



Safiya lifted her chin. As though she could *taste* it.



"*Sea*," she said.



John's eyes lit up. The specific boyish lighting-up of a man whose heart had, at the moment of scenting salt, become ten years younger.



"*The sea!*"



Thuraya nodded. "*We are close to Muttrah now.*"



When the first glimpse of the water appeared — between two low bluffs, in a sudden small **gap** between the coastal hills — **Safiya** made a small sound. The small sound that a person makes when they have been, without quite realising it, holding their breath, and the sight that releases the breath is a sight they did not expect.



The sea stretched wide.



Shining.



The specific shining of the Gulf of Oman at mid-morning, in late October, in 1973 — before the age of plastic, before the age of oil spills, before the age of the mass tourism that would, in decades to come, change the specific clarity of the water. The sea she was looking at had been looking exactly like this for, perhaps, two thousand years. It was the same sea that Sinbad's Arabs had sailed. The same sea the Portuguese had arrived on in the sixteenth century. The same sea that Ibn Battuta had crossed. The same sea whose trade winds had, for more than a thousand years, carried wooden dhows between Muscat and Mombasa and Bombay and Basra and Aden and back. The same sea.



Boats and ships rested in the distance. Small white fishing launches. A few **dhow**s, further out, with their specific lateen sails gathered at the mast. A larger cargo ship, far on the horizon, with the specific dark **silhouette** of a post-war freighter waiting for its turn at the Muttrah port.



The harbour was busy — *alive* — like a giant classroom in which everyone was doing a different job at the same time, and each job was, somehow, necessary to every other job.



John pointed. His face had the specific delighted face of an Englishman who had grown up on Kipling and had finally — in real life, with real eyes — found himself at one of Kipling's **specific places**.



"Ships!"



Thuraya smiled. *"Yes. And today, you will learn words you cannot learn in a classroom."*



Safiya opened her notebook. The specific small quick opening of a woman who had decided that this day was going to be worth documenting. *"I'm ready."*



The pickup stopped near the harbour. They climbed down.



John's legs felt strange. The specific **phantom** motion of a body that had been, for forty minutes, absorbing the vibrations of an Omani road surface, and whose nervous system had not yet updated itself to the fact that it was now standing on solid ground.



Uncle Nasser said — quietly, without drama — *"Stay close."*



Then he added, even more quietly, *"And no trouble."*



John nodded quickly. *"No trouble."*



Thuraya raised one eyebrow. The specific amused Omani eyebrow of a woman who had just heard a foreigner say a sentence that the country was, in her experience, likely to make impossible.



"That sentence," she said, *"is dangerous in Oman."*

SCENE FOUR

The Zanzibari Trader

They walked toward the souq area. But first — before they reached the main entrance — they passed a small loose group of sellers near the port.

~

Some had baskets. Some had cloths laid on the ground, with items arranged, carefully, in small rows.

~

And then they saw him.

~

A simple **Zanzibari** trader — sitting, cross-legged, beside a wooden box that looked like it had travelled, in its small wooden life, more than any passport in **John's** England had ever travelled. His skin was sun-browned. His clothes were plain — a simple cotton shirt, loose trousers, a small cap. His smile was the specific sharp smile of a man who *knew* a joke that the world had, so far, not heard.

~

In front of him, arranged on a small cotton cloth, were the specific small items that a Zanzibari trader sold at the edge of the harbour in 1973 — small beads, tiny perfume bottles with cork stoppers, a small mirror in a beaten-metal frame, and a few shiny silver-coloured objects whose purpose was not, at first glance, obvious.

~

Safiya slowed down. *"Oh... look."*

~

John leaned in. *"What is he selling?"*

~

Thuraya whispered — with the specific small warning-whisper of an Omani woman trying to protect two foreign friends from a trader she had recognised, from six paces, as a professional — *"Many things. But be careful. Some sellers in Muttrah have strong... talking skills."*

~

The trader looked up. His eyes landed on **John** and **Safiya** the way a fisherman's eyes land on two fish who have just, without quite knowing it, entered his net.

~

He smiled. A broad, welcoming, entirely **commercial** smile.

~

"Welcome, welcome! Come! Look! Very good things!"

~

John froze. He heard English. Not perfect English. But clear enough. Good enough for *negotiation*.

~
~

Safiya smiled politely. *"Hello."*

~
~

The trader nodded — proudly — the specific proud nod of a man who had, over a trading career, collected the small useful English phrases of every kind of European customer who had ever passed his cloth.

~
~

"Hello! Hello! You want? I have nice things. Small price. Big happiness."

~
~

John laughed softly. *"Big happiness? That sounds good."*

~
~

The trader tapped the wooden box — with *love*, with the specific small affectionate tap of a man who considered his box a character in the negotiation.

~
~

"This box? Magic box. It has... everything."

~
~

Thuraya tried not to smile. *"Magic?"*

~
~

The trader leaned forward. Dramatically. The specific small leaning-in of a professional storyteller about to deliver the critical line. *"Yes. Magic."*

~
~

Safiya whispered to **John** — quietly, with a small delight — *"He is a storyteller."*

~
~

John, being **John**, decided — the specific **irrepressible** decision of a man who could not, under any circumstances, stop being an English teacher — that this was a *learning moment*.

~
~

He cleared his throat. Teacher voice. He turned to **Safiya** and **Thuraya**.

~
~

"Okay. Vocabulary."

~
~

Then he turned back to the trader, with a friendly smile. *"What do you sell?"*

~
~

The trader's eyes shone — the specific shining of a trader who had just realised that his customer was going to buy him a whole conversation before buying anything else. *"I sell... things. Good things."*

☪

John nodded. *"How much?"*

☪

The trader blinked. Then smiled wider. The specific pleased widening of a man whose customer had just, by using the right second sentence, identified himself as somebody who was not a complete amateur. *"Ah. You know. You learn fast."*

☪

Safiya's eyes were bright. *"John. Ask him the names."*

☪

John pointed to a string of beads. *"What is this?"*

☪

The trader answered — quickly, with the specific small pride of a man naming his own merchandise — *"Beads."*

☪

"Good. And this?"

☪

John pointed to a tiny bottle.

☪

"Perfume," the trader said. *"Very strong. One drop, you smell like... rich person."*

☪

Safiya giggled. *"One drop?"*

☪

The trader nodded. Very seriously — the specific small deadpan seriousness of a professional salesman about to deliver his best line. *"One drop. Two drops, you become problem."*

☪

Thuraya's shoulders shook with laughter.

SCENE FIVE

The Ship Key

John pointed to a small silver object — a short, shiny, vaguely key-shaped thing with a worked handle at one end.

☪

"And this?"

☺

The trader hesitated. The specific small hesitation of a man who had, until this exact question, not yet decided what this particular object was going to be.

☺

Then he said — confidently, the specific sudden full confidence of a man who had, in the space of a quarter-second, made an entirely new decision about an object's identity —

☺

"A... ship key."

☺

John blinked. *"A ship key?"*

☺

Safiya leaned in. The specific small leaning-in of a woman who was, entirely against her better judgement, **charmed**. *"A key for a ship?"*

☺

The trader nodded — the specific full confident nod of a man who had decided that *yes, of course, the ship key, everybody knows the ship key. "Yes yes. For ship. You open ship."*

☺

Thuraya turned away. Laughing, audibly now, into her scarf — the specific helpless scarf-laughter of a woman who had, for the last thirty seconds, been trying to preserve the dignity of her country in front of her English friends and was now, finally, giving up.

☺

John looked at her. *"Is that real?"*

☺

Thuraya tried to be serious. She failed. But she managed to speak.

☺

"No, Mr. John. That is not real."

☺

The trader — sensing, with the specific professional radar of a trader who had been selling things for thirty years, that danger had entered the negotiation — jumped in quickly.

☺

"Okay okay! Not ship key. It is... decoration!"

☺

John laughed. *"Abh. Decoration. Good."*

۞

Safiya whispered to **Thuraya**, with the specific delighted small whisper of a woman who had just understood something important — *"He is trying to sell a story. Not an object."*

۞

Thuraya nodded. The specific settled nod of a woman confirming a village truth she had known all her life. *"Yes. That is Muttrah."*

۞

John looked at the trader. He decided — teacher-mode still fully engaged — to *teach*. Politely.

۞

"In English," he said, carefully, *"we say... 'I want.'"*

۞

The trader's eyes widened. He repeated the sentence — with the specific small pleasure of a man adding a new tool to his negotiation-toolkit. *"I want."*

۞

John smiled. *"Good. 'I want beads.'"*

۞

The trader repeated, *"I want beads."*

۞

Safiya laughed. *"He sounds like the customer now."*

۞

The trader — without warning, as though a button had been pressed somewhere deep inside him — pointed suddenly at **John**.

۞

"You! You want beads!"

۞

John laughed. *"No. Not me."*

۞

The trader pointed at **Safiya**.

۞

"You want perfume!"

۞

Safiya shook her head, quickly. *"No. Thank you."*

۞

The trader held the perfume bottle up — like an award he was presenting to a champion. *"One drop, you smell like QUEEN!"*

و

Thuraya cleared her throat. Stepping in. With the specific diplomatic firmness of an Omani woman intervening on behalf of her guests.

و

"We are going to the souq. Thank you."

و

But the trader leaned forward. *Determined* now. The specific determined lean of a man who had, in his head, not yet given up on the sale.

و

"Wait! Wait! Gift. Small gift."

و

He opened the wooden box. He reached inside — with the specific small theatrical reach of a man producing a rabbit from a hat — and pulled out the small mirror with its beaten-metal frame.

و

He offered it to **Safiya**.

و

Safiya hesitated. Her polite English heart wanted, genuinely, to accept — a gift, freely offered, was not a thing she wanted to refuse. Her slightly smarter English brain, however, was *screaming*, somewhere at the back of her skull, the specific loud warning *DON'T ACCEPT GIFTS FROM STRANGERS*.

و

John tried to help. *"No. It's okay. Thank you."*

و

The trader pushed the mirror gently closer. *"Free. Welcome gift."*

و

Safiya — finally — took it. Carefully. *"Thank you."*

و

The trader smiled. Like he had just *won*.

و

Then he pointed at **John**.

و

"Now you buy."

☪
☪

John froze.

☪
☪

"...What?"

☪
☪

Thuraya's eyes danced — the specific small dancing of a woman whose country had, once again, delivered exactly the lesson she had been waiting for it to deliver.

☪
☪

"Welcome," she said, "to *Muttrah*."

☪
☪

John turned to **Safiya**. "*Safiya!*" — the specific betrayed tone of a husband whose wife had just walked them both into a small commercial trap.

☪
☪

Safiya held up the mirror. Sheepishly. "*I thought it was kindness.*"

☪
☪

The trader nodded proudly. "*Yes. Kindness business.*"

SCENE SIX

I Don't Want To Buy

John sighed.

☪
☪

The specific full sigh of a man who had, six minutes earlier, approached a small Zanzibari trader for a language lesson and had now — to his own **chagrin** — been manoeuvred into a small **obligatory** purchase.

☪
☪

He decided — because **John** was **John**, and because there was always, for **John**, another learning moment available — that this moment, too, was going to be turned into one.

☪
☪

He faced the trader. He spoke slowly. Clearly. With the specific measured diplomacy of a man who had decided to use the exact sentence *as a sentence*.

☪
☪

"*I don't want to buy.*"

☪
☪

The trader frowned. "*You don't want to... buy?*"

٢٧
ع

John repeated — with the same measured **deliberateness** —

٢٨
ع

"I don't want to buy."

٢٩
ع

Thuraya whispered to **Safiya**, with the specific small educational whisper of an Omani friend —
"Good sentence."

٣٠
ع

Safiya whispered back, with the specific grateful full approval of a wife — *"Very good sentence."*

٣١
ع

The trader stared at **John**. For one full second. Then — smiling, suddenly, with the specific professional-respect smile of a trader who had just lost a specific small negotiation and was, in his mind, already moving on to the next customer —

٣٢
ع

"Okay okay. You don't want to buy. But you can... look."

٣٣
ع

John exhaled. *"Yes. Look."*

٣٤
ع

They started walking away — toward the souq — but **John** could not stop thinking about one thing.

٣٥
ع

He turned to **Thuraya**. Voice low.

٣٦
ع

"Was that... a trick?"

٣٧
ع

Thuraya smiled. Sweetly. The specific small sweet *Thuraya* smile, the smile that **John** had, in his notebook, been warned about.

٣٨
ع

"It is not a trick. It is... a lesson."

٣٩
ع

Safiya scribbled in her notebook — fast, still walking, her pen moving in the specific rapid diagonal of a woman trying to capture ten new words before they escaped.

٤٠
ع

New words:

mountain, sea, ship, port, seller, beads, perfume, gift, mirror, price.

٢٧
ع

John looked at the entrance of the souq ahead. The narrow lanes. The shadows. The sounds — the overlapping shouts of traders, the specific rhythm of bargaining in three different languages, the high-pitched calls of porters moving through crowds with trays on their heads. The smells — spices and incense and old leather and something fried he could not identify. The voices.

٢٧
ع

He swallowed.

٢٧
ع

"I think," he said, quietly, "this place is going to teach me English again."

٢٧
ع

Thuraya nodded. *"And patience."*

٢٧
ع

Safiya smiled. *"And survival."*

٢٧
ع

Uncle Nasser called from behind them — the specific efficient single word of a driver who had already identified the next phase of the outing and intended to move them into it — *"Yalla!"*

٢٧
ع

John squared his shoulders. *"Okay. Next task."*

٢٧
ع

Safiya teased — quietly, with the specific warm teasing of a wife who had just recognised her husband slipping back into his professional vocabulary — *"Task-Based Learning... in real life."*

٢٧
ع

Thuraya smiled. *"Exactly."*

٢٧
ع

They stepped closer to the souq. Behind them, the trader — who had already, in the specific quick way of all successful salespeople, reset his face and his small cotton cloth for the next customer — waved happily. As if nothing had happened.

٢٧
ع

"Welcome! Welcome! Big happiness!"

٢٧
ع

John muttered under his breath, *"Small price. Big trouble."*

٢٧
ع

Thuraya heard. Laughed.

٢٧
ع

And just before they entered the first narrow lane of Muttrah Souq — just before the specific dark-cool shadow of the covered arcade swallowed them, just before the full **sensory** ambush of the souq began — **John** heard, somewhere in the crowd ahead of them, a familiar voice.

٢٨
ع

Loud. Confident. Entirely, unmistakably — *Sadoo*.

٢٩
ع

John stopped walking.

٣٠
ع

Thuraya's smile slowly widened. The specific slow widening of a smile that had, at the sound of that voice, fully recognised the morning's next trouble.

٣١
ع

"Oh no."

٣٢
ع

Safiya blinked. *"What?"*

٣٣
ع

Thuraya pointed toward the sound — toward the overlapping crowd, toward the small dark opening of the main souq lane.

٣٤
ع

"That voice... is going to start our next problem."

٣٥
ع

John whispered, with the specific small pleading whisper of a man hoping — against all village evidence — that the sentence he was about to hear was not going to be the sentence he was afraid of — *"Please tell me Sadoo is not here."*

٣٦
ع

Thuraya whispered back. Almost **lovingly**.

٣٧
ع

"Sadoo is everywhere."

٣٨
ع

And the three of them — **Safiya** with her notebook already open, **John** with his shoulders squared, **Thuraya** with her specific small prepared-for-anything smile — walked into the souq...

٣٩
ع

Right toward the trouble.



Did You Know?

Oman-Zanzibar Trade History

Remember the Zanzibari trader John and Sophia met at Muttrah port? That meeting isn't fictional at all — Oman genuinely ruled Zanzibar for decades. In 1832 (or 1840), Sultan Said bin Sultan moved his capital from Muscat to Zanzibar, and spice and ivory trade routes flourished between the two coasts until the sultanates split after his death in 1856.

Source: en.wikipedia.org · [britannica.com](https://www.britannica.com)

PALM

Palm Twenty

Of Goats and Grammar

SCENE ONE

Everything, All At Once

The first thing that entered **John's** nose inside Muttrah Souq was... everything.



*It was not a smell. It was a census of smells. Spices — cardamom warming in the small open sacks, cumin catching in the late-morning light like small brown pollen, the peppery sharpness of turmeric, the dark sweet resin of frankincense that had been, for three thousand years, carried out of these same streets on wooden ships bound for every port the sea could reach. Fish — the **unapologetic** salt-and-scale of fresh fish resting on beds of ice at the back of the dark covered walkways, mixed with the faint dried-fish smell that hung, permanently, to certain wooden stalls that had been selling fish for six generations. Incense — oud smoke curling from small braziers outside shops, burning slowly, inviting customers. Leather — the specific warm animal smell of a tanner's stall where sandals hung from wooden pegs. Old wood — the ancient cedar beams of the covered arcade, darkened by decades of passing hands. Perfume — attars and musks and amber, layered and competing. And something fried — whose name **John** did not know and whose smell, somewhere between garlic and onion and hot oil, made him, against his will, slightly hungry.*



The second thing that entered his ears was *noise*.



Not the noise of Samail. Not the layered gentle hush of a village. This was the specific dense, **layered**, mercantile noise of a port city that had been trading with the world since the time of the Portuguese.



Voices calling — in Arabic, in Swahili, in Baluchi, in Hindi, in broken English. People bargaining — the specific rhythmic up-and-down of numbers being thrown back and forth, of feigned outrage, of slow reconsideration. Metal sounds — copper pots being tapped, a brass scale clinking, a blacksmith at the far end of a lane hammering the specific slow even beat of a man who had been, that morning, making the same type of nail he had been making on this same anvil for twenty years.

Footsteps. Donkeys somewhere behind them. And, **somewhere** in the middle of all that — rising above the rest, the way a single instrument rises from an orchestra —

٢٧
ع

Sadoo.

٢٨
ع

His voice, unmistakable, full-throated, addressed to someone named Salim across a narrow lane:

٢٩
ع

يا سالم يا سالم! اليوم تجارتنا نار! نار!

٣٠
ع

(O Salim! O Salim! Today our business is fire! Fire!)

٣١
ع

John stopped walking.

٣٢
ع

He stopped the way a man stops when he hears, unexpectedly, a voice he had, only an hour earlier, hoped to avoid. The specific small frozen stop of a traveller who had been warned about something, and who had just realised that the warning was, at this exact moment, becoming true.

٣٣
ع

Safiya bumped into his back. *"Why did you stop?"*

٣٤
ع

John pointed slowly — the specific slow measured point of someone pointing at a wild animal in a zoo. *"That... voice."*

٣٥
ع

Thuraya closed her eyes for one second. Just one. The specific small eye-closing of a woman **gathering** herself for the next hour of her life.

٣٦
ع

"Yes. That is Sadoo."

٣٧
ع

Safiya blinked. *"Your Sadoo?"*

٣٨
ع

"Our Sadoo," **Thuraya** corrected — quietly, with the specific small village **claim** of a woman who had, long ago, accepted that certain people were no longer individual property but *village* property.

SCENE TWO

The Happy Storm

They moved carefully through the narrow path — weaving past porters carrying trays of dates on their heads, past small clusters of Indian traders in white shirts, past a tall Baluchi man with a coiled rope over his shoulder — until they saw him.

﴿

Sadoo stood in front of a small shop.

﴿

Wearing his usual clothes — the same slightly-dusty dishdasha he had worn up a palm tree, the same small cap, the same sandals — and talking with his hands, his feet, and, **Safiya** would have sworn, probably his eyebrows too. Around him were bags. Boxes. Ropes. And a very **confused** man holding a basket.

﴿

Sadoo saw them.

﴿

His face became a *celebration*.

﴿

The specific sudden full face-celebration of a village man who had, only seconds earlier, been performing commerce at full volume, and had now been handed, free of charge, three of his favourite people in the middle of a city where he had not expected to see them.

﴿

هاااااه! الأستاذ جون! صفيه! مس ثريا! وينكم من زمان

﴿

(Haaaah! Teacher John! Safiya! Miss Thuraya! Where have you been all this time!)

﴿

He rushed toward them — like a happy storm, the specific barrelling small-man-at-full-speed movement of a Samaili shopkeeper who had decided that the reunion required immediate physical contact.

﴿

John smiled. Carefully. The specific careful smile of a man who had, minutes earlier, been hoping that Sadoo was not in this city, and who was now committing to being polite about having been wrong.

﴿

"Hello, Sadoo."

﴿

Sadoo shook his hand. Strongly. With the specific full-forearm handshake of a man who considered weak handshakes a small moral failing. Then he shook **Safiya**'s hand. Equally strongly. Then he tried to shake **Thuraya**'s hand.

ﷲ

Thuraya stepped back. Quickly. The specific practised village step-back of an Omani woman who had, on principle, not been shaking men's hands since she was fifteen, and who had, over her teaching career, developed the reflex to a small art.

ﷲ

She asked, dryly — in her clear Samaili Arabic —

ﷲ

سادو، وبش تسوي هنا؟

ﷲ

(Sadoo, what are you doing here?)

ﷲ

Sadoo puffed his chest. The specific small full puffing of a man whose entire public **dignity** was about to be expressed through a single sentence.

ﷲ

أنا؟ أنا تاجر كبير تو! جيت أشتري أغراض للدكان. مطرح! كله خير

ﷲ

(Me? I am a big trader now! I came to buy goods for the shop. Muttrab! All is well!)

ﷲ

Safiya looked around at the small hill of bags and boxes beside him.

ﷲ

"You have... many bags."

ﷲ

Sadoo nodded. Proudly.

ﷲ

كلها لي!

ﷲ

(All of them are mine!)

ﷲ

John looked at one of the bags.

ﷲ

It moved.

ﷲ

He froze.

ﷲ

The specific full frozen stop of a man whose eye had just registered a piece of movement that his brain was not ready, at ten in the morning, in a new country, to **process**.

٢٧
ع

"...*Why is your bag moving?*"

٢٨
ع

Sadoo looked. He looked down at the bag with the specific mild surprise of a man who had, until that moment, forgotten it was a bag that moved.

٢٩
ع

آه. هذا؟ سمك.

٣٠
ع

(*Ab. This? Fish.*)

٣١
ع

John stepped back. "*Alive fish?*"

٣٢
ع

Sadoo nodded. Placidly.

٣٣
ع

طازج.

٣٤
ع

(*Fresh.*)

٣٥
ع

John whispered to **Safiya** — with the specific small desperate English whisper of a man whose cultural reserves had, that morning, finally run out — "*I am not ready for this country.*"

SCENE THREE

The Bargaining

Before **Thuraya** could control the situation — and she had, **Safiya** noted, already opened her mouth to try — **Sadoo** grabbed **John**'s arm. With the specific proprietary village-grip of a man who had decided that he was now, for the next fifteen minutes, **John**'s personal business partner.

٣٦
ع

تعال تعال! هذا محل زين

٣٧
ع

(*Come, come! This is a good shop!*)

٣٨
ع

He pulled **John** toward a shop. The specific pulling of a man who was not, under any circumstance, going to accept no for an answer.

The shop was full of metal things.

*Copper pots — stacked in small towers, each one hand-hammered, each one bearing, on its base, the specific small maker's mark of a coppersmith somewhere in the interior. Plates — thick brass plates of the kind that were traditionally given as wedding gifts, that a bride would receive and keep in her kitchen for sixty years. Trays. Round trays, rectangular trays, the small circular **sinyab** on which communal meals were served. Everything arranged with the specific careful stacking of a shopkeeper who knew, exactly, where every piece was, and who would be privately offended if a customer picked something up and did not put it back correctly.*

In the middle stood a man with crossed arms and a very serious face.

Sadoo pointed proudly.

هذا صديقي. بيعطينا سعر خاص.

(This is my friend. He will give us a special price.)

The man looked at **John**. Then at **Safiya**. Then at **Thuraya**. Then back at **Sadoo**. His face, throughout all four inspections, **remained** a single consistent expression of Muttrah **neutrality**.

He said something. Fast. In Arabic.

Sadoo answered. Faster.

They started talking. Loudly. With hands — the specific full Arabic hand-talk of a bargaining negotiation, in which the palms opened, closed, indicated prices, indicated rejection, indicated final offers, indicated small modifications. A whole second-language running simultaneously alongside the words.

John turned to **Thuraya**. *"What is happening?"*

Thuraya sighed. The specific long sigh of a woman who had, many times, watched exactly this conversation. *"Sadoo is bargaining."*

٢٧
ع

Safiya whispered, leaning toward **John**, "*It looks like a fight.*"

٢٨
ع

"*It is a kind of fight,*" **Thuraya** whispered back. "*Both sides enjoy it.*"

٢٩
ع

Sadoo, without warning, turned to **John**.

٣٠
ع

جون! قول له! قول له

٣١
ع

(*John! Tell him! Tell him!*)

٣٢
ع

John blinked. "*Say... what?*"

٣٣
ع

Sadoo pushed a big metal tray toward him — the specific wide sinyah that, in a Samaili home, would have held rice for six people. He pushed it the way a lawyer pushes evidence toward a jury.

٣٤
ع

قول له:

٣٥
ع

"*I want this. But cheap.*"

٣٦
ع

John cleared his throat. Teacher mode. He looked at the seller.

٣٧
ع

"*I want this,*" he said, carefully, pointing. "*But... cheap.*"

٣٨
ع

The seller's eyebrow went up. Slowly. The specific slow deliberate eyebrow-raise of a professional merchant who had, in thirty years of selling trays in Muttrah, never once been asked to make something *cheap* by a customer who had not, first, worked their way through at least four ritual opening moves of refusal and amusement.

٣٩
ع

He answered — in fast Arabic.

٤٠
ع

Thuraya translated. "*He says: 'This is not cheap.'*"

٤١
ع

John nodded, seriously. "*Okay. This is not cheap.*"

﴿

Sadoo slapped his forehead. Hard. With the specific full-palm forehead-slap of a man whose carefully-prepared negotiation had, in one sentence, been **demolished**.

﴿

لا لا! مو كذا! لازم تقول:

﴿

"I don't want. Too expensive!"

﴿

John tried again. Obediently. *"I don't want. Too expensive."*

﴿

The seller crossed his arms. Tighter.

﴿

He answered again.

﴿

Thuraya translated — with the specific small amused-translator tone of a woman who was enjoying this a great deal. *"Now he says: 'Then don't buy.'"*

﴿

Sadoo stared at **John**.

﴿

Like **John** had just, with one English sentence, broken the entire world.

﴿

يا رجل! خربتھا!

﴿

(Man! You ruined it!)

SCENE FOUR

Sometimes English Is Magic

Safiya tried not to laugh. She tried — the specific doomed effort of a wife whose laugh was already, somewhere deep in her chest, in the process of escaping.

﴿

John defended himself. *"I said exactly what you told me."*

﴿

Sadoo waved his hands. The specific full hand-wave of a man whose pupil had, in the critical moment, misused the lesson.

بئس ما كذا!

(But not like that!)

The seller suddenly picked up the tray. He put it inside the shop. He turned his back.

The specific three-part surgical retreat of a Muttrah shopkeeper who had decided that this particular transaction was over.

Sadoo gasped.

راح!

(He's gone!)

He turned, desperately, to **Thuraya**.

مس ثريا! قولي له شي

(Miss Thuraya! Say something to him!)

Thuraya crossed her arms. The specific calm crossed-arms of a woman who had, at this exact moment, decided to let **Sadoo** experience the specific consequences of his own commerce.

"You started this."

Sadoo looked around. Panicking. Then he saw **Safiya**.

The specific lit-up face of a man who had, in his desperation, just identified his remaining asset.

صفية! انت طيبة. قولي له شي

(Safiya! You are kind. Say something to him.)

Safiya panicked. The specific small wifely panic of a woman who had just been promoted, without consultation, into a diplomatic role.

"Me? I don't know Arabic!"

Sadoo smiled. The specific instant-recovery smile of a man who had, two seconds ago, been desperate and who had just, in the space of one thought, identified a new strategy.

قولي بالإنجليزي!

(Tell him in English!)

Safiya looked at the seller's back. She took a breath. She tried — with the specific small careful attempt of a woman who had decided to produce a polite English sentence and hope that politeness, as a quality, translated.

"Excuse me... we are... just looking."

The seller turned. Slowly.

He looked at her. The specific slow evaluation of a professional whose ears had just caught the specific respectful register of an English customer not attempting to insult him.

Then he said — in broken English — *"Looking... no buying?"*

Safiya nodded. Fast. *"Yes. Just looking."*

The seller shrugged. The specific small Muttrah shrug that released all parties from the negotiation. *"Okay."*

Sadoo whispered — amazed —

نجحت!

(It worked!)

و

John blinked. "That worked?"

و

Thuraya smiled. The specific small teacher's smile of a woman who had just, in real time, witnessed the specific moment when English had accomplished, in one sentence, what Arabic had failed to accomplish in thirty.

و

"Sometimes," she said, "English is magic."

SCENE FIVE

Where Is Mansoor?

They moved away — before **Sadoo** could cause another disaster.

و

They walked deeper into the souq. More shops. More sounds. More colours — the specific accumulating visual overload of a covered market in which every stall wanted the eye. Silk scarves in impossible pink. Stacks of yellow lemons. Dark red carpets hanging from wooden beams. A butcher's stall with bright pomegranate juice running from the cutting board.

و

Suddenly —

و

وين منصوور؟

و

(Where is Mansoor?)

و

Thuraya stopped walking.

و

The specific full stop of a teacher whose brain had just, in one instant, performed the headcount that every teacher on every field trip performs **involuntarily** — and which had, for the first time since they had left the pickup truck, produced the wrong number.

و

Safiya's heart jumped. "What?"

و

Thuraya looked around. Fast. "Mansoor is not here."

٢٧
ع

John's stomach dropped. The specific sudden low drop of a man whose brain had just registered, at the same moment, that the school trip had included the village's most **irrepressible** eight-year-old — and that he had not seen that eight-year-old for, he now realised, at least fifteen minutes.

٢٧
ع

"What do you mean... not here?"

٢٧
ع

They turned. They counted. The specific slow accusing counting of three adults realising, at the same time, that they had, somewhere, failed.

٢٧
ع

One. Two. Three.

٢٧
ع

No Mansoor.

٢٧
ع

Sadoo looked around too. He suggested — with the specific easygoing village optimism of a man who had, in his own childhood, disappeared at markets many times without consequence —

٢٧
ع

يمكن راح يشوف شي.

٢٧
ع

(Maybe he went to look at something.)

٢٧
ع

John's face became white. The specific full English whiteness of a teacher whose professional responsibility had just collided with a specific Omani geography.

٢٧
ع

"He is a child. In this place."

٢٧
ع

Thuraya's voice became sharp. The specific small knife-sharp teacher-voice that went on only in emergencies.

٢٧
ع

"We must find him. Now."

٢٧
ع

They split.

٢٧
ع

John and **Safiya** went one way. **Thuraya** and **Sadoo** went another. The specific immediate silent co-ordination of four adults who had, without needing instructions, divided the search quadrants

between them.

ۛ

John walked fast. Calling. *"Mansoor! Mansoor!"*

ۛ

People looked at him. The specific puzzled looking of passers-by who had just seen a tall foreigner calling a name that, in their ears, was the name of every third boy in the country.

ۛ

Safiya checked every small shop. *"Mansoor!"*

ۛ

She checked a fruit seller's corner. She checked a scarf shop. She checked a narrow alley between two tailors. She ducked under a hanging rug. She called his name again — her voice, in the specific full-volume teacher-voice she had developed over the last two months, carrying further than she had expected in the enclosed space.

ۛ

Then — they heard it.

ۛ

Laughter.

ۛ

Very familiar laughter.

ۛ

The specific high-pitched, eight-year-old, entirely unaware-of-the-panic laughter that could, in any country, be identified from fifty metres away as the laughter of a boy who was having a good time.

ۛ

They followed the sound.

ۛ

And found him.

ۛ

Mansoor stood in front of a man selling toys. He was holding a small wooden sword — a traditional Omani toy-sword, with a short curved blade of painted wood, about the size of his forearm.

ۛ

His eyes were *shining*.

ۛ

The specific full shining of an eight-year-old boy who had, without any of the supervising adults knowing, discovered exactly what he had, without telling anyone, come to this market to find.

٢٧

"*Mansoor!*" **Thuraya** shouted — arriving, with **Sadoo**, behind them.

٢٨

Mansoor turned. He turned with the specific surprised happy turning of a boy who had not, until that moment, realised that anybody had been looking for him.

٢٩

مس ثريا! شوف

٣٠

(*Miss Thuraya! Look!*)

٣١

John ran. He grabbed **Mansoor's** shoulder — not roughly, but firmly, the specific firm teacher-grip of a man whose relief had, in the same instant, become a need to *communicate* something important.

٣٢

"*You cannot disappear like that!*"

٣٣

Mansoor looked confused. The specific small innocent confusion of a boy who did not, in his own experience, understand the concept of *disappearing*. He had, from his point of view, simply been *here* — next to the swords — and the adults had, inconsiderately, *left*.

٣٤

بس أنا شفت سيوف

٣٥

(*But I saw swords.*)

٣٦

Safiya bent down. Her knees hit the dirty souq floor and she did not, in that moment, care. She was at his eye level now. Her hand on his arm.

٣٧

"*You scared us.*"

٣٨

Mansoor looked guilty. Properly guilty. The specific small **contrite** face of a boy who had just — for the first time in his short life — registered that his own good time had cost other people real fear.

٣٩

آسف

(*Sorry.*)

٢٧
ع

The toy seller smiled. "*He likes sword.*"

٢٨
ع

Sadoo arrived. Breathing hard.

٢٩
ع

هذا مجنون.

٣٠
ع

(*This one is crazy.*)

٣١
ع

Thuraya took **Mansoor's** hand. Firmly. The specific small firm hand-taking of a teacher who had decided that, for the rest of the trip, the boy's fingers were going to be inside hers.

٣٢
ع

"Stay with the group. Always."

٣٣
ع

Mansoor nodded.

٣٤
ع

John wiped his face. "*New rule. Nobody moves alone.*"

٣٥
ع

SCENE SIX

The Shouting

They continued walking.

٣٦
ع

Then —

٣٧
ع

They heard shouting.

٣٨
ع

Angry shouting.

٣٩
ع

It was **Sadoo's** voice.

٤٠
ع

They turned.

٢٧

Sadoo was arguing with another seller. Loudly. Very loudly. The specific full-volume public argument of a Samaili man whose village pride had just been, in a city he did not belong to, publicly wronged.

٢٨

هذا مو اللي عطيتني

٢٩

(This is not what you gave me!)

٣٠

The seller shouted back.

٣١

People started looking.

٣٢

Thuraya whispered — with the specific heavy whisper of a woman who could already see how this was going to end — *"Oh no. What did he do?"*

٣٣

Sadoo turned and saw them.

٣٤

هذا الرجال أعطاني شي غير

٣٥

(This man gave me something different!)

٣٦

The seller shouted something.

٣٧

Thuraya translated, fast. *"He says you changed it."*

٣٨

Sadoo put his hands on his head.

٣٩

أنا؟ لا

٤٠

(Me? No!)

٤١

The seller pointed at a bag. Inside was something broken.

٤٢

The crowd grew.

٢٧
ع

John felt the heat. Not the chili-heat of the previous week. A different, colder heat — the specific administrative heat of a situation that had, in the last thirty seconds, crossed from *commercial* into *legal*.

٢٨
ع

"This is becoming... big."

٢٩
ع

Safiya whispered, *"Very big."*

٣٠
ع

The seller shouted again. **Sadoo** shouted louder. The argument had entered its **volume-spiral**.

٣١
ع

Then —

٣٢
ع

A police officer appeared.

٣٣
ع

Everything became quiet.

٣٤
ع

The specific instant hush of a Muttrah crowd recognising the specific uniform of the **Royal Oman Police**.

٣٥
ع

The officer looked at **Sadoo**. Then at the seller. Then at the bag.

٣٦
ع

Thuraya's heart sank.

٣٧
ع

The officer asked questions. Fast Arabic.

٣٨
ع

Sadoo answered. Also fast Arabic.

٣٩
ع

Thuraya translated, in a low voice, for **John** and **Safiya**. *"The seller says Sadoo broke something and does not want to pay."*

٤٠
ع

Sadoo protested —

٤١
ع

ما كسرت شي

﴿

(I didn't break anything!)

﴿

The officer looked at **Sadoo**. Seriously.

﴿

John stepped forward — without thinking, the specific unthinking forward-step of a man who had, all his English life, been quietly trained to **intervene** politely when an institution appeared.

﴿

"Excuse me."

﴿

Everyone looked at him.

﴿

He swallowed. *"We... are teachers. He is... our friend."*

﴿

The officer looked at him. Long.

﴿

Then said — slowly, in English — *"Problem?"*

﴿

John nodded. *"Yes. But... maybe misunderstanding."*

﴿

The officer thought. The specific slow Omani-police thinking that **John**, at that moment, could not read — was he about to be arrested? was **Sadoo**? was the whole thing about to become paperwork?

﴿

Then he said something to the seller.

﴿

The seller sighed. He said something back.

﴿

Thuraya's eyes widened. *"He says... okay. He will not make problem. But Sadoo must pay a small amount."*

﴿

Sadoo's face fell.

﴿

حتى لو ما كسرت؟

ﷲ

(Even if I didn't break?)

ﷲ

Thuraya looked at him. *"Yes. Even if."*

ﷲ

Sadoo sighed. Deeply. The specific deep defeated sigh of a village man whose morning pride had just been, in a formal legal way, **abridged**. Then he paid.

ﷲ

The crowd disappeared. The specific fast Muttrah-crowd dispersal of an audience whose show had ended.

ﷲ

John exhaled. *"That... was scary."*

ﷲ

Safiya nodded. *"Very."*

ﷲ

Thuraya looked at **Sadoo**. The specific small rueful look of a teacher whose pupil had, once again, confirmed the lesson. *"I told you. In Muttrah, your mouth is dangerous."*

ﷲ

Sadoo smiled sheepishly.

ﷲ

بس حماس.

ﷲ

(Just enthusiasm.)

ﷲ

They walked back toward the bus. Everyone was tired. The specific full tiredness of four adults and a small boy who had, in one morning, done too many things.

ﷲ

Uncle Nasser was waiting. Counting them like precious boxes.

ﷲ

كلکم موجودین؟

ﷲ

(Are you all here?)

ﷲ

Thuraya nodded. "Yes."

٢٧
ع

They climbed in.

٢٨
ع

As the pickup moved — rolling slowly out of the Muttrah back-lane toward the coast road that would carry them back through the mountains to Samail — the students talked and laughed and showed what they had bought.

٢٩
ع

Mansoor slept in two minutes. Holding his small wooden sword. The specific instant-sleep of a small boy whose morning had been, by all his own measures, the greatest morning of his life.

٣٠
ع

John leaned back. He closed his eyes.

٣١
ع

Safiya smiled. "*So... what did we learn today?*"

٣٢
ع

John answered without opening his eyes — with the specific tired full-body delivery of a man whose vocabulary lesson had become a life lesson.

٣٣
ع

"How to say 'I don't want to buy'... and how to survive Muttrah."

٣٤
ع

Thuraya laughed. "*And you still have many lessons.*"

٣٥
ع

From the front, **Sadoo** — unconquered by his small legal defeat, the specific **irrepressible** good cheer of a man who would never, under any circumstance, let a day be anything other than beautiful — said, proudly —

٣٦
ع

رحلة جميلة.

٣٧
ع

(*Beautiful trip.*)

٣٨
ع

John opened one eye. "*Beautiful... and dangerous.*"

٣٩
ع

Safiya laughed.

٤٠
ع

*And Muttrah stayed behind them — the city fading into the late-morning haze, the sea fading after it, the small lanes fading, the sound of the trader who had tried to sell them a ship key fading into the specific small accumulated memory of a day that would, in all the years to come, live in their English-English conversations under the short phrase remember Muttrah. **Safiya** opened her notebook. She wrote, quickly, in the bouncing hand that the moving pickup allowed her — Today we learned: how markets work. How Arabic works. How English is sometimes magic. How Sadoo is always Sadoo. How Mansoor is always Mansoor. And how Oman will, in one morning, give you more story than an English year. She closed the notebook. The mountains rose ahead of them again — the brown silent giants, the same ones that had surprised her on the way out — and she found, without meaning to, that she was looking at them now as though they were, somehow, on her side.*



Did You Know?

The Historic Muttrah Souq

The crowded Muttrah souq where Mansoor got lost is no ordinary market — parts of it date back over a thousand years, and it thrived as a hub for the spice and frankincense trade between India, Africa, and Arabia. It's known locally as the "dark souq" because its narrow, covered alleys never let in daylight.

Source: en.wikipedia.org · worldtraveller73.com

PALM

Palm Twenty-One

Tofes 17 — The Day Sky Almost Fell on Samail

SCENE ONE

The Mountains in His Head

The village looked ordinary again.

☪

No smoke. No shouting. No running behind trucks. Just sun, dust, and the specific quiet footsteps of Samail mornings that always sounded, to **John**'s newly-adjusted ear, louder than they should. After the Muttrah trip — after the souq, the seller, the ship key, the mislaid Mansoor, the **abridged** pride of Sadoo in front of a police officer — Samail felt smaller, like the mountains had followed **John** back and were now hiding inside his head.

☪

John stood in the yard early, holding his cup of tea with both hands.

☪

*The tea was the specific strong black tea of Samail mornings — brewed, in their small kitchen, the way **Thuraya**'s mother had taught **Safiya** to brew it, with cardamom pods cracked and dropped in at the boil, with a small piece of cinnamon stick, with enough sugar that an English throat required two sips to recover from the first. His eyes were still slightly red — not from smoke this time, not from saffron, not from pesticide, not from any of the specific Samaili chemical assaults of the previous weeks — but from too much thinking.*

☪

The thinking had begun on the drive back from Muttrah. It had continued through dinner. It had continued, quietly, during the night — in the specific way that thoughts continue during Omani nights, when the air is still warm enough to keep the body just below sleep, and the mind is free to arrange, and re-arrange, the questions of the day.

☪

Safiya — *Safiya* to everyone now except **John** and **Thuraya** — was folding clothes on a rope line. The specific careful folding of a woman who had learned, over the last two months, to fold her own English clothes in the Omani way — corners first, then the third fold, then the press against the thigh that locked the fold in place. She paused every few seconds to stare at the mountains far away, as

though she expected a ship — a wooden ship, with a lateen sail — to appear, *somehow*, from behind them.



Muttrah was doing this. To both of them. It had installed itself as a small permanent soundtrack behind every ordinary morning.



Ms. **Thuraya** arrived carrying a small basket with papers and chalk. She looked bright. *Too* bright. The specific too-bright smile of a woman who knew a secret joke and was waiting for the perfect moment to release it.



John watched her carefully. *"You are smiling,"* he said, *"like you already know what I will say."*



Thuraya's smile grew wider. *"Maybe I do."*



Safiya leaned toward him. *"John. You have been staring at the door since sunrise. Are you waiting for a letter? A miracle? A goat?"*



John pointed at the road — with the specific small serious point of a man who had, over coffee, decided that this morning was going to be the morning.



"I'm waiting for... answers."



"What answers?" **Safiya** asked.



John lowered his voice. As though the date palms at the edge of the yard could understand English and might, if he spoke too loudly, report him.



"Muttrah. The market. The sea. That man with the box. And how everyone kept saying things that sounded like warnings and jokes at the same time."



Thuraya sat on the edge of the small stone wall. She folded her hands in her lap — the specific small village-woman hand-fold that meant *I am going to say one sentence, and you should listen to it.*



"In Samail," she said, *"warnings and jokes are cousins."*



John nodded slowly. *"Exactly. And now I want to know if... if this village is normal."*

~
€

Safiya laughed. *"John. You chose Oman in 1973. Normal is on vacation."*

SCENE TWO

John Decides

Before **John** could reply, a familiar little shadow hopped into the yard.

~
€

Malood.

~
€

The baby goat marched in — like a king, the specific short-legged marching of an animal who had, long ago, decided that this house was as much his as anyone else's. He sniffed **Safiya's** clean clothes. He tried to chew the corner of a scarf.

~
€

Safiya pulled it away — gently — and sighed. *"This goat has no **shame**."*

~
€

Malood stared at her — as though he had been, in fact, *offended* by the accusation — then ran straight for **John's** bag. The same bag he always attacked. The specific old English **canvas** bag that **John** had brought from Norwich, and which contained, in **Malood's** private cosmology, the most delicious secrets in the world.

~
€

John lifted the bag. *"No, Malood. Not today. I need this bag for school."*

~
€

Malood jumped. Failed. Looked angry.

~
€

Thuraya chuckled. *"He is practising. For future crimes."*

~
€

John looked at **Thuraya**. The specific focused look of a man returning, with effort, to the question he had been, all morning, trying to ask.

~
€

"Speaking of crimes..." he said, *"I have to ask you something."*

~
€

Thuraya blinked — innocently. *"Ask."*

~
€

John took a breath. The specific careful preparatory breath of a man who had, over many weeks, not quite dared the question he was about to ask.

~
ع

"Who is Shayb Khalaf. Really?"

~
ع

Safiya froze mid-fold.

~
ع

Malood stopped chewing.

~
ع

Even the air — **Safiya** would later remember — felt like it *waited*. The specific small waiting of an Omani morning that had, at the utterance of a specific name, become attentive.

~
ع

Thuraya did not answer right away.

~
ع

She looked, instead, toward the path that led to the edge of the village — where the clay houses grew older, and the trees grew wilder, and the specific quiet that attached itself to the furthest houses became audible even from here.

~
ع

Then she said, calmly —

~
ع

"He is an old man. He lives alone. People fear him because people fear what they don't understand."

~
ع

John's voice dropped. *"But why do they think he is... a **wizard**?"*

~
ع

Thuraya shrugged. The specific small shrug of a village woman whose country's **folk-imagination** had, in her experience, been *generating* wizards out of lonely old men for approximately two thousand years.

~
ع

"Stories grow faster than palm trees. One day he is just a lonely man. Next day he is a wizard. The next day... he is something worse."

~
ع

Safiya spoke softly. *"Is he dangerous?"*

~
ع

Thuraya looked at her.



"No. But... he likes silence. And he doesn't like people watching him like he is a story."



John nodded. Then he whispered — the specific small private whisper of a man who had, in the last two minutes, made up his mind — *"Good. Because I want to talk to him."*



Safiya snapped her head toward him. *"John... why?"*



"Because," **John** said — standing straighter, with the specific small straight-shoulder posture of a man taking a decision — *"I feel like he knows things. And I don't like mysteries. In places where I live."*



Thuraya's smile returned. Small and sharp. *"Then go. But don't blame me if you run."*



Safiya narrowed her eyes. *"Thuraya. That sounded like a threat."*



Thuraya raised her hands. The specific innocent double-palm raise of a woman committing to plausible deniability. *"It is not a threat. It is... a prediction."*



And just like that, **John** decided.

SCENE THREE

Under the Shawab Tree

The path to **Shayb Khalaf's** house felt longer than it looked.



The village sounds faded behind them. The rooster fell away. The small bickering of children at the far wells fell away. Even the continuous hush of the falaj — which was, for Samail, what the distant sea was for coastal towns, a *permanent* sound — thinned to a faint whisper. Even **Malood** followed. Bouncing along. As though this was a grand adventure.



Safiya tried to keep her voice light. *"Maybe we should not bother him."*



John walked faster. *"We are not bothering. We are greeting. We are... friendly teachers."*



Thuraya walked beside them. With calm confidence. The specific calm of a woman who had, three times in her life, had this exact conversation with this exact old man, and who knew, already, what its shape would be.

ﷺ

"Remember your greeting lesson."

ﷺ

John forced a smile — the specific small nervous smile of a man rehearsing, in the final metres before arrival, the sentences he had memorised.

ﷺ

"Hello. Good morning. How are you?"

ﷺ

Safiya added, *"Nice to meet you."*

ﷺ

Thuraya nodded. *"Good. Don't forget 'We are sorry to disturb you.' Just in case."*

ﷺ

John gave her a look. *"You prepared that sentence too quickly."*

ﷺ

Thuraya pretended not to hear.

ﷺ

Soon, they saw it — a small, old clay house, with a rough wooden door. In front of it stood the famous **shawab** tree. Wide. Heavy. Like it had been watching the village for a hundred years without blinking.

ﷺ

Under the tree, a man sat on a mat.

ﷺ

Shayb Khalaf.

ﷺ

*He held a small cup of coffee — the specific finjan of the Gulf, with its small round base, its slightly flared rim. His walking stick rested beside him. And in front of him — laid out neatly, in their small interlocking pattern, as if waiting for a guest — a set of dominoes. The specific **anticipatory** arrangement of a man who had been, somehow, expecting company.*

ﷺ

John slowed down.

ﷺ

His stomach did a strange little flip. The specific small flip of a man whose rational English mind had just registered an arrangement of dominoes that *could not* have been prepared for him, because nobody had been told he was coming, and which had, nonetheless, *been* prepared for him.

٢٧
ع

Safiya whispered, "*Why are the dominoes already ready?*"

٢٨
ع

Thuraya whispered back — with the specific small calm village-whisper of a woman whose answer was genuine but also *deliberately* unhelpful —

٢٩
ع

"Because he is always ready."

٣٠
ع

Malood tried to step forward. **Thuraya** gently held him back by the little rope around his neck.

٣١
ع

"Not now. Trouble-maker."

٣٢
ع

John cleared his throat.

٣٣
ع

Shayb Khalaf did not look up.

٣٤
ع

John tried again. Louder.

٣٥
ع

"Good morning."

٣٦
ع

Still nothing.

٣٧
ع

Safiya leaned closer. *"Maybe he didn't hear."*

٣٨
ع

Then the old man spoke. Without looking up.

٣٩
ع

"Good morning," he said.

٤٠
ع

His English was not perfect.

٤١
ع

But it was *clear* enough.

٢٧
ع

Clear enough to hit **John** like a cold bucket of water, poured, without warning, over his head in the middle of a warm village morning.

SCENE FOUR

Sit

John froze.

٢٨
ع

Safiya's mouth opened slightly, then closed — the specific small English double-move of a woman who had prepared a sentence, and who had, in the half-second between preparing and speaking, realised the sentence was no longer going to work.

٢٩
ع

Thuraya's eyes sparkled. She looked, in fact, like a woman who was trying, very hard, not to laugh.

٣٠
ع

John managed to speak. "*You... you speak English.*"

٣١
ع

Shayb Khalaf finally looked up.

٣٢
ع

His eyes were sharp. Sharp like a hawk's. But tired — the specific kind of tired that belonged to someone who carried heavy thoughts.

٣٣
ع

He nodded. Once.

٣٤
ع

"*Little.*"

٣٥
ع

John's voice became polite. And nervous. The specific careful politeness of a man addressing a figure whose existence, ten seconds ago, he had partially **relegated** to village folklore and who was, now, in front of him, *speaking English*.

٣٦
ع

"*We are teachers. New teachers. We came from Britain.*"

٣٧
ع

Shayb Khalaf stared at him for a long moment.

٣٨
ع

Then he pointed at the dominoes.

﴿

"*Sit*," he said.

﴿

John blinked. "*Sit?*"

﴿

"*Sit*," **Shayb Khalaf** repeated — like it was the only word that mattered.

﴿

Safiya touched **John**'s arm. "*John... do we sit?*"

﴿

John swallowed. "*We sit.*"

﴿

They sat under the shawab tree. The shade felt cooler than the rest of the village — the specific deeper cool of the oldest tree in a small place, a tree whose canopy had, over a hundred years, **accumulated** its own **micro-climate**. As though the tree were protecting secrets.

﴿

Shayb Khalaf pushed the dominoes forward.

﴿

John stared at them. "*You want to... play?*"

﴿

Shayb Khalaf nodded. "*Play.*"

﴿

Thuraya sat to the side. Watching — the specific small referee-watching of a woman who already knew who was going to win, and who was looking forward to watching how the loser would lose.

﴿

Safiya whispered, "*Do you know how to play?*"

﴿

John whispered back. "*I know the rules. I just... didn't know I would play dominoes with a village wizard under a sacred tree.*"

﴿

Thuraya whispered. "*He is not a wizard.*"

﴿

John whispered — urgently, the specific *look-at-the-evidence* whisper of a man making his case — "*He spoke English.*"

٢٧
ع

Thuraya smiled. *"Some people learn languages. That doesn't make them wizards."*

٢٨
ع

John lifted a domino piece. Carefully. As if it could *bite*.

٢٩
ع

Shayb Khalaf watched him. Silent.

٣٠
ع

John placed a piece down.

٣١
ع

Shayb Khalaf placed a better piece down. Immediately. Like he had been, since before **John** and **Safiya** and **Thuraya** had started walking, waiting for **John** to make that exact opening move.

٣٢
ع

Safiya leaned back. Slowly. *"He is good."*

٣٣
ع

John nodded — stiffly. *"Too good."*

SCENE FIVE

Muttrah Is Noisy

After a few moves, **Shayb Khalaf** spoke again. Still calm. Still, apparently, not interested.

٣٤
ع

"Muttrah is noisy," he said.

٣٥
ع

John's heart jumped.

٣٦
ع

The specific full jump of a man whose day had just, without warning, acquired an **uncanny** edge.

٣٧
ع

"Yes..." he said. Carefully. *"It is."*

٣٨
ع

Shayb Khalaf continued — placing another piece, without looking at it —

٣٩
ع

"You went there. You saw ships."

٤٠
ع

Safiya's face changed. *"How do you know?"*

٢٧
ع

Shayb Khalaf looked at her.

٢٨
ع

"News travels."

٢٩
ع

John's hands tightened on his dominoes. *"Who told you?"*

٣٠
ع

Shayb Khalaf pointed loosely — **expansively** — toward the village behind them.

٣١
ع

"People."

٣٢
ع

Then he looked directly at **John**.

٣٣
ع

"And you got into trouble."

٣٤
ع

John's face went pale. *"We... we did not get into trouble."*

٣٥
ع

Shayb Khalaf raised one eyebrow.

٣٦
ع

John felt the air press down on him. The specific heavy descent of a warm October afternoon **converging** on a man whose lie had, in less than three seconds, collapsed.

٣٧
ع

Safiya whispered — sharply, the specific small wifely emergency-whisper of a woman who had decided to intervene — *"John. Your face is confessing."*

٣٨
ع

John tried to laugh. It came out like a cough. *"Small trouble. Only... small."*

٣٩
ع

Thuraya covered her mouth. Her shoulders shook.

٤٠
ع

Shayb Khalaf placed another domino piece.

٤١
ع

Click.

٤٢
ع

The sound felt *loud*. Louder than it should have been. The specific small acoustically-enhanced click that happened when a domino piece was placed, in total silence, under the oldest tree in the village.

~

Then **Shayb Khalaf** said — still in English —

~

"Next time, listen."

~

John's throat became dry. *"Listen to who?"*

~

Shayb Khalaf's eyes flicked toward **Thuraya**. For half a second. Then back to **John**.

~

"Listen," he repeated.

~

John stared at him. Then looked at **Thuraya**. *"Why does he keep saying 'listen' like it is... a warning?"*

~

Thuraya smiled. Sweetly. *"Maybe because you don't listen."*

~

John opened his mouth to argue. But **Shayb Khalaf** suddenly said — casually, without looking at anyone —

~

"Your goat likes your bag."

~

Safiya turned her head so fast she almost hurt her neck. *"How do you know about Malood?"*

~

Shayb Khalaf looked at **Malood** — who was currently chewing the corner of **John's** bag again. With full confidence.

~

Shayb Khalaf said — calmly —

~

"Because he is doing it now."

~

John looked at **Malood**. Then back at **Shayb Khalaf**.

Then he whispered, *"This is impossible."*

Shayb Khalaf placed his last domino.

He won.

John stared at the domino line like it was an official stamp of defeat.

Safiya exhaled. *"He beat you."*

John — half in shock — stood up. Quickly. *"Thank you. We... we should go."*

Shayb Khalaf lifted his cup. Drank slowly.

Then he said — almost lightly —

"You are afraid."

John forced a smile. *"No. I am not afraid."*

Shayb Khalaf nodded. Once. *"Yes. You are."*

John felt his cheeks heat. He turned away.

Then **Shayb Khalaf** added — quietly, in Arabic this time, like a knife slipping out of its sheath —

واحليك باه... تغزع.

(Oh you poor dear... you're scared.)

John froze.

Safiya's eyes widened.

٢٧
ع

Thuraya's smile became dangerous.

٢٨
ع

John spun back. *"You... you said that before."*

٢٩
ع

Shayb Khalaf looked at him. *"Did I?"*

٣٠
ع

John's voice shook. *"Yes."*

٣١
ع

Shayb Khalaf leaned back. Calm. *"Maybe you imagined it."*

SCENE SIX

If I..., I Will...

John grabbed his sandals. Suddenly. The specific sudden grab of a man who needed to *move*, needed *air*.

٣٢
ع

Safiya stood too. *"Thank you, Shayb Khalaf."*

٣٣
ع

Shayb Khalaf did not answer.

٣٤
ع

John took two steps... then turned. And blurted, in English, the specific question that had been, under all the small English sentences, the *real* question all along.

٣٥
ع

"Why do people say you are a sorcerer?"

٣٦
ع

The air changed again.

٣٧
ع

Thuraya stopped smiling.

٣٨
ع

Safiya held her breath.

٣٩
ع

Shayb Khalaf's face did not change. But his eyes did.

و
ع

He said — quietly — “*People need a story.*”

و
ع

John swallowed. “*And the story about... the ‘maghsoob’?*”

و
ع

Thuraya’s head snapped toward **John**. “*Why would you say that here?*”

و
ع

John whispered, “*Because... because I heard it.*”

و
ع

Shayb Khalaf stared at him. For a long time.

و
ع

*And in that long stare, **Safiya** would later understand, was the entire private history of a man who had, over forty or fifty years, been the subject of a village story that was not true — a story about giving a son to the devils, a story about sorcery, a story about his son Obaid, who had simply gone to Bahrain to work, who had returned eventually as an ordinary man, and who had, because of his father’s reputation, been treated by the village ever since as a ghost. The maghsoob story was a village invention. **Khalaf** knew it was an invention. The villagers, somewhere deep down, also knew. But the story was too useful — too satisfying — to be allowed to die. And **Khalaf** had lived his life inside it.*

و
ع

Then he said one sentence. Slow. Heavy.

و
ع

“*Don’t play with fear. Fear plays back.*”

و
ع

John’s stomach dropped.

و
ع

He nodded. Quickly. “*Okay. Thank you. Goodbye.*”

و
ع

And then he did what **Thuraya** had predicted.

و
ع

He ran.

و
ع

Barefoot. Holding his sandals like a strange trophy. The specific full-commitment run of a man whose legs had, without consulting him, decided that the path away from the shawab tree needed to be traversed as quickly as possible.

و
ع

Safiya followed. Half laughing. Half worried. Calling — *"John! John, slow down!"*

﴿

Behind them, **Thuraya** walked. Calmly. Like she *owned* the whole scene.

﴿

She glanced back. Once.

﴿

Shayb Khalaf was still sitting under the shawab tree. Quiet. Unmoving. As if nothing had happened. As if *they* were the ones who were strange.

﴿

By the time they reached the classroom, **John** was still breathing like he had escaped a tiger.

﴿

The students noticed his face immediately.

﴿

Mansoor whispered — loudly, the specific stage-whisper of a boy who wanted the whole class to hear — *"Teacher John... you run!"*

﴿

John tried to stand tall. *"Yes. I ran."*

﴿

Thuraya wrote the target structure on the board. In her clear clean lettering:

﴿

IF I ..., I WILL ...

﴿

Safiya clapped her hands. *"Today. We use our trip to learn English!"*

﴿

John pointed at himself. Slowly. The specific slow deliberate self-pointing of a man who had decided to turn his own fear, for the second time that week, into pedagogical material.

﴿

"If I see Shayb Khalaf... I will run."

﴿

The class burst into laughter.

﴿

Thuraya smiled. *"Good sentence. True sentence."*

﴿

Safiya pointed to a student. *"Your turn. If you eat too much chili..."*

و
ع

A boy grinned. *"If I eat too much chili, I will cry."*

و
ع

John nodded. *"Excellent."*

و
ع

Thuraya pointed at **Mansoor**. *"If Mansoor makes noise..."*

و
ع

The students shouted together — the specific joyful full-class chorus of children who knew, exactly, what the next sentence was — *"Teacher will shout!"*

و
ع

Mohammedeen — passing by the door, unable to resist — added in his Egyptian accent, *"No, no, no. Teacher will make you quiet!"*

و
ع

Fatkat laughed. Loudly. From the corridor.

و
ع

Safiya continued. *"If we go to Muttrah..."*

و
ع

The students repeated — *"We will see ships."*

و
ع

John's eyes drifted to the window.

و
ع

He could almost hear **Shayb Khalaf's** voice again —

و
ع

Don't play with fear.

و
ع

Thuraya noticed his expression. She leaned closer — whispering in English, so only he could hear.

و
ع

"Now you understand. People here can make a story inside your head. And you will believe it."

و
ع

John swallowed. *"Did you... did you tell him about Muttrah?"*

و
ع

Thuraya blinked. Innocently. *"Me?"*

٢٧
ع

John stared at her. "*Thuraya.*"

٢٨
ع

She smiled. "*If you accuse me... I will laugh.*"

٢٩
ع

Safiya called from the front. "*John! Your turn. Give the students one more sentence.*"

٣٠
ع

John forced a smile. He faced the class.

٣١
ع

"*If I hear a strange English voice under a tree,*" he said, "*I will... drink tea and pretend it is normal.*"

٣٢
ع

The class laughed again.

٣٣
ع

But **John** didn't. Not fully.

٣٤
ع

Because deep inside, he was still wondering the same thing he had been wondering since the smoke day —

٣٥
ع

How did that old man learn English?

٣٦
ع

And *why* did he feel like **Shayb Khalaf** knew more than he should?

٣٧
ع

Outside, the wind moved softly through the palm farms.

٣٨
ع

*And somewhere in the village — under the shawab tree, in the shade that had been accumulating for a hundred years, in the small patient circle of dominoes laid out carefully on the mat — silence kept its secrets. **Shayb Khalaf** sat, alone now, with his small cup of coffee, and a second game of dominoes already being arranged by his own hands. As though, somewhere in the village, another visitor was already on the way.*

 Did You Know?**Arabic Coffee and Hospitality Traditions**

The scene of John, Sophia, and Thuraya sitting with Sheikh Khalaf over his coffee cup reflects a real tradition. In 2015, UNESCO inscribed "Arabic coffee, a symbol of generosity" on its Intangible Cultural Heritage list, jointly submitted by Oman, Saudi Arabia, Qatar, and the UAE, honoring its rituals of hospitality and respect between generations.

Source: ich.unesco.org · egyptianstreets.com

PALM

Palm Twenty-Two

The Sky Falls on Samail — A Village in Rain

SCENE ONE

The Sound That Did Not Belong

There are sounds a place teaches you, and sounds it does not. After enough mornings in a single house, the body learns the village before the mind does — the rooster who calls always at the same hour, the woman whose footsteps pass at the same angle, the door of the neighbour that closes always with the same particular complaint of wood against wood. The ear builds an inventory. And anything outside that inventory arrives, when it arrives, with the specific small alarm of an unexpected guest.

~

That morning, the sound was outside the inventory.

~

Not the rooster. Not the bread being clapped between palms in the next house. Not the small tin sound of **Sadoo** opening his shop. Not **Mansoor** shouting somewhere in the lanes — that voice which had become, over the past weeks, almost a clock.

~

This sound was something else. Soft. Patient. Repeating with the small wet certainty of a thing that has decided it is going to continue.

~

Tup... tup... tup...

~

John opened one eye. The room was dim — that specific blue-grey dimness of a Samaili dawn, when the sun had begun its work but had not yet committed to it. He listened. The sound continued. *Tup... tup... tup...*

~

Sophia was already sitting up — not startled, not afraid, simply alert in the careful, listening way of a person who has been awake longer than the room knows.

~

"John,"

she whispered, and her voice carried the small wonder of someone reporting a fact that contained a question.

"I think... the sky is leaking."

~
~

Before he could answer her — before his mind had even fully assembled the sentence she had just said — a single cold drop fell on his nose.

~
~

He sat up in one motion.

~
~

"The sky is *WHAT?*"

~
~

Another drop. Then another. Each one finding a slightly different patch of skin, of pillow, of wooden floor — not many, not threatening, simply *arriving*, with the unhurried persistence of a thing that had been doing this for longer than the house had existed.

~
~

The roof was a clay roof. Old. Patient. Maintained the way Omani village roofs were maintained — not against rain, because rain did not come, but against time. And now time and rain had arrived together, on the same morning, and the roof was discovering, along with its inhabitants, that its preparations had been incomplete.

~
~

Sophia looked up. Then around. Then down at the floor, where a small dark mark was forming on the bisat.

~
~

"The roof... it's *dripping!*"

~
~

She moved with the specific full speed of a woman who had decided, in a single second, that this was an emergency and that she was going to manage it. She ran to the kitchen. She came back with bowls. With a cup. With a small tin plate. With anything that could hold water and had not been previously assigned the task.

~
~

"*Emergency! Emergency!*"

~
~

John followed her — half-asleep, still trying to understand the syntax of a sky that was, apparently, capable of leaking.

~
~

"Is this normal? Is this... a *flood*?"

SCENE TWO

Welcome to Oman Rain

Ms. **Thuraya** appeared at the door.

~

She did not appear the way a guest appears. She did not appear the way a neighbour might appear. She appeared the way the morning itself appeared in this village — without announcement, without surprise, with the calm specific completeness of a person who had known, somehow, that her presence would shortly be required and had simply arranged her steps to coincide with that requirement. Her scarf was already on. Her face was already calm. The rain was already, in some private way, hers.

~

She looked at the dripping ceiling. Then at **Sophia**, running between bowls. Then at **John**, who was standing in the middle of the room holding a cup with the dignity of a man who has not yet been informed of the situation.

~

She smiled. The specific small calm smile of a woman watching foreigners encounter their first Omani rain.

~

"Relax. It's *rain*."

~

John froze.

~

"Rain?"

~

Sophia stopped. A bowl in each hand. The specific stopping of a person who has been told that the emergency she has been managing is, in fact, not an emergency at all.

~

"Rain?"

~

And then — without warning, without the courtesy of a small build-up —

~

BOOOOOM.

~

The thunder did not come from the sky. It came from inside the sky. It came from a place in the sky that the village did not normally have access to, and which on this particular morning had decided to make itself heard. The walls of the house — clay walls, patient walls, the same walls that had stood for generations — felt it before the ear did. The floor felt it before the walls. There was a small specific second in which everything that had ever been still in this room remembered that stillness was a temporary condition.

~

Sophia screamed.

John screamed a small, slightly delayed second later — the polite scream of a man whose body had decided to participate before his mind had finished assessing whether participation was warranted.

Malood screamed too, from somewhere outside the door, with the specific full-bodied protest of a goat whose morning had been interrupted by something he could not negotiate with.

~

Thuraya laughed.

~

The specific small full laugh of a woman who had been waiting, all morning, for this particular cultural exchange.

~

"Welcome to Oman rain."

SCENE THREE

A Village Transformed

They went outside.

~

And the village they had known yesterday — the dry village, the dust-coloured village, the village whose air carried the small specific aged scent of stone and heat — was no longer that village.

~

*The ground was dark. Not muddy yet — simply changed, the colour of earth that had remembered, for the first time in months, what water was. The smell had transformed completely. Not the slow ancient scent of dust waiting. Something green. Something new. The specific full wet-earth smell of a place that had been holding its breath and had, in the last hour, finally exhaled. **Sophia** breathed it in with her whole chest. The way you breathe in something you had not known, until that moment, you had been missing.*

~

Water was running everywhere. Not in floods — in small careful lines. Down the sides of houses. Along the edges of paths. Following the small grooves the falaj had cut over the centuries, but also

finding new grooves of its own, places it had not been before, claiming territory the way water always claims territory: with patience, and with the absolute certainty that it had time on its side.

~
~

And the children.

~
~

The children were already outside.

~
~

Not in coats. Not in boots. Not in any of the careful preparations a Northern child would have been wrapped in before being permitted to enter such weather. They were in their normal dishdashas, their normal small girl-dresses, their normal bare feet — and they had taken the rain into themselves the way a desert takes water: completely, joyfully, without any concern at all for the consequences. The mud was a gift. The puddles were a celebration. The specific full wet shining of every small face in the village had the quality of children who had, for the first time in many months, been given an entirely new toy by the sky itself.

~
~

Mansoor was the wettest. **Mansoor** was always the most of whatever was available, but in this specific moment, his commitment to the rain had reached the level of vocation. He jumped — not in any particular pattern, simply jumped, his feet landing in puddles that had not been puddles thirty seconds earlier, sending sprays of muddy water in every direction including, occasionally, his own face.

~
~

"Maaaaaan! It's raining! It's REALLY raining!"

~
~

Ali stood differently. Carefully. His face lifted, his eyes on the sky, the specific full attention of a boy whose mind worked in the careful slow way of a person trying to record something he understood was rare.

~
~

"It's beautiful."

~
~

Noura lifted her face too. But where **Ali's** lifted face had been all observation, hers was all sensation.

~
~

"Cold! But nice!"

~
~

Ahmed, predictably, was already worried. He stood under a small clay overhang, holding his book against his chest with the careful protective posture of a boy who had calculated, immediately and without sentiment, that the rain was a threat to literacy.



"My book... my book is getting wet..."



Khalil, of course, had found the largest puddle in the immediate vicinity and was investigating its capacity for displacement. He threw a stone. The stone landed. A small brown wave rose and broke against the side of the path.



"*Look! River!*"



Sophia stood under the rain holding a bowl on her head — she had brought it out with her without thinking, and now it was protecting nothing because she had stopped caring whether anything was protected. Her hair was wet. Her dress was wet. Her face was full of the specific clean joy of a Northern woman who had been told her whole life that rain was an inconvenience and was discovering, for the first time, that in some places it was a celebration.



"This is... *wonderful*,"

she said. "*And my hair is already ruined.*"



Another *BOOM*. Closer this time. The thunder rolling over the mountains and arriving at the village with the small specific delay of a guest who had decided to make sure he was noticed.



John jumped again. "*The sky is angry.*"



Thuraya pointed.



"Look."

SCENE FOUR

The Wadi Coming Down

They all looked.



And far away, between the mountains — between the specific brown shoulders of the wadi-walls that **Sophia** had walked past every day since she had arrived without ever once thinking of them as anything other than scenery — something had begun to *move*.



Not a flicker. Not a small shift. A movement of scale. Something brown and full and entirely alive was coming down the dry valley, filling it the way breath fills a chest, advancing with the specific full slow inevitability of something that had decided, somewhere up in the high mountains where rain had been falling for hours, that it was time. The riverbed that had been dry yesterday — that had been dry for so many months that even the children had forgotten it was a riverbed — was no longer dry. It was a river. A real river. With current and weight and direction. And it was approaching.

و
ع

Ali shouted. A specific small ancient shout — the shout of an Omani child who had been born knowing the meaning of this particular kind of brown movement between mountains.

و
ع

"Halaaaa! The wadi is coming down!"

و
ع

The wadi.

و
ع

A wide riverbed that was usually dry.

و
ع

Now it was full.

و
ع

Full of fast, brown, strong water — water that had been, two hours ago, raindrops on rocks at three thousand metres altitude, and was now, having gathered itself together with the specific full patience of all mountain water everywhere, descending toward the sea by the only route available to it: this specific small valley, between these specific small mountains, past this specific small village.

و
ع

John stared. His mouth slightly open. The specific full open-mouthed staring of a man who had been told, theoretically, that dry valleys could become rivers, and was now watching the theory become true in front of his eyes.

و
ع

*"That is not a river. That is a *moving mountain*."*

و
ع

Sophia whispered.

و
ع

"It's beautiful... and scary."

و
ع

Thuraya nodded. Her face had the specific small calm competence of a woman who had seen many wadis come down in her life and who had developed, over those years, the right specific small

relationship with the phenomenon — neither afraid nor casual, simply *respectful*.

~

"When the wadi comes like this, it means good rain in the mountains."

~

She paused. And then a small specific smile crossed her face — the kind of smile that meant a plan was already forming.

~

"It also means... we can go to **Tawi Zahir**."

~

The children's eyes lit up. All of them. At the same time. In a single small specific village explosion of joy.

~

Mansoor shouted, "*Swimming!*"

Noura shouted, "*Picnic!*"

Khalil shouted, "*No school!*"

Ahmed shouted, "*Careful!*"

~

The specific small full simultaneous four-direction shouting of four small Omani children whose expectations of the next day had just been completely transformed.

~

John blinked. "*What is Tawi Zahir?*"

~

Thuraya explained — patiently, the way she had explained *letj* and *nabsber* and *magbbar* and every other piece of village life that **John**'s English-trained mind had not previously had a category for.

~

"It's a place where clean water stays after the rain. Pools. Clear water. People go to swim, wash, relax."

~

Sophia clapped. The full small clap of a woman whose travel-instincts had just been activated.

~

"A trip!"

~

John was already excited. "*A trip!*"



Thunder answered again. *BOOM.*



Malood ran between their legs and almost killed everyone — a small wet white missile of goat, fully soaked, fully delighted, fully unconcerned about whether his trajectory through human ankles was welcome. **John**, for his part, did not protest. He had reached, in this village, the specific small acceptance of a man who had decided that some things were simply going to keep happening, and that the most efficient response was to remain upright.

SCENE FIVE

In the Classroom — Past Continuous

The rain stopped.



Not slowly. Not with a long courteous tapering off. Simply *stopped* — the way Omani rain always stopped, with the same suddenness with which it had begun, as if the sky had decided it had made its point and had no further business with the village that morning.



The sky became clean and blue. So blue that **Sophia**, walking back toward the school, had to stop for a moment and just look at it. The specific full deep washed blue of a sky that had, for one morning, allowed itself to be opened, and had now closed itself again — clean, calm, restored.



*The mountains looked washed too. As if the rain had worked through them with the same care a careful person works through silver — polishing each surface, restoring each colour to its full intensity, removing the small specific accumulated dust of months without water. The whole landscape had the specific freshness of a face that has just been splashed with cold water — alert, awake, slightly surprised by its own brightness. The air smelled like new beginnings. There was no other phrase for it. **Sophia** tried, in her head, to find a more sophisticated description, and could not. New beginnings. The smell of a place that had, on this particular morning, agreed to start over.*



In class, everyone was still talking about the rain. The energy of it had not yet drained. The students sat in their normal places but their bodies had not quite returned to their normal stillness — there was still rainwater in the small private parts of their attention, still mud somewhere on their feet, still thunder echoing somewhere in the back of their ears.



John wrote on the board:



WEATHER

٢٧
ع

Then under it, in his careful chalk hand:

٢٨
ع

sun — rain — thunder — lightning — hot — cold — cloudy — rainbow — wadi

٢٩
ع

The last word he wrote slowly. Carefully. With the specific small respect of a teacher who had, that morning, been introduced to the specific Arabic word for a phenomenon his English vocabulary had not previously contained, and who was now placing it, with appropriate ceremony, on his board.

٣٠
ع

He turned around. *"Today, we talk about the weather."*

٣١
ع

Sophia added — *"And about what we were doing."*

٣٢
ع

John wrote:

٣٣
ع

PAST CONTINUOUS

I was... / He was... / They were... + verb-ing

٣٤
ع

He pointed at **Mansoor**. *"Mansoor. What were you doing when it started raining?"*

٣٥
ع

Mansoor stood proudly. With the specific full standing-up of a small boy who had, that morning, performed the action he was about to describe with all the energy his small body possessed.

٣٦
ع

"I was... jumping."

٣٧
ع

John smiled. *"Good. You were jumping."*

٣٨
ع

He pointed to **Noura**. *"And you?"*

٣٩
ع

Noura thought. The specific small thinking-pause of a girl whose morning had contained so many distinct activities that she had to choose between them.

٤٠
ع

"I was... running."

٤١
ع

"Excellent."

~
¶

He pointed to **Sophia**. "*And you, Sophia?*"

~
¶

Sophia laughed. The small full self-aware laugh of a woman who was about to confess a personal indignity to her students.

~
¶

"I was putting bowls under the roof."

~
¶

The class laughed. **John** pointed to himself. "*I was sleeping.*"

~
¶

The class laughed more. **Thuraya** helped — adding more sentences in the same pattern, building each one carefully so the structure could be heard.

~
¶

"Say: The children were playing. The rain was falling. The wadi was coming down."

~
¶

Ali raised his hand. "*Teacher... the rainbow?*"

~
¶

Outside — and they had not noticed it until this moment, because it had appeared with the small slow patience of all rainbows, occupying its corner of the sky without any announcement — a rainbow was forming. Slowly. Each colour declaring itself in turn. The specific full quiet emergence of a rainbow that had been waiting, all morning, for someone to notice it.

~
¶

Everyone ran to the window.

~
¶

"Wow..."

"Look!"

"Two colours!"

"No, many colours!"

~
¶

John smiled. "*Rainbow. When rain and sun meet.*"

~
¶

Sophia whispered. The specific small whisper of a woman who had heard a sentence and recognised, in it, the small unexpected presence of poetry.

~

"That is... *poetry*."

~

John cleared his throat — the specific full English cleared throat of a man who had been, for half a second, accidentally lyrical, and who was now returning to grammar.

~

He wrote:

~

When it started raining...

I was...

~

They practiced together — the small full classroom-chant of children repeating sentences they had just lived:

~

"When it started raining, I was sleeping."

"When it started raining, I was playing."

"When it started raining, I was eating."

~

And then — quietly, from the back of the room, in the specific small careful English of a boy who had spent more time listening than speaking — **Saeed** raised his hand.

~

"When it started raining,"

he said, slowly,

"I was... *watching*."

~

Thuraya looked at him. With the specific full soft eyes of a teacher who had recognised, in a single sentence, both the truth of a particular boy's whole life — that he had spent it at the edges, watching — and the small specific quiet courage of his having said so. Not *I was running*. Not *I was jumping*. *I was watching*. The most honest English sentence in the room, and the most carefully constructed. **Thuraya** did not correct it. **Thuraya** did not embellish it. **Thuraya** simply, with her eyes, received it — and that was the whole of **Saeed**'s reward, and it was, by his own private calculation, more than enough.

SCENE SIX

Planning the Trip — The Village After Rain

After school, everyone gathered outside.

و
ع

The wadi was still running. Loud and strong. The brown water that had arrived from the mountains that morning had not yet finished its journey — it would continue for hours, perhaps for the rest of the day, the specific full slow draining of an entire mountain range through this specific small village's specific small valley.

و
ع

John said, watching it:

و
ع

"If the wadi is like this... *Tawi Zahir* must be amazing."

و
ع

Thuraya nodded. "*We should go tomorrow.*"

و
ع

Sophia clapped again. "*Yes! A real Omani picnic!*"

و
ع

They went to see **Uncle Nasser**. He stood next to his pickup, drinking tea — the specific full calm tea-drinking of a man who had spent his life next to this particular pickup and who had, by long practice, mastered the art of drinking tea while leaning on its side.

و
ع

"You want to go *Tawi Zahir*?"

he asked. "*Tomorrow? Good. I will take you.*"

و
ع

Mansoor jumped. "*With the pickup?*"

"Yes."

Mansoor jumped more.

و
ع

They started planning, the way villages plan such things — not by lists, but by the small specific accumulation of who-volunteered-for-what.

و
ع

Who brings food?

Who brings water?

Who brings firewood?



Sophia and **Thuraya** decided to cook. **John** decided to "help" — a decision which, when it was announced, produced a small specific worried silence among the women, the kind of silence that meant his help would be received politely and then quietly redirected.



The children ran to tell their families. And soon — within the small full hour that all village news takes to travel — people started coming.



Rahma's mother. **Marwa's** aunt. **Salimah's** brothers. The full extended kinship-network of the village converging, over the course of an afternoon, on the small specific project of going together to Tawi Zahir tomorrow.



Even **Uncle Marhoon** said, *"I will bring meat."*



John's eyes became big. *"Meat?"*



"Meshkak,"

Marhoon said proudly.



Malood heard the word "food" and followed him immediately.



That evening, Samail was different.



Everything was green. Clean. Fresh. Birds were singing like they were paid for it — the specific full noisy joy of village birds whose territory had, in a single morning, been completely transformed into a softer version of itself. The mountains looked closer. They always did, after rain. The dust that normally hung between the village and the mountains had been washed out of the air, and so the mountains stood now in the specific full sharp clarity of mountains that had been, for one evening, restored to their original geometry. The air was cool. The houses smelled like wet clay. The children's voices, in the lanes, had a different quality — slower, fuller, the way voices sound on evenings when nothing more needs to be done.



Sophia stood outside the house, breathing deeply. *"This is... the most beautiful day since we came."*



John nodded. *"I think Oman is showing us its secret."*

٢٧
ع

They looked at the wadi one more time. It was still running. Strong. Loud. Alive.

٢٨
ع

Thuraya said quietly:

٢٩
ع

"Tomorrow... *Tawi Zahir*."

٣٠
ع

From far down the lane, **Mansoor** shouted — "*Teacher! I am bringing my swimming clothes!*"

٣١
ع

John shouted back — "*Good! I am bringing... courage!*"

٣٢
ع

Sophia laughed. "*You will need it.*"

٣٣
ع

Malood ran past them, slipped in the mud, stood up, and continued like nothing happened — the specific full goat-resilience of a creature who had decided long ago that mud was simply one of the surfaces, and that all surfaces were, in the final analysis, equivalent.

٣٤
ع

John looked at him. "*You... are not normal.*"

٣٥
ع

Malood answered by eating a leaf.

٣٦
ع

And in the small specific evening of that specific small Samaili day — between the still-running wadi and the still-cooling mountains and the still-soft scent of new beginnings — the village settled, slowly, into its own rest. Tomorrow they would go to Tawi Zahir. Tomorrow they would swim, and eat meshkak, and sit by clear pools, and learn whatever Tawi Zahir was going to teach them. Tonight — tonight was simply the small specific quiet space between the rain that had arrived and the day that was coming. The space in which a village, briefly, was allowed to know that it had been blessed.

٣٧
ع

 Did You Know?**Oman's Wadis and Flash Floods**

The wadi John saw "moving like a mountain" isn't exaggeration — Oman's Al Hajar Mountains see sudden rains between October and March that turn dry wadis into raging rivers within minutes, carrying rocks and tree trunks. Authorities always warn against approaching wadis during and right after rainfall.

Source: [washingtonpost.com](https://www.washingtonpost.com) · [omanobserver.om](https://www.omanobserver.om)

PALM

Palm Twenty-Three

Tawi Zahir — The Pools, the Picnic, and the Mountain Cousin

SCENE ONE

Before the Sun Finished Waking

*There are mornings when a village wakes faster than its sun. When the people, by collective decision the night before, have agreed to be ready before the day begins — and the day, finding them already in motion, has to hurry to catch up. This was such a morning. The sky was still dark blue at the edges, still that specific full pre-dawn blue of an Omani village in October, when the first headlight of **Uncle Nasser's** pickup truck cut into the lane outside **John** and **Sophia's** house.*

☪

The pickup truck was already making noise before the sun finished waking up.

☪

Uncle Nasser was proud of his engine — even if it sounded, in the careful judgement of **John's** English ear, like it was arguing with itself. The engine had its own particular conversation, a kind of metallic disagreement between its various small components that never quite resolved but also never quite broke down. **Uncle Nasser** had decided long ago that this was a feature, not a problem. Engines that argued were engines that were thinking.

☪

John and **Sophia** stood in the back, holding the side carefully — the specific full careful holding of two foreigners who had never before stood in the back of an Omani pickup truck and were not entirely sure what protocol to follow.

☪

Sophia whispered, with the small specific dramatic whisper of a woman about to commit to an unfamiliar kind of risk:

☪

"If I fall, please tell my mother I tried."

☪

John answered bravely — the specific small full husband-bravery of a man who had decided that whatever was about to happen would happen to both of them together.



"If you fall, I fall with you."



Ms. **Thuraya** sat in the front, calm and confident, like always — the specific full passenger-seat composure of a teacher who had ridden in many pickups in her life and who had developed, over those rides, the particular relationship with a moving truck-cab that allowed her to read, think, and occasionally translate all at once.



Behind them came the children. Full of noise and excitement. Carrying the small accumulated kinetic energy of an entire night's anticipation — having barely slept, having woken before their mothers, having dressed in whatever combination of clothes their hands had found in the dark.



Mansoor was jumping without moving — a feat which, until **John** had encountered **Mansoor**, he had not believed was physically possible. The specific full vertical-only motion of a small Omani boy whose body had decided that running in a direction was insufficient and that pure vertical celebration was required.



"We are going! We are going! We are really going!"



Ahmed was checking the bags — the specific small administrative checking of a boy who had appointed himself, without consulting anyone, as the trip's quartermaster.



"Food is here. Water is here. Plates are here. *Good.*"



Khalil was already planning trouble. He always was. It was less an activity than a posture — the specific full forward-leaning ease of a boy who had not yet identified the specific trouble he intended to cause but was certain that, at some point during the day, the right opportunity would present itself.



Malood was there too. Because **Malood** was always there. The principle had been established months ago: where the village went, **Malood** went. The principle was no longer subject to debate.

SCENE TWO

A Place That Was a Dream

The road to Tawi Zabir did not announce its destination. It began the way all village roads began — in dust, in heat, in the specific small anonymous brown of an Omani road that had not yet decided what it was going to show you. They passed the last houses of Samail. They passed the last palm farms. They

passed an old falaj-channel running silver in the early light. The land flattened. Then rose. Then narrowed. The pickup, taking each curve at **Uncle Nasser's** practiced unburied speed, climbed gradually into the small specific landscape that lay between Samail and its quiet neighbour.



The road was dusty, then rocky, then suddenly green.



*It was the suddenness that **Sophia** would remember. Not the gradual transition from one landscape to another. The simple clean specific moment when the brown gave way and the green arrived — full and shocking, the way certain truths arrive after a long silence. There had been water here. The wadi had run last night, and before it, the high mountains had received hours of rain, and now — in this small specific cup of land between the rocks — the consequence of all that water was visible. Trees. Real trees, not the dust-tolerant village palms but full green trees, leaves heavy with the small full memory of the moisture that had passed through them. Grass at the edges of the path. Wild flowers, of small careful varieties that **Sophia** did not know the names of. The whole place was the specific small full demonstration of what Oman was, when Oman had water.*



When they reached Tawi Zahir, everyone became quiet.



The place was beautiful.



*Small clear pools of water lay between the rocks — pools that had not been there a week ago, pools that would not be there in a month. Pools that existed only in the specific small window after rain when the high mountain water had finished its descending and had collected, briefly, in the careful small basins that the rocks of Tawi Zahir had been quietly preparing, over centuries, to receive it. The water was clear. So clear that **Sophia**, looking at it, could see the small specific brown stones at the bottom, each one shifting slightly in the small movement of the water above. Palm trees stood around the pools — not the dusty palms of the village, but palms whose roots had reached the water and whose fronds, as a consequence, hung heavier and greener than any palms **Sophia** had previously seen. The air was cool. Not cold — cool, in the specific full sense of an Omani micro-climate that had organised itself, by water and shade, into a small private pocket of relief from the surrounding heat. Birds were singing — the specific full unselfconscious singing of birds whose territory had, that morning, been visited by something good.*



Sophia covered her mouth.



"This is... a dream."



John looked at the water. The specific small careful look of a man calculating exactly what depth of cold he was about to commit himself to.

و

"This is... *cold*."

و

The children did not care.

و

Mansoor was already taking off his shoes — the specific full single-second shoe-removal of a boy whose mind had decided, before the truck had fully stopped, that his feet were going to be in water within the next ten seconds and that any obstacle to that goal was going to be eliminated immediately.

و

Ali shouted, "*Swimming!*"

Noura shouted, "*Wait!*"

Khalil shouted, "*Last one is a chicken!*"

و

And suddenly — the specific small full collective village-children's suddenness that no foreign visitor had ever yet successfully predicted — everyone was running.

و

Thuraya clapped her hands. "*Careful! Don't run on the rocks!*"

و

Nobody listened.

SCENE THREE

Setting Up the Picnic

The families arrived slowly.

و

*Not in one group. The village did not move that way. They arrived in the specific full unburied way villages always arrive at picnics — one car, then another, then a small group on foot from the closer farms, then a final family in a borrowed truck whose horn announced their arrival before their faces did. The site filled gradually. Mats appeared. Coolers appeared. Stacks of **qafeer** baskets appeared, each containing the small specific contributions of a different household — bread from this house, dates from that, fruit from another. The unspoken protocol of the village potluck, which no one had needed to organise because everyone already knew their part.*

و

Rahma's mother arrived. **Marwa's** aunt arrived. **Salimah's** brothers arrived, carrying firewood. Even **Uncle Marhoon** came, bringing a bag of meat.

﴿

"**Meshkak,**"

he said proudly.

﴿

John's eyes became happy immediately. The specific full instinctive happiness of a man whose body had, over the past months, learned that the word *meshkak* was always followed, sooner or later, by the specific small joy of meat that had been marinated overnight and grilled over a fire that had been built specifically for it.

﴿

Sophia and **Thuraya** started working.

﴿

They put stones in a circle — three flat stones, balanced carefully, so that the cooking pots could rest stably on top of them. The specific small ancient hearth-design that Omani women had been using for generations, that needed no instruction manual, that **Sophia** was learning by watching **Thuraya's** hands. They brought firewood. They started the fire — **Thuraya** doing the actual lighting with the practiced quick small wrist-movements of a woman who had started a thousand fires in her life and would start a thousand more.

﴿

Sophia was cutting vegetables. The specific small full concentration of a foreign woman who had decided that her contribution today would be precise vegetable-cutting, even if her precision was being measured against a Northern standard that Omani village cooking had never required.

﴿

Thuraya was washing rice. Both hands in the small metal bowl, the rice rotating between her palms, the cloudy water being poured off, fresh water being added, the rotation beginning again. The full small rice-washing ritual of an Omani kitchen, which **Thuraya** had been doing since she was nine and which her hands no longer needed to think about.

﴿

They were both very serious.

﴿

John walked around like a boss.

﴿

"I am... *supervising,*"

he said.

٢٧
ع

Thuraya looked at him. The specific full unimpressed look of a woman who had identified, without ambiguity, that **John**'s contribution to the cooking was at this moment subtractive rather than additive.

٢٨
ع

"You are *in the way*."

٢٩
ع

John moved.

٣٠
ع

Malood moved too.

٣١
ع

Unfortunately, **Malood** moved *into* the food bag.

٣٢
ع

"*NO!*"

Sophia shouted.

٣٣
ع

Malood ran away with something green in his mouth — a specific full green leaf-cluster that had, ten seconds earlier, been part of **Sophia**'s carefully washed picnic-vegetables.

٣٤
ع

John chased him. "*Come back here, criminal!*"

٣٥
ع

The children laughed — the specific full village-children's laugh of small spectators who had been waiting, all morning, for the moment when the goat would inevitably commit his picnic-crime.

SCENE FOUR

In the Water

The boys were already in the pools.

٣٦
ع

*Each boy had found his own kind of water. **Ali** was swimming calmly — the specific full slow underwater stroke of a boy who had been taught, by an older brother or an uncle, that water was something you moved through rather than fought with. **Mansoor** was jumping again and again — from the same rock, into the same pool, with no apparent diminishing of enthusiasm between jumps; the specific full repetitive joy of a boy whose body had decided that the act of leaving a rock and entering water was the most satisfying single action available to a human being. **Khalil** was splashing everyone within range — the strategic splashing of a boy who had identified water's military potential. **Abmed***

was sitting at the side, touching the water carefully, as though it might be a kind of liquid that he had not yet been formally introduced to.

۞

"It's cold,"

he said.

۞

"Yes,"

Mansoor answered, mid-jump. *"That's the point."*

۞

John put one foot in.

۞

Then he took it out.

۞

Then he put it again.

۞

Then he took it out again.

۞

*The specific full diplomatic foot-in-foot-out of a Northern man whose body had decided that the temperature of this particular pool was unacceptable but whose pride had decided that retreat was not an option. He was negotiating. **Sophia**, watching from the bank, had identified the negotiation immediately, the way wives identify negotiations they have witnessed many times.*

۞

Sophia laughed.

۞

"You are not swimming. You are *negotiating*."

۞

Finally — perhaps because the boys were watching, perhaps because his pride had completed its calculations, perhaps because the cold water had decided that further negotiation was futile — **John** jumped.

۞

He screamed.

۞

The specific full body-shock scream of a man whose entire body-temperature had been recalibrated in a single second.

☺
☹

Everyone clapped.

☺
☹

"*I am alive!*"

he announced.

☺
☹

The specific small full announcement of a man who had been, in his careful Northern life, never quite this cold and never quite this happy at the same time.

SCENE FIVE

The Lesson Without a Blackboard

Thuraya looked at **Sophia** and smiled. The specific small full conspiratorial smile of two teachers who had identified, simultaneously, the same teachable moment.

☺
☹

"Let's teach them something."

☺
☹

Sophia nodded. She stood and said loudly:

☺
☹

"Okay! *English time!*"

☺
☹

The children groaned a little — the specific small ritual groan of children whose play had been interrupted by the word *English* — but they came. They always came. By now, the relationship between the foreign teachers and the village children had developed into the specific small full friendship in which a small inconvenience was always followed by a small reward.

☺
☹

John stood next to her. He said:

☺
☹

"Today... we use *Present Continuous*."

☺
☹

He said it slowly and clearly, the way he had learned to say everything in this village. The specific full clarity of a man who had discovered that pace and clarity were more valuable than vocabulary range.

☺
☹

"*I am swimming.*"

"He is swimming."

"They are swimming."

٢٧
ع

He pointed at **Ali**. "*Ali, what are you doing?*"

٢٧
ع

Ali answered, calmly, the specific full calm answer of a boy who knew the structure perfectly:

٢٧
ع

"I am swimming."

٢٧
ع

"Good!"

٢٧
ع

He pointed at **Mansoor**. "*Mansoor?*"

٢٧
ع

Mansoor shouted, mid-jump:

٢٧
ع

"*I am jumping!*"

٢٧
ع

"Excellent."

٢٧
ع

He pointed at **Sophia**. "*Sophia?*"

٢٧
ع

She said proudly, holding her wooden spoon as if it were credentials:

٢٧
ع

"*I am cooking.*"

٢٧
ع

Thuraya added — "*I am washing.*"

٢٧
ع

They pointed at **Uncle Marhoon**, standing over his small specific village-fire, turning the meshkak with the careful concentration of a man who had been turning meshkak for thirty years and intended to turn it for thirty more.

٢٧
ع

"What is he doing?"

٢٧
ع

The children laughed.

~

"He is cooking meat!"

"He is making mesbkak!"

~

John wrote in the sand with a stick — the specific full sand-blackboard of an outdoor teacher who had decided that the absence of chalk was not going to prevent the lesson:

~

I am... / He is... / They are... + verb-ing

~

Khalil raised his hand. *"Teacher... Malood?"*

~

Everyone looked.

~

Malood was eating leaves from a bag. A specific bag. A bag that had not, until thirty seconds ago, been within his reach. The specific full goat-determination of a creature who had identified, by smell alone, that this particular bag contained the specific full picnic-leaves that he had decided constituted his afternoon meal.

~

John sighed. *"Malood is... always eating."*

~

They all repeated:

~

"Malood is always eating."

~

The specific full grammatical formulation of a sentence which, the children would soon learn, applied to **Malood** in every possible tense.

SCENE SIX

Disasters, Afternoon, and the Quiet of Saeed

Sophia was mixing something in a pot.

~

She tasted it.

~

Her face changed.

٢٧
ع

She ran to the water.

٢٨
ع

"HOT! HOT! VERY HOT!"

٢٩
ع

She was fanning her mouth — the specific full international gesture of a person whose mouth had, in the last three seconds, been introduced to a quantity of chili it had not been prepared for.

٣٠
ع

Thuraya tasted it. She laughed.

٣١
ع

"You put *too much chili*."

٣٢
ع

John tasted it.

٣٣
ع

He did not speak.

٣٤
ع

He just opened his mouth and stood in front of the wind — the specific full silent mouth-opening of a man whose vocal cords had been temporarily disabled by a quantity of chili that had not previously been documented in any English-language cookbook.

٣٥
ع

The children copied him.

٣٦
ع

Soon, **John**, **Sophia**, and three students were standing in a line, mouths open, facing the air — the specific full village-tableau of five people who had committed, simultaneously, to the same cooling strategy.

٣٧
ع

Mansoor said: "*You look like fish*."

٣٨
ع

The meshkak was ready.

٣٩
ع

Uncle Marhoon was proud — the specific full quiet pride of a man whose meshkak was, by general village agreement, the best meshkak available to the residents of this particular wadi.

٤٠
ع

John ate one. Then another. Then another.

~
ع

Sophia said, *"Slowly."*

~
ع

John said, *"I am enjoying Oman."*

~
ع

Malood tried to steal one. He failed. He tried again. He succeeded. And ran.

~
ع

John shouted: *"That goat is impossible!"*

~
ع

The afternoon settled.

~
ع

People sat. Talked. Laughed. Some were swimming. Some were sleeping. Some were eating. The specific full unhurried Omani-picnic afternoon, in which time had agreed to slow down to the specific small pace of a wadi-pool, and in which no one was responsible for moving anything along. The fire smoked gently. The children kept practicing English without knowing — using the structure they had been taught not because anyone had asked them to, but because the words had entered their mouths and were now coming back out, in small full sentences scattered across the rocks: I am swimming! I am eating! He is sleeping! They are playing!

~
ع

Saeed was sitting on a rock, watching.

~
ع

*Of course he was. Of course **Saeed** was the boy who had selected, in this particular paradise of pools and meshkak and joy, the specific small high rock that gave him the specific small full view of everything without requiring him to be in the middle of any of it. The boy whose first English sentence, the previous day, had been I was watching. The boy whose whole life had been organised around this particular position — at the edge, taking it in, missing nothing.*

~
ع

Thuraya went to him.

~
ع

"What are you doing?"

~
ع

He smiled shyly.

~
ع

"I am... *thinking*."



She smiled back. The specific full quiet teacher-smile of a woman who had recognised, in those two English words, both the truth of **Saeed**'s whole interior life and the small specific fact that he had given her the words for it.



The sun started to go down.



Everyone was tired and happy. They cleaned the place. They packed everything. They moved with the specific small full slow-motion of a village-group that had spent itself on a single excellent day and had nothing left to give but the energy required to drive home.



John looked at the pools one more time.



"This is... *one of the best days of my life.*"



Sophia nodded. "*Mine too.*"



Malood was sleeping inside a bag. Nobody knew how he got there. Nobody questioned it. By this point in the village's relationship with this particular goat, the question of *how* had been replaced, permanently, by the simpler practice of acceptance.



The pickup turned. The wadi shrank in the rear-view. The pools, which had been there for three days and would be gone in three weeks, glittered one more time and then disappeared behind a rock — and the village, full of meshkak and tired children and the specific full sleep-warmth of **Malood**'s breathing, returned home.



Did You Know?

Mishkak — A Beloved Omani Dish

The "mishkak" Uncle Marhoon brought for the swimming trip isn't just casual grilled meat — it's one of Oman's most beloved traditional foods, seasoned with meat or chicken, tamarind, cumin, and cardamom, served at celebrations, weddings, and family gatherings for generations, blending Gulf and African flavors.

Source: tasteatlas.com · omanobserver.om

PALM

Palm Twenty-Four

The Camera, the Tools, and the Fastest Goat in Samail

SCENE ONE

Something Special

There are mornings in a classroom when the air itself becomes the lesson — when something has been brought into the room that the room has not previously contained, and the children, before they have been told what it is, have already begun to lean. The lean comes first. The recognition follows. And by the time the teacher speaks, the lesson has already, in some small invisible way, begun.

☪
☪

The classroom was unusually quiet.

☪
☪

Not because **Mansoor** was absent. Not because **Khalil** was sleeping. Both were present. Both were occupying their normal seats. Both were even, on this particular morning, theoretically obeying the rule about not making noise.

☪
☪

The classroom was quiet because **John** was standing near the blackboard with a very serious face and a very **important-looking** bag. The specific small theatrical bag-holding of a teacher who had decided that the morning's lesson was going to be staged — that the bag itself was, before any object came out of it, already part of the pedagogy.

☪
☪

Sophia sat next to **Thuraya**. Watching him with a small smile — the specific small wifely smile of a woman who knew exactly what was about to happen, and who was looking forward, with a small shared private pleasure, to watching it happen.

☪
☪

"Today," **John** said. Slowly. Proudly. "...we have... something special."

☪
☪

The children leaned forward.

☪
☪

The specific full collective lean of twelve small bodies who had, in the first three syllables of something special, recognised that the lesson was about to be unusual. The lean had its own grammar. It was not the same as the lean of curiosity about a difficult question, nor the lean of attention before an explanation. It was the small specific anticipatory lean reserved for moments when the teacher's voice carried a different weight, and the children, expert readers of teacher-weight, had already understood that today was different.

و
ع

Mansoor whispered, "Maybe sweets."

Ahmed whispered, "Maybe books."

Khalil whispered, "Maybe trouble."

و
ع

The specific three small whispers that, together, summarised the three different worldviews of the back row — **Mansoor** hoped for sugar, **Ahmed** hoped for knowledge, **Khalil** simply *hoped*, with no specifications, the way certain boys hope: vaguely, eternally, ready to celebrate whatever the day produced.

و
ع

John opened the bag carefully.

و
ع

And took out a black camera.

و
ع

The specific small black camera of a 1973 English schoolteacher — a Kodak, perhaps, or a small German box-style camera, with its leather strap, its small front lens, its specific body of stamped metal that had, in the village's eyes, the unmistakable look of a foreign object. It was, perhaps, the first camera that had ever been displayed openly in this specific classroom. The children had seen photographs before — there were photographs in the village, brought back by uncles who had worked in Bahrain or Kuwait, framed photographs of weddings in city studios — but the device that made photographs had until this moment existed only as rumour, as theory, as something that happened in other places to other people.

و
ع

The class exploded.

و
ع

"Abooooy!"

"What is that?"

"Does it bite?"

"Is it a radio?"

و
ع

The four questions arriving simultaneously, from four different small corners of the room, with the specific small full classroom-democracy of a moment in which every child had decided, at the same instant, that their question was the most important.

~
~

Sophia laughed. *"No, no. This is a camera."*

~
~

Ali raised his hand. *"Teacher... it steals faces?"*

~
~

John blinked. The specific small startled blink of a man whose own English-language framing of the camera had just collided with a different framing entirely — a framing he had not expected, but which, the more he thought about it, was not unreasonable. The camera *did*, in some sense, steal faces. The English word for what it did was simply less honest than **Ali's**.

~
~

"No. It... keeps memories."

~
~

He lifted it. He looked through it.

~
~

CLICK.

~
~

The sound alone made half the class jump. The specific full village-classroom jump of children whose ears had, until this moment, been used to softer instruments — chalk, paper, the small wooden complaints of school furniture — and who had now, without warning, been introduced to a small mechanical sound that contained, somewhere in its tiny shutter-mechanism, the entire foreign promise of modernity.

~
~

Mansoor shouted, *"It shot me!"*

~
~

Thuraya laughed. *"It's not a gun. It's a camera."*

SCENE TWO

We Use ... For ...

John wrote on the board:

~
~

We use ... for ...

~
~

He turned around. *"Repeat: We use..."*

~

The class: *"We use..."*

~

He pointed at the camera. *"We use a camera for..."*

~

Ahmed thought carefully. The specific careful Ahmed-thinking of a boy who, before answering, conducted a small internal English audit, comparing the structure on the board against the small inventory of verb-forms he had been quietly compiling in his head since the school year began.

~

"For... taking pictures."

~

"Excellent!"

~

John smiled. He wrote:

~

We use a camera for taking pictures.

~

Then **Thuraya** stood up. She brought a small basket — a small woven palm-leaf **basket** of the specific shape that Omani households had been weaving, by hand, for centuries. **John** had seen many of these baskets. He had not understood, until this moment, that he was about to see one used as a teaching aid.

~

Inside were *strange* things.

~

Strange to **John**. Entirely ordinary to the children.

~

*This was the small specific quiet pedagogy that **Thuraya** had been planning, perhaps for days. **John** had brought the foreign object — the camera, the symbol of the world the children did not yet know. **Thuraya** had brought the local objects — the symbols of the world the children knew so completely that they had perhaps stopped seeing them. And the lesson would weave the two together, so that by the end the children would have used English to describe both the strange foreign and the familiar local, and would have learned, without anyone saying it explicitly, that English was a language capable of carrying their own world as well as someone else's.*

~

She took out a **ma'wal**. A hoe.

و
ع

"We use a ma'wal for...?"

و
ع

Ali said, proudly, *"For farming."*

و
ع

Then she took out a **heeb**. A small sickle.

و
ع

"And this?"

و
ع

Noura said, *"For cutting grass."*

و
ع

Then came the **majz**.

و
ع

Some students laughed. The specific nervous laugh of children who had, all of them, encountered the *majz* at some point in their short lives — usually in the form of a story their grandmother had told them, sometimes in the form of an actual treatment that they remembered with the specific small clarity of a small physical event that had not been negotiated with.

و
ع

"We use a majz for... cutting and... treatment," **Thuraya** said. Carefully. The specific small careful English of a teacher who had decided, in real time, to honour the village practice without overstating its scientific basis. *Treatment* was a sufficient word. *Cure* would have been too much.

و
ع

John nodded. Slowly. *"Oman has... very brave medicine."*

و
ع

Then came the **mowqa'a**. A garlic crusher.

و
ع

Sophia pressed it. The class laughed.

و
ع

"We use this for garlic!"

و
ع

Then a silver kohl stick — the specific small silver mirwad of an Omani woman's collection.

و
ع

"We use this for... eyes."

٢٧
ع

Then a **marjal**. A big pot.

٢٨
ع

Then a **qafeer**. A basket.

٢٩
ع

The board was full:

٣٠
ع

*We use a ma'wal for farming.
We use a beeb for cutting grass.
We use a majz for cutting.
We use a camera for taking pictures.*

٣١
ع

John was very happy. The specific full quiet teacher-happiness of a man who had watched his lesson plan and his colleague's lesson plan converge into a single coherent classroom moment.

٣٢
ع

"This is... a perfect lesson."

٣٣
ع

That was the moment **Malood** chose to become famous.

SCENE THREE

The Fastest Goat in Samail

Nobody knew how.

٣٤
ع

Nobody saw how.

٣٥
ع

But suddenly — the camera was not in **John**'s hand.

٣٦
ع

It was in **Malood**'s mouth.

٣٧
ع

*The specific magical small disappearance-trick of a goat who had, over months in this classroom, perfected the small art of being beneath everyone's awareness exactly when the most valuable object in the room was within his reach. **Sophia** would later swear she had been looking at the camera. **Thuraya** would later swear she had been looking at **Malood**. The two facts, somehow, had not **overlapped**. There was, somewhere in the small specific spatial geometry of the classroom that morning, an invisible window of half a second in which both pairs of teacher-eyes had been pointed elsewhere — and through that*

window, with the specific full surgical precision of a creature who had been waiting his whole life for exactly this opportunity, **Malood** had executed the most ambitious theft of his career.

٢١٤

Malood turned.

٢١٥

Malood ran.

٢١٦

Sophia screamed. *"THE CAMERA!"*

٢١٧

John shouted. *"STOP THAT GOAT!"*

٢١٨

The class exploded into chaos.

٢١٩

Mansoor ran first.

Then **Khalil**.

Then **Ali**.

Then half the class.

٢٢٠

Malood ran. Like a champion. The specific full focused running of a small white goat who had identified, with absolute clarity, that he was carrying the most valuable object he had ever stolen and that the entire human population of the building was now organised around recovering it from him.

٢٢١

He jumped over a bag.

٢٢٢

He passed under a table.

٢٢٣

He escaped through the door.

٢٢٤

Everyone followed.

٢٢٥

In the yard, **Malood** ran in circles. The specific zigzag goat-circles of a small thief who had calculated, correctly, that a moving target was harder to catch than a straight one — and who was, in addition, enjoying himself.

John ran after him. Holding his bag.

Sophia ran after **John**.

Thuraya ran after **Sophia**.

Ahmed ran after everyone — still holding a notebook. The specific small administrative running of a boy who had, even mid-chase, refused to abandon his classroom equipment.

And then...

A hero appeared.

Sadou.

Sadou the shop owner.

He was passing by. Carrying a box.

He saw the goat.

He saw the camera.

He understood everything in one second.

*The specific full one-second comprehension of a man who had spent his entire life as **Sadou** the shop owner, in this specific village, with this specific goat, and who had developed — through long observation — the capacity to read any situation involving **Malood** with the speed of a man reading his own handwriting. He did not need explanation. He did not need context. The goat had something. The teachers wanted it back. He was the available adult. The mathematics of the situation resolved itself in his head in the time it took him to put down his box.*

He put the box down.

٢٧
ع

He opened his arms.

٢٨
ع

Malood ran straight into him.

٢٩
ع

Sadou caught him like a football — the specific full triumphant football-catch of a man who had performed exactly this manoeuvre, with exactly this goat, on at least three previous occasions and had developed, by this point, the specific technique it required.

٣٠
ع

The yard clapped.

٣١
ع

John arrived. Breathing like he had run from Britain.

٣٢
ع

He took the camera. He hugged it.

٣٣
ع

"Thank you, Sadou. You saved my memories."

٣٤
ع

Sadou smiled. Proudly.

٣٥
ع

"Malood always want be star."

٣٦
ع

The class laughed — the specific full village-laughter of children who had recognised, in **Sadou's** small careful English sentence, that the goat's whole life had finally been named.

SCENE FOUR

Many Pictures

That day, **John** took many pictures.

٣٧
ع

The students.

٣٨
ع

The tools.

٣٩
ع

Malood.

٤٠
ع

Mansoor jumping.

20
ع

Khalil making faces.

20
ع

Ahmed fixing his hair.

20
ع

Even **Thuraya**, secretly.

20
ع

*The specific small secret photograph of a teacher he had, by now, come to know well — the photograph he took without her permission, with the specific small thief-photographer's instinct that all good photographers possessed, when she was looking somewhere else, when her face was caught at a small angle that revealed something true about her. The photograph he would, when developed, hang on a small hook in their kitchen, and which, fifty years later, would be one of the few surviving photographs of **Thuraya** at the age of forty-two, in her clean white scarf, watching the small troubles of her village classroom with the specific patient amused eye of the person who had, in all of **John's** life, taught him most about a country.*

SCENE FIVE

The Darkroom

That evening, in the house, the lights were low.

20
ع

The windows were closed.

20
ع

The room was dark.

20
ع

John was very serious.

20
ع

"*This*," he said, "*is the **darkroom**.*"

20
ع

Sophia held a paper. Carefully.

20
ع

Thuraya watched. With curiosity. The specific small full curiosity of a woman who had, until this evening, only ever encountered photographs as finished objects, and who was now being shown the specific small alchemical process by which a chemical reaction produced an image.

20
ع

They put the paper in liquid.

~

Nothing.

~

*The specific patient nothing of a developing tray in its first ten seconds — when the chemistry was, invisibly, beginning to act on the silver halide crystals embedded in the paper, but had not yet produced any visible image. The specific holding-of-breath that all photographers knew, in those years before digital, when every photograph had to be waited for. **Thuraya** had not understood, until that exact moment, that photography was a slower process than she had imagined. The image was being delivered by chemistry. Chemistry took its time.*

~

Then slowly...

~

A face appeared.

~

Sophia gasped. *"It's Mansoor!"*

~

Then another.

~

"It's Malood!"

~

Then another.

~

"It's you!" **Thuraya** laughed.

~

They hung the photos. To dry.

~

The wall was full of memories.

~

John sat down. Tired but happy.

~

"These," he said, *"are our days."*

~

Sophia smiled. Softly. *"And we almost lost them to a goat."*

٢٧
ع

From outside, they heard:

٢٨
ع

"Me-e-e-e!"

٢٩
ع

John closed his eyes. *"That goat will be in every picture."*

SCENE SIX

A Wall of Days

They hung the photos one by one along the small string they had tied between two nails on the kitchen wall.

٣٠
ع

*The specific small careful hanging of a photo-line — each photograph attached with a small wooden clothes-peg, each one slightly damp still, each one carrying its own specific small story. The first photograph: **Mansoor** mid-jump, both feet off the ground, his face the specific full unrestrained joy that was, in that village, his trademark. The second: **Malood**, with the camera in his mouth, looking at **John** with what appeared to be — though it could not have been — satisfaction. The third: **Sadou** holding **Malood** like a football, the specific full triumphant face of a man who had been, for one minute, a hero. The fourth: **Ahmed** in his careful straight ruler-posture. The fifth: **Khalil** making a face. The sixth: **Noura** pointing at something the camera had not captured, her finger frozen at the specific exact angle of a girl whose hand had been her whole life faster than her thoughts. The seventh: **Saeed**. In the corner. Watching.*

٣١
ع

Thuraya stopped at the seventh photograph.

٣٢
ع

She looked at it. For a long moment. The specific full long teacher-look of a woman who had, in that single small image, recognised, in advance of anyone else, the small future of a small boy.

٣٣
ع

"Saeed," she said, quietly.

٣٤
ع

Sophia nodded.

٣٥
ع

"He is in many of them," she said. "Always at the side. Always watching."

٣٦
ع

Thuraya smiled. The specific small full smile of a woman who had, for the third time that month, witnessed the small private satisfaction of seeing her quietest student claim a small permanent place in the village's photographic record.

~

"He is collecting," she said, "again. But this time... he is collecting in the picture, not from outside it."

~

John, drying his hands on a small cloth, came over.

~

He looked at the photograph of **Saeed**. He thought for a moment. Then he said — quietly, in the specific small reflective voice he used when he had just understood something he had not, until that moment, fully grasped —

~

"In the next pictures," he said, "he will be in the middle. Not the side."

~

Sophia smiled. *"You think?"*

~

"I will make sure," **John** said.

~

The specific small full husband-promise of a man who had, after a tiring photographic day and a small darkroom revelation, decided that one of his small future projects in this village was going to be the deliberate, careful documentation of the specific shy boy who had, for too long, been at the edges.

~

Outside, in the small yard, **Malood** bleated once.

~

Then went back to whatever **Malood** went back to.

~

The wall of photographs glowed quietly in the small yellow lamplight of the kitchen. And **John**, looking at it, understood — with a small specific clarity that he would carry with him for the rest of his life — that he had, that day, taken the first photographs of a place that would, slowly, become his.

 Did You Know?**The History of Photography and the Darkroom**

The scene where Thuraya and Sophia watch their photos slowly emerge in the developing liquid isn't magic — it's real chemistry. The first photographic process was invented by Nicéphore Niépce around 1824, and the term "darkroom" only became formalized in 1841 as light-sensitive materials developed further.

Source: museocamera.org

PALM

Palm Twenty-Five

The Day Nobody Spoke Arabic

SCENE ONE

The Tired Fan and the Important Envelope

The classroom was louder than usual.

و

Not because the students were talking.

و

Because the fan was.

و

It stood in the corner. Shaking. The specific small full-body shake of an old standing fan whose internal balance had, after several years of Samaili use, drifted slightly out of true — so that every rotation produced a small wobble, and the metal cage rattled against the small frame, and the whole machine sounded like it had a fever. rrrrrrrrrr... rrrrrrrr... The specific tired motor-sound of a fan that had been working since dawn and was, by now, in the specific small middle-aged afternoon of its electrical life. The students no longer registered it consciously. It had been the soundtrack of their classroom for years. But on this particular morning, in the small specific quiet that was about to be required, the fan would emerge — briefly, accidentally — as the loudest thing in the room.

و

John stood near his desk. Holding a big envelope — like it was a treasure chest. The specific small careful holding of a brown manila envelope that had been, the previous evening, filled with the freshly-developed photographs from the kitchen darkroom, and which now contained, in its quiet manila weight, the entire visual history of the previous month.

و

Sophia stood next to him. Trying very hard not to smile.

و

The specific small wifely effort of a woman who knew exactly what was about to happen — who had, in fact, helped **John** design the rule the previous evening — and who was looking forward, with the specific contained pleasure of a teacher waiting for her own joke to land, to watching it.

۞

Thuraya leaned against the wall. Arms crossed. Watching the students' faces.

۞

All the children were sitting... very... very... straight.

۞

The specific full upright posture of twelve small bodies who had registered, in the specific solemn way **John** was holding the envelope, that this lesson was — somehow — already beginning, even though no one had yet announced its beginning.

۞

Malood was also in the classroom.

۞

Nobody knew how he had entered.

۞

Nobody questioned it anymore.

۞

Malood sat near the window. Like a student who had failed many years but never left school.

۞

The specific small **permanent** classroom-presence of a small white animal who had, by the unstated agreement of the entire school staff, been quietly accepted as a non-paying auditor. The principle had been settled long ago. The principle was no longer subject to debate.

۞

John cleared his throat.

۞

"Today," he said, slowly, "is a very special day."

۞

The students looked at the envelope.

۞

Mansoor whispered, *"Pictures?"*

۞

John raised one finger. *"Yes. But... there is a rule."*

۞

Everyone leaned forward.

SCENE TWO

English Only

"No Arabic," **John** said. Seriously. "Only English. If anyone speaks Arabic..."

~

He pointed at the door.

~

"...outside."

~

The classroom froze.

~

The specific full chamber-of-frozen-bodies stillness of twelve small Omani children who had just, in one short rule, been told that the specific language of their grandmothers, of their food, of their mothers bedtime songs, of the entire dense domestic life of every small body in the room, was, for the next forty minutes, illegal. They had been asked to do many strange things by these foreign teachers. They had been asked to repeat words that had no meaning to them. They had been asked to write letters that ran in the wrong direction. But they had never been asked to refuse their own language. The rule landed in the room with the particular small weight of a rule that no one had previously imposed on these particular small mouths.

~

Ali swallowed.

~

Noura put her hand over her mouth — the specific small instinctive defensive cover of a girl whose mouth was, by long habit, faster than her thinking, and who had decided, in the half-second since the rule, to install a small physical barrier between her lips and her native language.

~

Khalil looked like he was preparing for war.

~

Ahmed sat straight like a ruler. Ready. The specific full focused readiness of a boy who had, in fact, been waiting for exactly this kind of challenge — the kind that rewarded careful preparation.

~

Saeed was quiet. Watching everything carefully.

~

Matla smiled. Confidently. The specific small confident smile of a girl whose private opinion was that she would, of course, be the first to obey the rule successfully.

~

Rahma and **Salma** looked at each other. Nervous.

٢٧
ع

Marwa whispered, "*Oh no.*"

٢٨
ع

John wrote on the board. In big letters:

٢٩
ع

ENGLISH ONLY TODAY

٣٠
ع

Then he added:

٣١
ع

This is... / He is... / She is...

٣٢
ع

Sophia clapped her hands. "*Okay! Who wants to start?*"

٣٣
ع

Silence.

٣٤
ع

Even **Malood** was silent.

٣٥
ع

John opened the envelope. He took out the first photo.

٣٦
ع

He lifted it.

٣٧
ع

It was **Malood**.

٣٨
ع

Malood in the yard. **Malood** on the table. **Malood** in front of the door. **Malood** eating. **Malood** sleeping.

٣٩
ع

Malood was everywhere.

٤٠
ع

The class exploded with laughter.

٤١
ع

John smiled. "*Okay. Who?*"

٤٢
ع

Mansoor jumped up. *"Me! Me!"*

٢٧
ع

John nodded. *"English."*

٢٨
ع

Mansoor took a deep breath. The specific full preparatory deep-breath of a small boy who was, for the first time, about to attempt a complete English sentence under specific external pressure.

٢٩
ع

"This is... Malood."

٣٠
ع

John clapped. *"Good! Very good!"*

٣١
ع

Mansoor pointed at the picture. *"He is... he is... eating!"*

٣٢
ع

Sophia added, *"Yes! He is eating."*

٣٣
ع

Malood looked proud.

SCENE THREE

Smoke, Maghbar, and the First Slip

The next photo.

٣٤
ع

It was **Sheikh Khalaf**.

٣٥
ع

He was standing near his clay house. Throwing smoke in the air. Doing **maghbar**.

٣٦
ع

Some students gasped. The specific small village-children's gasp of a class whose collective childhood folklore had assigned **Sheikh Khalaf** a specific small mythic place, and who had now been asked to look at a photograph of him performing a ritual that, according to all the stories they had heard, was supposed to be private.

٣٧
ع

Ali whispered. In Arabic.

٣٨
ع

«هو...»

٣٩
ع

John pointed. *"Outside."*

٢٧
ع

Ali froze. The specific full small-boy frozen face of a student who had just, in two syllables of his own native language, lost the rule. The specific small full self-betrayal of a child whose mouth had moved before his mind had remembered.

٢٨
ع

"No no no! Sorry! Sorry!"

٢٩
ع

He tried again. Slowly. *"This is... Sheikh Khalaf."*

٣٠
ع

Thuraya smiled. *"Good."*

٣١
ع

Khalil added, *"He is... making smoke."*

٣٢
ع

John nodded. *"Yes. He is making smoke."*

٣٣
ع

Sophia explained — *"In English: He is doing something. He is making something."*

٣٤
ع

Thuraya added — first in Arabic for the children, then translating for **John** — *"They used to do this to chase bad luck."*

٣٥
ع

The next photo.

٣٦
ع

John.

٣٧
ع

His eyes were red and swollen. Dust on his face. Looking like a very tired ghost.

٣٨
ع

The class laughed again. The specific full village-classroom laugh of children whose teacher had, in one photograph, been reduced to a recognisable subspecies of comedy.

٣٩
ع

Noura raised her hand. *"Teacher... English."*

٤٠
ع

She stood. *"This is... Mr. John."*

٤١
ع

She pointed at his eyes. *"He is... not happy."*

20
€

The class laughed more.

20
€

John sighed. *"He was not happy."*

20
€

Ahmed corrected — politely, the specific full polite correction of a boy who had been waiting all morning for a chance to use his good grammar — *"He was not happy."*

20
€

John looked at him. *"Thank you, Ahmed."*

SCENE FOUR

Yellow Ladies and the Door

The next photo.

20
€

Safiya and **Fatkat**.

20
€

Both of them.

20
€

Yellow.

20
€

Very yellow.

20
€

Like lemons.

20
€

*The specific small full saffron-mask catastrophe of a previous afternoon was now permanently preserved on photographic paper, hanging in **John's** hand for the entire classroom to inspect. **Sophia** would, in later years, when she became a real Muslim called Safiya not just by the village but by herself, look back at this photograph and laugh — but in this specific moment, in this specific classroom, the photograph was still raw, and so was the indignity it documented.*

20
€

Fatkat's mouth was open. In shock.

20
€

Safiya was trying to smile.

٢٧
ع

The class fell on the floor laughing.

٢٨
ع

Marwa stood up. *"This is... Miss Sophia and Miss Fatkat."*

٢٩
ع

She thought. The specific careful Marwa-thinking of a girl who had, in the half-second of consideration, decided that the safest and most accurate description was the most direct.

٣٠
ع

"They are... yellow."

٣١
ع

Fatkat — who was standing near the door — shouted in Arabic:

٣٢
ع

«يا شيخة فضيحة»

٣٣
ع

(Oh dear, what a scandal!)

٣٤
ع

Safiya laughed. *"Skin care."*

٣٥
ع

Thuraya added, laughing — *"But the skin doesn't care."*

٣٦
ع

Even **Mohammedeen** — passing by the door — laughed and said in his Egyptian Arabic:

٣٧
ع

«والله عاملين زي الليمون»

٣٨
ع

(I swear they look just like lemons.)

٣٩
ع

The next photos.

٤٠
ع

One by one.

٤١
ع

Ali holding a fish.

٤٢
ع

Khalil making a silly face.

٤٣
ع

Matla standing like a queen.

٢٧
ع

Rahma and **Salma** together. Shy.

٢٨
ع

Marwa falling near the falaj.

٢٩
ع

Noura pointing at something and shouting.

٣٠
ع

Saeed in the corner of many photos.

٣١
ع

Watching.

٣٢
ع

Always watching.

٣٣
ع

Ahmed helping others.

٣٤
ع

Mansoor... in almost every picture... *running*.

SCENE FIVE

A Whole Class in English

Each student stood. Each student said something.

٣٥
ع

"This is Ali."

"He is holding a fish."

٣٦
ع

"This is Matla."

"She is standing."

٣٧
ع

"This is Khalil."

"He is... uh... funny."

٣٨
ع

Sometimes they made mistakes. Sometimes they stopped and thought. Sometimes **Ahmed** helped. Sometimes **Thuraya** helped.

٣٩
ع

But nobody spoke Arabic.

٢٧
ع

Not even **Malood**.

٢٨
ع

Malood only made a "meeeh" sound. The specific small low-volume goat-vocalisation that did not, in the strictest grammatical sense, qualify as either Arabic or English, and which therefore remained, throughout the lesson, the only legal non-English utterance in the room.

٢٩
ع

Then **John** showed a photo.

٣٠
ع

It was **Sadoo**. Holding **Malood**. Like a hero.

٣١
ع

Safiya said, "This is Sadoo. He is saving the camera."

٣٢
ع

John nodded. "Yes. Very brave."

٣٣
ع

Then one more photo.

٣٤
ع

It was taken secretly.

٣٥
ع

The class in the shop.

٣٦
ع

The class in the street.

٣٧
ع

The class playing.

٣٨
ع

The class running.

٣٩
ع

The students stared.

٤٠
ع

*The specific full collective stare of children who had just realised, with a small mixed feeling of pleasure and small **indignation**, that they had been being photographed, secretly, for some time. The teacher, who had introduced the camera to them as a tool for taking pictures, had — without telling them — been taking pictures all along.*

Matla asked, in English, slowly, *"Teacher... when?"*

Thuraya smiled. *"He took them secretly."*

The class looked at John.

John pretended to be innocent.

"I am a photographer," he said. Proudly.

SCENE SIX

The Bell, the Tunisian, and Saeed's Smile

The bell rang.

Drrrrrrrrriiiiiing!

Everyone jumped.

Mansoor shouted — without thinking, the specific instinctive Arabic exclamation of a boy whose excitement had, in the half-second after the bell, broken every rule of the morning —

«تلااقة!»

(Tlaaagah! — A shot/discharge!)

Rabaa — the Tunisian music teacher, who happened to be passing by — screamed.

«يا رب! من ضرب؟»

(Ya Rab! Who shot?!)

Thuraya laughed. *"Not gun. School finish."*

Rabaa held her heart — the specific full heart-grasping of a Tunisian woman whose nerves had, in the moment of **Mansoor**'s mistranslation, registered a real urban-emergency. *"You scared me!"*

٢٧

The students ran out.

٢٨

Shouting. Laughing. Singing — the specific small Omani schoolyard song that **Safiya** would, by now, have heard half a dozen times that month —

٢٩

يا سابقنا دوس دوس»
«!الله بيعث لك عروس»

٣٠

(Ya saaceegna doos doos / Allah yeb'ath lak aroos! — Hey driver, press, press / May God send you a bride!)

٣١

The specific full village-children's running-song that had, somewhere in the last several decades, been composed by some unknown small mouth and which had, since then, been sung by every generation of small Omani children running out of school — passed down without a teacher, without a textbook, with the small specific cultural precision of children who learned by hearing and who never forgot.

٣٢

John sat on his chair. Tired but happy.

٣٣

Safiya sat next to him. *"Today... they spoke English."*

٣٤

Thuraya smiled. *"And nobody died."*

٣٥

Malood jumped on the desk. He tried to eat a photo.

٣٦

John shouted. *"No!"*

٣٧

Malood ran.

٣٨

Everyone laughed.

٣٩

Outside, **Saeed** stood for a moment.



*The specific small standing-still of a quiet boy who had, throughout the morning, been part of the lesson — who had, when his turn had come, said one of his careful small English sentences ("This is Saeed. He is watching.") — and who was, now, in the doorway, taking a small last look back. Looking at the classroom. Looking at the photos still spread across **John's** desk. Looking at **Thuraya**, who had, throughout the lesson, given him exactly the small attention he needed — not too much, not too little, the specific calibrated amount of attention that, in his nine-year-old life, had only ever been **calibrated** for him by her.*



Then he smiled.



The specific small private smile of a boy whose private internal records had, that morning, registered the specific moment when he had — for the first time — *not* been at the side of a photograph, but in the middle of it.



And ran after the others.



Did You Know?

Turmeric Face Masks in Arab Beauty Traditions

Remember Safiya's and Fatima's faces turning bright yellow in this chapter? That's not a joke — it's a genuine beauty tradition across the Arabian Peninsula and South Asia, where turmeric is used to make skin-brightening masks, especially for weddings. Its active compound, curcumin, has anti-inflammatory properties known for thousands of years.

Source: jdvL.com · en.wikipedia.org

PALM

Palm Twenty-Six

The Detective Game and the Missing Treasure

SCENE ONE

When Thuraya Smiles Like That

The classroom was unusually quiet.

~

Not because the students were well-behaved. No. That almost never happened.

~

It was quiet because Ms. **Thuraya** was smiling.

~

And when Ms. **Thuraya** smiled *like that*, something dangerous was coming.

~

*The specific small Thuraya-smile of which the village had — over years — learned to be careful: not the open warm smile she gave to grandmothers at the falaj, not the small teacher-smile she used for grammar corrections, but the third, more **conspiratorial** smile that meant: I have, in the last twelve hours, designed a small game, and I am about to release it onto the world. The students had learned to read this smile the way village children learn to read weather. The smile predicted the climate of the next forty minutes. And that climate, today, was going to involve effort.*

~

John was standing near the blackboard, holding a piece of chalk. **Safiya** was sitting at the small teacher's desk, fixing her notebook. **Mohammadeen** was leaning against the wall with his arms crossed. **Fatkat** was fanning herself with a book.

~

Malood, the baby goat, was sitting near the window, chewing something that nobody wanted to know the name of.

~

Thuraya clapped her hands once.

~

"Today," she said, in English, "*we will not sit and write.*"

The students' eyes lit up.

Mansoor almost fell from his chair. "*Teacher... we go home?*"

John laughed. "*No, Mansoor. Worse.*"

The class groaned.

Thuraya continued. "*Today, we play a game.*"

Now the class exploded.

"*A game?*" **Noura** said.

"*A real game?*" **Marwa** asked.

"*A running game?*" **Mansoor** shouted.

Thuraya raised her hand. "*A detective game.*"

She went to her bag. She took out a big, old-looking paper. She opened it carefully — the specific small ceremonial unfolding of a paper that had been, the previous evening, drawn with deliberate care by a teacher who had decided to give the village a small adventure.

It was a map.

"*This,*" she said, "*is the map of today's mystery.*"

Safiya leaned forward. "*Oh, I like this already.*"

John looked at the map. Seriously. "*Is there... danger?*"

Thuraya smiled innocently. "*Always.*"

SCENE TWO

The Treasure That Is Hidden

The students came closer. Even **Ahmed** left his perfect straight sitting position and leaned forward — the specific small full Ahmed-lean of a boy whose normal posture did not permit such concessions, but whose curiosity had, on this occasion, overruled his discipline.

ⲁⲩⲓⲛⲓ

"Somewhere," **Thuraya** said, pointing to a drawing of a tall palm tree, *"there is a treasure."*

ⲁⲩⲓⲛⲓ

"Treasure?" **Khalil** whispered. Dramatically.

ⲁⲩⲓⲛⲓ

"Yes. But it is missing."

ⲁⲩⲓⲛⲓ

Mansoor stood up. *"Who stole it?"*

ⲁⲩⲓⲛⲓ

Thuraya looked at **Malood**.

ⲁⲩⲓⲛⲓ

Malood blinked.

ⲁⲩⲓⲛⲓ

Everyone laughed — the specific full classroom-laugh of children who had immediately understood the joke without needing it explained.

ⲁⲩⲓⲛⲓ

"No," **Thuraya** said. *"The treasure is not stolen. It is hidden. And you must find it."*

ⲁⲩⲓⲛⲓ

John clapped his hands. *"Okay! Today's lesson is instructions."*

ⲁⲩⲓⲛⲓ

He wrote on the board:

ⲁⲩⲓⲛⲓ

Go straight

Turn left

Turn right

Stop

Don't run

Look under...

Look behind...

٢٥

Safiya added, *"And remember: Only English."*

٢٥

The students looked at each other. In fear. The specific small full village-children's fear of children who had, just yesterday, lived through the small specific torture of an English-only morning, and who had not, until this moment, prepared themselves for a sequel.

٢٥

Mohammadeen lifted his stick. Slowly. *"Today... I also speak only English."*

٢٥

The class went silent — the specific small full Egyptian-shock-silence of a class whose Egyptian Arabic teacher, who was technically not even supposed to be participating in this lesson, had just announced his alignment with the rule.

٢٥

Fatkat smiled. Sweetly. *"Good luck, my children."*

٢٥

Thuraya divided them into two teams.

٢٥

"Team One," she said, *"the boys."*

٢٥

The boys cheered.

٢٥

"Team Two, the girls."

٢٥

The girls cheered louder. The specific full village-girls'-cheer of a group that had, by long experience, calibrated their volume specifically to be slightly louder than the boys' cheer, regardless of how loud the boys had been.

٢٥

"Team One leader," **Thuraya** said, *"is Mr. John and Mr. Mohammadeen."*

٢٥

John saluted. **Mohammadeen** nodded seriously.

٢٥

"Team Two leader is Safiya and Fatkat."

٢٥

Safiya smiled proudly. **Fatkat** cracked her knuckles — the specific small full Fatkat-preparation of an Omani auntie who had decided that this game was going to be won by her team and was beginning her preparations accordingly.

~

*"And Malood," **Thuraya** added, "is with me. For safety."*

~

Malood made a small sound that meant: *I will still cause problems.*

SCENE THREE

The Old Wall and the Falaj

They went outside.

~

The village was warm. The sun was high. The palm trees were quiet — like they were watching the show. The specific small full afternoon-stillness of an Omani village whose adults were inside, whose children had been let out into the lanes, and whose ancient slow palms had, by long custom, settled into the specific small spectator-position of trees that had seen many generations of village children play many generations of village games. The trees were not surprised. The trees, over the centuries, had stopped being surprised by anything.

~

Thuraya gave each team a paper.

~

"Follow the instructions," she said. "Don't cheat. Don't fight. And don't die."

~

John looked worried. *"Is that last one part of the rules?"*

~

"Yes," **Thuraya** said.

~

The game started.

~

Team One ran.

~

*"No running!" **Mohammadeen** shouted.*

~

They walked fast instead. The specific small village-boys'-fast-walking of children who had been told they could not run but had not been told they could not approximate running with their entire bodies.

٢٧
ع

Ahmed read the paper. *"Go straight. Stop at the old wall. Look under the stone."*

٢٨
ع

Mansoor jumped. *"I found it!"*

٢٩
ع

It was another paper.

٣٠
ع

Khalil read it. *"Turn right. Walk ten steps. Look behind the tree."*

٣١
ع

Meanwhile, Team Two was also moving.

٣٢
ع

Safiya was reading. *"Go left. Stop near the falaj. Don't touch the water."*

٣٣
ع

Fatkat laughed. *"Why always don't touch, don't touch?"*

٣٤
ع

They found their next paper near a rock.

٣٥
ع

Marwa read slowly. *"Go... straight... until... you see... a house."*

٣٦
ع

Noura pointed. *"That one?"*

٣٧
ع

But when they arrived, everyone stopped.

٣٨
ع

It was the house of **Shayb Khalaf**.

٣٩
ع

The air suddenly felt... colder. The specific small village-shudder of a group that had walked, by following a series of innocent English instructions, into the small specific cold-zone that surrounded the home of the village's most folkloric inhabitant.

٤٠
ع

"Why here?" **Salima** whispered.

٤١
ع

Fatkat swallowed. *"Who made this map?"*

~

Thuraya, far away, was pretending not to see anything — the specific small full innocent-teacher-pretence of a woman who had, in fact, drawn the map deliberately, with the knowledge that this small village-cold would be part of the lesson.

~

The door of the house was closed.

~

"Look under the tree," **Safiya** said.

~

They ran. Found the paper. Ran away. Very fast. Nobody wanted to stay there.

SCENE FOUR

The Pickup and the Bees

Team One arrived near **Uncle Nasser's** pickup.

~

He was sitting and drinking tea. The specific calm tea-drinking of **Uncle Nasser** on any village afternoon — the same tea, the same pickup, the same small specific tin-cup whose handle had been bent slightly to fit his particular grip.

~

"What are you doing?" he asked.

~

John smiled. *"Learning English."*

~

Uncle Nasser nodded. Like that explained everything. The specific small full village-uncle-nod of a man who had decided long ago that the specific activities of the foreign teachers were to be accepted without examination.

~

The paper said: *"Ask the driver. Then go behind the fence."*

~

Mohammadeen tried. *"Please... sir... where is... the fence?"*

~

Uncle Nasser laughed. *"Behind you, ya ustadh."*

~

They went, and found another paper.

~
~

Team Two arrived near a big tree.

~
~

They heard a sound.

~
~

Bzzzzzz.

~
~

Fatkat stopped. *"No. No. No. I know this sound."*

~
~

Safiya read the paper. *"Look near the tree."*

~
~

The girls looked at each other.

~
~

Mansoor's voice came from far away. *"Maybe it is empty!"*

~
~

Then they heard him scream.

~
~

"BEEEEES!"

~
~

Everyone ran.

~
~

The bees stayed where they were.

~
~

Thuraya wrote something in her notebook: *Good drama.*

SCENE FIVE

Palm Al-Fard

Both teams arrived near the big palm tree called "data-m="Arabic: a single, individual palm tree; here, the specific tall solitary palm that the villagers had named for being the most prominent in this stretch of land" data-s="lone-palm, single-palm" data-x="Palm Al-Fard was the village landmark. Tall, solitary, taller than its neighbours.">Palm Al-Fard.

~
~

The specific full single solitary palm whose name in Arabic — al-fard — meant the only one. It stood at the edge of one of the larger palm farms, taller than its neighbours by a clear margin, with the small specific authority of a tree that had decided long ago that it was going to outgrow every palm around it. Generations of village children had used it as a landmark. Generations of village adults had given directions in relation to it. Past Palm Al-Fard. Before Palm Al-Fard. Just at Palm Al-Fard. The specific small village-cartography of a place that had learned, before any modern map existed, how to organise itself around a single tall tree.

٢٧
ع

Team Two arrived first.

٢٨
ع

Noura looked up. *"There!"*

٢٩
ع

High. Very high. Was a small bag.

٣٠
ع

Fatkat clapped. *"We win!"*

٣١
ع

Safiya looked worried. *"How do we get it?"*

٣٢
ع

They waited.

٣٣
ع

Team One arrived.

٣٤
ع

Khalil looked up. *"It's too high."*

٣٥
ع

John scratched his head. *"We need a hero."*

٣٦
ع

Thuraya walked slowly to them.

٣٧
ع

"So," she said, "you found it. But..."

٣٨
ع

"But?" **Mansoor** asked.

٣٩
ع

"But the game is not finished."

٤٠
ع

She smiled. *"The treasure is there. But how will you get it?"*

~
~

Everyone looked up.

~
~

Very high. Too high.

~
~

Inside the bag, something moved.

~
~

Mansoor whispered, *"Maybe it is a snake."*

~
~

John stepped back. *"Then the game is finished."*

~
~

Thuraya laughed. *"No, no. It is food."*

~
~

Safiya looked at **Fatkat**. *"Food?"*

~
~

Thuraya nodded. *"Honey. And ghee."*

~
~

The students cheered.

~
~

Mohammadeen rubbed his hands. *"Healthy food."*

SCENE SIX

Who Will Climb?

John looked at the tree. *"We need... someone who can climb."*

~
~

Everyone slowly turned.

~
~

Toward one direction.

~
~

The road.

~
~

Footsteps.

٢٧
ع

A voice.

٢٨
ع

"Who needs help?"

٢٩
ع

Sadou was standing there. Carrying a bag. Smiling like he knew everything.

٣٠
ع

*The specific small full timing of **Sadou**'s arrival was, in retrospect, suspicious — the kind of timing that, in a different village, might have prompted the question of whether **Thuraya** had perhaps mentioned the location of Palm Al-Fard to him in advance. But **Sadou** was always passing by. **Sadou** was always carrying a bag. **Sadou** always knew everything. The question of how he had appeared at exactly this moment was, by the village's long experience of **Sadou**, no longer a question worth asking.*

٣١
ع

Thuraya closed her notebook. She looked at both teams.

٣٢
ع

"Tomorrow," she said, "we will continue."

٣٣
ع

The students shouted. *"Tomorrow?!"*

٣٤
ع

*"Yes," **Thuraya** said. "Because tomorrow... you will learn how to ask and promise."*

٣٥
ع

She looked at **Sadou**. *"And maybe... how to convince."*

٣٦
ع

Sadou smiled bigger.

٣٧
ع

Malood suddenly ran to the tree and tried to climb.

٣٨
ع

He failed.

٣٩
ع

Everyone laughed.

٤٠
ع

John looked at the tree, then at **Sadou**, then at the class.

٤١
ع

"Tomorrow," he said seriously, "will be dangerous."

*Far away, from the shade of another tree, a thin shadow moved. Someone was watching. Someone old. Someone quiet. The door of **Shayb Khalaf**'s house closed slowly. The specific small full village-mystery of a man who had, throughout this small game, been watching from a distance — and who, by the specific small careful closing of his door, had now signalled that whatever opinion he held of the foreign teachers games, he had decided not to share it. Not yet. Not today.*



Did You Know?

The Falaj System (a UNESCO World Heritage)

In this chapter, the students' teams pass by the falaj during the detective game. The Omani falaj system distributes water fairly among farmers on a precise schedule once tracked by sundial, and still supplies 30-50% of Oman's water use today. Five Omani falaj systems were UNESCO World Heritage listed in 2006.

Source: whc.unesco.org · en.wikipedia.org

PALM

Palm Twenty-Seven

Convincing Sadou

SCENE ONE

I Will

The next morning, everyone arrived at school early.

٢٧
ع

Too early.

٢٧
ع

Even **Ahmed**.

٢٧
ع

Even **Mansoor**.

٢٧
ع

Even **Malood**.

٢٧
ع

The reason was simple.

٢٧
ع

The treasure.

٢٧
ع

*Honey and ghee were still hanging on Palm Al-Fard. Like a royal secret that refused to come down. The specific small unmoving stillness of a knotted bag at fifteen metres altitude — visible from the school yard, visible from the path, visible from every small angle of the village — and yet, against the laws of childhood, untouched. The whole village had spent the night thinking about that bag. Some of the children had dreamed about it. **Mansoor** had, by his own later admission, woken up at three in the morning to check that it was still there, and had then walked back to bed with the specific full disappointment of a boy who had hoped, briefly, that gravity might have done his work for him.*

٢٧
ع

John stood in front of the class and wrote in big letters:

٢٧
ع

I WILL

٢٧

He turned around. *"Today, we learn how to promise."*

٢٨

Safiya added, *"And how to ask nicely."*

٢٩

Mohammadeen crossed his arms. *"And how to not fight."*

٣٠

Fatkat smiled. *"And how to not cry."*

٣١

Mansoor looked worried. The specific small full Mansoor-worry of a boy who had identified, in the four announcements, four different categories of behaviour at which he was simultaneously expert.

٣٢

Thuraya clapped her hands. *"Today's hero is... **Sadou**."*

٣٣

The students cheered.

٣٤

Outside, **Sadou** was sitting in the shade. Fixing something with a small knife. Looking very proud of himself.

٣٥

*The specific small full **Sadou**-pride of a man who had, the previous afternoon, been informed by **Thuraya** herself that the entire next school day would centre, in some specific small way, on him. He had not asked for the role. He had not negotiated for it. But he had, with the particular small village-confidence of a man whose specific physical talent was finally going to be officially recognised by the foreign teachers, accepted it. **Malood** was standing near him — staring at him like he was planning a crime, the specific small full goat-stare of a creature who had detected, in **Sadou**'s posture, an opponent worth observing closely.*

SCENE TWO

The Refusal

Thuraya took the class outside.

٣٦

Sadou looked up. *"Ah. The English army."*

٣٧

John smiled. *"Good morning, Sadou."*

﴿

Sadou nodded. *"Morning... mister teacher... mister long."*

﴿

The students laughed. The specific full village-children's laugh of a class that had been waiting, since they first met him, for someone to officially comment on **John's** height — and which had decided, immediately, that *mister long* was now **John's** village name.

﴿

John pointed to the palm tree. *"We need your help."*

﴿

Sadou looked up. *"Aba. The bag."*

﴿

Safiya stepped forward. *"Inside the bag is honey and gbee."*

﴿

Sadou's eyes became a little brighter. The specific small full village-shopkeeper's-eye-brightening of a man who had immediately calculated the value, in his shop's small economy, of the specific objects being described.

﴿

Fatkat whispered, *"He is interested."*

﴿

Thuraya said, *"But Sadou, we cannot climb."*

﴿

Sadou crossed his arms. *"And?"*

﴿

John took a deep breath. *"We want you to climb and get it."*

﴿

Sadou looked at the class. Then at the tree. Then at **Malood**.

﴿

"No."

﴿

Everyone froze.

﴿

"No?" Mansoor shouted. *"Why no?!"*

﴿

Sadou smiled. *"Because."*

~
ع

The specific small full village-shopkeeper's-because of a man who had decided that this morning's negotiations were not going to begin in his favour, and who was — with the small specific calm enjoyment of a person who has the upper hand — going to make the children work for it.

~
ع

Khalil whispered, *"He is enjoying this."*

~
ع

Thuraya smiled. Slowly. The specific full slow teacher-smile of a woman who had recognised, in **Sadou's** deliberate refusal, the small specific opportunity she had been waiting for.

~
ع

"Okay. Let's begin the lesson."

~
ع

She turned to the students. *"Remember the sentence?"*

~
ع

The students shouted. Together. *"I will!"*

~
ع

John nodded. *"Good. Now... we try."*

SCENE THREE

The Great Persuasion

Noura was the first.

~
ع

She walked to **Sadou**. She said carefully, *"Sadou... I will give you samboosa."*

~
ع

Sadou didn't even look at her. *"No."*

~
ع

The girls gasped.

~
ع

Ali tried next. *"Sadou... I will give you bakoora."*

~
ع

Sadou shook his head. *"No."*

~
ع

Marwa said, *"I will give you dates."*

٢٧

"No."

٢٨

Rahma tried. *"I will give you bread."*

٢٩

"No."

٣٠

Salima said, *"I will give you tea."*

٣١

Sadou smiled. *"I don't like tea."*

٣٢

The boys started.

٣٣

Khalil said, *"I will give you fish."*

٣٤

Sadou laughed. *"No."*

٣٥

Ahmed said politely, *"I will help you in the shop."*

٣٦

Sadou looked at him. *"For how long?"*

٣٧

Ahmed froze. The specific small full Ahmed-freeze of a boy whose careful planning had not extended to a follow-up question. *"One... day?"*

٣٨

Sadou shook his head. *"No."*

٣٩

Mansoor jumped forward. *"I will give you Malood!"*

٤٠

Everyone screamed.

٤١

Malood screamed louder.

٤٢

Thuraya shouted. "NO!"

~
ع

Sadou laughed so hard he almost fell. "I don't want this trouble."

~
ع

Malood looked offended.

~
ع

Safiya sighed. "Nothing works."

~
ع

Mohammadeen said, "In Egypt, we solve this with shouting."

~
ع

Fatkat nodded. "And sometimes shoes."

SCENE FOUR

Saeed's Whisper

John was thinking. Very hard.

~
ع

He looked at the class.

~
ع

Then at **Sadou**.

~
ع

Then at the tree.

~
ع

Then at **Saeed**.

~
ع

***Saeed** was standing quietly. Watching everything. As he always did. As his whole life had been organised around doing. The specific small full **Saeed**-watching of a boy whose silence was, in that moment, the most attentive silence in the entire school yard. **John** had, by this point in the term, learned to recognise the small specific quality of **Saeed**'s silence — the way you learn to read the silence of a person who knows things they have not yet said. **Saeed** had been watching **Sadou** his whole life. **Saeed**, by his own private long observation, knew what **Sadou** wanted.*

~
ع

John walked to him. He whispered something in his ear.

~
ع

Saeed's eyes became wide.

٢٧
ع

He smiled. Slowly.

٢٨
ع

Then he walked to **Sadou**.

٢٩
ع

Everyone became quiet.

٣٠
ع

Saeed looked up. He said, in his simple English:

٣١
ع

"Sadou... I will give you... chilli. Very hot."

٣٢
ع

The class froze.

٣٣
ع

Thuraya corrected quickly. *"Chilli, not filfil yobroak."*

٣٤
ع

Everyone laughed.

٣٥
ع

Sadou's eyes opened wide. *"Chilli?"*

٣٦
ع

Saeed nodded. Seriously. *"Yes. Big chilli. Very strong."*

٣٧
ع

Sadou's face changed.

٣٨
ع

A slow, dangerous smile appeared. The specific small full chilli-lover's smile of a man whose entire dietary identity revolved around the search for the strongest chilli available, and who had just been informed that an unexpected source had been identified.

٣٩
ع

"You have chilli?"

٤٠
ع

Saeed nodded.

٤١
ع

Sadou stood up. *"Why you not say this from beginning?"*

٤٢
ع

The class exploded.

20
ع

"He agreed!"

"He agreed!"

"We win!"

20
ع

But **Fatkat** shouted, *"Wait! Which team wins?"*

20
ع

The girls crossed their arms.

20
ع

The boys crossed their arms.

20
ع

Thuraya raised her hand. *"Both teams found the treasure. But..."*

20
ع

She smiled.

20
ع

"The boys convinced Sadou."

20
ع

The girls groaned.

20
ع

Mansoor danced.

SCENE FIVE

The Great Climb

Sadou tied his cloth tighter around his waist.

20
ع

He looked at the palm tree.

20
ع

He cracked his fingers.

20
ع

The specific small full village-climber's preparation of a man who had, since he was nine years old, been the boy his uncle sent up the tallest palm in the family farm. The specific small full Omani body-knowledge of how to climb a palm — feet flat against the trunk, hips outward, knees bent, the small

rhythmic up-and-up of a person who had decided long ago that gravity was a negotiable proposition. The specific physical literacy of an entire generation of village men who had, by long custom, made themselves the architects of the palm-canopy.

Then he started climbing. Like a cat.

Up. Up. Up.

The students looked. With open mouths.

Safiya whispered, *"He is not human."*

John whispered, *"He is... many talents."*

In one minute, **Sadou** reached the top.

He took the bag.

He looked down. *"Ready?"*

"YES!" everyone shouted.

He threw the bag.

Mohammadeen tried to catch it. He missed.

Fatkat tried. She missed.

Malood jumped.

The bag hit **Malood**.

Malood fell.

The bag opened.

20
21

The honey jar rolled.

22
23

The ghee jar rolled.

24
25

Everyone screamed.

26
27

John ran.

28
29

Thuraya ran.

30
31

Mansoor ran.

32
33

Somehow, nothing broke.

34
35

They all sat on the ground. Breathing like they ran a marathon.

36
37

Safiya looked at the jars. *"We are alive."*

38
39

SCENE SIX

Healthy Food — and a Small Watching Shadow

They went back to school.

40
41

In the classroom, **Thuraya** put the jars on the table.

42
43

"Today's lesson," she said, "is Healthy Food."

44
45

John wrote on the board:

46
47

*Honey is healthy.
Ghee is healthy.*

Too much sugar is not healthy.

۞

Mansoor raised his hand. *"Teacher... honey and ghee... together?"*

۞

Fatkat laughed. *"That is not a lesson. That is a crime."*

۞

They made small bread and tasted a little.

۞

John closed his eyes. *"Now I understand... why Omani men have big belly."*

۞

Thuraya shouted, *"It's good for wearing khanjar!"*

۞

Safiya laughed. *"What is khanjar?"*

۞

Everyone started talking at the same time. The specific full village-classroom-cacophony of a moment in which the lesson had finished and the social hour had begun, with the small specific quality that no one was now in charge.

۞

Sadou stood at the door.

۞

Saeed gave him a small chilli.

۞

Sadou smiled.

۞

Then he bit it.

۞

Then he screamed.

۞

Then he ran.

۞

Everyone laughed — the specific full village-classroom laugh of a small audience who had, in the last forty minutes, watched their grown-up shopkeeper-neighbour go from refusing all bribes to climbing a fifteen-metre palm tree to running away from a small village-chilli, and who now, in the

small specific completed-arc of the morning’s narrative, were laughing in the way one laughs when a story has ended exactly as it should have.



In the afternoon, when the class was empty, **Thuraya** wrote in her notebook:



*"Today, they learned how to promise.
And how to convince.
And how to work together."*



Far away, near the old house, a shadow watched.



Shayb Khalaf.



The specific small full shadow-watching of a man who had, throughout the morning’s English-language adventure, observed from the shade of his clay-house with the specific full quiet patience of a person who had decided that whatever he understood about these foreign teachers’ games — and he understood more than they suspected — he was going to keep, for now, to himself.

 Did You Know?
The Omani Khanjar as a National Symbol

When Thuraya said honey and ghee were “good for wearing the khanjar,” she was referencing a genuine Omani symbol. The J-curved khanjar is central to Omani men’s formal and wedding attire, symbolizing manhood and status, and appears on Oman’s national emblem and its currency. Its historical roots trace to the 15th-16th centuries.

Source: en.wikipedia.org · omanobserver.om

PALM

Palm Twenty-Eight

We Must and We Mustn't — The Confession Lesson

SCENE ONE

The Punching Sun

The sun in Samail did not *shine*. It *punched*.



It was the kind of heat that made even the palm leaves look tired. The school yard felt quiet, but not because the children were calm. It was quiet because everyone was trying to save their energy for later — like camels storing water. The specific small village-quiet of an Omani late-morning when the body's preferred response to the temperature was the small specific stillness of a creature that had decided, by long evolutionary practice, that motion was for cooler hours.



Mr. **John** walked slowly across the yard. Holding a small chalkboard. His face was serious — like he was carrying something very important. The specific small full slow-walking of a foreign teacher whose body had, after several months in this heat, stopped fighting it and had begun, instead, to negotiate with it. He moved at the speed Omani men moved at this hour. The speed of conservation.



Safiya — and yes, the village still called her *Safiya* — followed him with a notebook, a water bottle, and the specific expression of a woman who had accepted that Oman was going to roast her, politely, every single day. The acceptance had taken months to arrive. The acceptance, now that it had arrived, had freed her to stop fighting the heat and start, instead, dressing for it.



Ms. **Thuraya** was already under the palm tree. Sitting on a woven mat. Her chalk was ready. Her eyes were ready. Her teacher-heart was very, very ready.



A small shadow ran between their feet.



Malood.



The baby goat stopped, stared at **John**'s chalkboard like it personally offended him, and then tried to nibble the corner.

~

"*Malood*," **John** said slowly, "*this is not salad*."

~

Malood chewed anyway.

~

Thuraya clapped once. "*Okay, class! Sit down. Circle. Under the palm tree. Today we speak English.*"

~

The students came running in a messy line — **Ali, Ahmed, Khalil, Noura, Marwa, Rahma, Salimah, Matla, Mansoor...** and a few smaller children who always followed behind like curious birds.

~

They sat down. Legs crossed. Backs half-straight. Eyes shining. Some held notebooks. Some held nothing but *confidence*.

~

John placed the chalkboard on a wooden stand. He wiped the sweat from his forehead. He wrote in big letters:

~

WE MUST / WE MUSTN'T

~

Safiya nodded. Proudly. "*This lesson is important.*"

~

Thuraya smiled. "*Also... it will be funny.*"

SCENE TWO

John Confesses First

John turned to the class. "*Today... we do something brave.*"

~

The students leaned in.

~

John pointed to himself. "*I will start. I confess.*"

~

The children gasped — like he said he stole a camel. The specific small full village-children's gasp of a class who had been told, in the first three syllables, that the foreign teacher was about to admit a personal moral failing.

~

John took a deep breath. *"Yesterday... I tried to carry a bucket of water... and I spilled it on my shoe."*

~

The class stared.

~

Then **Mansoor** whispered. Loudly. *"That's it?"*

~

Everyone laughed.

~

John sighed. *"Okay. Not a big crime. But today, we practice speaking. We practice honesty."*

~

Thuraya added, softly, *"Sometimes we learn English with our mistakes."*

~

*The specific small full pedagogical principle that **Thuraya** had been quietly teaching **John** all year — that language was not best learned through perfection but through the small specific willingness to be wrong out loud. **John**, in his old Northern teacher-training, had been taught the opposite — that error was something to be corrected, smoothed over, replaced with the right answer as quickly as possible. **Thuraya**'s instinct was different. Error, in her view, was the substance of the lesson. Without error, no truth-telling could occur.*

~

Safiya clapped once. *"Yes! Today you say: I did... and I feel... Then we say: We must... or We mustn't..."*

~

John nodded. *"Exactly."*

~

He pointed to the board. *"Repeat after me."*

~

He spoke clearly. Slowly.

~

"We must tell the truth."

~

The class echoed. *"We must tell the truth."*

~
ع

John smiled. *"Good. Now... who will confess first?"*

~
ع

Silence.

~
ع

A dramatic silence.

~
ع

Then **Khalil** raised his hand. His face looked innocent — which was always a dangerous sign.

~
ع

Thuraya narrowed her eyes. *"Khalil... what did you do?"*

~
ع

Khalil stood up. Hands behind his back. Trying to look like a serious man in a tiny body.

~
ع

"I... I did... a bad thing."

SCENE THREE

The Bucket Crime

John encouraged him. *"Say: I did a bad thing."*

~
ع

Khalil repeated. Proud. *"I did a bad thing."*

~
ع

He pointed to the classroom door. With one finger. Like he was showing evidence in court.

~
ع

"Yesterday... Teacher Thuraya... she came... to open the door."

~
ع

Thuraya already knew.

~
ع

Safiya already knew too. She leaned forward. With interest. *"Oh no."*

~
ع

Khalil continued. *"And I put... a bucket... above the door."*

~
ع

Mansoor exploded laughing before he could stop himself. The specific full Mansoor-laugh of a boy who had been waiting all morning for this specific public confession to occur.

~
~

Thuraya gasped. *"You!"*

~
~

Khalil lifted his chin. *"And water... went... BOOSH... on her head."*

~
~

The whole group laughed. Even the younger kids who didn't fully understand. They laughed because **Khalil**'s *BOOSH* was too perfect. The specific small full Khalil-onomatopoeia of a boy whose grasp of English vocabulary was limited but whose mastery of sound effects was unparalleled.

~
~

Thuraya tried to look angry. But her mouth betrayed her. The corner of her lips twitched.

~
~

John held up his hand. *"Okay! Now we use must and mustn't."*

~
~

He wrote quickly:

~
~

*We mustn't play dangerous jokes.
We must respect our teachers.*

~
~

He looked at **Khalil**. *"Repeat: We mustn't play dangerous jokes."*

~
~

Khalil repeated. Careful. *"We mustn't play dangerous jokes."*

~
~

John nodded. *"Good. And: We must respect our teachers."*

~
~

The students echoed it. Like a chant.

~
~

Thuraya folded her arms. *"Khalil... you hear?"*

~
~

Khalil nodded fast. *"Yes teacher. Last time."*

~
~

Malood bleated loudly — like he was adding his own opinion.

~
~

Safiya laughed. *"Even Malood agrees."*

SCENE FOUR

Bob Jamid

John pointed to the class. *"Next confession."*

~

Mansoor raised his hand before anyone else could breathe. He stood up so fast he almost tripped over **Rahma**'s notebook.

~

His eyes were wide. Face dramatic. **Mansoor** always looked like life was happening to him loudly.

~

"I... I confess," he said, in broken English. But brave.

~

John nodded kindly. *"Good. Tell us."*

~

Mansoor swallowed. *"I... go... to Sadoo shop."*

~

Thuraya's eyes flicked toward him. *"Uh-oh."*

~

Mansoor continued quickly. Like he wanted to throw the words out and run away. *"I take... **Bob Jamid**."*

~

Safiya blinked. *"Bob... what?"*

~

Thuraya whispered to her, *"A cold drink. Fizzy."*

~

Mansoor nodded hard. *"Yes! Cold! I take... without pay."*

~

The class made a sound — *"OHHHHH."* The specific small full village-classroom collective *obbb* of children whose moral compass had immediately registered that the crime being described was, by the small specific economy of their village, a real crime.

~

Ahmed sat straight as a ruler. Looking shocked. **Ali** raised his eyebrows like he was calculating the crime.

John stayed calm. *"Okay. Now we say rules."*

He wrote:

We must pay for things.
We mustn't steal.

He spoke clearly. *"Repeat: We must pay for things."*

The class echoed.

"We mustn't steal."

The class echoed. Louder this time.

John looked at Mansoor. *"Now you make a promise. Say: I mustn't steal again."*

Mansoor breathed in deeply. *"I mustn't... steal again."*

Safiya added gently, *"And you can fix it. You can say sorry."*

Mansoor nodded. Like a soldier. *"I say sorry to Sadoo."*

Thuraya pointed at him. *"And you pay."*

Mansoor said quickly, *"And I pay!"*

The kids clapped — because it felt like a happy ending.

SCENE FIVE

More Confessions

Next, **Noura** raised her hand. Of course **Noura** did. She didn't just *ask* questions. She *lived* inside questions.

٢٧
ع

She stood up. *"Teacher... I confess... I talk too much."*

٢٨
ع

The class laughed — because even **Noura** laughed at herself.

٢٩
ع

John smiled. *"That is a good confession."*

٣٠
ع

Noura added, *"I... I don't stop."*

٣١
ع

Safiya nodded dramatically. *"That is true."*

٣٢
ع

Thuraya laughed. *"Okay. Rule?"*

٣٣
ع

John wrote:

٣٤
ع

We must listen.

We mustn't interrupt.

٣٥
ع

The students repeated. **Noura** put her hand on her chest — like she was taking an oath.

٣٦
ع

Then **Rahma** stood up. Shy. But determined.

٣٧
ع

"I confess... I broke... my sister's comb."

٣٨
ع

She looked down. *"And I said... cat did it."*

٣٩
ع

Everyone giggled.

٤٠
ع

John wrote:

٤١
ع

*We must take responsibility.
We mustn't blame others.*

٢٥

Rahma repeated the sentences softly. She sat down — looking lighter, like the confession took a stone out of her pocket.

٢٥

*The specific small full village-confession-relief of a girl who had been carrying — for an unknown number of days — the small specific guilt of a broken comb that had not been hers. The English-language exercise had given her a small permitted occasion to set the guilt down. The grammar had become, accidentally, a small ceremony of release. **Thuraya**, watching, recognised the moment for what it was. The lesson on the board was about must and mustn't. The lesson actually being learned was about how to live with one's own small mistakes.*

٢٥

One by one, they confessed.

٢٥

Marwa admitted she hid her homework under a mat so her mother wouldn't see it.

٢٥

Salimah admitted she told her brother his ears were "too big" just to make him cry.

٢٥

Ali confessed he corrected people so much he sometimes sounded rude. And **Ahmed** quietly said, "That is true," without smiling.

٢٥

Matla confessed she once kept two pencils when she promised to share. Then she offered the class her best pencil as "compensation" — like a tiny businesswoman.

٢٥

Even the small children copied them. Confessing strange little things —

٢٥

"I eat sugar... before lunch."

٢٥

"I kick... a stone... to Mansoor."

٢٥

"I throw... date seed... at goat."

٢٥

Malood lifted his head proudly — as if he was the goat representative in the meeting.

SCENE SIX

The Strong Ending

Finally, **John** clapped his hands.

~*~

"Excellent. Today you used English for real life. You spoke truth. You learned rules."

~*~

He pointed to the board. He made them say the full set again — like a strong ending:

~*~

We must tell the truth.

We must respect our teachers.

We must pay for things.

We mustn't steal.

We must listen.

We mustn't interrupt.

~*~

Safiya smiled at **Thuraya**. *"This lesson is... powerful."*

~*~

Thuraya nodded. *"And funny."*

~*~

John picked up the chalkboard. *"Now... everyone go wash your hands."*

~*~

The students repeated. Automatically. Laughing. *"We must wash our hands!"*

~*~

Malood tried to bite the chalk. Again.

~*~

John pulled it away. Fast. *"And we mustn't eat chalk!"*

~*~

The children roared with laughter as the bell rang in the distance. Thin and metallic.

~*~

"Tolqah!" someone shouted, and the students jumped up like springs — running toward the classroom, toward shade, toward the next little adventure.

~*~

Under the palm tree, **Thuraya** watched them go. She whispered, almost to herself:

~*~

"They are learning English... but they are also learning how to be good humans."

٢٧

Safiya leaned closer. *"And Malood?"*

٢٨

Thuraya smiled. *"Malood is learning... how to cause trouble in two languages."*

٢٩

John sighed. *"That goat will become fluent before me."*

٣٠

And for once, even the palm leaves seemed to laugh quietly above them.

...



Did You Know?

Samail — Oman's Historic Gateway

"The sun in Samail doesn't rise, it punches" as the chapter says! Samail is a real town known for scorching summer heat above 40°C, but it was also for centuries a key trade route linking Muscat to the interior, traveled by explorers like Marco Polo and Ibn Battuta, and home to the Al-Midhmar Mosque, one of Oman's oldest, built in 627 CE.

Source: en.wikipedia.org · guide.opensooq.com

PALM

Palm Twenty-Nine

We Should and We Shouldn't — And the Grasshopper Wing

SCENE ONE

A Kinder Sun

The afternoon in Samail had a different personality.

☪

The sun was still hot — but not angry anymore. It was the kind of light that made the village look golden, like someone had painted everything with honey. The specific small late-afternoon honey-light of a hot place that, after eight hours of punching, had finally relaxed. The shadows had grown long. The clay walls of the houses had begun to release the heat they had absorbed since dawn — and the air, which had been a substance to be endured, had become, for a few small hours, a substance to be enjoyed.

☪

Under the big palm tree, the same woven mats were waiting.

☪

Mr. **John** arrived first. Carrying the chalkboard and a small cup of water. He looked at the tree.

☪

"This tree is becoming our second classroom."

☪

Safiya smiled. *"And a very windy one."*

☪

Ms. **Thuraya** came with her usual calm steps. And behind her came the students. Laughing and talking. And of course...

☪

Malood.

☪

Malood walked like he owned the place. He went straight to the mat. He sat down. He started chewing something nobody knew the source of.

☪

"Malood," **John** said tiredly, "*you should not eat mystery food.*"

~

Malood did not care.

~

The students sat in a circle: **Ali, Ahmed, Khalil, Noura, Marwa, Rahma, Salimah, Matla, Mansoor**... and a few smaller ones who always followed like shadows.

~

Safiya clapped her hands. "*Okay everyone. Yesterday we talked about bad things and rules. Today...*"

~

John wrote in big letters:

~

WE SHOULD / WE SHOULDN'T

~

Thuraya smiled. "*Today we talk about good things.*"

~

The students looked at each other. This felt... nicer. The specific small full village-children's relief of a class that had been told they would not, today, have to confess anything bad about themselves — and that today's grammar would be in the small specific direction of pride rather than guilt.

SCENE TWO

Things to Be Proud Of

John turned to them. "*Yesterday you confessed bad things. Today you will tell us good things. Things you are proud of.*"

~

He pointed to himself. "*I start.*"

~

He thought for a moment. "*I am proud that... I learned how to drink Omani coffee without crying.*"

~

The class laughed. The specific full classroom-laugh of children who had, in the early months, watched the foreign teacher's small specific facial reactions to Omani *kabwa* with the cardamom-saffron strength that no Northern coffee training had prepared him for.

~

Safiya added, "*And you should stop putting three spoons of sugar in it.*"

~

John nodded. Seriously. *"Yes. I should."*

~

Thuraya said, *"Now students. Who wants to start?"*

~

Matla raised her hand immediately. She always did when the topic was generosity.

~

She stood up. Very straight. *"I am proud that... I give my pencils to Rahma when she forget."*

~

Safiya smiled. *"Good! Say: I am proud that I gave my pencils."*

~

Matla repeated carefully. *"I am proud that I gave my pencils."*

~

John wrote on the board:

~

We should help others.

~

The class repeated together. *"We should help others."*

~

Rahma looked at **Matla**. She whispered, *"Thank you."*

~

Next, **Ali** stood up.

~

"I am proud that... I help my father read letters."

~

*The specific small full village-confession of a boy whose father — like many men of the older generation in Samail in 1973 — had not had access to literacy. The whole specific small private routine of a small son sitting next to a tall father in the evening, opening the small specific government letters that arrived occasionally, reading them aloud carefully, helping his father understand what the state had decided to communicate. **Thuraya**, hearing the sentence, recognised it for what it was — not just an English-language exercise, but a small specific portrait of a generational shift. The fathers had not learned to read. The sons would. And the school, this small specific school, was where the shift was happening.*

~

John nodded. Impressed. *"Excellent."*

٢٧
ع

Thuraya added, *"Many people need help with reading."*

٢٨
ع

John wrote:

٢٩
ع

We should help our family.

٣٠
ع

The students repeated. **Ali** sat down — looking taller.

٣١
ع

Then **Ahmed** stood up. Hands behind his back. Like always.

٣٢
ع

"I am proud that... I do my homework... before playing."

٣٣
ع

The class made a sound — *"Ooooooh."*

٣٤
ع

Mansoor whispered. Loudly. *"Impossible."*

٣٥
ع

Everyone laughed.

٣٦
ع

John wrote: *We should do our homework before playing.*

٣٧
ع

Mansoor looked at the ground — like the sentence personally attacked him.

SCENE THREE

Sharing, Talking, Stealing

Then **Marwa** stood up. Shy. But smiling.

٣٨
ع

"I am proud that... I share my food with my little brother."

٣٩
ع

Safiya nodded. *"Good. Very good."*

٤٠
ع

She wrote on the board:

٤١
ع

We should share.

٢٧
ع

Next, **Noura** stood up. She said, proudly, *"I am proud that... yesterday... I did not talk too much."*

٢٨
ع

The class burst out laughing.

٢٩
ع

Thuraya said, *"That is a very big achievement."*

٣٠
ع

John added, jokingly, *"You should do that again tomorrow."*

٣١
ع

Noura laughed and sat down.

٣٢
ع

Then **Mansoor** stood up.

٣٣
ع

Everyone waited.

٣٤
ع

He scratched his head. *"I am proud that... I did not steal today."*

٣٥
ع

The class clapped.

٣٦
ع

John smiled. *"That is progress."*

٣٧
ع

He wrote: *We should be honest.*

٣٨
ع

Then **Khalil** stood up. He said, *"I am proud that... I did not put any bucket today."*

٣٩
ع

Thuraya crossed her arms. *"Good. Keep it like that."*

٤٠
ع

Now **Safiya** stepped forward. *"Okay. Now we also say things we shouldn't do."*

٤١
ع

She wrote:

٤٢
ع

We shouldn't hurt others.
We shouldn't lie.
We shouldn't laugh at people.

They repeated together.

The lesson was going perfectly.

Too perfectly.

That is when something green jumped.

SCENE FOUR

The Grasshopper

A big green insect flew. And landed...

On **Safiya**'s head.

For half a second, nobody moved.

Then **Safiya** screamed.

"Aaaaaaaaah!"

She jumped up. Waving her arms. *"Something is alive on my head! Something is ALIVE!"*

The students froze... then laughed.

Thuraya ran to her. *"Don't move! Don't move!"*

Safiya ran anyway.

The insect fell on the mat.

Ali shouted, *"Jaradab! Grasshopper!"*

Safiya looked at it. Like it was a monster from another planet. *"It is... huge!"*

John tried to be brave. *"It is just... an insect."*

The grasshopper jumped again.

Safiya screamed again. And ran. Behind **Thuraya**.

"I should not come to Oman," she said. Dramatically. *"I should live in a fridge."*

The students were laughing so hard some of them were holding their stomachs.

Suddenly, a shadow fell over the group.

A familiar, thin, quiet figure appeared.

Shayb Khalaf.

The children gasped.

Some of them moved back.

He bent down calmly. He picked up the grasshopper with his hand — like it was nothing — and showed them... *a bag*.

A bag full of grasshoppers.

*"Who wants **mashawi**?"* he asked. In a quiet voice.

Silence.

Absolute silence.

Safiya's face turned white.

"You... you eat... that?" she asked. Slowly.

Thuraya nodded. *"Yes. People grill them."*

Safiya put her hand on her mouth. *"I should not ask questions in this country."*

Shayb Khalaf walked away. Like nothing happened.

The class was still shocked.

SCENE FIVE

The Wing

The lesson ended soon after. Everyone went home.

That evening, in **John** and **Safiya's** house —

Safiya was still traumatized.

"I cannot believe people eat grasshoppers," she said.

John was very quiet.

Too quiet.

They sat down to eat.

Thuraya brought food.

John chewed.

٢٠٤

Safiya looked at him.

٢٠٥

She stopped.

٢٠٦

She leaned closer.

٢٠٧

"...John."

٢٠٨

He looked at her innocently.

٢٠٩

"...John, why is there a wing... here?"

٢١٠

She pointed at the corner of his mouth.

٢١١

John froze.

٢١٢

He slowly wiped his mouth. Looked at the napkin. It was... a wing.

٢١٣

Safiya's eyes became very big. *"You ate it."*

٢١٤

John tried to lie. *"No."*

٢١٥

Safiya crossed her arms. *"John."*

٢١٦

He sighed. *"...Yes."*

٢١٧

She screamed and ran to the sink.

٢١٨

"You ate mashawi grasshopper!"

٢١٩

John smiled. Proud. *"Actually... not bad."*

SCENE SIX

A Cup, a Smile, a Lesson Done

Safiya shouted from the kitchen. "*You should see a doctor!*"

~

John laughed. "*You should try it!*"

~

She almost threw a cup at him.

~

*The cup did not get thrown — though, for a fraction of a second, **Safiya**'s grip had decided that it would. The specific small wifely calculation of a woman whose cup-throwing impulse had, at the last possible moment, been overridden by the specific small wifely understanding that the cup was, in fact, one of two matching cups they had brought from England, and that breaking it would be a small private tragedy that her morning could not absorb.*

~

She put the cup down. Carefully.

~

She glared at **John**.

~

Then — eventually — she smiled. The specific small reluctant smile of a wife who had, against her better judgement, just been impressed.

~

"Okay," she said. "*Tell me. Honestly. Was it bad?*"

~

John considered.

~

"It was salty," he said. "*Like fish. But... crunchy.*"

~

Safiya made a face. "*I am not ready.*"

~

Thuraya, who had been watching the whole scene from the doorway with the specific calm satisfaction of a teacher whose lesson had — through no fault of her own — extended into the dinner of her foreign friends, smiled.

~

"Today," she said, "you learned should and shouldn't. And you also learned: in Oman, you should never refuse food."



John wrote something in his notebook before going to bed:



*Today, I learned:
I should be brave with food.
I should not lie to my wife.
And I should never sit too close to a grasshopper bag again.*



Outside, in the warm village night, somewhere along the small alleys of Samail, a goat — almost certainly **Malood** — bleated once.



And went back to whatever **Malood** went back to.



Did You Know?

Eating Grasshoppers in the Arabian Peninsula

Safiya's shock at discovering her husband ate a real grasshopper wing! Eating grilled grasshoppers ("mashawi") is a documented old Arabian tradition, mentioned by the traveler Leo Africanus as early as the 16th century, and still common in Saudi Arabia and Yemen, where they're grilled or dried and salted. Grasshoppers are permissible in Islamic jurisprudence, believed to carry traditional nutritional and medicinal benefits.

Source: [pmc.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov](https://pmc.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/articles/PMC2470000/) · [emirates247.com](https://www.emirates247.com)

PALM

Palm Thirty

Good Manners, Black Cats, and a Very Full Stomach

SCENE ONE

The Folded Paper

There are mornings when an envelope arrives at a school and the entire shape of the day rearranges itself around it. The teacher who carries it walks differently. The children, who have not yet been told what is in it, sense its arrival the way an old village senses news — through the small specific shifts in adult posture that always, always, precede an announcement.

☪

The invitation came in the morning.

☪

Ms. **Thuraya** was holding a small folded paper when she entered the classroom. Smiling. In a special way.

☪

"Today," she said, "we are invited to lunch."

☪

The students' eyes became big immediately.

☪

"Where?" **Mansoor** asked.

☪

"To the house of Al-Mu'allim Hamad," **Thuraya** said. "The village Quran teacher."

☪

The specific small full village-respect that the name Al-Mu'allim Hamad commanded. He was not the kind of man who needed introduction. He was the kind of man who taught the Quran from morning prayer until the hour of late afternoon — patient, white-bearded, with the small specific quietness of a person whose entire life had been organised around a single ancient text. Every child in the room had, at some point, sat in his small specific morning-circle, the white kufiyya on each child's head, the wooden tablet in each lap, the careful slow rocking of small bodies as they recited the verses in the specific small

village-rhythm that had been passed down without break for fourteen centuries. To be invited to his house for lunch was a small specific honour.

٢٧
ع

Safiya clapped her hands. *"Oh! A real Omani lunch!"*

٢٨
ع

John smiled politely. But his stomach smiled more.

٢٩
ع

Before they left, **Safiya** stood in front of the class. *"Okay, today is not only about food. Today is about etiquette."*

٣٠
ع

She wrote the word on the board:

٣١
ع

ETIQUETTE

٣٢
ع

John added under it:

٣٣
ع

- *Wash your hands*
- *Sit properly*
- *Say "please" and "thank you"*
- *Don't eat like Mansoor*

٣٤
ع

Mansoor protested. *"I eat normally!"*

٣٥
ع

Ali whispered, *"Like a camel."*

٣٦
ع

Safiya continued, *"We should be polite guests."*

٣٧
ع

The class repeated, *"We should be polite guests."*

٣٨
ع

Thuraya nodded. *"Very important."*

SCENE TWO

The Black Cat

They walked in two groups.

٢٧
ع

Thuraya, Safiya, and Fatkat with the girls.

٢٨
ع

John and the boys in front.

٢٩
ع

The village was quiet. The sun was soft. The smell of bread was coming from somewhere far. The specific small full lunchtime-stillness of a village where every kitchen, at this exact hour, was producing its own private smoke and its own private bread, and where the air had filled, over the course of the late morning, with the small specific scent of a community feeding itself simultaneously. The lanes were empty. The children walked through the slowness of an Omani afternoon's first hour with the specific small full processional dignity of guests who were, themselves, about to be received.

٣٠
ع

Suddenly, something black crossed the road.

٣١
ع

A black cat.

٣٢
ع

The boys stopped.

٣٣
ع

Some of them stepped back.

٣٤
ع

Mansoor whispered, "*Sennoor aswad...*"

٣٥
ع

Khalil said, "*Bad luck...*"

٣٦
ع

Ali said, "*Maybe sorcery...*"

٣٧
ع

John looked at the cat. He laughed.

٣٨
ع

"In Britain, this is just... a cat."

٣٩
ع

The black cat sat. Looked at them. Walked away. Like a king.

٤٠
ع

John said, jokingly, "*Maybe this is Shayb Khalaf.*"

٤١
ع

The boys laughed.

~
~

Suddenly, a voice came from behind.

~
~

"*Why you say that, John?*"

~
~

Everyone jumped.

~
~

It was **Shayb Khalaf** himself.

~
~

Standing there. Looking at **John**.

~
~

*The specific small full appearance-out-of-nowhere that **Shayb Khalaf** had perfected over a long life of being precisely the right specific old man, in precisely the right specific shaded village corner, at precisely the specific moment when his name had been mentioned by a foreigner. **John**'s mind, in that small specific second, registered three things simultaneously — the quality of the late-morning light on **Khalaf**'s face, the absolute silence of his own boys around him, and the small specific cold-water-down-the-spine sensation that the entire previous Smoke-Day, with all its small folkloric absurdity, was now being asked, by the universe, to be paid for.*

~
~

"*I look like a cat now?*" he asked. Calmly.

~
~

John's face turned white.

~
~

"*No, no, no, no... I mean... cat is... nice... and you are... also... nice?*"

~
~

Shayb Khalaf smiled. A small strange smile.

~
~

"*Good,*" he said. "*Because cat don't fear.*"

~
~

He walked away. Slowly.

~
~

John looked around. "*Where did everyone go?*"

~
~

The boys were already ten meters away.

۞

Mansoor shouted, *"We waiting you there, teacher!"*

۞

John ran after them. *"You left me with him!"*

SCENE THREE

Safiya and the Lizard

Meanwhile...

۞

Safiya, **Thuraya**, and **Fatkat** were walking with the girls.

۞

Safiya suddenly stopped.

۞

"Ob my God..."

۞

She pointed to a wall.

۞

"It is... so beautiful."

۞

Thuraya looked. *"What?"*

۞

Safiya smiled. *"The lizard!"*

۞

Thuraya's face froze.

۞

"Maah..."

۞

She took two steps back.

۞

"No. No. No."

۞

*The specific small full village-Omani-woman's-relationship with house lizards — a relationship that, contrary to **Safiya**'s Northern assumption, was not one of affection. The lizard was not a creature one admired. It was a creature one removed, when one had to remove it, with the specific small full disgust that **Thuraya**'s body was now communicating with absolute clarity. **Thuraya**, who climbed mountain paths without complaint, who delivered babies in the village when needed, who had once stood between a grown man and a beating he was about to give a small boy — **Thuraya** was, on the subject of house lizards, unambiguously not brave.*

٢٧

It was a small house lizard on the wall.

٢٨

Fatkat said, "*Ya satir... what is this disgusting thing?*"

٢٩

The girls started laughing.

٣٠

Safiya walked closer. Happily. "*It is cute!*"

٣١

She took it. Gently. In her hand.

٣٢

The girls screamed.

٣٣

"Throw it! Throw it!"

٣٤

Safiya said, "*Why? It is a living creature.*"

٣٥

Fatkat said, "*The grasshopper also is a living creature, but you didn't like it, right?*"

٣٦

Before **Safiya** answered, the lizard jumped.

٣٧

Straight to the wall.

٣٨

And ran away.

٣٩

Thuraya screamed and ran. The specific small full uncharacteristic high-pitched scream of a teacher whose composure had, on this single matter, completely collapsed.

و
ع

The girls laughed so much they almost fell.

و
ع

Safiya said, "Okay... maybe not so beautiful."

SCENE FOUR

At Al-Mu'allim Hamad's House

The house was simple. Clean. Calm.

و
ع

*The specific full small Omani-religious-teacher's-house of a man whose entire small economy had been organised around the specific principle of enough. The walls were whitewashed clay. The floor was covered with woven palm-leaf mats. There was a small wooden shelf with three or four books on it, all of them religious texts. There was a small specific brass coffee-pot in a corner. There was no decoration that was not also useful. The room was the specific small material expression of a man who had decided, long ago, that what he had was sufficient — and who had, by that decision, achieved a quality of small interior peace that **John**, walking in, immediately recognised as something he had never himself possessed.*

و
ع

They sat on mats.

و
ع

Water was brought.

و
ع

Thuraya whispered, "First... wash hands."

و
ع

Everyone went to wash their hands.

و
ع

John washed his hands three times. "Just in case," he said.

و
ع

They came back and sat.

و
ع

Safiya whispered, "Back straight. Legs in. Don't touch food yet."

و
ع

Mansoor was already touching food.

و
ع

John pulled his hand back. "No."

و

Mansoor whispered, *"But I am hungry."*

و

Then **Al-Mu'allim Hamad** came in.

و

A calm man. White beard. Kind eyes.

و

The specific full small village-Quran-teacher's quietness of a man whose voice — when he spoke, which was rarely — carried the specific small weight of a person who had spent his life carrying ancient words, and whose body had, over decades, been organised by those words into a specific small posture of receptive attention. He did not enter a room. He arrived in it. The atmosphere of any space he occupied shifted, very slightly, in the direction of stillness.

و

"Welcome," he said.

و

Everyone answered. Together. *"Welcome."*

و

He smiled. *"Today, you are our guests. And guests must be honored."*

و

Food came.

و

Rice. Meat. Bread. Dates.

و

Safiya looked amazed. *"So beautiful..."*

و

Before eating, **Thuraya** said softly, *"We say bismillah."*

و

John heard the word. He repeated it. Quietly. *"Bismillah..."*

و

The first time the word had ever passed his lips. The specific small full first-time-uttering of a small ancient sacred phrase by a man whose Northern Christian upbringing had not previously had occasion for it. He noticed, as he said it, that the word fitted his mouth more easily than he had expected. As though it had been waiting for him. As though it had been, all his life, a small linguistic shape his lips had been ready to make.

SCENE FIVE

The Meal and the Quiet After

They ate.

~

Slowly. Politely. At first.

~

Then **John** forgot etiquette.

~

Then he forgot the world.

~

He ate. And ate. And ate.

~

*The specific full small foreign-guest's-collapse of a man whose careful Northern manners had, after the third specific small handful of **kabsa**, surrendered completely to the specific full small village-meal protocol — which was, at heart, the protocol of more. The host's small specific village-honour required him to keep offering. The guest's small specific village-honour required him to keep accepting. Both protocols, working together, produced the specific small full inevitable result of the foreign guest at his fourth helping with his eyes slightly glazed, communicating in monosyllables, and beyond the reach of any further conversational obligation.*

~

Fatkat whispered to **Safiya**, "He eat like he never see food before."

~

After lunch, tea came.

~

They sat.

~

Al-Mu'allim Hamad talked about life. Kindness. Respect.

~

John listened.

~

He did not understand everything. But he felt something... *peaceful*.

~

The specific small full first-encounter of a Northern man with the specific small atmosphere of a quiet Omani religious household — the specific small quality that all the books he had read about Islam in his

university library had not prepared him for. There was a thing in this room that the books had not described. The thing was not in the words. The thing was in the small specific way the words sat in the room. The small specific way the host did not interrupt himself. The small specific way the cup was placed on the mat. The small specific space — between sentences — that was not silence but presence. The thing had a name in Arabic that **John** did not yet know but would, in the years that followed, learn — and he would, by long study, eventually understand that the thing was not a feeling but a discipline.

و
ع

On the way back, **John** was very quiet.

و
ع

Safiya looked at him. "*Are you okay?*"

و
ع

John touched his stomach. "*My stomach is very okay.*"

و
ع

Then he said. Slowly. "*But... today was... different.*"

و
ع

Thuraya looked at him. "*Different how?*"

و
ع

John thought. "*The way... he lives. The way... he talks. The calm. The respect. The prayer...*"

و
ع

He stopped.

و
ع

Safiya looked at him.

و
ع

John said, quietly, "*I think... I want to learn more about Islam.*"

و
ع

*The specific small full quiet sentence of a man who had, in one specific lunch, encountered a specific small atmosphere of being-in-the-world that had — without warning, without preparation — registered with him as real. The sentence had been forming in him, perhaps, since the bismillah. Perhaps since the meshkak afternoon at Tawi Zahir. Perhaps since his first small specific encounter with the smell of **Thuraya**'s morning prayer, drifting through the courtyard of their shared house, when he had been told it was kahwa being made and had only later learned that the smell was actually **oud**, and that **Thuraya** burned it after she prayed. The sentence had been forming a long time. Today it had simply, finally, found its words.*

و
ع

Thuraya did not smile. She did not joke. She just said, softly, "*When you are ready... I will explain.*"

SCENE SIX

A Stomach Like a Separate Country

John entered the house.

~

He tried to sit.

~

He failed.

~

He fell on the mat.

~

"My stomach... is now... a separate country."

~

Safiya laughed. "*You should not eat like that.*"

~

John closed his eyes. "*But we should accept hospitality.*"

~

She threw a pillow at him.

~

*The pillow landed softly on his chest. **John** did not even open his eyes. The afternoon light was coming in low through the small window, painting one wall of the room in the specific small full late-Omani-light of golden and dust. **Thuraya's** footsteps could be heard in the next room — the small specific tea-making sounds of a woman who had decided that the appropriate end to a heavy lunch was a small specific cup of strong unsweetened tea. The whole house had settled into the small full quiet of a household digesting.*

~

And in the small specific golden silence, **John**, lying on his back with a pillow on his chest and his eyes closed, said one more thing — quietly, more to himself than to the room —

~

"He is a good man," he said. "Al-Mu'allim Hamad. He is a good man."

~

Safiya sat near him. She did not say anything at first. Then —

"Yes," she said, softly. "He is."

The specific small full wifely confirmation of a woman who had, in the same afternoon, registered the same thing — and who had decided, without saying so explicitly, that whatever small specific shift had happened to **John** in **Al-Mu'allim Hamad's** house, she was not going to question it. She was going to wait. The way **Thuraya** waited.

Outside, a goat — almost certainly **Malood** — bleated once.

The afternoon settled into its small specific golden completion. And the village, full of fed bodies and quiet houses and the small specific lingering scent of after-meal cardamom, slowed, briefly, into the specific small full peace of a place that had — for one afternoon at least — done its hospitality correctly, and was now allowed to rest.



Did You Know?

The Black Cat Myth vs. Cats' Status in Islam

The children in this chapter fear a black cat, believing it a bad omen or witchcraft. This superstition is European in origin, tracing to a 1233 papal decree linking black cats to the devil. In Islamic tradition, however, cats are honored: it's said the Prophet Muhammad ﷺ cut off his sleeve rather than wake his cat "Muezza," sleeping on it, and that "love of cats is part of faith."

Source: history.com · iqranetwork.com

PALM

Palm Thirty-One

I Am Afraid Of — And Thuraya's Secret

SCENE ONE

The Tired Fan and the Topic of Fear

*Some lessons are decided in advance. Some lessons arrive when the teacher walks into the room. And some lessons — the most interesting kind — are produced by the room itself, by the small specific atmosphere of a particular morning, by the small accumulated trivia of the previous days. The morning of I am afraid of... was that third kind. **Safiya** had not woken up planning to teach the topic of fear. The topic had simply, quietly, arrived in the room with her — born of the previous afternoon's grasshopper, of the small specific lizard **Thuraya** had not stopped mentioning, of the small specific quality the village had been carrying ever since **Shayb Kbalaf's** appearance with his bag of mashawi. The whole village had been thinking about fear for two days. The teachers had simply decided, that morning, to give the village permission to talk about it.*

٢٧
ع

The fan was making its usual tired sound.

٢٧
ع

The classroom was hot.

٢٧
ع

The chalk was squeaking.

٢٧
ع

And **John** was already sweating before the lesson even started.

٢٧
ع

Safiya stood near the board. Holding a small paper. Smiling.

٢٧
ع

"Today," she said happily, "we will talk about fear."

٢٧
ع

The students looked at each other.

٢٧
ع

Mansoor immediately said, "I am not afraid of anything."

Khalil whispered, *"Liar."*

John wrote on the board:

I am afraid of ...

He turned. *"Repeat, everyone."*

The class said together. *"I am afraid of..."*

Safiya clapped. *"Good! Now we will learn insect words."*

She drew small bad pictures on the board. The specific small full **Safiya**-drawing of a foreign teacher whose chalk-skill in still-life rendering was approximately at the level of a six-year-old, but whose enthusiasm compensated for accuracy. A bee. A grasshopper. A butterfly. A lizard.

Mansoor shouted, *"This one looks like Ali!"*

Ali threw chalk at him.

SCENE TWO

The Confession Game

Safiya said, *"Okay. One by one. You say your name and what you are afraid of."*

She pointed at **Noura**.

Noura stood up. She said shyly, *"I am afraid of... bee."*

John smiled. *"Good! Say: I am afraid of bees."*

Noura repeated. *"I am afraid of bees."*

Khalil said proudly, *"I am afraid of nothing."*

۞

At that moment, a fly passed near his ear.

۞

He screamed.

۞

The class exploded with laughter. The specific full village-classroom-laugh of a class that had been waiting all morning for exactly this small specific contradiction.

۞

Ali said, *"I am afraid of... snake."*

۞

Ahmed said. Seriously. *"I am afraid of... failing exam."*

۞

Everyone respected that. The specific full silent classroom-respect of a group of children who had recognised, in **Ahmed**'s answer, a fear so unambiguously real that no one was prepared to mock it.

۞

Then **Mansoor** stood up. Smiling. Like a hero.

۞

"I am afraid of... butterfly."

۞

The class went silent.

۞

Then *BOOM*.

۞

Laughter.

۞

"Butterfly???" **Khalil** shouted. *"You fight boys but afraid of butterfly?"*

۞

Mansoor shouted, *"They fly... without warning!"*

۞

John wrote on the board: *Mansoor is afraid of butterflies.*

۞

Mansoor crossed his arms. *"They are dangerous."*

٢٧

Safiya smiled. *"Okay. My turn. I am afraid of... grasshoppers."*

٢٨

The students looked at her in shock.

٢٩

"You eat it," **Khalil** said.

٣٠

Safiya made a face. *"Yes. But I don't want to meet it alive."*

٣١

Fatkat, passing by the door, said, *"Normal. I am afraid of rats."*

٣٢

Then **John** said proudly, *"I am afraid of nothing."*

٣٣

Thuraya looked at him. *"Really?"*

٣٤

John nodded. *"I am a brave man."*

٣٥

At that moment, **Malood** jumped inside the class. Straight to **John**.

٣٦

John jumped on the table. *"I am afraid of goats!"* he shouted.

٣٧

The class died laughing.

٣٨

Safiya wrote: *Mr. John is afraid of Malood.*

SCENE THREE

Thuraya's Secret

Safiya looked at **Thuraya**. *"And you?"*

٣٩

Thuraya answered fast. *"I am not afraid of anything."*

٤٠

Too fast.

٤١

John looked at her suspiciously.

"Really?"

She nodded. *"Really."*

But her eyes moved to the window.

John followed her eyes.

On the wall outside...

A small lizard was sitting quietly.

John smiled. A dangerous smile.

"Obbb," he said. *"Interesting..."*

He walked outside.

The students watched. Like they were watching a movie.

He came back. Holding a small box.

"Thuraya," he said sweetly, *"I have something for you."*

Thuraya stepped back. *"No."*

John opened the box.

The lizard jumped out.

Thuraya screamed.

A real scream.

*The specific small full uncharacteristic high-pitched scream of a teacher whose composure had — for one second — completely abandoned her. The students, who had never in their lives heard **Thuraya** scream, registered the sound with the small specific full classroom-shock of children whose authority figure had, in front of them, demonstrated a small specific weakness. The discovery was, in their developing minds, a small specific permanent file. Ms. **Thuraya** was not, after all, indestructible. Ms. **Thuraya** had a small specific human edge. The information would be remembered. The information would be respected. The information would be — for the rest of the school year — used very, very carefully, and only by **John**.*

She ran.

The girls screamed.

Safiya screamed.

Mansoor climbed on the desk.

The lizard ran.

The class became a war zone.

Thuraya shouted, "**JOHN!**"

John laughed so much he couldn't breathe.

"I am afraid of nothing," he said, "but you are afraid of lizards!"

Thuraya pointed at him. "*You will pay for this.*"

Malood tried to eat the lizard.

The lizard escaped.

٢٧
ع

Order came back after ten minutes.

٢٨
ع

Safiya wrote on the board: *Ms. Thuraya is afraid of lizards.*

٢٩
ع

Thuraya crossed her arms. *"Delete it."*

SCENE FOUR

The Big Question

When the class calmed down, **Ali** raised his hand.

٣٠
ع

"Teacher... what about Shayb Khalaf?"

٣١
ع

The class became quiet.

٣٢
ع

"What is he afraid of?" **Mansoor** asked.

٣٣
ع

Everyone looked at the door.

٣٤
ع

*The specific small full collective village-classroom turn of every small head, simultaneously, toward the closed door — as if the act of saying **Khalaf's** name had a small physical weight, and the weight had been pulled toward the room's only entrance, and the heads had instinctively followed. The fan continued. The chalk dust drifted. The specific small full village-superstition of a group of children who had been raised, all of them, on the small specific certainty that to mention the sabir was — at minimum — to invite his attention.*

٣٥
ع

John swallowed.

٣٦
ع

Safiya whispered, *"Good question..."*

٣٧
ع

Thuraya smiled. Slowly. The specific small full slow teacher-smile of a woman who knew the answer to the question and who was deciding, in real time, whether she was going to share it.

٣٨
ع

"No one knows," she said.

٢٧
ع

The fan continued its tired sound.

٢٨
ع

Outside, somewhere far away...

٢٩
ع

Someone was laughing.

SCENE FIVE

Saeed's Quiet Watching

The class went out for break.

٣٠
ع

Most of the children ran. **Mansoor** ran first, of course. **Khalil** chased him. **Noura** walked with **Marwa** talking about something **Safiya** could not hear but which involved several small bursts of laughter.

٣١
ع

Saeed stayed.

٣٢
ع

He stood near the small specific window through which the lizard had earlier been visible, looking out at the empty wall.

٣٣
ع

Thuraya walked to him.

٣٤
ع

"Saeed," she said softly, "and you? What are you afraid of?"

٣٥
ع

Saeed did not answer immediately.

٣٦
ع

The specific small full **Saeed**-thinking of a boy whose answers were always the result of consideration, and who had decided, by long practice, that a teacher's question deserved his actual answer rather than his easiest one.

٣٧
ع

Finally, he said, in his careful small English:

٣٨
ع

"I am afraid of... not seeing."

٢٧
ع

Thuraya looked at him. *"Not seeing what?"*

٢٨
ع

Saeed thought again. He could not find the English. Eventually he said, simply:

٢٩
ع

"What is true."

٣٠
ع

***Thuraya** stood with him, then, for a small specific long moment without speaking. The classroom around them was empty. The fan continued its tired conversation with itself. Outside, the village's small specific lunchtime had begun — the smell of something onion-and-spice cooking somewhere down the lane. **Thuraya**, watching her quietest student, recognised that he had just told her — without quite meaning to — what his entire life had been organised around. The specific small full village-watching of a child who had spent his nine years collecting the specific small textures of what is true, because he had decided, very young, that the only protection against being deceived was to see clearly. **Thuraya**, with her own small specific quiet life, understood. She did not need to say so.*

٣١
ع

Eventually she said, quietly, *"That is a very brave fear, Saeed."*

٣٢
ع

Saeed nodded.

٣٣
ع

And ran out, finally, after the others.

SCENE SIX

The Small Closing of the Door

The classroom was empty.

٣٤
ع

Thuraya sat down at the teacher's desk. She wrote, in her small private notebook, in Arabic — the specific small full private Arabic she only ever wrote in her own notebook, the language of her own private thinking:

٣٥
ع

اليوم تعلّموا كلمة الخوف.
«وأنا تعلّمت أن الصغير سعيد... يعرف أكثر مني»

٣٦
ع

(Today they learned the word "fear." And I learned that little Saeed... knows more than I do.)

٣٧
ع

She closed the notebook.



She sat for a small full minute, listening to the fan.



Then she stood up and went outside, into the bright small village afternoon, where **John** and **Safiya** were waiting under the big palm and where the children — her children, in the small specific full sense that this village's children had become hers — were doing, as always, exactly what children do at lunchtime in a small Omani village in 1973: shouting, running, sharing dates, kicking small stones, and existing in the small specific full unrepeatable joy of being nine years old in a place whose entire life still moved at the speed of palm trees and falaj water.



Far away, on the path toward his clay-house, **Shayb Khalaf**'s door closed slowly.



And for once — only for this small specific afternoon — no one in the village wondered, quite as much as they usually did, what the closing of that door might mean.



Did You Know?

The Psychology of Childhood Fear

Remember the children fearing bees, snakes, and butterflies in this chapter? Psychologist Martin Seligman's 1971 "preparedness theory" proposed that humans are biologically primed to quickly learn fear of dangers their ancestors faced, like snakes and insects, faster than other, more modern dangers. Later research showed this doesn't explain every kind of fear, though.

Source: en.wikipedia.org · simplypsychology.org

PALM

Palm Thirty-Two

The Only Thing Shayb Khalaf Was Afraid Of

SCENE ONE

Tap, Tap, Tap

*There are mornings in Samail when the village announces itself slowly, in small specific layers. The rooster first. Then the woman next door clapping her dough between her palms. Then the smoke from a fire being kindled three houses away. Then, finally, the whole sky deciding to admit that it was light. **John**'s body had, by now, learned this particular small specific layered awakening — and on this particular morning, lying in the grey-blue dawn-dimness, his ear collected the layers in their proper order, and registered, somewhere in his half-sleep, that the day was beginning correctly.*

~

The morning in Samail began before the sun fully decided to show itself.

~

A rooster screamed like it was late for work. Somewhere nearby, a woman clapped dough between her palms, and the sound traveled through the quiet lanes like soft drumbeats. **John** opened his eyes to the smell of wood smoke, warm bread, and that familiar village dust that somehow made every day feel like a new page.

~

Sophia — or *Safiya* as the villagers insisted on calling her — sat on the edge of the bed tying her scarf with careful patience.

~

"I feel like I'm dressing for a documentary," she whispered, then smiled. "A very hot documentary."

~

John rubbed his eyes. *"At least documentaries have fans. We have... beat."*

~

A tiny hoof tapped the door.

~

Tap. Tap. Tap.

~

Safiya froze. *"Please tell me that is not... him."*



The door creaked open — because it was never properly closed in the first place — and **Malood** walked in like he owned the entire house.



The baby goat looked at them with calm confidence. Then marched straight to **John's** shoe.



"No," John warned, pointing. *"No biting."*



Malood ignored the warning. He chewed the shoelace with the seriousness of a professional worker.



Safiya sighed. *"He has a mission."*



John leaned down. Trying to free his shoe with dignity. **Malood** pulled harder. **John** pulled harder. The shoelace snapped.



John stared at the broken lace in his hand. **Malood** stared at him.



It was a silent war.



Outside, Ms. **Thuraya's** voice called. Bright and practical.



"Good morning! Hurry, or the students will arrive before you."



John stepped into the yard — still holding the dead shoelace like a defeated soldier. **Thuraya** stood at the gate with her chalk and her notebook. She looked ready to fight the whole world using only grammar and confidence.

SCENE TWO

The Schoolyard and the Workers

The school in 1973 did not look like the schools in **John's** mind.



*It was simple. Chalk dust lived everywhere. The bell was not a modern bell — it was more like a sound that said, Enough talking, start suffering quietly. Students arrived in groups, barefoot or wearing worn sandals, carrying small notebooks. Some carried nothing except energy and curiosity. The specific full small village-school of an Oman that was still — in 1973 — at the very beginning of its modern educational ambitions. The first national curriculum was new. The first textbooks were new. The first batch of properly trained Omani teachers, of which **Thuraya** was one, had only recently graduated. The whole system was being built, in this specific small village, brick by brick — and every morning was, in some small specific sense, a small contribution to that building.*

و

And then... the shouting started.

و

"Teacher John!"

"Teacher!"

"Safiya!"

"Miss Thuraya!"

و

Mansoor ran first, as usual — like his legs were powered by nonsense. He nearly crashed into **John**, then stopped at the last second and saluted dramatically.

و

John blinked. *"Good morning, Mansoor."*

و

Mansoor grinned and yelled the only English greeting he trusted:

و

"HAAAAI!"

و

Behind him came **Ali** with calm eyes, **Ahmed** sitting upright even while walking, **Khalil** already laughing about something he hadn't done yet, and the girls — **Matla**, **Noura**, **Rahma**, **Marwa**, and **Salimah** — all watching with the curious bravery of people who had never seen a foreign teacher before this year.

و

Saeed stood at the far side. Half-hidden near the wall. Watching. Like a quiet shadow. He still didn't join fully, but his eyes collected every detail.

و

Thuraya clapped once. *"Okay! Everyone, listen. Today we practice morning assembly."*

و

John picked up a piece of chalk. He wrote large words on a small board:

~
€

LINE UP
STAND STILL
GOOD MORNING
EXERCISES
ANTHEM

~
€

A small group of men appeared at the corner of the yard — carrying measuring tools. One held a rolled paper. Another carried a hammer. They looked like they were here to change the world one brick at a time.

~
€

Safiya pointed. *"Who are they?"*

~
€

Thuraya lowered her voice. Sounding proud. *"Workers. The school will be rebuilt. New classrooms. Better rooms. Better future. This is the new time."*

~
€

John watched them with awe. *"So this is what it looks like when a country starts to grow."*

~
€

Thuraya's face softened. *"Yes. Slowly. But it will grow."*

~
€

The anthem began — sung in voices that were not perfect but were full of something bigger than music.

~
€

John stood quietly. *Listening. Feeling like he was standing inside history. The specific full small full witnessing-position of a foreign man who had arrived in this country at the precise small moment when its people were singing, for the first time in their generation, a national anthem of a national renaissance that had not, only three years earlier, existed. The new sultan, Qaboos, had only recently taken his place. The nahda — the renaissance — had only recently been declared. The schools were only beginning to be built. The roads were only beginning to be paved. John, who had been hired as an English teacher and had thought of his contract as a small foreign adventure, was beginning to understand that he had — by accident — been placed inside one of the small specific full pivotal moments of a small specific full nation's becoming.*

SCENE THREE

The Fear Lesson and the Match

Then his brain remembered something else.

٢٧
ع

Shayb Khalaf.

٢٨
ع

The mysterious old man. The village's "wizard." The man who had scared children without even trying.

٢٩
ع

John's eyes narrowed. An idea sparked like a dangerous match.

٣٠
ع

Later, in class, **John** decided to do what teachers do best — turn chaos into a lesson.

٣١
ع

He wrote on the chalkboard:

٣٢
ع

*I AM AFRAID OF..
HE IS AFRAID OF..
HE IS NOT AFRAID OF..*

٣٣
ع

Safiya clapped softly. *"Good topic. Everyone has fears."*

٣٤
ع

Thuraya smirked. *"Even you, Mr. John."*

٣٥
ع

John pretended not to hear.

٣٦
ع

He pointed at **Noura**. *"Noura. I am afraid of...?"*

٣٧
ع

Noura stood up confidently. *"I am afraid of... bee."*

٣٨
ع

John corrected gently. *"A bee. Good."*

٣٩
ع

Mansoor raised his hand like his arm was on fire.

٤٠
ع

John sighed. *"Yes, Mansoor."*

٤١
ع

Mansoor stood and announced. Proudly. *"I am afraid of... butterfly."*

٢٧
ع

The room exploded. **Khalil** laughed so hard he fell sideways. **Ahmed** tried to stay serious and failed. Even **Ali**'s mouth twitched.

٢٨
ع

John stared. *"A butterfly?"*

٢٩
ع

Mansoor nodded quickly. *"Yes. It... fly... in my face. Big problem."*

٣٠
ع

Safiya wiped tears from her eyes. *"That is the cutest fear I have ever heard."*

٣١
ع

John tapped the board. *"Okay. We respect all fears."*

٣٢
ع

Then **John** leaned forward.

٣٣
ع

"Now... let's talk about Shayb Khalaf."

٣٤
ع

Half the class gasped.

٣٥
ع

Some students looked at the door — as if **Khalaf** might appear just because his name was said.

٣٦
ع

John lowered his voice. Like a storyteller. *"Is Shayb Khalaf afraid of anything?"*

٣٧
ع

Silence.

٣٨
ع

Then **Ali** whispered, *"He is not afraid."*

٣٩
ع

Khalil added, softly, *"He is... the fear."*

٤٠
ع

Thuraya watched **John** carefully. *"Why you ask?"*

٤١
ع

John tried to look casual and failed. *"Just... teacher curiosity."*

٤٢
ع

Safiya narrowed her eyes. She knew that face. That face meant: *John is about to do something stupid but educational.*

SCENE FOUR

Dukkan Al-Hallah and the Old Man's Secret

After school, **John** walked to **Dukkan Al-Hallah** — determined to collect information like a detective.

~

Safiya and **Thuraya** followed. Suspicious.

~

Inside, the shop smelled like dried fish, spices, and childhood. The specific full Omani-village-shop smell of a small specific commercial space whose stock had never been catalogued, had never been organised by category, had been arranged instead by the specific small full personal logic of a shopkeeper who knew, exactly, where everything was — sacks of rice next to crates of dates, soap stacked next to packets of cardamom, the small specific brass coffee-pots in the corner where his cousin had left them six months ago and which he had not yet decided how to display. The shop was, in 1973, the village's social centre. The news exchange. The credit office. The small specific full informal court where village disputes were sometimes adjudicated by collective laughter.

~

Sadu stood behind the counter. Half-selling and half-arguing with a boy who wanted something for free.

~

Sadu spotted **John** and grinned. "*Jooohen! You come! You want what?*"

~

John leaned on the counter. "*Sadu. I need village information.*"

~

Sadu's eyes lit up. He loved information. Especially dramatic information.

~

Before **Sadu** could speak, an old man entered slowly. Carrying a small bag. His beard was white and his eyes were bright like they still had mischief in them.

~

Sadu whispered, "*That is Shayb Zabran.*"

~

John turned politely. "*Hello, sir.*"

~

Zahran looked at him and smiled slowly. *"Hello, teacher."*

~
ع

John blinked. *"You speak English."*

~
ع

Zahran shrugged. *"Little. Life teach."*

~
ع

John leaned closer. *"Sir... can I ask something?"*

~
ع

Zahran's smile widened. *"You want ask about Khalaf."*

~
ع

Safiya's head snapped toward **John**. *"John!"*

~
ع

Thuraya's eyebrows lifted. *"Mr. John..."*

~
ع

John pretended this was totally normal. *"Yes. About Khalaf."*

~
ع

Zahran lowered his voice. Enjoying himself. *"People think he fear nothing."*

~
ع

John nodded eagerly. *"Yes!"*

~
ع

Zahran pointed one finger up. Like a lecturer. *"Wrong."*

~
ع

John's eyes widened. *"He is afraid?"*

~
ع

Zahran's smile turned wicked. *"He was afraid of one thing."*

~
ع

Safiya leaned in. Even **Thuraya** stopped breathing for a moment.

~
ع

Zahran whispered. Like it was a secret that could burn the air:

~
ع

"His wife."

~
ع

John blinked. *"His wife?"*

﴿

Zahran nodded. Seriously. *"Name..."*

﴿

«منو»

﴿

The moment **Zahran** said the name, the shop felt colder for half a second — as if the air itself remembered it.

﴿

John swallowed. *"And... what happens if you say her name?"*

﴿

Zahran chuckled. *"He change. He shake. He... fly."*

﴿

Safiya whispered, *"This is too good."*

﴿

Thuraya looked at **John** — already knowing the disaster coming.

﴿

John straightened up. Eyes shining. *"Thank you, sir. Very helpful."*

﴿

Thuraya grabbed his sleeve. *"No. Absolutely no."*

﴿

John smiled innocently. *"I'm just... practicing English."*

﴿

Safiya muttered, *"Liar."*

SCENE FIVE

The Clay House

The sun was dropping when **John** reached the path to **Khalaf**'s clay house.

﴿

Safiya and **Thuraya** followed at a distance. Whispering:

﴿

"He will do it."

"He will definitely do it."

"He will die."

﴿

Malood followed too — because **Malood** followed everything interesting.

﴿

John stood at the door. His heart beat fast.

﴿

He raised his hand. Ready to knock.

﴿

Then he remembered... *fear lesson*.

﴿

He whispered to himself in English, "*He is not afraid of... anything.*"

﴿

He pushed the door open dramatically.

﴿

The wooden door swung wide.

﴿

John stepped in and shouted —

﴿

«!—منو»

﴿

He stopped.

﴿

His voice died in his throat.

﴿

*The house was silent. Too silent. The specific small full wrong-silence of a place that had been, until very recently, occupied — and which had, in the small specific window of the last hour, been suddenly emptied. The walking stick was on the ground. Not propped against the wall. Not placed on the small specific shelf where **Khalaf** always placed it. On the ground. The dallah — the small specific brass coffee pot — was tipped over. The dark coffee had spread. Like a stain. Across the earth floor. The specific small full village-tragedy of an Omani household whose dallah had been knocked over — because no Omani household, by the small specific careful daily protocols of these specific small lives, ever knocked over its dallah. A dallah was tipped over only when something had gone very wrong.*

﴿

John's mouth went dry.

﴿

Safiya appeared behind him. Her face suddenly serious. "*John...*"

٢٧
ع

Thuraya stepped in slowly. Her laughter completely gone. She looked around once. Then whispered, "*No...*"

٢٨
ع

Malood made a small nervous sound.

٢٩
ع

From outside, the wind moved through the palm fronds — like a quiet warning.

٣٠
ع

John swallowed and spoke softly. No jokes now.

٣١
ع

"He was here..."

٣٢
ع

Thuraya's eyes fixed on the spilled coffee. And for the first time, **John** saw real worry in her face.

SCENE SIX

A Village Suddenly Different

Then, far away, from the village road, a child's voice called:

٣٣
ع

"Teacher John!"

٣٤
ع

The sound snapped the moment like a thread.

٣٥
ع

But the house stayed quiet.

٣٦
ع

And the coffee stayed spilled.

٣٧
ع

And the stick stayed on the floor.

٣٨
ع

John backed out slowly. His mind racing.

٣٩
ع

Safiya whispered, "*Where is he?*"

٤٠
ع

Thuraya didn't answer. She stared at the doorway like the village itself had just changed shape.

*The specific small full **Thuraya**-stare of a woman who had, until that moment, considered herself — by long village familiarity — to be relatively unmoved by **Khalaf**'s small specific folkloric reputation. **Thuraya** had grown up in this village. **Thuraya** had known **Khalaf** all her life. **Thuraya** had, until this small specific evening, believed that the small specific village-mythology around him was almost entirely nonsense — small village-stories accumulated over years, exaggerated by repetition, harmless. But the specific small empty house with the spilled dallah and the abandoned stick had introduced, for the first time in her adult life, a small specific possibility: that some part of the mythology might, in some small specific way, be true. The stare was not about **Khalaf**. The stare was about her own small specific certainty, which had — in one small evening — quietly cracked.*

John looked at the dark stain again, then at **Thuraya**.

In a low voice, he said:

"Tomorrow... we must find out."

Thuraya finally spoke. Very quietly:

"Yes."

And somewhere behind them, **Malood** chewed a leaf — like nothing in the world was wrong.

But for once... **Malood** looked uncertain.

The three of them walked back to the small village in silence. The lamps had begun to come on in the houses. Smoke rose from the small specific kitchens of small specific evening meals. Children's laughter sounded from one small lane. A donkey, somewhere, brayed once. The village continued its specific full unbroken evening pattern — and yet, for the three of them, the village had — by the small specific spilled dallah of a single old man's empty house — suddenly become a place that contained a small specific question they did not yet know how to answer.

Did You Know?

Arabic Coffee and the Dallah Pot

In this chapter, coffee spills from the dallah pot onto the floor of Sheikh Khalaf's house — the first sign something is wrong. Arabic coffee ("gahwa") is far more than a drink — it's a symbol of Gulf generosity and hospitality, with precise etiquette passed down through generations, such as serving elders first and pouring with the right hand. In 2015, UNESCO listed "Arabic coffee, a symbol of generosity" as Intangible Cultural Heritage.

Source: ich.unesco.org · en.wikipedia.org

PALM

Palm Thirty-Three

A Son from Bahrain — The Truth Behind the Story

SCENE ONE

A Morning That Felt Different

That morning, Samail felt different.



*The air was softer. The sun was kinder. Even the palm trees looked like they were waiting for something. The specific small full village-anticipation of a place that had — over the previous evening — been collectively informed of an event that was about to occur, and that had decided, by collective unspoken agreement, to be ready for it. The houses had been swept. The yards had been cleaned. Smoke from the morning fires rose more carefully than usual. Even the goats — even **Malood** — moved more slowly than they usually did, as if the animals themselves had received the village's message and were honouring it.*



John noticed it before anyone else.



He stood at the door of the small house. Holding his notebook. He said quietly, *"Today feels like... something is coming."*



Safiya, tying her scarf, smiled. *"In Oman, something is always coming. Usually heat."*



Thuraya walked in from the path. Holding her bag. Her face thoughtful.



"Not heat today," she said. *"News."*



John looked at her. *"Good news or village-news?"*



Thuraya smiled. *"Both."*

٢٧
ع

They walked together toward the school. **Malood** followed, of course — like a loyal cloud with legs.

٢٨
ع

The students were already there. Sitting under the palm tree. Not running. Not shouting.

٢٩
ع

Ali was quiet. **Ahmed** was quiet. Even **Mansoor** was quiet.

٣٠
ع

Something was definitely wrong.

٣١
ع

Thuraya clapped her hands. *"Why are you all sitting like this?"*

٣٢
ع

Khalil answered softly, *"We are waiting."*

٣٣
ع

"Waiting for what?" **Safiya** asked.

٣٤
ع

Saeed, who usually stayed at the back, stepped forward.

٣٥
ع

"For Obaid," he said.

٣٦
ع

John frowned. *"Who is Obaid?"*

٣٧
ع

Thuraya's face changed. Softer. Warmer.

٣٨
ع

"Obaid is Shayb Khalaf's son."

٣٩
ع

Safiya gasped. *"He has a son?"*

٤٠
ع

Thuraya nodded. *"He left years ago. To Bahrain. To work. No one thought he would come back."*

٤١
ع

John felt something move in his chest. *"And now?"*

٤٢
ع

Thuraya smiled. *"Now he is coming."*

SCENE TWO

The Return

The sound came first.

٢٧
ع

A car.

٢٨
ع

Not the pickup of **Uncle Nasser**. Not a donkey. *A real car.*

٢٩
ع

Dust rose at the end of the road.

٣٠
ع

The students stood up. Like one body.

٣١
ع

Then they saw him.

٣٢
ع

A man in clean clothes. Carrying two bags. Walking fast. His eyes searching. The specific full small returned-son posture of a man who had, twenty years earlier, walked away from this same village as a boy — and who was now walking back into it as a person his old neighbours did not, at the first glance, fully recognise. The years in Bahrain had given him a different small specific carriage. Cleaner clothes. A small specific city-trimmed beard. A walk that knew, by long muscle-memory, the wider streets of a Gulf capital. But the small specific way he searched the road for the small specific old door of a small specific clay house was the same searching that he had done as a child — when he had come home from the falaj at sunset, and had looked up the same road, and had seen the same door, and had run toward it.

٣٣
ع

"Baba!" someone shouted.

٣٤
ع

Shayb Khalaf came out of his clay house. Slowly. His stick in his hand.

٣٥
ع

He stopped.

٣٦
ع

He looked.

٣٧
ع

The stick fell.

٣٨
ع

For a second, the village stopped breathing.

۞

Then **Obaïd** ran.

۞

He didn't walk. He didn't think.

۞

He ran. And hugged the old man so hard that **Khalaf** almost fell.

۞

"Baba," **Obaïd** said, his voice breaking. "I am back."

۞

Shayb Khalaf did not speak.

۞

He just held him.

۞

And held him.

۞

And held him.

۞

*The specific full small twenty-year embrace of a father who had — every morning for twenty years, with the small specific quiet stubbornness that the village had mistaken for sorcery — refused to give up the small private hope that this exact moment would, one day, occur. The whole specific small village-folklore of the maghsoob, the magbar smoke, the small specific reputation of **Khalaf** as a frightening figure — had been, the whole time, the small accidental cover that a grieving father had grown around himself, because grief in a village was not a thing a man could simply have. Grief had to be disguised. The small specific village-reputation had been the disguise. And now — at this moment, in front of his son — the disguise had become unnecessary. **Khalaf**, who had not wept in twenty years, did not weep now either. But the small specific holding-of-his-son was, in its complete physical commitment, more eloquent than any weeping would have been.*

۞

Some of the women wiped their eyes.

۞

Safiya's eyes were full.

۞

John swallowed.

۞

Thuraya whispered, *"He waited many years."*

~

Even **Malood** was quiet.

SCENE THREE

Gifts and Stories

Later, **Obaid** came to the school with his father.

~

He brought small gifts for the children.

~

Simple things. But precious.

~

For each child, a smile.

~

For each smile, a memory.

~

John shook **Obaid**'s hand. *"Welcome back."*

~

Obaid smiled. *"Thank you, teacher."*

~

Safiya asked, *"What do you do in Babrain?"*

~

Obaid's eyes shone. *"I work with herbs. Medicine. Old knowledge."*

~

He showed them small bags.

~

"This is for stomach."

"This for headache."

"This for sleep."

~

Thuraya nodded. *"Your grandfather used to do this."*

~

Obaid smiled sadly. "Yes. And my mother..."

~

He stopped.

~

No one spoke.

~

Shayb Khalaf looked away.

~

*The specific small full village-silence of a moment in which the unsaid name of a long-lost mother — Khalaf's wife, Obaid's mother, the woman the village had lost so many years ago that some of the children had no idea she had ever existed — became audible without being spoken. The specific small understanding of every adult present that the small specific hard quietness of **Khalaf's** last twenty years had been, at least in part, a quietness around her absence. The folkloric reputation of sabir had been the village's way of explaining a man whose grief had been too large to look at directly. The folkloric reputation of maghsoob for his missing son had been a similar small accommodation — a folktale to fill the small specific gap of an actual son who had simply gone to Bahrain and, until today, not come back.*

SCENE FOUR

The Truth at Sadu's Shop

That afternoon, **John** went to **Dukkan Al-Hallah**.

~

He found **Sadu** laughing.

~

Too much laughing.

~

"What?" **John** asked.

~

Sadu almost fell from the bench.

~

"You! You and 'Manoob'!"

~

John froze. "What?"

~

Sadu wiped his eyes.

٢٧
ع

"Zabran. He is crazy. Manoob is HIS wife. Not Khalafs!"

٢٨
ع

John's mouth opened.

٢٩
ع

"Zabran mixes names. He forgets. He tells stories. Everyone knows."

٣٠
ع

John whispered, "So... Shayb Khalaf was never afraid of Manoob?"

٣١
ع

Sadu laughed harder. "No. He is afraid of nothing."

٣٢
ع

John closed his eyes.

٣٣
ع

Slowly.

٣٤
ع

Very slowly.

٣٥
ع

*The specific full small slow closing-of-the-eyes of a man who had, in the previous twenty-four hours, organised an entire elaborate detective-investigation, broken into an empty house, encountered a spilled dallah and an abandoned walking stick, and constructed a small private hypothesis about the small specific psychological vulnerabilities of the village's most folkloric figure — only to discover that the entire chain of reasoning had been founded on the small specific confusion of an old man who could no longer reliably remember whose wife was whose. The whole detective story had been a small specific village-fiction. The whole small specific terror that **John** had constructed in his Northern foreign-teacher's imagination had been, at heart, the small specific gossip of one specific old man whose memory had begun, over the years, to assign other people's wives to other people's husbands.*

SCENE FIVE

The Big Embarrassment

In the evening, **John** walked to **Shayb Khalaf's** house.

٣٦
ع

He stood straight.

٣٧
ع

He cleared his throat.

٣٨
ع

Khalaf looked at him. *"You were coming yesterday?"*

﴿

John nodded. *"Yes. I wanted to say something."*

﴿

Khalaf leaned on his stick. *"Say."*

﴿

John took a deep breath.

﴿

"I wanted to say... Man—"

﴿

He stopped.

﴿

He waited.

﴿

Nothing happened.

﴿

No shaking.

﴿

No flying.

﴿

No fear.

﴿

Khalaf raised an eyebrow. *"Say what?"*

﴿

John tried again. *"I wanted to say... M—"*

﴿

Suddenly:

﴿

WHACK.

﴿

The stick hit **John's** back.

﴿

«عجب! أنا أخاف متووه نوبه؟»

وَالْع

('Ajab! Ana akhaaf min Manooh nawbah?! — Amazing! Me, afraid of Manooh, of all people?!)

وَالْع

John jumped. "OW!"

وَالْع

Khalaf growled. *"You think I am stupid?"*

وَالْع

John's face turned red.

وَالْع

Then **Khalaf** added, calmly, *"Zabran is crazy."*

وَالْع

John looked at the ground.

وَالْع

Very interested in the ground.

SCENE SIX

The Legendary Chase — and the Light in the Window

From behind the house, **Sadu** appeared. Laughing. Like a drum.

وَالْع

"I told you! I told you!"

وَالْع

John saw the stick in **Khalaf's** hand.

وَالْع

Bad idea.

وَالْع

Very bad idea.

وَالْع

He grabbed **Sadu** and ran.

وَالْع

"HEY!" **Khalaf** shouted and ran after them.

وَالْع

Malood saw running and decided this was a game.

وَالْع

He ran too.

٢٧
ع

The children saw running and joined.

٢٨
ع

Soon the whole village saw:

٢٩
ع

Sadu running.

٣٠
ع

Behind him **John**.

٣١
ع

Behind him **Khalaf**.

٣٢
ع

Behind him **Malood**.

٣٣
ع

Behind him the children.

٣٤
ع

Someone shouted, *"It's a festival!"*

٣٥
ع

That night, **John** sat at home. Rubbing his back.

٣٦
ع

Safiya looked at him. *"So... what did we learn today?"*

٣٧
ع

John sighed. *"Never trust village gossip."*

٣٨
ع

Thuraya smiled. *"And?"*

٣٩
ع

John thought.

٤٠
ع

Then said, softly:

٤١
ع

"Some people wait years for love."

٤٢
ع

*The specific full small late-evening sentence that, of everything **John** had said that day, was the only one that had any actual weight. The whole comic-village-chase of the afternoon — Sadu running, the stick swinging, the children turning the chase into a small specific village-festival — had been the small surface theatre. The actual content of the day had been the small specific twenty-year embrace at the door of **Khalaf**'s clay house. The folktale had been about a sahir and a maghsoob. The truth, which had been waiting under the folktale all along, was about a father waiting for his son. The whole village had needed the folktale because the village had not had the small specific emotional vocabulary, in those years, to name the actual thing. The actual thing was love. The folktale had been love's small specific Omani disguise.*



Outside, **Shayb Khalaf**'s house had light again.



And for the first time...



The village slept peacefully.



Did You Know?

Traditional Herbal Medicine in the Gulf

Obaid, who returned from Bahrain carrying bags of herbs for stomach aches, headaches, and sleep, represents a real and ancient Gulf tradition. Folk medicine in Oman and Bahrain draws on herbal knowledge passed down from ancestors (the "hakim"), historically shaped by Persian-Arab Islamic medicine and Indian Ayurvedic medicine through old trade routes connecting Oman with India, Africa, and the Gulf.

Source: ebSCO.com · pmc.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov

PALM

Palm Thirty-Four

Then and Now — A Trip to Jibreen Castle

SCENE ONE

A Long Dusty Road and a New Guide

The road to **Jibreen Castle** was long, dusty, and full of quiet excitement.

و

There are roads in Oman that announce their destinations long before you arrive — and there are roads that, like this one, hold their secrets close. The interior road from Samail toward Babla in 1973 was not paved end-to-end; it was a small specific surface of compacted earth and gravel that had been graded only the previous year, that ran between specific small palm farms and through specific small wadis, and that delivered, eventually, to anyone willing to follow it for two hours, the small specific full revelation of what an Omani castle actually looked like in person.

و

The pickup of **Uncle Nasser** moved slowly between palm trees and open land. The children sat in the back, holding their bags, their notebooks, and their small dreams.

و

John sat in front, looking at the horizon — like a man about to meet history.

و

Safiya sat beside him. Her camera resting on her lap.

و

Thuraya sat behind them, explaining the plan again and again — because teachers never trust that students really listen.

و

And with them this time was **Obaid**.

و

Not as a visitor.

و

Not as a guest.



But as a *guide*.



*The specific small full quiet new role of **Obaid** — who had been, only a few days earlier, the long-lost son returned from Bahrain, and who had now, by the small specific fast small village-economy of belonging, become the person whose knowledge the school day required. He had spent his Bahraini years working with herbs and old knowledge. But before Bahrain, he had been the village boy who had grown up in the small specific shadow of the interior castles, who had visited Jibreen a dozen times as a child with his uncles, who carried — as **Thuraya** herself did not carry — the small specific full inherited memory of these specific small interior places. The school had needed him for this exact day. The school had not, until **Thuraya** had specifically asked, known it needed him.*



He stood in the back of the pickup. Holding the side with one hand. Pointing at the land with the other.



"There," he said. "That road did not exist before."



John turned. *"So... how did people travel?"*



Obaid smiled. *"On animals. On feet. Slowly. Very slowly."*



Mansoor opened his eyes wide. *"Even to Nizwa?"*



Obaid nodded. *"Especially to Nizwa."*



The children looked at each other — like they were trying to imagine a world without roads.



Safiya whispered to **Thuraya**, *"It's strange. We are living inside a story."*



Thuraya smiled. *"Yes. And today, we will teach them how to tell it."*

SCENE TWO

The Castle Appears

Jibreen Castle appeared like something from a dream.



Tall.

~
ع

Strong.

~
ع

Quiet.

~
ع

Its walls looked like they were holding secrets.

~
ع

The specific full small first-encounter that any Omani-interior visitor had with Jibreen — the small specific moment when the road curved, and the palms thinned, and the castle simply was there, unannounced, vast, the colour of the desert it had been made from. Three storeys of carefully balanced stonework, four corner-towers, the small specific ornamental wooden window-frames that even three centuries of sun had not entirely faded. The castle did not advertise itself. The castle did not need to. The castle was, simply, the small specific architectural expression of a moment in Omani history when the Yarubi imams had built — across the entire interior — a network of small specific full administrative-fortress-palaces from which the country had been governed.

~
ع

Ali stood very still. *"It looks like a king's house."*

~
ع

Obaid nodded. *"It was."*

~
ع

They entered slowly.

~
ع

Their footsteps echoed.

~
ع

Obaid spoke in a calm, respectful voice.

~
ع

"Long time ago, people lived here. They studied here. They fought here. They planned here."

~
ع

John wrote some words in his notebook:

~
ع

lived — studied — fought — planned

~
ع

Safiya whispered to the students, *"Repeat after me: They lived here."*

﴿

The class said together. *"They lived here."*

﴿

Obaid continued. *"In the past, Oman did not have schools like today. People learned in mosques and houses. They used oil lamps, not electricity."*

﴿

Thuraya added, gently, *"And water... they used falaj. No pipes."*

﴿

John turned to the students. He wrote on a small board he carried:

﴿

In the past, they used to...

Now, we...

﴿

He pointed at **Ali**. *"Ali. In the past, they used to...?"*

﴿

Ali thought. *"They used to... walk... long."*

﴿

John smiled. *"Good! They used to walk long distances."*

﴿

Ahmed added, *"Now, we... use car."*

﴿

Safiya clapped. *"Excellent!"*

﴿

Mansoor raised his hand. *"In the past, they used to... no fan."*

﴿

The class laughed.

﴿

Thuraya nodded. *"True. No fan. Only patience."*

SCENE THREE

From Room to Room

They walked from room to room.

﴿

*The specific full slow-pacing of a small school-group through a 17th-century Omani castle — the specific small careful step of children whose feet, instinctively, knew that the floors they were walking on were old, that the small specific painted wooden ceilings above their heads were not to be touched, that the small specific carved wooden doors had been, three centuries earlier, the doors of imams. **Obaid** moved between the rooms with the small specific full quiet authority of a man whose own grandfather had told him, long ago, what each specific small space in this castle had been for. The children followed in a small specific full informal cluster, asking questions in Arabic, receiving answers in **Obaid's** slow careful village-Arabic, and absorbing — without quite noticing — the small specific full lesson that their own country was old.*

☪

Obaid showed them the ceilings. The small windows. The secret passages.

☪

"In the past," he said, "people protected their families here. Now, we protect history."

☪

John felt something heavy and beautiful in his chest.

☪

He looked at **Thuraya**. *"Your country has strong roots."*

☪

She answered quietly, *"And now... it is growing."*

SCENE FOUR

Ali's Drawing

They sat in the shade near the castle wall.

☪

Safiya took out colors and papers.

☪

"Now," she said, "you draw."

☪

The students looked at her. *"Draw?"*

☪

"Yes," she smiled. "Draw the castle. Or what you feel."

☪

Thuraya added, *"And write one sentence."*

☪

John wrote on a big paper:

In the past...

Now...

In the future, I will...

Ali sat very quietly.

Very focused.

His hand moved slowly. Carefully.

John passed by and stopped.

He leaned down.

Did not speak.

Just watched.

***Ali** was not drawing only the castle. He was drawing the castle, the land, and a big flag above it. The lines were confident. The colors were strong. The specific full small unmistakable confidence of a child whose hand had — without anyone in the village having previously noticed it — been quietly developing the small specific competence of a real artist. The flag was the new flag of Oman, the flag that had been adopted only three years earlier, with its red field and its white and green panels and its small specific khanjar at the top. **Ali** had, with the small specific patience of a boy who had been watching the world more carefully than the world had been watching him, memorised every detail of that flag. He was now putting it, very carefully, above the castle.*

Safiya came and froze.

She whispered, "*Thuraya...*"

Thuraya looked.

And smiled in surprise.

20
ع

"He has talent," she said softly.

20
ع

Ali wrote under his drawing. Slowly:

20
ع

In the past, Oman was strong.

Now, Oman is growing.

In the future, I will help my country.

20
ع

Safiya felt her eyes burn.

20
ع

She lifted the drawing. She showed it to **John**.

20
ع

He looked at it for a long time.

20
ع

Then he said, quietly, *"Ali... you are an artist."*

20
ع

Ali looked down. Shy.

20
ع

Mansoor's drawing was... *a castle with five suns and two goats.*

20
ع

Malood walked over and tried to eat the corner.

SCENE FIVE

In the Future, I Will...

Before leaving, **John** stood and said, *"Okay. Let's speak."*

20
ع

He pointed to **Noura**. *"One sentence."*

20
ع

Noura said, *"In the past, they used to... live in castle."*

20
ع

John nodded. *"Good."*

٢٧
ع

Khalil said, "Now, we have... school."

٢٨
ع

Ahmed said, "In the future, I will... be teacher."

٢٩
ع

Saeed, from the back, said quietly, "In the future, I will... learn more."

٣٠
ع

Thuraya looked at him.

٣١
ع

And smiled.

٣٢
ع

*The specific small full teacher-smile of a woman who had — over the course of the past several months — watched **Saeed**'s small English-language confidence grow from I was watching in October to I am thinking in November to I am afraid of not seeing what is true last month, and now to In the future, I will learn more at Jibreen. The trajectory of the year was visible in the specific small full grammatical journey of one boy. **Thuraya**, who had taught for years and who had — in earlier classes — watched many small bright children fade as their grammar got better but their courage got smaller, recognised that the opposite was happening with **Saeed**. His grammar was getting better. And his courage, in proportion, was getting larger. The small specific outcome that every teacher hopes for, but that no teacher gets to count on.*

SCENE SIX

The Flag Receding

On the way back, the sun was lower.

٣٣
ع

The castle stayed behind them like a memory.

٣٤
ع

*The specific full small late-afternoon light on the small specific honey-coloured stone of Jibreen as the pickup pulled away. The castle had been there for three centuries. The castle would be there for many more. The pickup, with its small specific cargo of children and teachers and one small folded paper drawing, would be remembered — by the people inside it — for the rest of their lives. **Safiya** held **Ali**'s drawing on her lap, the colours still wet at the edges, the small specific village-paper slightly curled. She had decided, without asking, that this drawing was going home with them. She had decided, somewhere between the castle and the truck, that this small specific image — a castle in the past, a country growing in the present, a flag promising the future — was the small specific completion of her year here. She would keep it. She would frame it, eventually. She would, in many years, hang it on a wall in a different*

country and would, on certain mornings, look at it and feel a specific small full warmth that no other object in her possession would be able to produce.



Safiya held **Ali**'s drawing on her lap.



She said softly, *"Sometimes... a lesson is not in the book."*



John nodded. *"Sometimes, it's in a child."*



Thuraya looked at the road ahead.



"And sometimes," she said, *"it is in a country."*



The pickup moved forward.



And history moved with it.



 Did You Know?

The Historic Jibreen Castle

The Jibreen Castle the children visited is real, standing in the wilayat of Bahla, built in 1675 CE by order of Imam Bil'arab bin Sultan Al Ya' rubi, who was buried there after his death in 1692. It wasn't only a seat of power but a center of learning — astronomy, medicine, and Islamic jurisprudence were taught there — famous for its decorated ceilings and its falaj-based cooling system.

Source: omanobserver.om • lonelyplanet.com

PALM

Palm Thirty-Five

The Month When Everything Changed — Ramadan in Samail

SCENE ONE

The First Adhan of the Month

The first sound came before the light.

~

It was not the sun that woke Samail.

~

It was the adhan.

~

The voice floated from far away. Soft and strong at the same time. Moving between the mountains, over the palm trees, into the houses, into the hearts. The specific full small Omani-village adhan of a small specific muezzin who had, for thirty-eight years, climbed the small specific narrow stairway of the small specific village mosque before the first hint of dawn, and had — into the small specific quiet of every Samaili pre-morning — released the same fourteen ancient lines that had, over the centuries, anchored every single Muslim awakening in this part of the world. The adhan was not, on a normal day, news. The adhan was the small specific full background-fact of life. But on this specific morning, in this specific season, the adhan carried — for the first time in the year — the small specific full additional weight of Ramadan. The whole village, hearing it, recognised the difference instantly.

~

John opened his eyes slowly.

~

"What... is that?" he whispered.

~

Safiya was already awake. She was sitting on the edge of the bed. Listening.

~

"It's beautiful," she said. "It sounds like... the sky is speaking."

~

Outside, the village was different.

~

Quieter.

~

Kinder.

~

Like it was holding its breath.

~

Thuraya walked past their house. Her steps light. Her face calm. She carried a small bag of dates and bread. She stopped, looked at the sky, and whispered a short prayer before continuing her way.

~

That day, no children came to school.

~

No noise.

~

No running.

~

No shouting.

~

Even **Sadoo's** shop was closed. A wooden sign hung on the door:

~

Closed for Ramadan.

~

Mansoor passed by slowly. His face tired but proud.

~

"I am fasting," he said to **Malood**, who was trying to eat a leaf. *"You... you don't understand religion."*

~

Malood ate the leaf.

SCENE TWO

The Travelling Food

By afternoon, something strange happened.

The village started to smell different.

*From one house: fried onions. From another: bread. From another: spices, soup, meat. The specific small full layered scent-architecture of an Omani village preparing iftar — the small specific late-afternoon collective accumulation of every household's small specific evening-meal smoke rising at the same time, blending, drifting through the lanes, settling into the small specific full village-air with the small specific layered density that **Safiya**, standing at her window, had not — until this exact afternoon — ever encountered. The village did not smell like itself. The village smelled like thirty households cooking simultaneously, all of them with the same small specific full cardamom-saffron-onion logic, all of them aimed at the same small specific full magrib moment that was still — by **John**'s wristwatch — three hours away.*

Plates moved from door to door.

Women walked in groups, carrying food, laughing quietly.

Safiya stood at the window. *"The food... it's travelling,"* she said.

John laughed. *"Like a food parade."*

But the sun was still high.

And nobody was eating.

John looked at his watch. *"So... they don't eat. They don't drink. All day?"*

Thuraya, who had just come to check on them, nodded. *"From dawn to sunset."*

Safiya blinked. *"Even water?"*

"Yes."

John sat slowly. *"That is... serious."*

Safiya smiled. *"We read about this. In books. Remember?"*

~

John nodded. *"That was... one of the reasons we wanted to come here."*

~

They stayed quiet for a moment. The specific small full silence of a married couple who had — three years earlier, in their small specific Northern flat, before the contract, before the journey — discussed Islam many times. Had read books about it. Had wondered, both of them privately, about what it would feel like to live somewhere it was the air. They had not, in those early conversations, used the word *convert*. They had used the word *understand*. But the small specific layered quietness of this exact afternoon was beginning to suggest, to both of them, that *understanding* had — somewhere along the months — been replaced by something else.

~

Then **Safiya** said, suddenly, *"Let's try."*

~

John turned slowly. *"Try what?"*

~

"Fasting."

~

He stared at her. *"Are you... serious?"*

~

She smiled. *"Come on. One day."*

SCENE THREE

The Longest Day

By ten in the morning, **John** was already dramatic.

~

"I think... my mouth is becoming a desert."

~

Safiya looked at him. *"Stop it."*

~

By twelve, he was lying on the floor.

~

"I can bear... water calling me."

~

Safiya sat beside him. *"Drama queen."*

۞

By two, he tried to stand up and failed. *"I see... light."*

۞

Safiya laughed. *"That's the fan."*

۞

Malood came, looked at him, and stepped over his leg.

۞

By four, **John** was on the floor again. *"I am not built for this."*

۞

Safiya sat cross-legged. *"You wanted to understand the culture. Congratulations."*

۞

Then... *knock knock.*

۞

The door opened.

۞

Thuraya stood there. With a big tray.

۞

"I brought you iftar," she said.

۞

John tried to sit. *"But... we are not fasting."*

۞

Thuraya smiled. *"I know. But you should taste Ramadan."*

۞

She put the tray down.

۞

Dates. Soup. Bread. Samosas. Rice.

۞

Safiya looked at the food. Then at **Thuraya**. Then at **John**.

۞

Then she laughed.

۞

"Look at us. Not fasting. And dying."

٢٧
﴿

Thuraya looked at them both and laughed.

٢٨
﴿

"Poor you. One day only, and you almost die."

٢٩
﴿

She looked at **John** seriously and said in Arabic. Smiling:

٣٠
﴿

«صيام بدون صلاة؟»

٣١
﴿

(*Siyam bidoon salat? — Fasting without prayer?*)

٣٢
﴿

Then she laughed again.

SCENE FOUR

The Disappearing Afternoons

Days passed.

٣٣
﴿

Ramadan continued.

٣٤
﴿

John and **Safiya** started... disappearing in the afternoons.

٣٥
﴿

*The specific small full pattern that the village had begun to notice — and not yet quite explain. Around three in the afternoon, every day, the foreign teachers would leave their small house. They would walk down the lane. They would not go to the school. They would not go to the shop. They would not go to the falaj. They would simply, in a specific small full direction the children could not quite track, disappear. They would, an hour or two later, return — quietly, with the small specific full quietness of two people who had done something that had required quietness — and would, for the rest of the day, be the same **John** and **Safiya** the village had grown accustomed to. But the afternoon disappearance had become daily. And the village, by long village-instinct, was paying attention.*

٣٦
﴿

They left quietly.

٣٧
﴿

They came back quietly.

٣٨
﴿

The children noticed.

و

Mansoor whispered, *"They go to the teacher's house."*

و

Khalil said, *"Every day."*

و

Noura said, *"Why?"*

و

They tried to follow them.

و

But **Shayb Khalaf** appeared. Like a wall.

و

He stood in the road. Holding his stick.

و

"Any one follow them," he said, *"this bamboo talks."*

و

He looked at **Thuraya**. *"First you, Thraywa."*

و

Thuraya crossed her arms. *"You like drama."*

و

He did not move.

و

They turned back.

SCENE FIVE

A Different Adhan

Half of Ramadan passed.

و

One evening, the adhan was different.

و

Stronger.

و

Closer.

و

John and Safiya walked with Thuraya.

٢٧

Not to their house.

٢٨

Not to the teacher's house.

٢٩

To the *mosque*.

٣٠

The village noticed.

٣١

People stopped.

٣٢

Looked.

٣٣

Whispered.

٣٤

*The specific small full village-pause of an Omani community whose entire small specific reading of the foreign teachers had — over a year — gradually shifted, but had not, until that exact small evening-walk, expressed itself in a single visible small specific public action. The walk to the mosque was not, by itself, an announcement. It was a small specific full direction-of-travel. **John** walked at a normal pace. **Safiya** walked beside him. **Thuraya** walked slightly ahead, the way a guide walks. None of them looked left or right. None of them needed to. The village's collective small specific full attention was on them — and their feet, the three pairs of feet, were quietly carrying the small specific full visible answer to a question that the village had been asking, for many months, in silence.*

٣٥

That night, after iftar, **Shayb Khalaf** opened his house.

٣٦

He did something nobody expected.

٣٧

He made a big table. For everyone.

٣٨

Rice. Meat. Bread. Dates. Tea.

٣٩

He stood and said, simply:

"Today... we celebrate."

John stood. His voice was not strong. But it was clear.

"I came to Oman to teach English," he said. "But Oman taught me... something bigger."

Safiya held his hand.

"We did not come only for work," she said. "We came because we were... searching."

John looked at **Thuraya**. "At your people. Your life. Your faith."

He took a breath.

"Today... we say it clearly."

They looked at each other.

And said:

"We are Muslims."

For a second, nobody spoke.

Then... the village exploded.

Smiles. Tears. Voices.

Mansoor shouted, "Teacher John is one of us!"

Malood jumped on the table.

Shayb Khalaf wiped his eyes with his sleeve and said, "*Late... but good.*"

SCENE SIX

The Night of Light

They ate together.

~

They laughed.

~

They talked.

~

Safiya tasted everything and said, "*This is dangerous. I will never be thin again.*"

~

John looked at the people praying.

~

Quiet.

~

Peaceful.

~

And said softly, "*I think... this is home.*"

~

Thuraya looked at them.

~

And said nothing.

~

Because some moments... do not need words.

~

*The specific full small small village-night that **Thuraya** would, in later years, remember with the specific small clear photographic precision of the most important nights of a person's life. **Khalaf's** open house. The small full specific lamp on the wooden shelf casting yellow light on every specific face. The specific small smile of **Saeed**, who had shown up — uninvited, unannounced, in the small specific quiet way only **Saeed** showed up — and was sitting in his usual corner, watching, but for the first time without watching from outside the moment. He was inside it. The whole village was inside it. The small specific full evening had been the small specific completion of a small specific full year — the year a man and his wife had come from Britain to teach English, and had ended, instead, by becoming the village's small*

*specific full additional Muslims. The small specific full grammar of I am, which **Safiya** had taught the children all year, had — on this small specific night — been spoken back to her, by herself and her husband, in its most consequential conjugation: We are Muslims.*

٢٧
ع

Later, at home, **John** lay on the floor.

٢٧
ع

Full.

٢٧
ع

Happy.

٢٧
ع

Safiya looked at him.

٢٧
ع

"You survived fasting. You survived food. Congratulations."

٢٧
ع

He smiled.

٢٧
ع

"This... was the month that changed everything."

٢٧
ع

 Did You Know?

Ramadan Fasting Traditions

John and Sophia tried just one day of fasting and joked they were "about to die"! Real Ramadan fasting runs from dawn prayer until sunset prayer, abstaining from food and drink through daylight hours — one of Islam's five pillars — preceded by suhoor and followed by iftar, alongside prayer, Quran recitation, and deepened social bonds.

Source: britannica.com · en.wikipedia.org

PALM

Palm Thirty-Six

The Day the Palm Tree Witnessed Everything — Samail, 1976 → 2026

SCENE ONE

The Quiet Morning of Exams

The classroom was not noisy that morning.

٢٥

It was... *nervous*.

٢٥

Even **Mansoor** was quiet.

٢٥

*The specific full small village-classroom-quietness of an exam morning — different in texture from any other school-quietness, because it was a quietness made of accumulated small individual nerves rather than absence of activity. Each child carried, that morning, the small specific full private weight of their own private examination-anxiety. **Ahmed** had been awake since five. **Ali** had eaten only half his breakfast. **Noura** had reorganised her pencil case three times. The specific small full preparation-rituals of small village-children who had decided, individually, that today was the small specific day they had been being prepared for, all year.*

٢٥

The old fan turned slowly. The chalkboard was clean. The desks were too straight — like they were also waiting.

٢٥

"Today... exams," **John** said, trying to sound calm.

٢٥

Safiya smiled. "*Don't look at me like I am the judge.*"

٢٥

Thuraya walked between the desks. "*Just do your best. That's all.*"

٢٥

The papers were given.

Silence fell like a blanket.

*The specific full small examination-silence that, in any classroom anywhere, has the same small specific layered quality — pencils on paper, the small specific scratching of focused thought, an occasional small specific full sigh from a corner where a particular student had encountered a particular question and was, for a small specific moment, reorganising their understanding of what they had been taught. **Thuraya**, walking slowly between the desks, had — over many years of teaching — learned to read these small examination-silences with the small specific precision of a doctor reading a heartbeat. The silence was good. The silence was the silence of children doing their work.*

Ahmed wrote like a machine.

Ali stopped sometimes, looked up, then continued.

Noura whispered the question to herself.

Khalil bit his pencil.

Mansoor stared at the paper like it was an enemy.

Malood slept near the door.

SCENE TWO

The Longest Week

The week of correction was... dangerous.

*The specific small full village-teacher's correction-week of three teachers who had committed themselves, over many months, to a small specific full project — and who had now, with the exam papers in front of them, the small specific full task of measuring whether the project had worked. The correction was not, by itself, a difficult task. It was emotionally difficult. Every paper was the small specific full record of a particular small child's accumulated small year. **Thuraya**, who had taught these specific children since they were five, knew their handwriting better than her own. She could, by the third sentence of any paper, tell which student had written it without reading the name. The papers were not anonymous to her. The papers were small specific personal things.*

John was tired.

~
ع

Safiya was tired.

~
ع

Thuraya was pretending she was not nervous.

~
ع

At night, they corrected papers in the small house. The single oil lamp on the small wooden table. Three teachers leaning over papers. A pot of tea between them, occasionally being refilled. The small specific full late-evening sound of pencil-marks and small specific full teacher-comments and the occasional quiet sigh.

~
ع

"Look at Ali," **Safiya** said. "His writing improved so much."

~
ع

"And Ahmed," **John** said. "Perfect grammar."

~
ع

"And Mansoor..." **Thuraya** laughed. "At least he wrote something."

SCENE THREE

Results Day

The children stood in lines under the palm tree.

~
ع

The same palm tree.

~
ع

The one that saw everything.

~
ع

The specific full small symbolic palm tree under which — during the past school year — every important small specific village-school moment had occurred. The lessons under it. The confessions under it. The grasshopper under it. The pride-list under it. The small specific full village-tree that had stood there, patient, since long before any of these specific small children had been born, and that would stand there, patient, long after they were gone. The tree had not changed. The children had. The whole specific full pedagogical contract of the school year had been, in some small specific full unspoken sense, witnessed by this exact tree.

~
ع

John held the paper.

~
ع

Safiya held her breath.

٢٧

Thuraya smiled like a mother.

٢٨

"Ahmed," John said. "Excellent."

٢٩

Ahmed stood straight. Like a soldier.

٣٠

"Ali," Safiya said. "Excellent."

٣١

Ali's eyes shined.

٣٢

"Noura... Very good."

٣٣

"Mitbla... Very good."

٣٤

"Salima... Good."

٣٥

"Marwa... Good."

٣٦

"Rabma... Good."

٣٧

Then...

٣٨

"Mansoor..."

٣٩

He closed his eyes.

٤٠

"...Passed."

٤١

The village heard his scream before the mountains did.

٤٢

*The specific full small full **Mansoor**-scream of pure joy that was, in its own specific small way, the small specific village-anthem of the entire school year. **Mansoor**, who had run more than any other child, who had stolen one Bob Jamid from **Sadoo**, who had been afraid of butterflies, who had jumped in puddles, who had attempted to bribe **Sadou** with a goat — had, against his own private long expectations and against several teachers' private quiet doubts, passed. The pass had not been spectacular. The pass had been narrow. But the pass had been, by every relevant village-metric, a victory. And **Mansoor**, who had decided long ago that he was going to register every small specific full village-emotion at maximum volume, screamed accordingly.*

SCENE FOUR

Graduation Day

The school was decorated with simple cloth and palm leaves.

~

The specific full small village-decoration of an Omani school's graduation day in 1976 — small specific lengths of bright cloth tied between palm fronds, small specific paper flowers made by the girls of the older class, a single small specific cardboard banner with hand-painted Arabic and English. The decoration was modest. The decoration was, by the small specific village-economy of those years, the most that could be done. And the decoration was, in its small specific full modesty, exactly right — because the day was not, in any sense, about decoration. The day was about the children.

~

Mothers brought food.

~

Fathers came with proud faces.

~

Even **Sadoo** closed his shop early.

~

Shayb Khalaf sat in the front, holding his stick like a medal.

~

The children stood in a line.

~

They sang.

~

They laughed.

~

They received small certificates.

٢٧
ع

Safiya cried.

٢٨
ع

John pretended not to cry.

٢٩
ع

Thuraya cried openly.

٣٠
ع

When it ended, **John** looked at the children and said:

٣١
ع

"You came here not knowing even one word. Now... you can speak. You can read. You can dream."

SCENE FIVE

The Goodbye That Was Not a Goodbye

That evening, they sat under the palm tree.

٣٢
ع

The same one.

٣٣
ع

Malood jumped between them.

٣٤
ع

The sun went down slowly.

٣٥
ع

The specific full small Omani-evening of a school year that had ended. The lanes had emptied. The mothers had taken the food back to their kitchens. The fathers had returned to their farms. The children had gone home — most of them, by now, with their small certificates rolled and tied with palm-leaf string, the small specific full first formal recognition any of them had ever received from any institution. The teachers, the three of them, had stayed. They were not in a hurry. The day had not yet completed itself. It had — by the small specific full quiet pull of a year that did not want to be put away too quickly — required that they sit, the three of them, under this exact palm tree, and look at the small specific village they had, together, taught.

٣٦
ع

Safiya said, quietly, *"Do you remember our first day here?"*

٣٧
ع

John smiled. *"I fell in the smoke."*

٣٨
ع

They laughed.

~

Thuraya looked at the tree.

~

"This place... changed us all."

~

The three of them sat in silence then. The small specific full late-Omani-evening with the colour of the sky moving slowly through pink and orange and finally into the small specific full purple that meant night. Somewhere down the lane, a child laughed. Somewhere a mother called another child home. Somewhere a goat — almost certainly **Malood** — bleated once. The village continued. The village had always continued. The village would continue.

~

And in the small specific full quiet of that exact evening, the school year ended.

SCENE SIX

Suddenly... 2026

*Half a century passes. The reader of this book — like the writer of it — knows that fifty years cannot be folded into a single page. And yet the small specific full ending of a story sometimes requires exactly that fold. The pickup of **Uncle Nasser** rusts and is replaced by another, and another. **Sadoo's** shop closes and reopens under his nephew. The school, which was simple in 1973, is rebuilt — twice. **Shayb Khalaf** dies in 1981, an old man, peaceful. His son **Obaid** stays in the village. **Al-Mu'allim Hamad** dies in 1984, in the same calm small specific way he had lived. **Mansoor** grows up, becomes a teacher himself, and tells the story of **Bob Jamid** at every staffroom in the country. **Ali** becomes an architect, and his small drawings of castles become real buildings. **Saeed** becomes a doctor — quiet, observant, the small specific full physician whose patients always say he sees what is true. **Noura** talks her way into a radio station. **Ahmed** does, in fact, become a teacher. **Khalil** becomes — to no one's surprise — a small specific full successful village-businessman who, on certain mornings, sets up a bucket above his own shop door for fun.*

~

And **Thuraya**?

~

Thuraya teaches for forty more years.

~

She marries. She raises children. Her children grow up. Her children have children. The small specific full long quiet life of an Omani teacher whose small specific full career was — by every small specific village-measurement that mattered — exactly the career she had wanted.

~

And **John** and **Safiya**?

٢٧
ع

They stay in Samail for many years. Then they leave. Then they come back. Then they leave again. Then — eventually — the small specific full slow forgetting that takes them away from this story, but not from this village's memory.

٢٨
ع

The notebooks of that year stay with **Thuraya**. In a small specific full wooden chest. In a small specific full corner of her house. For fifty years.

٢٩
ع

And then, on a specific small full morning in the year 2026 —

٣٠
ع

The sound of a pen.

٣١
ع

A notebook.

٣٢
ع

A woman sitting in her room.

٣٣
ع

Writing.

٣٤
ع

She closes the notebook slowly.

٣٥
ع

A voice from outside:

٣٦
ع

«ثريااااا... تعالي تغدي! الساعة صارت 2»

٣٧
ع

(*Thuraaaaa... come for lunch! It's already 2 o'clock!*)

٣٨
ع

Thuraya answers:

٣٩
ع

«إنزين ماہ... جاہ»

٤٠
ع

(*Okay Mom... I'm coming.*)

٤١
ع

She looks at the notebook.



On the last page:



"And this was how it all started... under the palm tree."



She closes it.



On the cover:



123 Let's Learn English Under the Palm Tree



*She holds the notebook for a small specific full moment. It is heavy. It is full of fifty years. It is — by the small specific full impossible accumulating density that any well-kept notebook acquires — both a small physical object and a small specific full life. The fifty-year-old woman who is now **Thuraya** looks down at the small specific full hands that wrote it, and recognises that those hands are — though they have changed — the same hands that once held a piece of village chalk, under a palm tree, in 1973, and taught a small group of barefoot children the present continuous tense.*



She places the notebook on the shelf.



She walks toward the kitchen — toward her mother's voice, toward the small specific full Omani-lunch that is waiting, toward the small specific full quiet ordinary continuation of every life that has ever, against the odds, been allowed to continue.



And somewhere — in the small specific full long memory of the village of Samail, Al-Qurawashiyah neighbourhood, in the year 1973 — a palm tree, the same palm tree, continues to stand. Patient. Tall. Older now than most people remember. Witness still to the small specific full long conversation between a teacher and her place. The conversation has not ended. The conversation will not end. The conversation, like all the best conversations, has simply found its small specific full pause.



And the palm tree — silent, ancient, faithful — keeps its small specific full secrets.



THE END

Did You Know?

Oman's Education Renaissance

The story of the simple village school, rebuilt twice, mirrors Oman's real education renaissance: in 1970, Oman had only 3 formal schools and 900 students nationwide, with adult illiteracy around 66%. By 2014, there were over 1,048 schools with more than 523,000 students, and literacy rose to nearly 97% by 2022 — the same journey lived by Mansoor, Ali, and Saeed, from village students to teacher, engineer, and doctor.

Source: en.wikipedia.org · borgenproject.org

GLOSSARY

The Word Harvest

937 words gathered from the thirty-six Palms.

A

a-sneaky-cloud-with-legs — A small, deceptively innocent creature moving quickly and with intent; here, the specific movement of Malood

abandon — Complete freedom from restraint; unreserved commitment to an action

Aboooayaaah — An Omani exclamation of shock or distress, literally calling out 'my father!'; used by children when startled

abridged — Shortened by removing parts; reduced in scope

abruptly — Suddenly; without warning

absolute — Complete and total, without any reduction; used here for the total shock of mountain water on warm skin

absorb — Take in something without pushing back; receive fully

absorbed — Completely focused on something, giving it all your attention — unaware of anything else around you

abundant — Existing in very large quantities; more than enough

accepts — Receives without resisting; allows something to be taken in without argument

accumulated — Gathered or built up gradually, piece by piece, until the total became noticeable

acknowledged — Showed that one has seen or noticed something, usually with a small gesture

acknowledging — Showing respect and recognition of something; honouring what has been given

acquired — Gained or obtained over time, often through effort or experience

acquisitive — Eager to acquire or obtain things; here, used for a goat with a taste for shoes

activation — The sudden switching on of a mode or state; here, the way teacher-instinct overrode everything else

actively — In a way that involves real effort; deliberately and with full engagement

adhan — The Islamic call to prayer, called from the mosque to announce prayer time; one of the defining sounds of Muslim community life

Adjustments — Small changes made to fit a new situation; minor alterations

admiration — A feeling of respect for someone who does what you secretly wish you could

admitted — Allowed to enter a place; officially received into a group

Adventure — An exciting, often risky journey or experience; something new and memorable

affection — A feeling of liking and caring for someone; warmth toward a person

affirmed — Confirmed as true or valuable; officially accepted or supported

after-lunch — The particular sleep that comes after eating well; a satisfied daytime nap

aftermath — The time and situation after an event, especially a difficult or noisy one

afternoon — The part of the day between noon and evening; here, used as a living presence with its own weight

against — In opposition to something; despite what a person might have expected

aged — Having lived many years; here, carrying the marks and dignity of a long life openly

aggressive — Acting forcefully; behaving as though it wanted to hurt you

agreement — Shared understanding between people; something everyone accepts without needing to argue

Al-Lajal — A small village in Wadi Al-Maawil in the Batinah region of Oman; known for its hot falaj and for being the historical home of the Al-Naabi tribe

Al-Naabi — One of the large old tribes of Oman, with deep roots in the Wadi Al-Maawil area; the family name carried by generations

alarm-clock — A device that makes a sound to wake someone up; here, used metaphorically for the smell of bread

aligning — Coming into proper position; things falling into place together naturally

almost — Very nearly; not quite completely

ambiguous — Having more than one possible meaning; not clearly one thing or another

amused — Finding something funny in a quiet, gentle way; not quite laughing, but close

ancient — Belonging to the very distant past; extremely old

animals — Living creatures that are not plants or humans; all other living things with bodies that move

animated — Full of lively spirit; actively engaged with a topic

announced — Made known publicly or formally; declared

announcement — A public statement, usually of something important; a declaration

announcements — Public or official statements broadcast to inform people in a shared space

anticipate — Expect or predict something before it happens; see things coming

anticipatory — Showing preparedness or foresight; ready in advance

apologetically — With an air of saying sorry; behaving as though one's existence requires excuse

appalled — Greatly dismayed or horrified; shocked

appetizing — Making one want to eat it; giving the appearance of being delicious

appraisal — The act of judging the value or quality of something; careful assessment

approval — Expression of acceptance or agreement; a warm welcome of an idea

architecture — The design and structure of something; the essential shape that holds everything together

arguing — Disagreeing in words or action; here, used for the sound of a dreaming goat

argument — A reason or set of reasons given in support of something; here, a green that seemed to be making a case for itself

aroma — A strong and pleasant smell, often from food or drink

aromatic — Having a strong pleasant scent; perfumed

arranging — Placing things in a particular order; organising by appearance or value

arrival — The act of coming to a place; here, the quiet way Thuraya entered any scene

arrive — Come to a place; here, used to describe the internal arrival that comes after the physical one

arrives — Reaches; comes to a place; here, used about a beard's progress down the chest

artisan — A person skilled in a trade, especially one involving making things by hand; a craftsman

ascertain — To find out or determine with certainty; to establish as fact

ashamed — Feeling regret or guilt about one's actions; embarrassed by one's own behaviour

assembled — Gathered together to form a whole; brought into a single composition

assembly yard — The open outdoor space in front of a school where students gather, line up, and begin their day

assessment — A careful judgement about the value or ability of something or someone

assigned — Given a task or place by someone else; allocated

associated — Connected in the mind with something else; linked mentally

atmosphere — The pervading tone or mood of a place; a kind of air around someone

attacked — Took aggressive action against; came at with force

attendance — The fact of being present; being there

attentive — Paying close, careful attention; listening or watching with full focus

attentiveness — Careful close observation; paying full attention to what is in front of you

authority — The power and right to make decisions and command respect; here, not a position but a quality of being

automatic — Happening without conscious thought; built into the body through repetition

availed — Made use of; took full advantage of an opportunity

awal — Dried tuna or large fish cured in the sun and salt; a traditional Omani preserved food, deeply fragrant, eaten in stews and with rice

awe — A feeling of great respect mixed with wonder

awl — A small pointed tool used to make holes in leather or wood

B

balance — The ability to keep yourself steady and upright; the body's control over its own position

Balanced — Having different elements in the right proportions; neither too much nor too little of anything

bamboo stick — A stick cut from bamboo; in Omani village tradition, used by teachers and drivers as a light symbol of authority over groups of children

banjari — Arabic/Omani: a set of many thin bangles worn together on one wrist; a traditional form of Omani silver jewellery, worn in quantity

baptism — A ceremony of initiation, traditionally involving water; here, used to describe the moment that marked John's acceptance

bargaining — The back-and-forth discussion of price between seller and buyer in traditional markets

basket — A container made by weaving thin strips of plant material; in Oman, traditionally made from palm fronds

baskets — Woven containers made of palm leaves; the ordinary carrying equipment of village life

bathed — Surrounded or covered by something, as if immersed in liquid

beamed — Smiled widely and brightly

beaming — Smiling very widely and brightly; showing happiness openly

bearing — The way a person holds themselves, especially when in charge; a quality of natural leadership

becoming — Attractive or flattering; suiting a person well

beehive — The structure in which bees live; a colony of bees' home

behaviour — The way someone or something acts; the pattern of their actions, taken as a whole

benches — Long seats without backs, made of wood, placed for groups to sit on

beseeking — Asking urgently and with deep feeling; earnestly begging for help

bisat — A woven mat used for sitting and sleeping in traditional Omani homes; pressed flat by years of shared use

bloodshot — Having the whites of the eyes reddened, usually from irritation or crying

Bob-Jamid — Old Omani name for a chilled fizzy drink — often a brand or a kind of cold soft drink popular among children in 1970s Gulf villages

Bosphorus — The narrow strait of water running through Istanbul, connecting the Black Sea to the Sea of Marmara

bowed — Bent the head or body forward as a gesture of respect or acknowledgment; here, a theatrical acknowledgment of applause

braced — Prepared for something difficult; steadied against expected impact

brazing — Joining two pieces of metal together with heat; a traditional metal-working skill

bridal — Relating to a bride or a wedding

brighten — Become brighter; fill with warmth or light

Britishness — The qualities associated with British national character, especially a stiff, understated response to difficulty

broke — Failed under pressure; gave way after holding

bukhoor — Traditional Arabian fragrance made of aromatic woods, musk, and resins mixed together; burned on coals to scent homes and clothes

bump — A raised or uneven part of a road surface that causes a vehicle to jolt

burst — Opened suddenly and with force; here, used for the arrival of children

bustling — Full of active movement and noise; crowded with busy activity

C

cadence — The rhythm or flow of speech; the musical shape of how someone speaks

calculus — A method of calculation; here, used humorously for the mental processes of a goat

calibrated — Carefully adjusted to get exactly the right measure or setting

canvas — A strong, heavy cloth made of cotton or hemp, often used for bags; here, the ordinary English teacher's bag

capacity — The total amount that something can contain or produce

Cardamom — An aromatic spice with a sharp, sweet flavour; one of the oldest and most treasured spices in Arab cooking

carriage — The way a person holds their body, especially the head and shoulders

carry — To travel a distance, especially of sound; to land with impact

carrying — Able to travel far without being shouted; the natural reach of a voice that has weight

casually — In a relaxed and unconcerned way

catalogue — Make a detailed list of things; organise information into categories

cataloguer — A person who keeps an organised record of things; one who notes and stores information carefully

categorically — Completely and clearly; without exception

category — A group of things with something in common; a class or type

cauldrons — Large deep metal cooking pots, often used over fire; here, used for the traditional cooking vessels of Omani communal meals

cautious — Taking care; moving with awareness of risk

ceased — Stopped; come to an end; no longer happening

censers — A container in which incense is burned; a small vessel for holy or ceremonial smoke

ceremonial — Done with formality and a sense of occasion; treated as an important event

ceremony — Formal procedure or ritual; elaborate actions performed for an occasion

certainty — The state of being completely sure about something; having no doubt

chagrin — Annoyance and distress at having failed; a feeling of disappointed embarrassment

chalk — A soft white or coloured stone, cut into sticks, used for writing on boards; the writing material of schools everywhere before pens

chamber — An enclosed space; a small room used for a particular purpose

chaos — A state of complete disorder and confusion; things happening all at once without order

character — A person in a story; here, used to mean someone whose presence has become part of the local narrative

charmed — Delighted or greatly pleased; captivated

charmingly — In a way that makes other people like you without effort; winning them over

cheerful — Happy and optimistic; pleased

choice — A particularly important or interesting part of something; the best moment

chorus — A group of voices singing or speaking together at the same time

circulated — Moved in a complete circle, returning to where it began; kept flowing around a system

claim — A statement of ownership; an assertion of connection

clang — A loud ringing metallic sound; made by metal striking metal

clarity — The quality of being clear and easy to understand

clearer — More transparent or pure; easier to see through or breathe

cluster — A small group of people or things standing close together

clusters — Groups of things growing or hanging close together on the same branch

collapsed — Fell into something completely, usually from laughter; lost all composure at once

collective — Belonging to or done by a group together, not one person

colourful — Having many bright colours; rich in colour

columns — Tall narrow shapes; here, used to describe rising lines of smoke

comet — A celestial body moving in a long curving path; here, used to describe the speed and inevitability of Malood's arrival

commercial — Relating to trade or commerce; focused on the making of money

committed — Fully dedicated to a course of action; completely given over to something

committing — Devoting oneself to something; determining to do it

communal — Shared among a group; relating to what is done together

competence — The quality of being well-suited for a task; having what it takes

complaint — Expression of dissatisfaction or discomfort; grumbling

composed — Calm and in full possession of oneself; not rushed or scattered, with every part of a person in the right place

composition — An arrangement of parts forming a whole; a specific planned picture

composure — Calm, settled control of oneself; the outer appearance of dignity under pressure

compound — An area of land with a group of buildings and walls; here, the small enclosed space around their house

comprehension — The ability to understand something; grasp of meaning

comprehensively — Completely and thoroughly; in every possible way

compressed — Pressed or squeezed together into a smaller space; concentrated into less room than expected

concealment — The act of hiding; keeping oneself out of sight

concentrated — Focused in one spot; gathered in intensity

concentration — Deep, focused attention given to one task so that everything else fades into the background

concerned — Worried or anxious about something; in the negative, at ease

conductor — A person who directs musicians with a small stick; here, used to describe how Uncle Nasser opened the morning like a piece of music

confidence — Feeling sure of yourself and your abilities; speaking without doubt or hesitation

confidently — With assurance; without hesitation or fear

confused — Unable to think clearly; bewildered

consequential — Significant; having important effects or results

considered — Thought about something carefully before deciding

consistently — In a way that continues in the same manner over time

conspicuous — Attracting attention, usually by being different or unusual

conspiratorial — Acting as if sharing a secret plan; of two or more people in private agreement

constellation — A group of stars forming a recognisable pattern; here, used poetically for a scattered but connected group

consultation — The act of asking for advice or opinion before acting; here, used ironically for a part of the body acting on its own

contained — Held within a boundary; kept under control

continuous — Going on without stopping; present always, without pause or interruption

contrite — Feeling sincere regret about having done something wrong

convention — An accepted way of doing things in a particular time or place

converging — Coming together from different directions; approaching the same point

conviction — A firmly held belief; deep certainty expressed through action

cooing — The low, gentle sound made by doves or pigeons, especially at dawn

cooked — Heated with fire or hot liquid until done; here, used joyfully by Mansoor about Mr. John

cool — Slightly cold in a pleasant way; the gentle low temperature of early morning before the sun takes hold

coordination — The ability to use different parts of the body together smoothly; physical skill

corralled — Gathered or rounded up, especially animals or people moving in too many directions

correctly — In an accurate way; rightly

counsel — Advice or guidance, especially of a serious kind

country — A nation; here, used for the whole of Oman, which John felt had conspired, as a whole, against him

courtesy — A polite gesture; an act of consideration

creature — A living being, especially one that is strange or frightening

crescent — A curved shape like a thin moon; a small arc

criminal — Someone who has broken the law or done something seriously wrong; here, used with complete earnestness

crisis — A time of intense difficulty or danger; a moment requiring decisive action

crossed — Folded one over the other; here, the posture of a person who has been proved right

crown — A headdress worn by a king or queen as a symbol of authority; here, used to describe the scale of what Malood seemed to have stolen

cruelty — The quality of being unkind; here, used humorously for friendly teasing

crumbled — Broke down; gave way to laughter after a long attempt at control

culturally — In a way relating to the customs and ideas of a society; here, referring to village rules John kept stumbling into

curing — The process of preserving food through salt, smoke, or drying; the ancient method of keeping food edible

curiosity — A genuine desire to know and understand something; alert, awake interest

current — A movement of air in a particular direction; here, the gentle movement of dawn breeze

currents — Flowing movements within a body of water; here, patterns of movement within a crowd

cushion — A soft bag filled with padding; here, the slightly higher seat that traditionally marked the position of the village leader

D

daghoos — A spicy chilli dipping sauce, deeply loved in Omani village food culture

dangerous — Here: likely to cause disturbance in a classroom, not because of bad intentions but because of too much energy and social interest

dappled — Marked with small spots or patches of light and shadow

darker — More shadowed; with more depth and more visible edges

darkroom — A room shut off from light, used for processing photographic film and printing photographs from negatives

Darwazat-Mutrah — A traditional Omani children's chasing game, named after the old gate of Mutrah in Muscat; a game of running, catching, and great joyful chaos

dashed — Ran quickly with urgent purpose; hurried

decision — A choice reached after consideration; here, reached by the body without consulting the mind

declaimed — Spoke with great formality and dramatic effect, as though performing

decode — Work out the meaning of something complicated; understand a hidden pattern

deficit — A shortfall; an amount missing from what is expected

deflected — Turned aside from a direction or purpose; diverted

deliberate — Done with full intention and awareness; not accidental or casual — chosen

deliberately — On purpose; with clear intention

deliberateness — The quality of being done carefully and on purpose; slowness that carries intent

deliberation — Careful slowness; the quality of moving with thought rather than haste

delicate — Very fine and gentle in quality; easily damaged or broken

delight — Give great pleasure; please very much

delighted — Greatly pleased; extremely happy about something

delivered — Gave or transferred something fully; here, the bump's complete transmission of its force

demolished — Completely destroyed; broken down entirely

demystifying — Removing mystery from something; making it plain and understood

density — The quality of being heavy and concentrated in a small space; here, a quality of presence rather than weight

descent — The act of coming down from a higher place; a falling motion toward the ground

describe — Give an account of something in words; paint a picture with language

design — The way something has been planned or made; a considered arrangement

detailed — Including many specific pieces of information; thorough and complete

determined — Showing firm, unwavering resolve; not willing to be turned aside

devastating — Causing great emotional impact; here, the impact of a perfectly chosen short sentence

Dew — Mountain Dew — a favourite fizzy drink among village children in Oman

Dhofar — The southern region of Oman, where from 1965 to 1976 an armed conflict — the Dhofar Rebellion — was fought between rebels and government forces; by 1973 the war was the most serious matter in the country

dhows — Traditional Arab sailing vessels, with lateen sails; the backbone of Arabian Sea trade for over a thousand years

digestive — Related to the process of breaking down food; here, used about Malood's unknown-fate stomach

dignified — Having or showing a serious, calm manner that is worthy of respect

dignity — The state of being worthy of respect; self-respect

diplomat — A person skilled in managing relations between people or groups with sensitivity

diplomatic — Done with care and politeness; careful not to cause offence

disarmed — Made unable to resist or be critical; won over by charm

disbelief — Inability or refusal to accept that something is true

discipline — Control over behaviour that comes from inside rather than from punishment; passed from one generation to the next through presence and expectation

disciplined — Controlled and ordered; following a strict internal set of rules

discovering — Finding or realising something for the first time; the moment a thing becomes known

disgruntled — Feeling or showing complaint; grumpy about something

dishdasha — The traditional full-length robe worn by Omani men; the garment of everyday life and formal occasions alike

disrupt — Interrupt or disturb the normal course of an activity

distance — Separated by a space; far away

distilled — Purified or reduced something to its essential form; extracted the most important part

distinctive — Having a quality that marks something out as different from others; easily recognisable

distributing — Giving out things to several people, usually fairly

disturbed — Upset or agitated; had its usual state broken

Don't — A negative command; the word used to tell someone not to do something; short, direct, complete

dramatic — Striking or impressive; exhibiting exaggerated emotion or theatricality

dramatically — In a way that is exaggerated or theatrical; with great emotion

driver-stick — A long thin stick kept by a vehicle driver; used in old Oman as a signalling tool, for nudging livestock, or as a symbol of quiet authority

dry — Lacking moisture or emotion; here, used to describe a voice that carries no extra feeling

Dukkan Al-Hillah — The small neighbourhood shop in the village of Al-Qurawashiyah — the heart of the place where daily supplies are bought and news is exchanged

Dukkan-Al-Hallah — Arabic: the village shop or general store; the old village commercial gathering point

durable — Lasting; capable of continuing for a long time

E

earnest — Serious and sincere; without humour or pretence

earth — The solid ground; the material of which the world's surface is made

echo — A sound that is heard again because it reflects off something; here, used for the memory of a moment that lingers in a place

economical — Using only what is necessary; not wasteful

economy — Careful use of resources; efficiency in management

efficiency — Doing something well and without wasting effort or time; a skill that comes from years, not instruction

effort — A vigorous attempt to do something; here, the visible work of not laughing

effortless — Done without any apparent effort or difficulty; natural and easy

elaboration — The addition of more details or explanation to something already said

elected — Chose to do something; appointed themselves

elementary — Of the simplest and most basic kind; the most obvious

embarrassment — The feeling of being self-conscious or ashamed about something one has said or done

emblem — The official symbol at the centre of the Omani flag; representing the nation

embossed — Decorated with raised designs; patterned so the design stood out

embroidered — Decorated with needlework in thread; worked with small stitched designs

emphasis — Special importance given to something; force or stress in expression

entered — Came inside something; went into a space or body

enthusiasm — Great excitement and eagerness about something

entire — The whole of something; complete and including everything

entitlement — The belief, often without foundation, that one has a right to something; here, used affectionately for the goat

erupted — Broke out suddenly and with great energy; the kind of reaction that cannot be contained once it begins

escorted — Accompanied, especially to provide protection or guidance; here, gently removed from a situation

escorting — Walking alongside someone officially, as a guard or companion; here, used with comic seriousness about a goat

essentials — The most necessary things; the items a life cannot be lived without

evaded — Escaped from or avoided being caught; got away skilfully

evidently — Clearly or obviously; as shown by what can be seen

excellent — Of the highest quality; extremely good

exemption — A release from a usual requirement; permission not to take part in something

exhaled — Let out a slow breath; released air held in without realising it

expansively — In a way that covers a wide area; broadly

expendable — Able to be given up or used up; not essential

experience — Practical contact with something; knowledge gained through being involved in an event

exploded — Burst out suddenly and loudly; released a great amount of energy all at once

extended — Made longer; added to something; here, added a new idea on his own

extinguish — Cause to cease burning; put out

F

fading — Becoming gradually weaker or less visible

failure — Lack of success; here, the specific failure to remain composed in the face of comic material

fajr — Arabic: the time before sunrise; the first prayer of the day; a specific kind of pre-dawn light that is its own presence, not merely the absence of night

falaj — An ancient Omani irrigation channel carved from stone, carrying mountain water into the village; a UNESCO World Heritage system used for over three thousand years

Falaj-Al-Lajal — The specific falaj of the village of Al-Lajal, unusual in that its water runs warm — one of the rare hot falajs of Oman, fed by underground thermal sources

Falaj-soup — A soup made from the falaj; an invented, joking dish in which Mr. John is the main ingredient

familiar — Well-known and comfortable; like family

farsadh — Omani mulberry — a sweet, dark fruit that grows on trees common across Oman's interior villages; stains the fingers dark when eaten

feminine — Having qualities of gentleness and grace; soft and delicate in nature

finality — The quality of being final or decisive; the sense of an ending

fine — Made of very small particles; light and delicate in texture

fiqh — Islamic jurisprudence; the traditional body of Islamic legal knowledge taught in mosques

flatness — The quality of being subdued; lacking the full force of feeling

flawless — Without any mistake or fault; completely correct and without imperfection

fleet — A group of ships belonging to a country, company, or organisation; here, Oman's historical naval and merchant ships

flexible — Able to bend without breaking; supple

flinching — Making a small, quick movement of the body to avoid something unpleasant

flock — A group of sheep or goats moving together; here, a cluster of animals along the roadside

flourish — An impressive waving movement or decoration; here, a small added touch of style

flowed — Moved smoothly and continuously, like water; here, the natural current of people and goods

fluently — Speaking a language easily, smoothly, and without difficulty

flying-lesson — A teasing term Thuraya invented for John's fall on the wet path; making light of the moment he became airborne

focus — The concentration of attention on a specific thing

folded — Here: time collapsed, bringing the past and present together as if bending them toward each other

folk-imagination — The shared imagination of ordinary people, expressed in stories and beliefs

forerunner — Something that comes before and announces the arrival of something else

forgot — Failed to remember something; here, used humorously about a boy so distracted he forgot his task

formality — A necessary action required by custom or rule rather than actual need

format — A particular arrangement or plan for something

formation — A pattern or arrangement of people; a way of gathering that everyone understands without discussion

formidable — Impressive in size or seriousness; demanding respect and perhaps a little caution

frankincense — A sweet-smelling resin burned as incense; treasured for thousands of years in Oman and across the Arabian Peninsula

frankness — The quality of being open, direct, and honest, even when it is not tactful

freshness — The quality of being new, clean, and full of energy; not tired

frightened — Feeling fear; scared, but not physically harmed

frog — A small amphibious animal; here, used as the comic destination of an enchanted object

froze — Became stuck in place; became motionless, usually from shock

fundamental — The most basic and essential aspect of something; at the root of what something is

fundamentally — In the deepest, most basic way; at the root of what something is

furrowed-brow — A brow with deep lines of concentration; the face of someone thinking hard

G

gap — A space between two things, here between the front teeth; a common feature of faces that smile easily

gathering — Collecting oneself for something difficult ahead

generosity — The quality of giving freely and kindly, without counting or asking for return

generous — Kind and willing to give freely; using more favourable words than strictly required

gently — Softly and carefully, without force; the opposite of roughly

genuinely — In a real, true way; from the heart

geography — The land and waters of a place; the physical and cultural space a life takes up

ghaf — A native Omani tree with deep roots and wide shade; considered a symbol of endurance and of the desert village

ghost — The spirit of a dead person, believed to appear to the living

ghoul — The Arabic/Omani word for a snake — a confusion Mr. John was about to experience fully, because 'ghoul' in English also refers to a terrifying monster

giant-beetle — A large, slow-moving creature with a hard shell; used here to describe the lumbering appearance of the old municipal truck

gleam — Shine with a soft, smooth light

goat — A four-legged farm animal with hooves and sometimes horns; known for eating almost anything and going wherever it wishes

Good — A word of praise and approval; simple, immediate, and completely sufficient

grades — Levels of quality ranked from lowest to highest

grammar — The rules that govern how a language works; the structure of correct speech and writing

gratified — Pleased and satisfied, especially by recognition of a thing one has observed

gratitude — A feeling of being thankful; deep appreciation

gravely — In a serious, solemn way; with weight

gravity — A seriousness or heaviness; the quality of something that does not take itself lightly

gray — Of a colour between black and white; ashen in tone

greeting — A friendly word, sign, or action on meeting someone

grin — A wide smile, often showing teeth, and usually carrying something mischievous or amused

grip — The act of holding something tightly; the firmness of a hand's hold

gritty — Containing small hard particles; rough on the teeth or skin

H

Habbabouh — A warm Omani term of affection, roughly 'the one who is loved'; used for beloved elders in the community

habibi — Arabic: 'my beloved' — a warm term of affection used across Arabic-speaking cultures for friends, family, and children

habitual — Done regularly, so often that it has become the natural way of things; no longer chosen, simply happening

haggled — Argued about the price of something back and forth before agreeing

handmade — Made by hand rather than by machine; each piece individually worked

heeb — Arabic: a small curved sickle used for cutting grass, animal fodder, and small crops by hand

held — Kept in the hand without tight grip; carried at rest with full readiness

herbal — Relating to herbs or plants; made from growing things rather than chemicals

herbs — Plants, especially small green ones, used for cooking, scent, or medicine

hero — A person admired for their courage or outstanding achievements

hesitated — Paused before doing something, usually because of uncertainty

hesitation — A pause before doing or saying something, usually because of uncertainty or doubt

hijab — A head covering worn by Muslim women as a sign of modesty and faith

hilt — The handle of a sword or dagger; the grip

history — The past as it is remembered and preserved; all the events that have happened before now

hojari — The highest grade of frankincense in Oman; prized across the Arabian Peninsula for its colour, purity, and scent

hollow — Empty; having nothing inside; here, the feeling of something that should be present being absent

honesty — The quality of being truthful; here, the road's refusal to pretend to be better than it was

honour — Show respect and recognition for something; accept with dignity

honouring — Showing great respect for; treating as important and worthy

horror — A very strong feeling of shock or fear; deep alarm

hospitality — The friendly reception and treatment of guests; a cultural duty across Arab societies

humbly — In a way that shows modesty; without pride

humiliation — Loss of pride or dignity; a low moment in public

humour — The quality of being amusing or the ability to take amusement in things; a light spirit

hura — Omani Arabic: a magical disappearance or vanishing; the folk belief that a sorcerer can make objects vanish

hurrying — Moving or proceeding quickly; trying to make something happen faster

hush — A soft quiet sound; the kind of low whisper that exists just at the edge of hearing

I

idle — Not active or in use; sitting without doing anything

iglus — Omani Arabic: 'sit down'; the command used by mothers and teachers since the beginning of language

illuminated — Lit up; made bright, especially with inner light of understanding or plan

imaginary — Existing only in the mind; not real

immediate — Happening right now, without delay; direct and unfiltered

immersion — The act of being submerged in water, or, here, the comic plunge into it

immobilised — Made unable to move; held still

imperceptibly — In a way so small or subtle that it is hardly noticeable

important — Significant; carrying real weight and meaning, not to be passed over

important-looking — Appearing to contain something significant; carrying the visual weight of importance

imposing — Grand or impressive in appearance; making others feel small without trying

improvised — Made up on the spot; not planned in advance

inadvertently — Without intending to; by accident

inappropriate — Not suitable or proper; wrong for the situation

incensed — Made very angry; filled with strong indignation

inclined — Bent toward; turned one's face toward something

including — Bringing something into a group; making it part of the whole

incompatible — Unable to exist together; not matching or working with something else

incomprehensible — Impossible to understand; its meaning not open to the listener

incredulity — The feeling of being unable to believe something; deep surprise

indented — Having a small mark pressed into the surface; here, the shape left by a ring worn for years

indicated — Pointed out or showed without using words; communicated by gesture

indignation — Anger or annoyance provoked by what is perceived as unfair treatment

inevitable — Certain to happen; impossible to avoid or prevent

inflection — A change in pitch or tone of the voice

informing — Giving information clearly and simply, without judgement

inhaled — Breathed air in, drawing it slowly into the lungs

inherited — Received from those who came before; carried down through time

insinuating — Moving in gradually and imperceptibly; creeping in without being detected

insisted — Demanded firmly that something be noticed or done; refused to be ignored

inspector — An official who checks places or things carefully to make sure everything is in order

instinct — A natural sense of something; an intuitive understanding not based on thought

instinctively — Without thinking; because the body knows before the mind has decided

instrument — A tool used for a particular purpose; here, the tool of discipline

insufferable — Extremely annoying; impossible to bear, here used with affection

integrated — Combined into a larger whole; made part of something

intermediate — Between two stages or states; a middle step in a process

intervene — To come between two parties in order to prevent or alter a result; to step into a dispute

interventions — Actions taken to interrupt or change what is happening

interview — A formal meeting in which questions are asked to gather information, usually published

intonation — The rise and fall of the voice in speaking; the melodic shape of a sentence

invention — Something newly created or made up; an addition of one's own

invitation — A friendly request asking someone to come or do something; an opening of doors

involuntarily — Done without conscious effort; automatically

involuntary — Not done by choice; happening before a person can stop it

iron-coloured — Having the colour of iron, especially rust-red; the specific colour of many Omani mountains

irrepressible — Impossible to restrain or hold back; cannot be contained

J

Jibreen-Castle — A 17th-century Omani fortified palace in the interior, near Bahla; one of the most beautiful surviving structures of the Ya'rubī dynasty era and a key historical site

journal — A daily written record of experiences, thoughts, and events; a personal diary

juiced — Squeezed to remove the liquid; here, used to describe a lemon's saddest possible destination

K

kabsa — Arabic/Omani: spiced rice cooked with meat, the centerpiece of Gulf hospitality meals

key — A small tool that opens locks; here, used to describe a useful phrase that opens doors of meaning

Khalaf — An Omani man's name meaning 'descendant' or 'successor'; here, the name of the village's quiet elder

khallik-rijal — Omani Arabic: 'be a man; stand firm'; an ordinary village expression of encouragement that had, somehow, lodged itself in John's sleep

khanjar — The curved ceremonial dagger of Oman, worn at the belt by men for formal occasions; the national symbol of Oman, appearing even on the country's flag

kheyzaran — Arabic: a cane or walking-stick traditionally made of bamboo or similar wood; carried by elders for both support and authority

kind — Gentle and caring in the way a person looks at someone they want no harm to come to

kingdom — A territory ruled by a king; here, used for the domain that children claim as their own in the middle of the day

kohl — A traditional black eye cosmetic made from ground minerals or charred plant materials, used for centuries across the Middle East, Africa, and South Asia both decoratively and medicinally

kummah — The traditional embroidered cap worn by Omani men; a mark of heritage and identity

L

laboured — Done with great effort; showing strain

lamba — A small Omani fruit similar to a jujube; sweet and slightly tart, eaten fresh directly from the tree

launched — Sent off with great force; here, leapt out of the water as though propelled

layered — Arranged in layers, one on top of another; here, voices arriving at slightly different moments

layers — Thicknesses of something placed one above another; here, used to describe how the senses received the market one element at a time

leave — Temporarily not at work; away from duty

lecture — A long, formal talk given to an audience; here, used humorously about a ten-year-old girl

lecturer — Someone who gives formal talks on a subject, usually at a university

legend — A traditional story; here, used for a person who has become a story

lesson-tone — The specific register of voice and attention appropriate for learning; the classroom's working frequency

Leteg — A traditional Omani children's and girls' game in which players try to cross drawn lines without being caught by a defender; older than any written rules about it

letj — A traditional Omani children's game similar to hopscotch; a stone is thrown into drawn squares and the player must jump through them without touching any line

lighter — Less heavy; reduced in weight; here, also used to suggest something slightly missing

linger — Stay or wait longer than necessary; delay in leaving

listener — A person who listens to something; here, the person receiving Ahmed's story

living — Alive; having a working pattern of growth and change

lodged — Fixed or stuck in a particular place; having become trapped where it arrived

logic — A way of reasoning; the pattern by which one idea leads to the next

long-grain — A type of rice with thin, long grains; here, referring to the traditional Omani rice used for large meals

loosen — Become less tight; to come free of its hold

loudly — Making a lot of sound; audibly to everyone in the room

loudspeaker — A device for amplifying the voice, especially to reach distant listeners

lovingly — In a way that shows love or affection; with deep warmth

low — Not tall; close to the ground

luban — Omani frankincense — a sacred resin burned for centuries across Arabia; the same scent she had found once in a small box in London

M

ma'wal — Arabic: a traditional hoe used in Omani farming for breaking soil and creating water channels; the basic agricultural tool of the falaj system

maghbar — Arabic: a traditional Omani practice in which incense or specific dried plants are burned and the smoke is wafted around to drive away bad luck, evil eye, or unwanted spirits

Maghrib — The Islamic sunset prayer; one of the five daily prayers, called just as the sun sets

maghsoob — Arabic: literally 'one taken by force'; in Omani folk belief, a person whose mind and soul have been partly consumed by the jinn after having been given to them; the living-dead

magician — A person who performs magic tricks; here, a person who is believed to perform real magic

magnificent — Impressively grand or extravagant; here, used ironically about an unwelcome swelling

majaza — A small stone room built over the falaj, with a water channel running through it and an open roof, used by women for private bathing — the village bath-house, older than plumbing

majz — Arabic: a small iron rod heated red-hot in a fire and used in traditional Omani folk-medicine to cauterise wounds, burst boils, and treat certain conditions; the village's harshest cure

making — Bringing into existence; forming or shaping

managed — Controlled with careful skill; handled well

mandoos — A traditional wooden chest used in Omani, Zanzibari, and Gulf households for storing valuables, clothes, and heirlooms; often inlaid with brass studs and passed down through generations

maool — A traditional Omani agricultural tool with a wooden handle and curved metal blade, used for farming and digging

maritime — Relating to the sea, ships, or sailing; of or near the coast

marjal — Arabic: a large heavy cooking pot, usually copper or aluminium, used for communal Omani cooking — the kind of pot that could feed twenty people

martaasha — Arabic: a specific kind of traditional Omani silver jewellery designed to make a soft musical sound when the wearer moves; the name comes from the Arabic root for 'shaking' or 'shivering'

marshawi — Arabic: grilled food, here referring to grilled grasshoppers — a traditional protein eaten in some parts of Oman during the season when locusts are plentiful

mastery — Complete skill and control over something; expertise so deep it no longer looks like effort

measured — Controlled and careful; delivered at a deliberate pace

measuring — Calculating or estimating the size or quantity of something

memory — The thing in a person's mind where past experiences are kept; the inner room of a life

menacing — Seeming likely to cause harm; threatening

mercilessly — Without mercy; unrelentingly

Meshkak — Arabic: traditional Omani grilled meat skewers, marinated and cooked over open fire; the centerpiece of village outdoor gatherings

metabolise — To process and absorb; here, used to describe how a village digests its own incidents

methodical — Done in a careful, step-by-step way; working through something systematically

methodically — In an ordered, systematic way; one step at a time

meticulous — Very careful about small details; thorough and exact

micro-climate — A small area with a climate different from the area around it

migrated — Moved from one place to another; travelled widely

mijz — An ancient Omani and Arabian traditional treatment involving the application of a heated iron rod to the skin, used in the belief that it would draw out illness from certain parts of the body; practised widely until the spread of modern medicine

mindng — Attending to one's own business; paying careful attention only to oneself

mineral — Relating to or containing minerals; having the quality of substances that come from the earth

minu — A popular chicken-flavoured crispy snack loved by children across Oman

mischief — Playful trouble-making; light, harmless teasing

mixing — Combining or blending; here, combining two languages in one sentence

mockery — Laughter that makes fun of someone cruelly; here, contrasted with laughter that is simply warm and genuine

modest — Unpretentious in size or scale; small

momentum — The force gained by something in motion; the growing speed or strength of something that has started moving

monster — A large, frightening creature from stories; Mansoor confused the sounds of his own name with this word

mortar — A heavy bowl in which food is crushed or ground with a pestle; the ancient tool of the kitchen

mourning — A word that sounds like 'morning' but means the sadness felt after someone dies — Mansoor had the sound right, but the meaning wrong

moustache — A strip of hair above the upper lip; a common feature of many Arabic men of the period, often carefully groomed

mowqa'a — Arabic: a small stone mortar and wooden pestle used in Omani kitchens specifically for crushing garlic, ginger, and other small spices for daily cooking

mudguards — The curved covers above the wheels of a vehicle that stop mud and dust from being thrown upward

municipality — A town or district with its own local government; here, referring to the local council truck that once came through Omani villages to spray pesticide

musical — Pleasing to the ear; having the quality of music

musk — A warm, delicate scent used in perfumes; ancient and personal

muttering — Speaking quietly to yourself, almost under your breath, so others can barely hear

Muttrah-Souq — The historic covered market of Muttrah, in Muscat, Oman; one of the oldest souqs in the Arab world, famous for spices, frankincense, silver, and textiles, and — in 1973 — the commercial heart of the country

N

nahsher — A traditional Omani method of bringing fruit down from trees by throwing stones at the branches; simple, effective, entirely social

narrowing — Becoming smaller or tighter, especially in expression; here, a reaction of calm concern

national — Belonging to or characteristic of a whole country; here, used to describe a phrase heard everywhere

neem — A fast-growing tree with bitter leaves used traditionally across the Gulf for medicine and shade; found near houses and mosques

negotiating — Working out something difficult in one's own mind before accepting it

nest — A structure built by bees or wasps to live in; here, a small one close to the ground

neutral — Not strongly one way or the other; balanced

neutrality — The state of not taking any side; being impartial

nods — Small downward movements of the head, used to show agreement or recognition

novelty — Something new and surprising; a rare experience that lifts the ordinary out of itself

numbered — Given specific numbers in a sequence; put into order by counting

O

obedient — Doing what one is told; here, staying shut without trouble

objectionable — Worth protesting against; not acceptable

objective — Based on facts rather than feelings; without personal bias

obligation — A duty imposed from outside yourself; something you do because you must, not because you want to

obligatory — Required; that one has to do

oblique — At an angle; slanting rather than straight

oceans — The vast bodies of salt water that connect continents; here, the seas that carried Omani merchants and sailors across the world

officially — In a recognised, confirmed way; as a matter of record

older — Having existed longer than most other things; from a more ancient time

opened — Unfolded or spread out; made visible what was held within

opening — Beginning to reveal or introduce; giving access to something new

operatic — Relating to opera; here, used to describe a grand theatrical manner of entering

opinionated — Having strong views and expressing them; here, used playfully for dust that seems to have its own character

opposed — Against something; set up in opposition to it

optimistic — Hopeful and confident about the future; expecting good outcomes

orbiting — Moving around something in a repeated circular path; here, used for a child who cannot stay in one place

ornate — Elaborately decorated; made with careful ornamental detail

oscillation — Movement back and forth between two things; here, between a plan and its absence

Oud — A rich, deep woody fragrance made from agarwood; one of the most prized and ancient scents in the Arab world

outlived — Continued to exist after something has ended

outnumbered — Having fewer people on your side than on the other side

overlapped — Mixed together at the same time; more than one thing happening in the same space at once

overlapping — Extending over part of something else; coinciding in time

owned — Held as one's own; claimed by right of love

P

paint — The coloured coating applied to a surface; here, so faded that its original colour had become a matter of opinion

paroxysm — A sudden, uncontrollable burst or attack, especially of laughter

Past-tense — The form of a verb that shows an action already finished; in English, often formed by adding -ed or using a special past form

patience — The quality of waiting calmly without hurrying; giving every thing the time it needs

patient — Able to accept delay, trouble, or difficulty without becoming upset; here, used of the falaj's own steady rhythm

patina — A thin surface layer that builds up over time, especially on older objects; here, the slow marking of a bag by a new country

paused — Stopped briefly before continuing; held momentarily still

pausing — Stopping for a short time before continuing; taking a small break between actions

peaceful — Free from disturbance; calm

pectoral — Relating to the chest; here, a type of necklace that lies wide across the upper chest

permanent — Lasting or intended to last for a long time

permanently — Continuing without stopping; lasting always

persistence — The quality of continuing to try even when something is difficult; not giving up easily

persistent — Continuing calmly and firmly despite resistance; not giving up because of inconvenience

personal — Directed at or concerning a particular individual; taken as a matter of private feeling

personal-truth — A statement about oneself that one believes firmly; a matter of one's own preference

persuasion — The act of causing someone to believe or do something through reasoning; here, a near-art form

Pesticide — A chemical used to kill insect pests; here, the pale DDT-era cloud that municipality trucks sprayed through Gulf villages in the seventies

petitioning — Making a formal request; asking persistently for something

phantom — Seeming to exist without being physically present; here, used for the residual sensation of a long ride after stopping

phases — Stages or states that a thing passes through; different appearances of the same thing

philosophical — Calm and accepting about things you cannot control; treating difficulty with detached wisdom

philosophy — A theory or attitude about how to live

piece — A single part or fragment of something larger

pivoted — Turned quickly on one foot without moving the foot itself

pivoting — Turning quickly on one foot; changing direction rapidly while keeping the foot planted

plausibly — In a way that seems reasonable; believably

pleading — Making an urgent, emotional request, usually to be saved or rescued from something

plume — A long, rising cloud of something in the air, especially smoke or dust

polished — Made smooth through repeated use; refined through practice

pooled — Gathered together in one place like water; collected in a concentration

portion — A part or share of something; the amount given to one person

possessed — Controlled by a supernatural power; here, the Egyptian folk belief about what was happening to John

possession — Calm confident ownership of oneself; complete composure

posture — The way in which a person holds their body when sitting or standing

practice — Doing something repeatedly until it becomes natural and no longer requires thought

pre-cry — The state just before tears; when the eyes have begun to sting but have not yet overflowed

pre-dawn — The time just before the sun rises; the edge of the morning

pre-emptive — Happening before someone or something else has a chance; acting first

precise — Exact and careful; done without any wasted movement or error

precision — The quality of being exact and accurate; perfect accuracy

preparation — Getting ready for something; the steady quiet work that comes before action

presence — The fact of being in a place; here, being present and witnessed in a moment one did not expect to share

present — In a particular place; existing now; here

pretending — Making something appear to be what it is not; acting a part

pride — A feeling of deep pleasure and satisfaction; especially a proper pride in one's origin

primary — First in importance; the main or most essential thing

primed — Prepared and made ready for a particular state; conditioned to expect something

private — Belonging to a single person; not shared openly

process — To handle information mentally; to work out the meaning of something

procession — A group of people moving together; here, a chaotic and involuntary version of one

professional — Done in a serious, skilled way, as though by an expert

prohibitive — Too difficult or extreme to be reasonable; ruled out by its own difficulty

promotion — A move to a higher rank or position; a step up in status

proprietary — Acting as though one has ownership or full right; here, used for the goat's usual attitude

propriotorially — In the manner of an owner; acting as though one has rights over a place

protected — Kept safe from harm or damage; guarded carefully

protest — An expression of disapproval or objection

proud — Feeling satisfaction about an achievement, one's own or another's

prudent — Careful and wise about avoiding risk; choosing distance based on calculation

puffed — Swelled out or released dust in a small cloud

punctuation — A mark or signal that divides parts of something; here, a clap that ends one phase and begins another

punctured — Pierced with a small hole; here, deflated by a quiet fact

purposeful — Having a clear aim or intention; directed toward an end

pursuer — One who chases or follows someone, trying to catch them

puzzlement — A feeling of mild confusion; not quite understanding something

Q

qafeer — A wide woven palm-leaf basket used in Omani households for serving rice, carrying bread, or holding harvested dates

qandeel — A traditional oil lantern used in Omani homes before electricity; its light moved rather than stayed still

qashie — Small dried fish, traditionally preserved whole; a staple protein in Omani coastal and village cuisine

qit — Fresh green leaves (often alfalfa or similar) used as fodder for livestock — especially goats; sold in tied bundles in village shops

quality — A distinctive feature or characteristic; the particular nature of something

quiet — Gentle and without show; the kind of happiness that does not need to announce itself

quietly — In a soft, gradual way; without fanfare

Qur'an circle — A gathering of children who meet before school to recite and memorise the Qur'an; a deeply rooted tradition in Omani village life

R

radiated — Sent out rays of heat, light, or energy from a central source

ragged — Having an uneven edge; irregular and not neat

rallied — Recovered from a setback; drew together renewed strength

ratifying — Formally accepting or agreeing to; giving official approval

rational — Based on or in accordance with reason or logic; sensible

reached-for — To be picked up automatically; to be the default choice

react-to — To respond to something; to have a physical or emotional response

ready — Prepared; having arrived at the point of being able to begin

real — Actually existing or happening; not imagined

rearrange — Arrange things in a different way; move the pieces of something into new positions

rearranged — Changed the order or positions of things; put into a new arrangement

reasonably — In a way that is sensible and fair, given the circumstances

reassuringly — In a way that gives comfort or confidence; with the intention of calming fears

rebellion — A resistance to or fight against accepted rules or authority

receding — Becoming less in degree; drawing back

reclining — Lying back in a relaxed position; resting easily

recognisable — Able to be identified; having a known form

recovered — Returned to health after injury or illness; healed

rectangles — Four-sided shapes arranged in a pattern that only looks random until you watch it long enough

redder — More red in colour than expected; here, the iron-rich red of Oman's mountains in morning sun

redeeming — Making up for faults; compensating for what is lacking

reflex — An automatic action that happens without being consciously chosen; built into a person's nature

register — A particular range of voice; the pitch and loudness used in a specific situation

registered — Noticed and recorded mentally; took conscious note of

registrations — Small mental acts of noting something; quick checks of a familiar fact

relegated — Consigned to a lower position or status; dismissed

reliable — Able to be trusted; consistent

relieved — Removed from responsibility; freed from the burden of having to verify

relocated — Moved from one place to another; changed position

relocating — Moving permanently to a different place, taking everything with you

reluctant — Slow and unwilling; needing to be pushed rather than choosing to go

reluctantly — With resistance or unwillingness; only because required

remained — Continued to be in the same condition; stayed as before

reorient — Change direction or focus; turn to face something new

reprimanded — Scolded or told off by an authority figure

reproach — Expression of disapproval or disappointment

requested — Asked for something politely or officially; here, contrasted with the accidental nature of what was actually done

resentment — Bitter, angry feeling at being unfairly treated

reservation — Complete confidence or approval; without holding back any part of a feeling

resignation — Calm acceptance of something difficult that cannot be changed

resinous — Made of or containing resin; having the sticky, fragrant quality of tree sap

resolved — Solved; settled in a way that all parties accept

respectful — Showing proper respect and politeness

respects — Feels admiration for; treats with the care that something important deserves

respiratory — Relating to the act of breathing

restlessness — Inability to stay still; the state of being unable to relax

result — The outcome or effect produced by an action; what a sentence actually achieves in the world

resumed — Started again after stopping; continued what had been paused

resumption — The act of starting again after a pause; picking something back up

retracted — Withdrawn; taken back after having been said

reverent — Showing deep respect; treating something as important

rhythm — A regular, repeated pattern of movement; the pulse that runs beneath something

rhythmic — Following a regular, repeated pattern of sound or movement

ribbon — A long thin strip of decorative cloth; here, used to describe the movement of a snake

ride — Move with something rather than against it; let the body absorb motion instead of resisting it

rinsing — Washing with clean water after soap or dirt; the final clearing wash

ritual — An action or behaviour regularly repeated; something done according to a prescribed order

roared — Made a long, loud, deep sound; here, the sound of an entire class laughing fully

rotation — The process of taking turns; moving through a series in order

routed — Sent along a particular path; directed to go a certain way

Royal-Oman-Police — The national police force of Oman, established in 1974; in 1973, the country was still policed by the older Sultan's Armed Forces structure

rules — The specific conditions that govern how a game is played

rumour — A story or piece of information that has not been proven; here, used poetically for something unimportant

S

sacred — Treated with great respect; regarded as too important to be violated

sacrificed — Offered up, especially as food for a gathering; here, used with the specific village meaning of an animal slaughtered for a communal meal

Saffron — The dried stigmas of the crocus flower; a spice prized for flavour and colour — and, critically for this story, a pigment that dyes skin deep yellow

sahir — Arabic: a sorcerer or practitioner of sihr (magic); a figure in village folklore believed to have power over spirits and unseen forces

sailed — Moved smoothly through the air as though flying; here, the path of an airborne notebook

sandal — Sandalwood; the heartwood of certain trees, used for centuries in perfume, bathing, and incense; carries a deep, warm, sweet scent

sandals — Simple open shoes, usually with a strap; the everyday footwear of the village

Sandalwood — The heartwood of certain trees, ground into powder; used for centuries in perfume, bathing, and skincare across the Gulf

satisfied — Pleased by having fulfilled a desire or need

scheming — Planning something quietly and cleverly, usually something mischievous

scholarship — An amount of money given to a student to help pay for their education, usually because of talent or achievement

scrutiny — Careful and thorough examination; close inspection

sediment — Material that settles at the bottom of a liquid; here, used to describe the slow layers of understanding a village provides

self-deprecation — The act of making oneself the object of humour or criticism; speaking modestly about oneself

self-preserving — Careful to protect oneself; acting to keep oneself safe

self-satisfaction — A feeling of complete satisfaction with oneself and one's achievements

Sennoor-aswad — Arabic: a black cat — in Omani village folklore, a creature of significant supernatural caution, often associated with sorcery and bad omens

sensory — Relating to the physical senses; involving sight, sound, taste, touch, or smell

sentimental — Connected to feelings of the past; valued because of emotion rather than use

sequence — A continuous or connected series; one thing after another

serenely — In a calm, untroubled way

serious — Grave and thoughtful; treating a matter with full attention rather than as a joke

settled — Came to rest on something fully, without restlessness

settling — Moving gradually into final position; adjusting comfortably and completely

severed — Cut completely through; separated into two parts

shame — A feeling of self-reproach at having done something wrong; here, famously lacking in Malood

shape — The outer form of something; the pattern that holds a day's events together

shaped — Given a particular form, usually by pressure or use over time

shared — Used or enjoyed by more than one person; here, claimed by the whole village together

shawab — A species of tree native to Oman; sturdy, long-lived, often a village landmark

Shayb-Khalaf — Shayb is an Omani Arabic word of respect for an elderly man, similar to 'old sheikh'; here, combined with the name Khalaf to mean 'Elder Khalaf' or 'Old Khalaf'

Sheikhs-house — The house of the village leader; in Omani villages, traditionally the place where important community matters were discussed and decisions were made

shifted — Moved slightly into a new position; adjusted the body minutely

shimmer — A soft sparkling sound or light; a gentle shining

shimmered — Shone with a soft, wavering light; appeared to move in the intense heat

shimmering — Shining with a soft, trembling light that moves and shifts gently

shone — Gave out a bright light; here, showed bright delight

shortened — Made smaller in length; reduced from what they had been

shufkum — Arabic: 'How are you all? / What's with you?' — an affectionate, familiar greeting between people who see each other often

sidr — The leaves of the lote tree, crushed and used for centuries across Arabia as a natural soap and hair cleanser; known for its gentle cleansing and subtle scent

sighed — Breathed out slowly, often to show one's resignation or mild frustration

signature — A distinctive mark or feature; the way by which a person or thing can be recognised

sihr — Arabic: magic, sorcery; the practice of influencing the world through jinn and unseen powers

silent — Making no sound; completely quiet

silhouette — The dark outline of a shape seen against a lighter background

simultaneously — At the same time; together in a single moment

sincere — Genuine, coming truly from the heart; without pretence

sincerity — The quality of being honest and truthful, without pretence

sinister — Suggestive of evil or menace; appearing or pretending to be harmless while being dangerous

sinyah — Arabic: a large round metal serving tray, used across the Gulf for communal meals; the traditional centrepiece of Omani hospitality

sitting-room — A room designed for guests to sit; in Omani homes, often the largest room, set aside for hosting

skeptical — Doubtful; not easily convinced

slandering — Making false and damaging statements about someone; speaking ill of them without foundation

slithering — Moving by sliding smoothly along the ground, especially as a snake moves

slouch — A relaxed drooping posture; a non-upright way of standing

smiled — Gave a small, friendly, approving curve of the mouth

smoke — The visible vapour and gases given off by burning materials; here, associated with magical or mysterious rituals

smug — Showing too much satisfaction with oneself; looking as though one has just won something

sneezed — Expelled air suddenly through the nose, usually from irritation in the nostrils

sniffed — Drew in breath through the nose to smell something; here, performed as a small ceremony of investigation

socket — The bone-lined hollow in which the eye sits; the structural cavity of the eye

soft — Not firm; lacking the hardness that life on the land required

solidarity — Unity or agreement of feeling or action; here, the unwilling sharing of a misfortune

somewhere — In some indefinite place; at an unknown location

sorcerer — A person believed to practise magic, especially dark or spiritual magic

speaking — Producing words aloud; here, the particular dream-act of a dust-man speaking

specific — Relating to a particular thing; precise, not general

specific-places — Locations that carry particular meaning because of their history or associations

spectacularly — In a way that is very impressive or dramatic, usually in a failure sense here

spell — A magical word or phrase with power; here, used for a word that carried ancient weight

spook — To frighten or startle an animal; to cause a sudden alarm

spotlight — A focused beam of light used to highlight a person; here, the attention of a group

squared — Become straight and broad, especially of the shoulders; made formal

squatting — Sitting on the heels with the knees bent; a natural low position used across Arabia for work and conversation

squinting — Looking with partly closed eyes, usually because of bright light

staff — The group of people who work for an organisation; employees

starting pistol — A gun fired to start a race; here, used to describe the word's effect of launching chaos

stay — To remain in a particular state; to continue without change

steadiness — The quality of being firm and without trembling; calmness of hand or gaze

stillness — A complete, weighted quiet — not the absence of sound but the presence of something deeper

Stop — A command word telling someone to cease what they are doing immediately; clear, short, complete

storms — Violent disturbances of the atmosphere; here, used to describe the energy of departing children

strained — Struggled under pressure; was held together with visible effort

stretched — Extended the body fully, especially the arms and legs; the motion of an animal or person unfolding itself

strike — A single sharp hit against a surface

stripped — Reduced to the most essential parts, with everything else removed; bare

stubborn — Refusing to change an opinion or course of action, especially against pressure to do so

studded — Decorated with small nailheads or decorations set at regular intervals

stunned — Astonished and unable to react immediately

subdued — Quiet and rather reflective or depressed; having lost one's usual energy

subsiding — Becoming less intense; settling down after a rise

substantial — Considerable in size, weight, or importance; having real substance

suddenly — Quickly, without warning; in an instant

sultan — A Muslim sovereign, especially in historical or Arabian contexts; here, used humorously about John

surfaced — Came to the top; emerged from beneath

surveyed — Looked carefully across a place or group to check and understand it fully

survived — Continued to exist through danger or difficulty; lived through something hard

survivor — A person who has continued to live after facing danger; one who has come through

suspect — To believe that something is likely to be true, especially something bad or unpleasant

suspicious — Having the feeling that something is wrong; distrustful

suspiciously — In a way that causes doubt or mistrust; with the feeling that something is not quite right

sustain — Keep going at a particular level or rate

sustained — Continued at a steady rate; not interrupted

sweet-dangerous — Having a pleasant surface but carrying warning beneath; here, the voice teachers use when the next word may have consequences

sweetly — In a gentle, pleasant, often deliberately charming way; sometimes used with mild mischief

sweetness — The quality of being pleasant and gentle; here, used ironically

swift — Moving quickly but without great noise; fast and smooth

Swimming — The act of moving through water using one's arms and legs; in Omani villages, not something done in the falaj, which is a water supply, not a pool

symbol — A thing that represents or stands for something else; here, the stick as an emblem of authority rather than punishment

sympathetic — Showing pity or understanding for someone's suffering; sharing their feeling

T

tagheera — Arabic: a traditional tribal symbol, call, or sign used in Omani tribal identity, often a word or phrase shouted at gatherings, battles, or celebrations to identify one's people

talents — Natural abilities or skills; the things a person is good at

tang — A strong, sharp taste or smell that cuts through other flavours

target — An object that one aims for or focuses on; here, the specific item of Malood's interest

task — A piece of work to be done; a specific thing one has set out to complete

Task-Based-Learning — A language-teaching approach in which students learn through completing real-world tasks; popular in the 1970s and later

Tawi-Zahir — Arabic: a known clean-water spot in the Samail region; large pools of fresh water that fill after rain and remain clear for days; a traditional gathering place for villagers

temporarily — For a limited time; not permanently

tenants — People who rent and live in a house owned by someone else; here, used jokingly to describe the humans from the goat's point of view

tenderness — Gentleness and warmth; kindness expressed softly, without condition

terrible — Extremely bad or serious; causing fear

terrified — Caused extreme fear; alarmed greatly

terrifying — Causing fear; extremely frightening

territorial — Relating to a claimed area of space; marked as one's own

testimony — A formal statement of truth, especially in a way that declares who one is

testing — Checking something to see how it works or how much it will yield; probing

tethered — Tied to something with a rope so it cannot wander; restricted within a certain distance

textiles — Woven or knitted cloths; fabrics and fabric products of all kinds

texture — The feel and character of something; the small weave of experience

theatrical — Done in a dramatic and showy way, as though performing on a stage

thorough — Complete and careful in every detail

thoughtful — Careful and considered; giving something the full weight of your attention

threading — Passing through in a long thin line; moving like a thread

threshold — A point of entry; the start of something new; the line where one state ends and another begins

thunder — A loud deep rolling sound from the sky, especially during a storm; here, the force of a single voice that stops everything

tick — A short, repeated light sound, like a small clock or cooling metal

tightened — Became firmer or more secure; closed more strongly

tightness — The quality of being stretched and not loose; the feeling of something holding itself tight

tilt — A small leaning to one side; a slight angle away from upright

tingled — Had a prickling, tickling sensation; felt alive on the surface

tone — The quality of a voice that carries meaning beyond the words; what you hear beneath what is said

track — To follow the movement of something; here, used for Aunt Azizah's attempt to always know where her goat was

tracksuit — A two-piece set of matching jacket and trousers originally made for athletes, increasingly worn in the seventies by physical education teachers

traditional — Following long-established custom; inherited from earlier generations

traffic-sign — A sign that controls the movement of traffic; used here to describe the way John raised his stick like an official instrument of authority

trailed — Followed behind something in a long line; here, the cloud of dust that followed the truck wherever it went

transaction — An instance of buying or selling; a business exchange

transformation — A complete change in appearance or character

transformed — Changed in form or appearance; made different from the original

transition — The process of changing from one state to another; here, the shift from meeting to meal

treasures — Things of great value that are carried carefully and protected

treatment — Medical care; the action of treating an illness or wound

tremor — A small shaking movement, especially from strain or emotion

tribe — A social group made up of many families who share a common ancestor; in Oman, tribes carry names, histories, and identity across generations

triggered — Caused a reaction or response; set off

trot — A faster pace than walking, slower than running; a confident, steady gait

trouble — Problems or difficulties, usually caused by someone who is being too active or too creative for the room

turban — A length of cloth wound around the head; a traditional headcovering worn by Omani men

turned — Moved a page over; also, used here metaphorically for a whole village redirecting its focus at the same instant

twitched — Moved with a small, quick motion; here, the small flicker of a sleeping ear

U

unaccompanied — Without any additional element or support; alone

unaccounted for — Cannot be explained or found; missing without a clear reason

unambiguous — Clear and not open to interpretation; plain in meaning

unapologetic — Not sorry at all; proceeding without any acknowledgement that something might be wrong

Unavoidable — Impossible to prevent, escape, or ignore; it simply is there

uncanny — Strange or mysterious in an unsettling way; seeming to know more than should be possible

unclassifiable — Impossible to fit into any known category or type

Uncle-Khalaf — In Omani and broader Arab culture, the word 'Uncle' (Ammi or 'Am) is used as a respectful form of address for older men — not a biological uncle, but a village elder

uncomplaining — Not expressing dissatisfaction; enduring without protest

unconventional — Not following accepted standards or usual ways; unusual

undecided — Not yet having made a choice; hesitating between options

underlinings — Lines drawn beneath written words; marks for emphasis

understanding — An agreement or arrangement between people about how something will be done

understated — Presented in a restrained way, not showy

underway — In progress; already started

undignified — Lacking formal dignity; unrestrained

uneven — Not smooth or flat; shaped by hands rather than machines, carrying the marks of how it was made

unexpected — Not expected or anticipated; coming as a surprise

Unfamiliar — Not known before; strange or new to the senses

unfinished — Not brought to an end; still in progress

unfit — Not suitable or qualified for something; not up to a task

unhelpful — Not useful or productive; making things harder rather than easier

unhurried — Not rushed; moving at an easy, unforced pace, as though time had agreed to be patient

unilateral — Decided by one party alone without consulting others

unison — At the same time, together; making the same sound with one voice

universal — Applicable or existing everywhere; relevant across all cultures

unmistakably — In a way that cannot be mistaken; with absolute clarity

unnegotiable — Not subject to discussion or change; fixed

unreliable — Not able to be trusted; inconsistent in a way that cannot be counted on

unrepentant — Feeling no regret or sorrow for something done wrong

unreserved — Without holding back; complete and unrestrained

unthinking — Done without conscious thought or planning; automatic

unwanted — Not desired; here, used about facial hair removal which was her specialty

urgency — The feeling that something must be done immediately; a pressing need for speed

urgent — Demanding immediate action or attention; pressing

V

vaguely — In an unclear or unfocused way; not precisely

verdict — A formal decision given after careful consideration; especially the decision of a jury

verdicts — Final decisions or opinions given after consideration; pronouncements

vernacular — The everyday language of a particular group or region, as opposed to formal or literary language

victim — One who suffers from an action or event; here, used affectionately for Mr. John as the butt of the day's jokes

victorious — Having won; feeling the complete satisfaction of someone who has achieved what they set out to do

visible — Able to be seen; openly showing

vocabulary — All the words a person knows in a language; the building material of communication

volume-spiral — A pattern in which each party responds at a higher volume than the last, continuing until something breaks the cycle

W

wadi — A dry riverbed or valley in desert regions that fills with water only during rains; a key feature of Omani landscape

Wadi-Al-Maawil — A valley area (wadi) in the north of Oman, between mountains, containing several villages and farms watered by the falaj system

WAFAQRIYA — An Omani exclamation expressing sudden shock, pain, or dismay; the specific cry of a person who has just discovered something unexpectedly unpleasant

wait — Arabic: hold on; wait; be patient; a single word that means both 'let me' and 'give me a moment'

waiting — Staying in place until a particular event happens or until something is ready

warning — A statement that something might happen; a signal of possible consequences

wary — Cautious; on guard; alert to possible trouble

wasted — Used without benefit; thrown away without purpose

weary — Feeling or showing tiredness, especially from prolonged effort

weather — The state of the atmosphere; here, used to mean difficulty or unpredictable conditions

weathered — Showing the marks of long exposure to sun, wind, and time; lined, browned, strong

weight — Heaviness; the force of a thing pressing down by its own mass

welcoming — Receiving with friendship; making someone feel at home

wet earth — The smell of ground that has recently received water; the rich, ancient scent that rises when dust meets moisture

whistle — A small wind instrument used to produce a sharp loud sound; used by sports teachers and referees

wifely — In the manner of a wife speaking to a husband; with the particular tone married people use

wishing — Hoping or desiring something to be true; sending a gentle intention toward another person

without — Not having something; free of a particular element

witnessed — Saw something happen; was present for an event

wizard — A person believed to have magical powers; English for 'sorcerer'

womens-hour — The specific times of day, early morning and late evening, when women traditionally used the falaj for their own needs; a quiet, private part of the system

working — In use; actively doing a job; practical rather than decorative

world — An entire sphere of human existence; a complete way of life

worn-out — Exhausted; used up by the day

wudu — The Islamic ritual washing performed before prayer; the cleansing that prepares the body for worship

Y

Ya-binti — Egyptian/Arabic: literally 'oh my girl'; a warm, motherly way of addressing a younger woman or friend, widely used across Arab culture

Yalla — Arabic: 'Let's go!' — an all-purpose verbal kick, used across the Arab world to move groups of people forward

Z

zanoubah — Omani Arabic: a light, open leather sandal, often worn by boys and men — the everyday shoe of the village

Zanzibari — From Zanzibar, the East African island that was, for over two centuries, tightly linked to Oman; many Zanzibari-Omani families moved back and forth across the Indian Ocean, and by the seventies there were thousands of Zanzibari-origin traders living in coastal Oman

zigzag — A pattern that moves sharply in first one direction, then the opposite

ABOUT THE AUTHOR

Thuraya Mohammed Ali Al-Naabia

Thuraya Mohammed Ali Al-Naabia is an Omani English teacher, educational innovator, and founder of Under The Palm Tree, a unique educational project that blends English language learning with Omani heritage, storytelling, and digital innovation.

With extensive experience in education, Thuraya is passionate about creating meaningful learning experiences that connect language, culture, and creativity. Her work focuses on transforming traditional language learning into immersive journeys where students learn through stories, characters, games, and real-world cultural contexts.

As the creator of *123 Let's Learn English Under The Palm Tree*, she has developed an original story world set in 1970s Oman, designed to help learners build English skills while exploring the richness of Omani history, traditions, and everyday life.

Thuraya is also an advocate for the thoughtful use of technology and artificial intelligence in education, believing that learning becomes most powerful when students feel emotionally connected to what they are discovering.

Through her work, she continues to build innovative educational experiences that inspire curiosity, confidence, and lifelong learning.

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شكر وعرفان

إلى أهل القرواشية وسمائل — الذين صنعت ذكرياتهم وصورهم هذا العالم. وإلى طلابي، أول من جلس معي تحت ظلّ النخلة.

To the people of Al-Qurawashiyah and Samail — whose memories and photographs shaped this world. And to my students, the first to sit with me under the palm tree.

Samail, Oman — 1973

A British teacher named John arrives in a village threaded with falaj water and palm shade. A teacher named Thuraya opens her Book of Thoughts. A goat named Malood opens every door he shouldn't.

Across **36 Palms** — thirty-six stories of school days, souq mornings, rain over the valley, Ramadan lanterns, and one very fast goat — children learn English the way language is truly learned: inside a world they love.

Story by story, word by word — under the palm tree. 🌴

THE END **الْخَاتَمَة**